

OFF-THE-RECORD

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RED DOT PRESS

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AUTHOR'S NOTE

ST. PAUL'S BAY, Malta—Dawn is coming up over the Mediterranean now. 7:12 A.M. I can hear the whining of early morning buses and smell the saltwater splashing underneath my balcony, out here at the far end of the island—this is the end of the line for buses, beaches and the life I once lived.

From my desk, I can see the hazy light of a new day. A man casts a fishing line from a dock while his dog lies patiently on the pavement. The neighborhood shopkeeper brooms the steps of his bodega.

After a week-long windstorm, palm trees barely flicker this morning as I watch the past five years float away in calm, rhythmic ripples toward St. Paul's Shipwreck Island—a rock where Paul the Apostle purportedly crashed in 60 AD on the way to Rome, to be tried for sharing publicly the ridiculous thoughts in his mind. Some are carved into the walls of a nearby church.

I HAVE FAITH IN GOD THAT IT WILL BE EXACTLY AS I HAVE BEEN TOLD.

Five years ago, a similar blind faith led me here, to a speck on the map underneath Sicily, a place with three hundred days of sunshine, homemade pasta and, most importantly, a place where nobody knew my name.

Since you, also, don't know my name, allow me to introduce myself. My name is Anthony Fenech.

I was a sports writer in my past life. Started at 19 years old in 2007 and lasted into the pandemic year of 2020, including five years when I covered the Detroit Tigers for the *Detroit Free Press* as the team's beat reporter. I covered my favorite team growing up for my hometown paper. I liked it; I was good at it.

Then came the "accident," as my former therapist called it. It went viral and redefined my life and I became a nameless, faceless person. All because somebody called me a bad name.

The guy was Justin Verlander, a superstar pitcher who in an impressive twist of irony was my favorite baseball player growing up, having anchored the Tigers' starting rotation for years. The accident happened in August 2019, when Verlander—then pitching for the Houston Astros—demanded that his team bar me from the clubhouse. The Astros obliged, breaking Major League Baseball's

rules that guarantee reporters equal access, and put three security guards in front of the clubhouse door.

He didn't say it to my face when they finally let me in, but the next day, Verlander called me unethical on Twitter. And while it wasn't the worst thing I've ever been called, soon it was scrolling across ESPN every few minutes: VERLANDER CALLS DETROIT FREE PRESS REPORTER 'UNETHICAL'

Of all the words to describe a journalist, Old Pal chose the one there's no coming back from.

The accident (her word, not mine) left my name disfigured in an industry where reputation is all you've got. It nearly destroyed mine, just two years after being honored as one of the top 10 sports beat writers in America by the Associated Press Sports Editors.

I first felt called to write this book in the aftermath of the accident. I took far too many drugs one weekend and dove headfirst into a box of receipts in the basement. The receipts tracked the five years I spent traversing the big leagues and brought to life memories that, for the first time since the accident, made me affectionate toward sports writing again.

The more time I spent on the book, the more fun I had, and the stronger my belief grew that walking away from the beat and writing a behind-the-scenes book about the beat writing life wasn't just the best move—it was the *only* move.

I arrived in Malta in fall 2020, ahead of the second wave of COVID-19, and hunkered down inside a converted boat house along the sea. When I discovered the nearby bus stop was named *Anthony*, I took it as a sign I was in the right place.

OFF-THE-RECORD is my reporter's spiral notebook of what I've learned and observed over the years. I wrote this book for the sources who trusted me, and especially for my sports writing superheroes, longing to experience their golden age... for if I couldn't live vicariously through theirs, I'd want them to live through mine, a wild west on steroids where tweets matter more than words.

There are two problems with that type of all-in, lottery-winning approach. The most obvious but least serious is that even the people I considered friends in the business have at times treated me like a walking Wuhan lab.

The first colleague I told about *OFF-THE-RECORD* ghosted me. Another sounded shocked anyone would write something this dangerous: "I wouldn't want people coming after me."

Which brings us to the other, more complicated problem: Losing my identity.

I had worked in sports media for my entire adult life before moving to Malta. Having your byline posted from a major metropolitan newsroom comes with a certain kind of attention. Your phone lights up constantly. Your name and face are everywhere—websites, podcasts, TV, radio, Twitter—two million people scroll past your work each year.

I was no longer in a job with its work rhythms and deadlines, a structure I needed. For the first time since high school, I was writing for an audience of one.

I knew enough to realize the challenge of writing hundreds of pages and tens of thousands of words. But I didn't know the act of writing the words would pale in comparison to the personal impact of reliving moments both good and bad, some of the worst and best of my life.

I've been living in my own Edge City, like gonzo god Hunter S. Thompson, who once wrote that "when a jackrabbit gets addicted to road-running, it is only a matter of time before he gets smashed—and when a journalist turns into a politics junkie he will sooner or later start raving and babbling in print about things that only a person who has Been There can possibly understand."

Same goes for this life. I got addicted. Smashed. Turned into a Ball Writing junkie and once found a letter two winters ago that my fiancée hid in a drawer: "I feel sad at the thought of leaving him like this. I don't think he's doing great. It's not even just his use or intake. The war he's fighting these days is deep in his heart. This feels like the last mission. I think he'd be willing to die for this feat." You wouldn't have needed to ask twice.

But that was two years ago. The water outside my window tells a different story.

It's never looked bluer than today, backdropped by steep brown cliffs and green springtime shrubbery. The day feels as bright as the one when I discovered I wanted to be a sports writer.

I was in high school, age 17, doing community service after being pulled aside for being very drunk at the last football game of my senior year. So, there I was at the local St. Vincent de Paul, unloading donations and organizing shelves of books, CDs, DVDs and movies in alphabetical order. And then I picked up a book that changed my life.

It was a compilation of sports columns by the *Free Press*' Mitch Albom, the most honored and by many measures the most read columnist and author sports writing has ever produced.

I couldn't put the book down. I read it in the restroom when I didn't have to go, placed it out of order on the shelf, always keeping one eye on it. I bought the copy after my shift and read every column in two days. I guess you could say I've been hooked on this life ever since.

As I reflect, it's difficult to clearly recall but a handful of the hundreds of games I covered. I can't recite records or statistics. No numbers come to mind at all—not even wins and losses. I think instead about relationships formed along the way, those that developed into friendships. Some strengthened by conflict, others severed by it. I think of proud moments I'd once forgotten and others, I'd like to forget but never will.

OFF-THE-RECORD is an authentic look at the life of a sports writer from online to print to Twitter to TV. The greatest job on Earth. As close to the bone as it gets, for better or worse.

Whatever I wrote in all those hotel rooms and press boxes and hospitality lounges, whoever I texted and called and bribed for scoops back then, is no different in these pages than it was during the wonder years when I covered baseball like my life depended on it.

I went from the rawest rookie to building life-long relationships in baseball. I wouldn't trade those years, or the years it took to write this book, for anything. If you doubt me, feel the early onset carpal tunnel in my wrists—this is the last gasp of sports writing.

I feel like goddamn Jim Bouton right now. I went for it. I risked it all, and all I got is this stack of white paper—the story of a charmed and cursed sports writing life, one far too good not to share.

—*Anthony Fenech*
April 20, 2025
Portobello Flats

SUMMER 2017

CHICAGO, *August 27*—A storm is coming. Dark clouds approaching the Sears Tower, raindrops streaking against a window and the back of a man's bald head. The last scene before the elevator door closes.

I am on the South Side at U.S. Cellular Field, home of the Chicago White Sox, and we are slowly descending from the third floor. The skyline is covered in gray. Walls are gray. Everything is gray.

In the back corner, stuck between drunken fans from the suite level, far too close to that man's bald head. I'm smothered by emotions, suffocated by the smell of a packed elevator. Didn't start smoking again until this past weekend, but I need a cigarette.

Not until I squeeze through the slow crowd of stragglers leaving do I think about how different I am now than when I walked into this godforsaken place a couple days earlier.

Sunday afternoon. Light up and wait for my ride to arrive. He will soon take me to Midway, where I can drink these stressors away, and then I'll fly to Denver, where I can smoke 'em away. Thinking about how, at this time yesterday, I was crying, silently sobbing in the back of the press box.

At the time, I had just messaged a star player's dad, giving him a heads-up for a story that was coming out about his son, who had become a problem in the clubhouse.

Now, I'm thinking about how my job as a beat writer will never be the same again. About how I'm a wanted man now. How I might even kind of like it.

My ride soon pulls up, his black Lincoln Navigator serving as a beacon of safety from this rainy, risky world of sports writing. "Don't get punched," a star player messaged me the other day. "For real."

Andrew, my Chicago driver who also shuttles players and umpires, talks in his New York tongue—conversation I'm not interested in at the moment.

I lean my head on the door panel. Close my eyes and try to forget about the weekend that was, the wreckage still to sift through.

I open them to receive a text message from the Tigers' top PR official. He is apologizing for yesterday, when he tried intimidating me by suggesting I could not continue my baseball writing job if I went through with the Very Serious Story.

“Players are not happy. So, someone else will be covering the last five weeks?”

“I don’t think that’s an appropriate question.”

“I am trying to help you do your job.”

He’s a veteran PR chief. Worked with him for years—normally a straight shooter who helps me do my job. But he definitely was not trying to help me do my job this weekend, when I had a flaming arrow pointed at the heart of the team.

“Once you post the story, I can’t help you if players decided to not talk to you or the *Free Press*.”

I understood—hell, I wasn’t happy either, but such is the life I chose.

The Very Serious Story threatens the harmony of the clubhouse and exposes the bad behavior of a highly paid, highly respected veteran player. A story PR does not want to be published.

I am holding the ‘L’ as we speak. The biggest of my career. I broke through the brick wall on the Very Serious Story almost a year ago—I had to wait until the time came, if ever it did.

There was a fight in the clubhouse last season. It fractured the team and the player who sparked it had become an even bigger problem this year—but I couldn’t put it out there unprompted. I have enough sourcing to go with the Very Serious Story, but I’ve had to wait—it’s bad form to drop a bomb unprompted, and nothing’s happened recently to warrant such a move.

Well, a few days ago, I was prompted.

I landed and started putting word out about the story. I talked to the player and the manager at the ballpark the next day and had the story written by 2 A.M. Saturday, with more than enough time to kick up my feet and enjoy a coffee before print deadline for the all-important Sunday Paper, the most circulated of the week.

Even when we somehow missed that deadline (don’t wanna talk about it), we still got the Very Serious Story in the chute and ready to go, scheduled to go live online at 1 A.M.

Yet here I sit—16 hours later—and the Very Serious Story has not been published. I still don’t want to talk about it—I successfully silenced Andrew a few minutes ago. Said I was tired and wanted to close my eyes for a bit.

The day was bad. I was hungover enough from whiskey and stress and threw out the burnt crackers the cafeteria was passing off as French toast.

I sat next to the Tigers’ traveling PR guy and he told me Justin Verlander (the star starting pitcher) wasn’t going to be talking to me anymore. Still mad over something I tweeted about him watching the solar eclipse earlier in the month (seriously), or the way I pushed back in the last postgame interview (he walked out), or maybe in protest of the Very Serious Story I was writing (everyone knows).

All Detroit’s media relations manager knew was what Verlander had previously told him—“I’m not talking to Fenech anymore.”

Sadly, the Very Serious Story has been killed. It's never going to be published. At least, not in that form. The story I waited so patiently on where I had to walk up to the player with everyone watching, where players and coaches were pulling me outside the clubhouse and pinging my phone. All that for nothing.

Past midnight, about half an hour before the story was set to go live, I got a phone call from a source who ended up saving us in the end—lest we look like insensitive clowns, kicking the poor chap while he's down.

We pulled the story, which hasn't seen the light of day—and likely never will.

Meanwhile, guess who had to go back into the clubhouse with no story.

How they must think I got scared and didn't write it.

I walked up to the star player two days ago and told him what I was writing and gave him the opportunity to say something. Two days later, still no story. (And no star player, either.)

Andrew says there's an accident on the Stevenson so we're taking side streets to Midway, moving through the bumpy, stop-and-go roads of the sports writing life. I'm still angry. Too angry to be scrolling through Twitter or texting anyone, let alone the top Tigers PR guy, who reigns supreme once again after foiling the beat writer in Hail Mary fashion.

"First, that was a very uncalled for comment yesterday. Second—whatever, I don't even want to get into it. Refer to 'First.'"

"I apologize for that. Have a good trip to Denver. Great ballpark and cool city."

DENVER, *August 29*—I stay downtown after tonight's game and go to this guy's apartment.

I met the guy a couple of weeks ago at a wedding in Cancún, and here we are, sitting outside on his seventh-floor patio with another couple. I'm wearing shirt-tie-jacket and a work bag, an easy way to introduce myself—hi, I'm Anthony Fenech—I'm a sports writer, I cover the Detroit Tigers for the *Detroit Free Press*.

Basically, I fly around the country nine months every year writing about baseball. The job is never-ending, like a machine you can't beat. How, sitting here thinking about it, it's rather ridiculous that I'm writing and tweeting about these millionaires playing baseball. A game.

August 30—Getaway Day comes fast. Clubhouse opens at 9:30 for day games. Justin Verlander is pitching. Tomorrow is the trade deadline. For the past two months, his name has been circulating in rumors. To the trained eye, his pref-

erence is clear: Verlander, 34, wants no part of the long rebuild in store for the Tigers next season.

Problem is that the team is paying him big bucks for a long time. This year, he's making \$28 million—he's owed \$117 million through 2020, thanks to a contract extension signed in his prime. The Tigers, meanwhile, have fallen on tough times: After years of competing for championships with high-payroll rosters, they stink now and have little choice but to enter a rebuild phase, where they'll essentially tank for a few seasons, trading their established players for top prospects and attempt to improve through the draft.

There are 162 games in a baseball season. Today's is No. 132. Tigers win. On the mound, Verlander pitches six strong innings for the trade deadline scouts in attendance, allowing one run.

Knowing his newfound stance about not speaking with me, I circle back to team PR: "You have to know that if he doesn't want to speak to the media when I'm around, that's fine. But I'm not going to leave. My credential allows me to be there."

Barring injury, the starting pitcher always speaks to the media after the game. But the last time Justin went through this routine, he couldn't make it through.

"You should stop."

When I didn't stop, he walked away.

What questions did he not like? Glad you asked.

The reason the Very Serious Story needed to be written was because last week, there was a bench-clearing brawl with the New York Yankees. During the brawl, cameras caught Verlander arguing with a veteran teammate in the dugout. It was shared on social media and sent to the Ball Writer. And guess who was starting the next day.

After the game, I asked what happened with his teammate the previous day.

"What happened?"

"The argument with..."

He cut me off.

"You should stop."

I continued.

"What was on TV and shared on social media..."

And he was gone.

So, I enter the locker room today with my antennae up. I see the team's PR guy—a non-confrontational fellow, soft-spoken, wouldn't hurt a fly. The players know this and Justin knows he's not just another player. He's wearing suede maroon. When the nice PR man approaches, his body language is that of standing his ground. When a handful of us sports writers half-circle him for the interview, I wait purposely for two others to ask questions before asking, 'How big were those two strikeouts in the fourth inning?'"

"Next question. Next question."

He scans the faces until someone else stammers in. I follow up with an even more basic question, "How was your fastball today?"

Nothing else, no eye contact. PR calls for last question. There are none. Verlander flees the scene.

August 31—Live from the Denver airport, it's the trade deadline.

Slow day thus far. Wasn't my best move booking a two-leg return trip, but the end of the season is fast approaching. I'm short of where I need to be for Gold Medallion status, so sacrifices must be made.

I'm flying to Atlanta then Detroit, slouched into an empty row and scrolling through Denver airport conspiracy theories when everything changes. It's Deep Throat, dropping a tip. "Trade coming today. Not Verlander."

Three-alarmer. I blast texts to everyone who might know.

Trying to find the identity of the mystery trade, I contact the team's general manager—the chief decision-maker, so-to-speak, known around here as the Highest Source In The Land. I slow-play my hand. "Just checking in. Do you think anything's going to happen today?"

Two minutes later, more aggressively: "Actually, I got a tip that something is going to happen. So, I'm checking up on that."

Time is of the essence. Trying to find agents in the know. "Keep me posted if you hear anything about J-Up." I tell his agent something is brewing. "Not Verlander is all I know."

I text Detroit's assistant GM: "Got a tip something is in the works—any context you can add, completely off-the-record?"

Standing in the jetway now, inching forward into a reporter's nightmare: Boarding a plane while news is breaking—before ten minutes of no Internet during takeoff.

Before I get to my seat, I'm beat. It's one of the National Guys, of course, who says a trade is "close"—Upton is headed out the door. Ken Rosenthal says J-Up is going to the Los Angeles Angels. Rosenthal is the biggest of the National Guys, an exclusive club of baseball reporting sharks who feed on schools of scoops.

Assistant GM: "This advice from my chief legal counsel. Look at Rosenthal's tweet."

"Why? Why do the National Guys always get it?"

Detroit's top radio guy messages: "Details? Wanna call in? U awake?"

No details, no I do not want to call in, no I'm not awake.

"About to take off," I say.

Before we do, I refocus my reporting eye on the much bigger whale in the distance. The National Guys are circling—they can see it, too, but they can't

see it like I do. This is my favorite team growing up, potentially trading my favorite player growing up. Now I'm the Ball Writer on watch at my hometown newspaper. The fact that Justin won't even talk to me right now is only icing on the top.

I touch base with his agent before boarding: "You think anything's going to happen?"

"I don't think so but predicting others' decisions is not something I'm usually comfortable with."

When I mention being on the plane while news is breaking, he reassures me: "Don't sweat it, you're really good at what you do and sometimes you can't control timing and info."

With the front office in close proximity back home, I touch base with my sources.

A Houston source says if they're in on Verlander, only the GM and owner know. Another's so paranoid about their tech-savvy front office, he offers his personal email instead of texting on his team phone.

DETROIT—Per tradition, my mom picks me up from the airport. It gives me time to see her for a bit during the six-month grind of the baseball season.

I get back home on the evening of the trade deadline. Midnight approaches. We have less than three hours to go, and conditions appear calm on the Verlander trade front, comfortable enough for a welcome home pour.

I check with a Tigers guy. Nothing.

Deep Throat confirms the front office is In The Room as we speak. They are spending the final hours of the trade deadline at the GM's suburban Detroit house. His wife made dinner, apparently. In fact, according to maps, from where I stand on my porch smoking a cigarette exchanging messages with his subordinates, I could make it to his kitchen table in 35 minutes flat. I know. I've been there.

Not the 24.1 miles in between, rather the dining room area the Tigers' front office currently shares—which includes most, if not all, of my top sources. None of those leakers in there want to be exposed. They're aware of not being on their phones. They probably go to the bathroom to text me while taking a leak. Some must take a lot of leaks.

Forty minutes until the trade deadline, there's a tipster on Line 2. He may or may not be In The Room tonight. Still talking about the Very Serious Story that won't ever be.

"I'm still curious how accurate you were."

"How accurate do you think I was?"

"Most of what u told me was accurate. Couple things were off base."

Tipster wants to read it.

"I'll let you," I say. "Wait until the end of the season." I'm guessing he'll get fired and forget about it anyways.

Sitting in a lawn chair on my porch with a scout on speaker phone when I see a text from my buddy, sharing a tweet that sounds a five-alarm fire. It knocks me off the call and out of the chair.

"Oh, shit... Oh, shit. Gotta go."

I hang up and hurry into the kitchen. I'm extra careful about fake accounts these days, so I pull up Twitter on my computer just in case. "Tigers and Astros very close to finalizing a deal for Justin Verlander," according to my main rival, a Ball Writer for the other paper in town. The pit of my stomach falls.

I feel many things, not one of them good. More confused than angry. Helpless, humiliated, embarrassed—all those. It can be borderline erotic, this feeling of utter failure, being beaten this badly and not knowing how. Is this really happening? Why? Why is nobody getting back to me? IS THERE SOMETHING WRONG WITH MY PHONE? I text the Highest Source In The Land:

"Is this true?"

DREAM JOB

DETROIT, *October 21, 2014*—Three years earlier.

I'm 27 years old and working the day shift on the *Free Press* sports desk. I'm curled in front of a computer with a wad of dipping tobacco and a half-full Styrofoam cup within reach.

Sitting in my cubicle in the sports department—second floor of a beautiful Albert Kahn building in downtown Detroit.

The building feels like home. I first walked in here seven years ago, when the bowling writer, who knew my uncle somehow, got my foot in the door. I was 19 and came through the Lafayette Street entrance carrying a full binder of clips I wrote for my high school newspaper, with far too many fanboy pictures of my favorite athletes.

My high school journalism teacher insisted we keep these clipbooks, for one day they might get us a job. And damned if she wasn't right: I met with the prep sports editor that day, a regal fellow who was in the market for another body to answer phones and jot down scores a few evenings a week, especially on Friday nights. I was in.

Although I like to think of myself as a sports writer, collecting whatever scrap assignments are sent my way, I should be honest with you: technically, I'm not. Not quite yet. My official title is sports web producer. I work the night shift usually, from 7 P.M.-3 A.M., almost every weekend.

A few years ago, academically dismissed from college and putting the finishing touches on a summer internship with MLB.com covering the Arizona Diamondbacks, my buddy asked what I was going to do. "I guess get a job at the *Free Press*," I remarked, way too matter-of-factly. You see, people don't just get jobs here. It is considered a destination paper—a major market where you end up and stay forever.

Back then, August 2011, they didn't have openings. But one day, the long-time sports editor, a short, blond mustachioed man called me up with the next best thing: They could bring me aboard as a sports web intern.

I didn't care—after years of working my way up starting with those prep phone calls, I just wanted to work at the *Free Press* in any capacity. Besides, I had just recently failed out of college. This wasn't the worst fallback plan.

So, I've been putting in long hours as the department dishrag until an actual beat opens up. When I don't work nights, I often do things like wake up at eight after working all night, and drive to Auburn Hills for Pistons practice—or anything else my mad scientist sports editor has concocted to appease (or abuse) my sports writing ambitions.

I bide my time here, working every night, weekend and holiday, sitting between a couple of fogeys whose disdain for the place has definitely started to rub off, and drinking from fresh pots of their extra-leaded coffee. There's a drawerful of empty 5-Hour Energy bottles at my desk. This is all to say: I'm in my late twenties now, this web desk stuff has gotten old—the shift is hell on my body, and I need to write.

The newsroom is as empty as ever. A few years ago, the sports department was moved here—out in the open, occupying two rows of cubes, surrounded by many more empties.

The open desks serve as a sobering reminder of where our business currently stands: Since I got here, the newspaper has shrunk steadily as parent company Gannett bleeds money.

Gannett is no different from any other media company. Every corner of the journalism industry has been affected by cuts and consolidations since the turn of the decade. As the Internet continues to shift the sand beneath legacy media like newspapers, the foundation only becomes shakier.

Gannett has owned the *Free Press* since 2005, when they bought the 174-year-old newspaper from Knight-Ridder for \$262 million. One company was liquidating its media properties, the other expanding its portfolio—the direction has been downhill ever since.

"You're getting out at the right time," is a common refrain, as going-away cakes pile up. "It's only gonna get worse."

Every week, someone else sees the light and jumps off the Titanic, taking the life raft and the better money, hours and work/life balance that come with it.

With those departures goes a generation of institutional knowledge and character—the nightly running conversations, consistent buzz of chatter and colorful jokes have turned to an unnerving whisper.

There's a brick of a big-screen TV with faded color. Plaques acknowledging journalism awards trim the walls and framed front pages hang from standing columns. Worn out teal carpet, a musty dim smell and a tan file cabinet with a bunch of dated white binders. We once had a lovely secretary, solely for sports, who printed out the front cover of each day's section for historical safekeeping. She took a buyout some time ago.

Recently, I stole a few binders for myself. There is some great sports writing on those printouts. The *Free Press* used to be an absolute talent factory.

These ancient artifacts of a sports journalism heyday long gone may not see tomorrow. Slowly but surely, the place is clearing out as the *Free Press* newsroom

officially relocates down the street sometime in November. We don't need all this space anymore. Word is, there are two floors for us in a fancy, billionaire-owned office building—what we really need is for that billionaire to buy us.

It's easy working on the web desk during the day. There aren't typically live games underway, so the flow of reporters sending stories isn't as busy as at night. I can also get some quality face time with the boss, who works out of a cubby-hole office across the hall.

I'm in a bit of a daze today when I see something that immediately shocks me into sitting up straight. I quickly swipe the dip from my lip.

It is a tan fedora, a Stetson—so recognizable. I peek my eyes above the computer and follow the path of the hat, straight into the boss' office. The hat is the signature headwear of Seamhead John Lowe, the longtime Tigers' beat writer. It has sounded alarms in my head by appearing unannounced in the newsroom.

By this point, John Lowe has become a trusted mentor and friend. He is one of the kindest, classiest and most professional guys I've ever been around. Seamhead has been covering the Tigers at the *Free Press* since before I was born—he began his career at 19, stringing home games for the *Los Angeles Daily News* while in college.

John then went to Philly and covered baseball and hockey for the *Philadelphia Inquirer* and moved to Detroit in 1986. This, folks, is a Hall of Fame beat writer if there ever was one, a walking baseball history book and the embodiment of a Seamhead—the highest compliment in the business.

I met Lowe back in 2007 when I first got here as a preps score taker. I reached out to him about tagging along at a game, to see what the beat was all about. Of course, he obliged. At the suggestion of my father, I showed up to the stadium wearing a shirt and tie and soon realized he wears a shirt *and* tie *and* jacket *and* hat for *every* game.

We hit it off that day and I started soaking up whatever wisdom he was willing to share. Always taking notes, asking questions and picking his brain. Phone calls, Panera Bread meetings, and soon, I'm at the *Freep*, too—and helping him out regularly at the ballpark.

You will hear much more about Seamhead John Lowe—but for now just know he is a legend, and in the newsroom on an offseason weekday afternoon—which is very unusual.

Now one of the *Freep's* top editors joins Seamhead in Gene Myers' office, and I don't need a fly on the wall to know what's being said. I message my buddy, breaking the Big News before anyone leaves the room: "John Lowe is retiring."

October 27—With the chance of a career up for the taking, I go into overdrive.

Although I have the writing chops and second-string experience necessary for an outside chance at succeeding Seamhead—I'm still nowhere near qualified to take over a big boy beat. And this is a big boy beat.

Since I started pursuing a sports writing career, the *Free Press* is the only newspaper I've wanted to work for. It's my hometown newspaper in one of the best sports cities in the country—it doesn't get better than this.

As the calendar flipped on the close of the baseball season—with Seamhead's impending retirement plans unbeknownst—I started staying in the newsroom long after last call, until sunlight crept over the Canadian border, compiling a lengthy list of every baseball agent I could find. Hundreds of names—cell phones office phones, email addresses. I started matching agents with current players, focusing on players with upcoming contract options and those hitting free agency this winter. Hours trying to prove my worth, preparing to pitch editors on adding another sports writing position.

I know Detroit is looking for a lefty reliever, so I list the candidates. I call their agents and the first to call me back is Tim Baratta, who says the Tigers have checked in on his client, Craig Breslow. "Don't put that out there." Absolutely not.

The most promising ground I've broken is with Oscar Suarez, who represents veteran reliever Joakim Soria. Soria has a \$7 million team option on his contract for next season—the team must exercise or decline it within three days following the conclusion of the World Series.

After my first cold call on October 13, I keep up with Suarez. I call again five days later, and we talk for 15 minutes. I text on the 21st and call on the 24th, alternating the days until the team's decision on Soria is finally made.

Today, the 27th, connecting with Suarez for yet another check-in. It's 72 hours before the deadline. He calls back instead.

Suarez isn't shy and is perhaps even unsmart in saying so many things to someone like me—not even a rookie yet, not even on the beat but foaming at the mouth for the shot. I haven't put in all this work, all these years on the web desk posting other reporters' words for nothing. The trust Soria's agent shows me provides hope.

October 31—I get a text late this morning from Suarez, who says the Tigers are picking up Soria's option. I seriously consider following *Freep* protocol and getting my source approved first but remember I need this scoop. So instead, I tweet it out first (11:33 A.M.) then message my source to the web editor on duty.

I decided Soria's agent was trustworthy enough and didn't need clearance—he's In The Room. I couldn't risk him texting a National Guy, who doesn't have to clear sources and could swoop in for the scoop. I was fearful of

looking a fool, but equally aware of how wins are tallied these days: whoever tweets the scoop first.

After the source is quickly cleared, so, too, is my reporting conscience—free of the improperly sourced breaking news floating around with my name on it.

From the sports editor, reply all: “Woo-hoo!!!!”

November 11—Gene Myers pulls me into his office during tonight’s web shift and asks if I want the good or bad news first.

I choose bad.

“The bad news is you still have to work on the web desk for a few weeks...”

Dramatic pause.

“The good news is you’re our next Tigers beat writer. Congratulations.”

He says not to tell anyone, an announcement is coming tomorrow, but I can tell my mom.

Tomorrow, I receive a flood of congratulations from my colleagues. I am finally a sports writer, unchained from the web desk—a *Ball Writer*, the Tigers’ beat writer, can you believe it?

From: Myers, Gene **Sent:** 11/12/2014, 7:45 PM

Subject: ANTHONY WILL TAKE OVER THE TIGERS BEAT

After more than seven years, in essence, in the Free Press’ farm system, Anthony Fenech has earned his big-league call-up. He will assume the reins of the Tigers beat.

This has been Anthony’s path to The Show: He started on the Prep Crew and he did stringing work while at Central Michigan. He blogged countless games for Freep.com while interning in Las Vegas, Pittsburgh and Phoenix. He became a Freep intern and officially hired. Since then, he usually has staffed the overnight sports web shift but covered enough baseball to earn his Baseball Writers’ Association of America card before the 2013 season. When it arrived, it was one of the happiest days of his life.

John Lowe proudly embraced a phrase for sports writers who devote their careers to baseball: Seamhead. For years, John has schooled Anthony on the ways of the Seamhead, including how, like a ballplayer, to stay strong and focused through a 162-game grind. He even sent this email last year: ‘A bit concerned about young Anthony here—might need a better health or eating plan to handle these variant hours. He had a tweet that a home-run call ‘interrupted a nap in my car.’

November 12—My first official day as a Ball Writer goes like this: At 4:15 P.M., I see a tweet from Ken Rosenthal, a FOXSports.com and MLB Network insider.

“Sources: Tigers close to re-signing Víctor Martínez to four-year deal.”

Rosenthal is baseball’s biggest news breaker. I have no sources and I’m in big shit.

I text the Tigers PR folks (communications VP Ron Colangelo and media relations director Aileen Villarreal): “Can you tell me anything about Víctor? I don’t need to use your name.”

Only one responds. “No.”

Besides PR, I don’t yet have the cell number of anyone In The Room.

Dave Dombrowski is the Tigers’ GM—the head front office honcho, a longtime baseball executive with a pearl-sparkling smile who carries himself like a politician. Dombrowski, 59, has been the GM of multiple teams for more than two decades—he is respected, known for winning and saying nothing to the media—or, perhaps more accurately, saying many things that amount to nothing.

I figure he won’t respond to an email about Martínez’s reported signing, so instead, I try his right-hand man—assistant general manager Al Avila.

“Al, reports swirling that you guys and Víctor are close on a four-year deal. Can you confirm this? And can you keep me in the loop and let me know when it’s official? I will not use your name.”

Avila—who I have never met and doesn’t answer—is as useless as the rest of them. Dombrowski, Avila, and the brain trust are in Scottsdale at the GM meetings.

I am in Detroit, inside the brand spanking new *Freeep* newsroom, which is bland and sterile. Working a web desk shift with my tail between my legs, my ass straight kicked—there are no cubicles here to hide behind. As the minutes turn into hours, the National Guys vulture in, breaking more details about Víctor Martínez re-signing. The deal is for \$68 million, one National Guy reports. It includes a no-trade clause, another says—and I can’t even muster as much as a confirmation. To pour salt into the wound, the rival paper has it proudly confirmed.

I get a chance to redeem myself later that night. Instead? More shame. Past ten, I get a text from PR, notifying me about a trade. I’m late and a loser again.

I message my friend Dylan Hernández, who covers the Dodgers for the *Los Angeles Times*—we met one summer in Arizona. I tell him about how I got smoked. He gives me an important introduction to the beat. There are two things I need to know: 1) The phone number of a woman named Rebecca, and 2) Get a Marriott Rewards number.

Soon, I’m calling Rebecca every day, asking for agents’ numbers.

She works for the Players’ Association and allows for two numbers per day. Simply dial her up, say who you are and which player’s agent you’re looking for. Agents are by far and away the biggest source of information out there. Tradition-

ally, they are the first people who are informed about a roster move involving their client—whether it's an injury, trade, promotion/demotion or signing. Agents are considered a first-hand source, someone In The Room.

But beware: Agents have agendas; they are snaky and have one goal in mind—making money for their clients and themselves. They leak information that may impact negotiations or influence the market in a favorable way.

Agents are their own bosses—they don't answer to anyone for leaking information. Agents enjoy particularly chummy relationships with National Guys—the big-platformed reporting insiders who break news for a living. Guys whose scoops I chase consistently: the Ken Rosenthals, Buster Olneys and Jon Heymans of the world. Agents can just one-stop shop with their favorite National Guy, reaching way more than the local guy with only a fraction of the audience.

This relationship is mutually beneficial and the bane of a beat writer's existence. We work our butts off to build relationships with agents, only to be left sleeping alone most nights.

SCANDAL !

DETROIT, *December 5*—Something bad has happened. I have an Internet Stalker. There's this guy who runs a blog with more than 15,000 followers on Twitter, and he's trying to ruin my career.

For reasons unclear, I've become his new whipping boy. I've never met him, never interacted with him, nothing—haven't even blocked him.

He's got a loyal army of followers who are tweeting at me, too. He's emailing me and my sports editor and tweeting at the sports department's Twitter account—this is not good.

"I am contacting you to find out why you chose Anthony Fenech on the Tigers beat. My sources have told me that Mr. Fenech has at least one DUI conviction.

"My sources also tell me that Mr. Fenech doesn't have a college degree. Is that a prerequisite for a beat writer's job at your paper? It would seem that Mr. Fenech leapfrogged others for this promotion. Please advise why this decision was made."

Internet Stalker has written a few articles about me, including one titled ANTHONY FENECH IS A FUCKING MORON. So let me come clean: Months away from my 21st birthday, I got a DUI after flipping my PT Cruiser on the freeway. I changed lanes at high speed and went airborne. My mom picked me up from the hospital.

Almost forgotten until now, when it's currently online. Twelve RTs and counting.

So yeah. That's basically what's happened, and I don't know what's going to happen from here, but I think the plan is just to ignore the noise and move on. Don't respond, don't interact—and no phone interviews without clearing it first.

So far, we have. Ignore and move on. Don't read the comments.

A news editor reaches out: "I'm sorry because it has to suck. Hang in there."

I started praying again, which seems to have worked. Still employed, I arrive at the airport for my first road trip—the winter meetings are this week.

At the gate, I cannot stop making inadvertent eye contact with this older gentleman on the same flight—gray hair parted to the side, glasses, looks like Stephen King in a slightly more friendly way. Like he knows me.

Has he read Internet Stalker's stuff?

SAN DIEGO, *December 8*—At the winter meetings, hundreds of reporters gather in hotel ballrooms chasing scoops. We're usually cooped up in the media room, with a main stage where press conferences are held, trades announced, and newly inducted Hall of Famers talk about being speechless.

I walk with a purpose, pretending I am a somebody. I stop Ken Rosenthal, as short in person as advertised on Twitter (5-foot-4½), introducing myself. Nice guy.

Each evening, the beat writers are summoned for a media session with the general manager, held in the team's suite. There are five of us, sitting in chairs, while general manager Dave Dombrowski sits at a high-top table on the other side of the room, flanked by assistant Al Avila. Ron Colangelo and Aileen Villarreal (Tigers PR) stand around with on-site executives and scouts.

I'm startled when I see the gray-haired guy from the flight here. We make eye contact again.

After the session, I realize in horror that I didn't turn my recorder on before I placed it on the table—I have no audio. My competitors have pity, sharing their tape so I'm able to write my stories.

December 10—Back at the lobby bar, I re-introduce myself to a tall, tan man with big shoulders who I recognize from the Tigers' suite—Dave Littlefield, formerly the Pittsburgh Pirates GM, was recently hired as a pro scout.

Embarrassingly, I don't remember our conversation from last night. We talk a bit more.

I meet Detroit's young analytics guy, Sam Menzin, and another fellow, Matt Something, who works for San Diego. I make a point of meeting agent Dave Pepe in the flesh, a former adjunct professor at Rutgers who represents veteran closer Joe Nathan. I reached out to Pepe this offseason, had a nice conversation, and I want to pitch an offseason feature story on Nathan, the aging former All-Star who is looking to regain both his fastball and the fans' trust. I suggest I could visit Nathan while training for the season. Pepe buys in.

While it wasn't explicitly stated as such, the story I was pitching to Nathan's agent was a fluff piece. By allowing a certain kind of access, it's almost certain the resulting story will be favorable for the subject.

December 11—My mouth is dry when I wake up.

I get a glass of water and check Twitter. Calamity! My team is close to a trade, reportedly sending a prospect shortstop to the Cincinnati Reds for righty starter Alfredo Simon.

And by the time I'm nearly finished whipping up a story for the first trade, Dombrowski is reportedly close to making another one—and this one is bigger.

According to Twitter, Detroit is landing star outfielder Yoenis Céspedes from the Boston Red Sox. Helpless, I communicate with the sports desk, Should I re-do the first story or write a whole new story? Soon, an alert for an impending press conference.

My sports editor sends an urgent message. Apparently one of the players Detroit dealt for has a domestic violence charge against him—I need to ask Dombrowski.

This morning has been a total mess. I barely slept after partying too hard at the lobby bar, and my head throbs with dehydration. The presser begins in ten minutes, and I can't risk not being there—I need to ask him that question—so I pass on dress clothes and go down in a white T-shirt and jeans, embarrassingly underdressed.

I call for the mic. I'm a little bit anxious about it—that I might stutter and sound like a scaredy cat—but I ask Dombrowski if the team considered the domestic violence charge.

"We're totally aware of the situations. I can't talk about his legal scenarios, but we're aware of it and comfortable with where it stands at this point."

I don't follow up, but I'm proud of myself. In a white t-shirt and jeans, no less. A New York Ball Writer emails: "Good question to Dombrowski on the legal issues. Keep showing balls like that and you'll do well."

Hurry back up to my room and write a new story. Put a dress shirt over the white tee and a jacket. Feeling quite hungover, I go to the front desk and check out.

Large garment bag, rolling carry-on, work bag slipping off my shoulder as I walk through the valet line.

Standing right in front of me, within an arm's length, is Scott Boras—the biggest agent in baseball, arguably the most powerful person in the sport. Boras reps a lot of Tigers. When he turns around, I extend my hand and say, "I should introduce myself..."

Boras is wearing a black fleece pullover with his company's logo on it. Jeans, shiny black shoes, thinning hair.

Stretching small talk, mustering up the nerve to make a move, Boras' ride pulls up. He's not waiting on cab to the airport. A sleek, black Mercedes convertible rolls into the valet. Newport Beach is only an hour and a half up the coast with light traffic.

The moment is fleeting, but I meet it. I pull out my wallet, suggest we exchange cards, and shake Scott Boras' hand.

“Call my assistant,” he says.

He writes her name on the back of the card in blue ink: RACHEL—EXT.

149.

DETROIT, *December 19*—Still swinging for the fences, trying to find feature stories. A colleague passes along an email address for Justin Verlander’s parents. I message them, introducing myself.

“I’m writing to see if you could reach out to Justin and see if he would consider letting me spend some time with him this winter and sit in on a workout or bullpen to write a behind-the-scenes kind of story.

“His story is an important one to this year’s team and I’d like to share it with our readers.”

Verlander’s dad, Richard, responds.

“We’re happy to talk with you but any interviews with Justin should go through normal channels with the Tigers. Happy Holidays.”

Nice guy.

Verlander’s agent hasn’t answered my two introductory voicemails, the email I sent last week, or another call today about it.

Don’t even know what he looks like.

And I’m certainly not going around guessing anymore after what happened yesterday, when I walked up to an agent who I thought was another agent.

“Are you Nez Balelo?”

Whoever it was, the guy felt bad for me.

December 21—Haven’t smoked in forever when I go to my buddies to watch football tonight. A week after the winter meetings—15-day clean streak. No more.

It’s Christmas time and already dark outside when my phone lights up. *Unknown* is calling. I don’t answer *Unknown*, especially not with Internet Stalker following me around.

A couple minutes later, another call—*Unknown* again.

Sorry, man—you must have the right number, but I’m not biting.

Then I receive a text message from a 949 number.

“Anthony, this is Scott Boras. Give me a call.”

Remember: I’m high as a kite, through the roof, hovering a thousand feet in the air. I pick up the phone and Scott Boras is telling me to call him.

I ask one of my buddies to smack me. I scream each time and call Boras back.

He got my number from Dylan.

“Dylan Hernández,” Boras says. “A man of mystery.”

Boras is calling to chat about client Max Scherzer—five seasons with the Tigers, now a free agent. He’s greasing my wheels, working his angles.

Scherzer, 30, won the Cy Young Award two years ago and became one of baseball’s best pitchers in Detroit, a workhorse who logs 200-plus innings yearly. Still stunned I’m talking to Scott Boras; my early objective becomes clear—keep him on the phone as long as I can.

We talk for 26 minutes. I call Ball Writer Dylan Hernández for translation—Boras wants me to write something about the Tigers pursuing him, to stir up the market.

A couple days later, I write a column about how they should be aggressive in pursuing Scherzer. I push Boras’ agenda under the guise of my opinion. I’m being used. It feels good.

December 23—Enjoying my newfound access to Scott Boras perhaps a bit too much, I call him on my drive into the newsroom tonight. I ask when he’s going to get me in touch with Tigers owner Mike Ilitch.

“If you’re any good at your job, you would have gotten the number by now.”

I’m covering the Red Wings game. Ilitch, a multi-billionaire, owns the local National Hockey League team, too—an Original Six franchise. I stop in the newsroom for expenses and stroll a few blocks to Joe Louis Arena for the game.

In the media dining room, I spot longtime Red Wings general manager Ken Holland at a nearby table. Holland has been in charge since 1998.

Determined to prove my worth to Boras, I walk up to Holland and introduce myself. I ask if he can pass along Ilitch’s number. Sorry, but no. Worth a shot.

December 31—Today is my Mitch Albom Birthday. I am 27 years, 2 months and 12 days old today—exactly how old Albom was on August 5, 1985, the day he debuted as a sports columnist. We measure our careers in Mitch Time around here: From the moment you walk into the *Free Press* sports department, you are measured by the cardboard cutout of Mitch in the corner, holding up one finger, *Voted #1 sports columnist in the country—again!*

I am five years behind Mitch Time, but I remain undeterred. When I landed in Detroit after the winter meetings, I ran into University of Michigan football coach Jim Harbaugh at baggage claim and introduced myself as Anthony Fenech, future *Free Press* columnist.

Which leads to my latest big idea: In an effort to make up some time, what if I wrote a behind-the-scenes book of my rookie year on the beat? I could write about almost getting canceled by an Internet Stalker and getting blasted at the winter meetings and running into Scott Boras in the valet line.

I could even write about today.

With Internet Stalker's spotlight on my every move, I try to keep a low profile this New Year's Eve as opposed to going out partying. My buddy is having people over at his bungalow in the hills. "Nothing too big." A few guys I know from college, a couple guys I meet for the first time. Wives/fiancés/girlfriends, etc.

I have a few beers, because what's the difference between one and five when you're Ubering home? We smoke a joint on the deck in the back.

I'm sitting on the couch almost starting to trust people again when I hear angry commotion in the kitchen. My buddy taps me on the shoulder and says, "Fen, let's go talk outside."

Buddy: "So don't freak out but apparently one of the other guys—I don't know what he was thinking—but he tweeted at the troll guy, saying you were here, and..."

EXCLUSIVE: Fenech spotted at New Year's Eve party smoking weed, source says. Working on pics... NICE HIRE @Freep!!! #DontDrinkAndDrive

This is my life now.

WASHINGTON, *January 18, 2015*—Working from a standing desk inside Reagan Airport when news breaks of Max Scherzer's impending signing. It's a National Guy with the scoop—Scherzer to the Washington Nationals for seven years and \$210 million. In the past couple years, the term "mystery team" has been popularized—national insiders floating out unnamed teams to further a player's market value as a favor to the agent.

So, I chase down the mystery team—despite Dombrowski's insistence all winter, the Tigers were not a serious player to re-sign Scherzer.

I treat this two-alarm fire like a four. I text Dombrowski after I fasten my seatbelt on the plane, asking indirectly if they were the mystery team: "Was the team engaged in talks with Scherzer at the end?" He gets back to me while we taxi the runway—"No"—and I tweet it out while we hit the air.

The extra effort pays off: When I get onto Wi-Fi, I see that Ken Rosenthal retweeted me.

When I land, I pick my car up from short-term parking and I stop at my buddy's house to hang with him and his pops for a bit. We're watching late-nite TV when I get a tip, a direct message on Twitter from a guy who used to work with my mom and apparently knows one of the player's wives, who posted on

Facebook that longtime fan-favorite utilityman Don Kelly has signed with the Miami Marlins.

I know Kelly. I have his number. To my scoopin' surprise, he confirms it's true. I ask if I can use his name. Yep, to that, too. This is easy.

January 22—The team's annual winter caravan begins with a media free-for-all—players scattered around tables in the stadium's beer garden. The goal is to talk to as many guys as possible so you can skip the actual bus tour stops.

As a rookie beat writer, I'm trying to get face time with key figures like Justin Verlander, who, I'll admit, was my favorite player growing up. I wore a tan glove in high school because he did. Now, I've gotta flush all that and cover him like an unbiased reporter.

I haven't even started this job in earnest, but already in my young journalism career, I miss being a fan. Enjoying a baseball game. Rooting for players and having a favorite one.

Anyways, Verlander. He's a big car guy. Got a garage full of exotics—Aston Martins, Lamborghinis, Porsches, you name it. My car—a 2000 Ford Taurus with nearly 200,000 miles—died a couple days ago.

Breaking the ice, I ask Justin, "Are you pissed off?"

He's in a good mood. The boys are back in town. Baseball around the corner.

"Yeah, of course," he deadpans. "Are you?"

"Kinda. My car died."

What kind of car, he asks.

"A Taurus."

Verlander laughs.

"Dude!"

January 24—The frigid streets around the stadium are full of fans. They've come early, standing in double-file lines waiting for the doors to open. It's TigerFest—the team's annual winter fan event.

Today, I can properly receive my due credit for writing that killer feature on Víctor Martínez and his American family last year—I haven't seen Víctor since the story came out.

At TigerFest, an elevator door opens, and Víctor walks out. I say hi but Martínez pays no attention. He chuckles, continuing, and I can't believe this.

"Did you read the story?"

"Yeah," over his back shoulder. "It was shit."

ROOKIE YEAR

LAKELAND, Fla., *February 16*—Walk downstairs for breakfast and see Tigers chief legal counsel John Westhoff, sipping cereal and reading a newspaper. I smile. He nods knowingly from behind his glasses.

Today is the first day of school—pitchers and catchers reporting day.

February 23—At least one player has taken an early liking to me.

Miguel Cabrera arrived in camp today; he smacks my ass after the morning session.

Miggy looks away when I turn around and busts out laughing when I turn back.

February 24—Awakened by news that Joba Chamberlain has been spotted in TigerTown. This was reported by Ken Rosenthal on Twitter at 6:44 A.M.

It's been more than three months now and still I have few sources. PR, nothing. Dave Dombrowski, nothing. Today, I'll even bother Jim Leyland, who currently serves Dombrowski as a special assistant.

"Do you know anything about this Joba signing?"

"No."

During Chamberlain's return, as I offer my recorder into the scrum, I look past the player and lock onto a guy standing near the clubhouse entrance. The guy is talking to a pitcher I can't quite recognize. Backwards hat, baggy clothes and beams like a guy I should know—a guy who might know a thing or two.

I may have seen this guy once or twice earlier in the spring, but now it seems like I'm noticing him here every day. Afterwards, I make it a point to introduce myself and we vibe like I figured we would.

We exchange numbers. Of course he can get me some, just let him know. Introducing my new favorite friend—we'll call him Gator.

February 25—Big News out of camp: Brad Ausmus is on Twitter.

“Twenty-first century, gotta move on. Can’t be stuck in the stone age.”

Ausmus appears very much at ease. Last fall, a year after taking over this expensive roster, they sputtered in the playoffs, swept by Baltimore in the Division Series.

Ausmus was viewed as a managing wunderkind when Detroit hired him to succeed Jim Leyland after the 2013 season. Last year’s successes are considered the baseline around Tiger Town. Time is ticking. The Tigers have big names with big contracts—Cabrera, Verlander, Price, J.D. and Víctor Martínez.

Mike Ilitch is 85. His dying wish is for his beloved baseball team to win the World Series.

Ausmus’s daily briefings drip with dry wit. Lots of sarcasm and laughter.

“You’re not going to have a ghostwriter, are you?” someone asks.

Nope—everything will come straight from the source. He may use the platform to “refute articles written by media members.”

We get along fine, Brad and me. Today, these relations—the back-and-forth we’re starting to establish—are on full display.

“The message to the team—between you and the team, right?”

February 26—On the back fields, I get a text message from someone at MLB Network, asking if I have time to come on television today. I’ve never been on TV like this, and I’m certifiably nervous—so I take swigs of apple-flavored whiskey when I get back.

It is sweltering as I stand on camera—mid-eighties, and my right hand is sweating so much the microphone keeps slipping to the side. I stumble over words badly at least once, but overall, I survive. MLB Network... hey, now!

I go back into the clubhouse—shirt and tie and jacket and still sweating, scrambling for quotes. I apologize to one player for staying late to answer questions—catcher Alex Avila, whose dad, Al, is Detroit’s assistant general manager.

Soon enough, back field activities will conclude with a couple days of live batting practice. Future scout friends from opposing teams will start trickling in, starting their season-long coverage from this sea of gravel stones.

The team’s decision makers are always watching, always evaluating. Dave Dombrowski looks on from the tower above.

February 28—I see Sam Menzin the next day by his lonesome, looking preppy as ever. Shirt in, visor again, arms crossed.

We're the only two people around, watching nondescript prospects take batting practice.

I start Sam off slow—who are the hitters? He tells me.

I ask about some of baseball's top prospects. For my fantasy draft, I say. He clams up.

"Why not? They're not even on your team."

"Anthony, I can't," he says, and walks away.

March 18—Lounging around with the Tiger Beat at a picnic table outside the clubhouse. We're waiting for the manager to arrive for his media session when an unmistakable voice hollers out from above.

"Hey, Frenchy..."

Nobody calls me Frenchy except Leyland. He is on the balcony above, smoking a cigarette outside Dombrowski's office. Leyland is wearing shorts, shoes and no socks.

"Hey Frenchy. Looks like it's time for some new undies... whaddaya say, Frenchy?"

Even at 70, from that faraway view, can't get nothing past the ol' skipper. He can spot the big hole in the back of my boxers.

After the session, Leyland comes down to join us before today's workouts begin. Soon, the Most Popular Boy of Perrysburg, Ohio's 1962 senior class is holding court again.

March 20—The Opening Day starter is revealed.

Ausmus tabs David Price—not Verlander, snapping his seven-year streak of Opening Day starts.

Given his stellar 2014 and exemplary clubhouse leadership, Price is a worthy choice.

If Verlander's right arm is attached, he starts Opening Day—or so it was thought.

They've gotten on so well, I've tried coaxing them into co-starring for the season preview story.

I try Justin first.

He's non-committal.

Next time, I try them together.

"Golfing is our personal time. Plus, we don't golf that much, anyways."

They let me down easy.
“We’ll think about it.”

I hand a business card to both of ‘em. The answer will be the same as it’s ever been: No.

Onto Plan B I go—a profile piece on Dave Dombrowski.

Detroit enters 2015 as the four-time defending division champions. But even with all that, Dombrowski finds himself in a peculiar position—his contract expires after the year.

DUNEDIN, Fla., *March 27*—Panic at the ballpark when Justin Verlander leaves the game.

The team announces right triceps discomfort. Expected to make next start. Afterwards, he chalks it up as no biggie and wonders if it wasn’t the coffee he drank before.

Verlander won’t make his next start—he doesn’t pitch again until June.

LAKELAND, Fla., *March 28*—I arrive early and take up surveillance. One eye on Verlander’s locker at all times.

When he shows up, I give it a second or two—then pounce.

How’s he’s feeling?

“Can you let me get dressed?”

CLEARWATER, Fla., *March 29*—Standing in the hallway when head trainer Kevin Rand calls me over.

“Can I offer you some advice?”

When a player is coming into the clubhouse, especially if they’re dealing with an injury, don’t walk up to them right away with questions about it.

I just knew a potential injury was a big deal, and I didn’t want to get beat on it.

“I’m not trying to be mean about it. I’m just looking out for you.”

LAKELAND, Fla., *April 3*—In the chaotic aftermath of the spring finale, with attendants and staffers and players ready for departure—opportunity knocks me over while collecting postgame quotes.

Careening out of the coaches' room, assistant GM Al Avila bowls into me while texting.

I try to use it to my advantage.

"I've been meaning to ask you. Can I get your number?"

"You better not bother me."

OPENING DAY

DETROIT, *April 6*—You only cover your first Opening Day one time.

Driving to the ballpark in the fast lane, a car speeds up from behind—black, fancy and fast. I move over and let the car pass.

It's Opening Day—a local holiday—and not too bad. Forty-two degrees and cloudy. Dressed dangerously, wearing a navy-blue jacket with a baby blue shirt. Gray slacks and brown wingtips.

Standing in the clubhouse before the game, Justin Verlander walks by. I ask if he was driving a fast black car this morning. He was, indeed. What kind? An Aston Martin. "I think you passed me on the freeway."

"Probably."

He asks what kind of car I drive.

My tongue twists. I say I drive a Ford Focus.

Miguel Cabrera sits at his locker in the clubhouse, eyeing me pregame. He looks at Ron Colangelo, points at me, "I like this guy. Look at him, he dresses nice."

* * *

EMBARRASSING FLASHBACK

DETROIT, *April 5, 2013*—Opening Day, my first game as a member of the Baseball Writers' Association of America. After the Tigers beat the Yankees, I head to the visitor's clubhouse—the quiet, losing side.

The New York media surrounds lefty reliever Boone Logan. Poking a tape recorder into a pack of reporters, the Taylor Swift Pandora on my phone goes off.

It's the pop-guitar riff from her latest hit song "I Knew You Were Trouble."

Once upon a time...

Clawing furiously at my pocket, trying to pull my phone out, to silence it. To stop this nightmare.

A few mistakes ago...

Pressing power, squeezing the phone, turning red as a light.

Afterwards, veteran outfielder Vernon Wells lets me know.

“My nine-year-old daughter listens to that, man.”

Players laugh. Reporters, too. It’s my first game as a Ball Writer—I don’t know how I’ll recover from this.

* * *

PITTSBURGH, *April 13, 2015*—First away series and I’m road tripping with my buddy on the Ohio Turnpike. We’re staying at the team hotel.

Sports editor says it’s fine to stay there, but not at the team rate. He doesn’t want the *Freeep* taking favors from the team.

The first night, we go to dinner at Hyde Park. The ‘Tigers’ coaching staff is in the back room having dinner.

Brad Ausmus is first.

“How ya doing, Anthony?” A pat on the back. Buddy is impressed.

We go up to Mt. Washington for a couple of beers. We’re still that high when we get back to the team hotel and run into players waiting at the elevator bank.

April 15—At the park early today, where Justin Verlander is throwing a simulated game—he’s even simulating the national anthem, standing with his hat over his heart.

Today is also Jackie Robinson Day.

We talk to David Price about the dwindling number of black players in MLB. Price believes we’re only here talking to him about it because it’s Jackie Robinson Day.

“Won’t hear about this again until next year.”

He’s not wrong.

DETROIT, *April 22*—Joe Nathan is injured again.

Pitching an injury rehab outing at Triple-A tonight, Nathan throws only 10 pitches before exiting the game. The team holds off on providing an update until tomorrow—never a good sign.

Ever the rookie, I ask another stupid question.

“Can I text him asking, ‘What happened?’ or is that like, insensitive to the situation?”

Marly Rivera explains: “No, the opposite—text him and ask him how he is feeling. It’s not insensitive—you ask like you do care. Be open about it, something like, ‘Heard you had to leave your rehab start’—then ask him how he feels.”

Nathan doesn’t respond.

April 23—Nathan’s season is over—he’s set to undergo elbow ligament reconstruction. Speaking red-eyed in front of reporters, Nathan describes the elbow “pop” he felt on his final pitch last night and defiantly declares he’ll be back.

“This won’t be easy. It’s gonna be a long road. I’ve always enjoyed the work...”

His voice cracks.

“I will rehab and do everything I’m supposed to as if I’m coming back to be a major league pitcher. That is my goal—to come back and pitch again.”

Back in the press box, I receive a call from Scott Boras. I step outside to call back. He wants to talk about Rafael Soriano. Boras is calling by way of Nathan’s injury, with a scoop: Detroit has interest in Soriano.

Get something from the team—in case Boras is using me again.

“I heard you guys are talking with Soriano, is that true?”

Director of baseball operations Mike Smith puts a stop to further inquiries: “I’m never going to be able to confirm or deny rumors like this for you, sorry.”

The other source—Al Avila—hasn’t responded.

Back in the press box, I write three stories: A game story, a sidebar on Nathan’s injury and an opinion piece about why it would be wise to pursue Soriano—a favor for Scott Boras.

OAKLAND, Calif., *May 27*—The best part about Gator’s friendship is his bead on the room.

About one player. “He’s soft. Got a Charley horse on his thigh and he’s been out for a week. A lot of guys have been upset with him.”

He says the Tigers might go with a spot starter. Probable pitcher Kyle Ryan remains in transit.

Gator again. “I heard Ryan just showed up.”

He’s standing at his locker when the door opens.

After the game, I meet visiting New York writers for a drink, including George King of the *New York Post*. John Lowe regales stories of King on the beat.

“One year, the Yankees played in the Boston Marathon game (traditionally played at 11 A.M.) on Patriots’ Day Monday. But, of course, ESPN wants *Sunday Night Baseball* the night before. So, it’s Red Sox-Yankees at 8 P.M. on Sunday

night, so that means the Yankees open at 7:30 Monday morning. And Joe Torre got there at 7:25 and George is standing there, waiting for the clubhouse to open at 7:30, and Torre says, ‘What are you doing here this early?’ And George says, ‘My job is to be here when that door opens.’”

He spends at least three hours on the phone every day. No, George King is actually *on the phone*, talking to people.

Ball Writing rules to live by.

DETROIT, *July 2*—Halfway through my rookie year, my best source isn’t in the front office, the clubhouse or the press box. I have yet to figure out what Gator does for a living or why he hangs out with baseball players—but I don’t particularly care.

He’s at his friend’s place drinking beers today, asking about the vibe in the room.

Gator is my best source. With the team at .500 (39-39) and slipping in the standings, roster moves are afoot. Ausmus gives reporters a hint—a reliever is coming up.

My source network is finally paying off.

Last month, I started squeezing information out of Ángel Nesbitt, a young Venezuelan reliever.

I kept in touch, and soon, he was tipping me off with roster moves.

Gator and I work as a tag team: I text my guy and Gator texts his guys.

Neither of my two tries—assistant GM Al Avila and the farm director—get back to me. Soon, the clubhouse will open to the media, and the remaining roster moves in question officially announced.

Waiting to hear back, I am beaten by a blogger. The news blindsides Gator, triggering a flurry of texts: Reliever Joba Chamberlain is being sent out.

Gator is on Line 1. A different player just called, and yep, Joba Chamberlain is gone. Tom Gorzelanny, too.

It was a better day for the beat writer. I got four-of-six roster moves. But my scoops amount to second-hand rumors—if I don’t find some real sources, I’m bound to get burned.

SEATTLE, *July 6*—Standing in the dugout hours before the game, I see Lloyd McClendon sitting alone in the home dugout.

I walk over and introduce myself.

McClendon is the Mariners manager. He was hired in 2014 after spending the previous seven years on the Tigers’ coaching staff. McClendon was on the

short list to succeed Jim Leyland, before Brad Ausmus blew the front office away with his interview.

Lloyd came here instead, and last season led the Mariners to an 87-75 record, within two games of their first postseason appearance in 13 years. This year, the M's are injured and below .500.

Taking my temperature, I sense he's open to talking.

I catch his attention by offering an unsolicited opinion on the Tigers' clubhouse leadership.

McClendon chuckles. Shakes his head. He hears about it. Anyone could've seen this coming.

"Those guys need a man in there," he says. "Victor, Miggy... those guys are not easy to deal with."

July 7—Ian Kinsler is talking about the time he met Seamhead.

It was after the 15-inning All-Star Game in 2008, the final year at Old Yankee Stadium. After all that, John Lowe came up to him in the clubhouse and pointed out something of historical significance about the game.

"John's cool as hell, man," Kinsler says. "I just listen to him, really... John's intelligent—he knows a lot about baseball."

John was a Detroit writer, Kinsler a Texas second baseman—the two teams played each other twice each year.

But in those years, with maybe just one chat a year, they built a rapport that paid big dividends when Kinsler was acquired by the Tigers in 2014. I was working on the web desk that night and I remember Mr. Sports Editor walking out of his office not 20 minutes after Seamhead broke the news: "John got Kinsler! John got Kinsler!"

Kinsler was on vacation in Hawaii. He just found out he got traded from Texas, where he was viewed as a franchise player. He spoke with John Lowe.

July 8—I sit in the dugout today with J.D. Martinez for a feature story to chronicle his breakout year. I'll call him the Mysterious Hitting Guru.

J.D. says he doesn't want to say anything about him until he gets paid and doesn't want to rub his hitting coaches the wrong way by potentially giving someone else credit for his success.

He didn't explicitly say do not talk to this guy.

I am equal parts inexperienced and undeterred. Before taking off in Seattle, I ask one of Boras' guys about the Mysterious Hitting Guru.

"Ask Scott... see if he's got any ideas."

By the time I land in Minneapolis, the search is over.
 “Scott said try Craig Wallenbrock.”

MINNEAPOLIS, *July 9*—I got through to Wallenbrock and gave him the spiel. Feature story on J.D. I’ll conceal your identity—the Mysterious Hitting Guru.

He gives no promises, but says he’ll talk to Martinez. Up to him. I was actually feeling pretty good about it until I got to the stadium and was summoned for a chat with Tigers PR.

Now I’ve got a disgruntled subject, and the story is up in the air.

“J.D. doesn’t want to talk to you,” media relations manager Aileen Villarreal said. “He told you not to talk to that guy.”

Yes, I understand. But I’m a journalist: talking to people who others don’t want us talking to is part of the job.

Martinez sits down to finish the interview but doesn’t change his tune.

“I still think it’s bullshit.”

We agree to disagree.

Back inside the clubhouse, more beef. This time, it’s David Price—a team leader—who corners me in front of the doors to the dressing room, asking what I did to Tigers PR. Why the argument? What did I say?

Price towers over me, pointing a finger at my chest.

“What did you say to her?”

“Honestly, man, that’s none of your business. It’s between me and her.”

July 10—Tigers lead Twins, 6-1. Bottom of the ninth.

Forty-eight hours until the All-Star break and the Tigers still don’t know who they are. A winning team? Contender? Third place? They have struggled to stay above .500 all season. Flaws are obvious—unathletic roster, one-dimensional offense, subpar defense—but the team’s biggest hole remains in the bullpen.

As the Royals showed last year, riding a three-headed monster of late-inning relievers within a win of the World Series, baseball has begun prioritizing bullpen usage.

Tonight, they’re up five runs with three outs to go.

By the time they get the first, activity in the press box: Writers clawing at keyboards. Two men on. A hit. Pitching change. Walk. Another hit. Type-typetypetype

What seemed excessive mere minutes ago—rewriting the lede, reworking the game story, reading bottom-to-top for stray mentions of the wrong score—is now necessary.

Now, as the final pitch is hit into the left field seats, the stories we're scrambling to rewrite are very different. Somehow, the Tigers lose.

Back in the press box, the TV is on mute.

Martinez says on TBS that Detroit is signing veteran reliever Neftali Feliz.

One colleague has had enough: "Fuck this job."

I leave the press box past 11. As if the drama and the game and the postgame signing wasn't enough fun, I still have the feature story I haven't started.

I meet up with scouts at the bar instead. A drink turns into three and I end up doing it the old-fashioned way, staying up all bloody night on coffee and tobacco.

The sun comes up. Day game today.

July 11—In the first inning, straight out of the *You Couldn't Make This Up If You Tried* files, disaster is coming.

J.D. Martinez just fouled off a pitch.

It is fast approaching, upwards of 85 mph, spinning like a programmed missile. It is a sneak attack, a foul ball I never see coming, not until it—*SMACK!*—makes a direct hit, causing a first-row explosion of Mountain Dew and popcorn.

The crowd gasps. Pop everywhere, popcorn all over the carpet. My computer is a casualty, screen spider-webbed, currently sitting in a box of rice.

On FOX Sports 1: "If you're wondering what the crowd was reacting to—that ball went into the press box, and I believe it was Anthony Fenech from the *Free Press* on the Tigers beat who had the bad end of that ball.

"I don't know if he caught it or not. I don't know if it knocked him down. He isn't in his seat anymore—he has since left the third row. So, I guess we'll find out soon enough."

Dave Dombrowski passes me in the hallway.

"I heard J.D. was upset with you."

After the game, I try and fail at lobbying J.D. to buy me a new laptop.

"That's what you get, bro."

DETROIT, *July 17*—Back from the All-Star break, I get an email from a guy with the Christopher "Mad Dog" Russo radio show, asking for availability to talk Tigers.

Soon, I'll be on SiriusXM Channel 144 with the Mad Dog—one of the most notorious loudmouths on the national sports talk scene.

But as the interview wears on, things get weird.

“I’m also reading that you got drunk and ran your car into another, into a PT Cruiser, is that correct, and flipped it over. I mean, how do you flip—Anthony, how do you flip a PT Cruiser? Is that true?”

My jaw drops. I am on satellite radio with Mad Dog, and he just hit me with that?

Hanging up, I realize I’ve been hood-winked. It won’t take long for Internet Stalker’s sports media terrorist group to claim responsibility. Apparently, I was speaking with someone named Sour Shoes from the Howard Stern Show. The prank call is on the Internet now.

July 19—Redemption is mine. A week after I got punk’d by Internet Stalker, I get an email from an ESPN producer, inviting me onto *SportsCenter* today.

No, it’s not another prank. Email address checked out; I found the producer on LinkedIn.

At a studio downtown, I sit in front of a color canvas of the Detroit skyline. I have the producer snap a picture so I can show my grandkids one day. *SportsCenter*!

TRADE DEADLINE

ST. PETERSBURG, Fla., *July 27*—It's raining when we land. I get a taxi and check into my room at a Hampton Inn, way too far from Tropicana Field.

Only positive of the place is they've got a shuttle to downtown St. Pete, where the dome is located. While waiting for the van, I scroll past a ruckus on Twitter—Tigers outfielder Rajai Davis has followed a bunch of St. Louis Cardinals accounts.

Someone notices. Davis' activity raises a red flag and gains traction on social media. Is Davis involved in a trade?

I treat this Internet Rumor like any dogged reporter would. I chase it down, emailing the Cardinals GM: "There is some buzz about Rajai Davis—he apparently followed a few Cardinals-related accounts. If there is anything to this, let me know."

When the clubhouse opens today, reporters quickly approach Davis' locker. With his back turned, he can't keep it together—he starts laughing and so do teammates nearby.

Well, they got me bad. I never followed up with Mozeliak after that. My fate was sealed as the guy who fell for the Rajai Davis Internet Rumor.

They lose the first two games—the bullpen taking the loss both times. Heading into the series, I had written they should "buy" at the trade deadline. After last night's walk-off loss, I wrote that they should "sell." Now, I'm getting torched online—they're calling me Flip-Floppin' Fen.

July 29—They avoid the sweep with a win on Getaway Day. In the clubhouse afterwards—two days until the trade deadline—the players try to put a positive spin on things. Verlander hopes his performance (8 innings, 1 run, 10 strikeouts) helps the front office believe there's a chance. I linger after the scrum and comment on his suede jacket, trying to get on his good side.

"Nice jacket."

"Thanks."

Leaving the clubhouse, we walk past Dave Dombrowski.

The veteran of the crew, Lynn Henning of the *Detroit News* stops Dombrowski to ask if he has a reaction to tonight's Twitter report, which says the Tigers are selling.

"I don't, no."

Waiting for the press elevator to arrive, Aileen tells the writers to come back.

"Dave is going to talk."

Dombrowski now has something to say: "We are going to be prepared to listen to offers on our players."

I start by rushing up to the press box and tweeting out Dombrowski's quotes. Then I have to write up a story about that and rewrite the game story—and I gotta do it by 5 P.M. at the latest because I have a 7:20 flight to Baltimore.

BALTIMORE, *July 30*—News breaks that the Tigers' fire sale has begun: They are trading David Price to the Toronto Blue Jays, according to a National Guy. It was an hour late, but any kind of confirmation feels like a win.

PR tells the writers to meet in the ballroom of the downtown Baltimore hotel they're staying in—Dave Dombrowski is going to talk at 3 P.M.

In exchange for Price, who will hit free agency this offseason, they received a package of three pitching prospects.

"It makes a big difference if you can get players who are close to the big leagues and ready to contribute. We're rebooting, not rebuilding, so you can go into next year and identify on the free agent and trade market what you want to pursue to still be really good."

I ask Dombrowski if, after years of buying at the trade deadline, it's "fun" to sell for a change.

"I wouldn't use the word 'fun.' It's a situation where you never want to be in a spot where you're doing what we're doing. I would much rather be acquiring than I would be trading. But it's just where we are at this point."

Across the harbor at the ballpark, David Price is packing up his stuff. Price, 29, has posted stellar numbers once again this season (9-4, 2.53 ERA). After Tampa Bay traded him, this time isn't nearly as tough.

"I think everybody kind of envisions themselves playing for one team their entire career. That's not the way it happens."

Asked to sum up his time in Detroit: "It was fun. The city took me in very well."

Before Price makes his exit, I approach him to say good luck.

He throws on a backpack, hops on a bicycle and heads to Toronto.

July 31—It's the trade deadline. Detroit still has one player they'd like to move: Yoenis Céspedes.

I shared one meaningful moment with Céspedes, running into him at Bonefish Grill in spring training. I nodded and he had no idea who I was.

When the clubhouse opens, the trade deadline clock ticks down to 4. Rumors swirl. They have been posting the lineup card outside the locker room, in the tunnel heading to the dugout.

Knowing my target and sensing nobody else does, I disappear into the tunnel and find the lineup card.

Céspedes is currently on it, playing left field and hitting fifth. I tweet out the news, walk back inside and watch as the others look in vain for the card.

Back in the clubhouse, there's breaking news on Twitter: The New York Mets are close to acquiring Céspedes from the Tigers. I have but one In The Room source I've made progress with—and I put the pressure on. With the deal already reported on Twitter, I try for a small piece of the pie.

The Tigers' return for the star has yet to be reported and fans are wondering if prized pitching prospect Zack Wheeler, currently rehabbing from elbow surgery, is involved.

"Is Wheeler in the deal?"

I pester. "Come on, give me something."

"No."

I tweet it out. It's all the news I'll break at the deadline, but at least it's something.

WASHINGTON, *August 3*—I take the train from Baltimore after today's series finale to see my little brother in D.C. for the day.

I'm writing a column for tomorrow's paper, saying Dave Dombrowski should receive a contract extension. It expires at year's end. My argument: You can't find a better general manager than Dombrowski, and he's already made trades with an eye for the future. I feel a pull to phone Dombrowski, but I don't. I don't want to bug him.

DETROIT, *August 4*—I see a newsstand in the airport, today's *Free Press* and the banner on Page 1A. JOB 1: EXTEND DOMBROWSKI. Underneath: KEEPING TIGERS GM IS CRUCIAL TO REBOOTING, REJUVENATING THE TEAM—ANTHONY FENECH, 1B

I go straight to the stadium. The press box is empty—everyone's downstairs, waiting for the clubhouse to open in a few minutes.

When I grab my notebook and recorder, out of the corner of my eye, I notice that Dombrowski is on the field, calling for his son. Landon, 14, is running in from center field.

Ball Writers, columnists, sports radio reporters, cameras and anchors for each of Detroit's TV stations are waiting outside.

I don't wait with them—I head for the tunnel behind home plate, a quiet place for my radio interview. After the radio hit, I spot Gene Mato, Aníbal Sánchez's agent, and say hello.

"I'm surprised Dombrowski did it. I didn't think he would sell. The team seems on edge."

I'm late: "Gotta get in there. I'll be in touch."

Past 3:30 and the clubhouse must be open by now, so I take the back way. Through the dugout, up the stairs and past a player. I open the double doors, see a lineup card taped on the back, and that's when I hear PR.

"Anthony, no!" It's Aileen Villarreal from down the hall. "The clubhouse is closed."

I'm confused.

"So, when is Brad talking?"

"We'll let you know."

Outside clubhouse walls, reporters are restless. I share my inside view: "I was just in there. They were freaking out, telling me to get out, that the clubhouse was closed."

Bernie Smilovitz pulls me aside. The longtime Channel 4 sports anchor thought my column today was spot on. In fact, he talked with Dave Dombrowski at a charity event last night.

"I wanted to ask him about his contract. I said, 'Hey, what's going on with your stuff?' He was dodgy about it. He said, 'Everything will work out, all right?' I've known Dave for years. I haven't seen him like that. He just seemed off."

I reach out to my two sources, again and again.

"The clubhouse is still closed. Seems like something is up."

Not until Landon Dombrowski walks out do we know what. Landon is in tears, consoled by his father, Dave, who has been fired after nearly 14 years as general manager of the Tigers.

The press release hits everyone's phones.

Dave Dombrowski is gone. Al Avila promoted to general manager. Presser soon.

Avila has worked under Dombrowski since joining Detroit. He's been next-in-line, the highest-paid assistant general manager, and up for other top jobs. Now, Avila finally has the keys. He received the good news at a car dealership, while returning a lease.

The news isn't as good for me. Avila has answered exactly none of seven messages since we exchanged numbers in spring training. What else would you

expect from a guy who has worked under Dave Dombrowski for the past quarter-century.

His first move is to lock up the front office. Many receive new contracts; some, like Sam Menzin, get promotions: Menzin is now the Tigers' pro scouting director.

We're standing in line together for the last pork chops in the pan.

I congratulate him on the new job.

"Now that you're promoted, here's my card."

Before I can pull it out, Sam says no, recoiling at the business card in fear.

"I can't take that. I don't speak to the media."

Mhmmm. That's what they all say.

Avila's terms have leaked. Five-year deal, according to my competitor two seats down.

I have nothing. Not even Gator can save me.

"It's being reported that your deal is five years after this one, is that true?" I text Avila.

"Yes."

"Thanks. Just wanted to say congrats. So, congrats."

"I appreciate it. I am sure we will work well together."

ROUND ROCK, Texas, *August 13*—I fly to Texas a day before the Tigers, taking a pit stop in suburban Austin to spend the afternoon at Seamhead's retirement digs.

Seamhead is a Churchill enthusiast. He introduced me to him years ago.

On the TV, a recent documentary on Buck Showalter's baseball life is paused.

We watch portions of that show, and John shares his favorite Showalter stories.

Grabbing lunch at the world-renowned Salt Lick BBQ, he gives this piece of advice while I wolf down mac and cheese: He suggests I place a call to Dave Dombrowski.

John notes Dombrowski's stature in baseball. It's an opportunity to further your working relationship with a personal touch—after years of calling this person for information, now you are reaching out in non-transactional fashion.

Hitting the road to Houston, I heed Seamhead's advice and call Dave. Just calling to check in. See how you're doing. We chit-chat for five minutes, rekindling our relationship.

"Thanks for the call, Anthony."

"I'll keep in touch, Dave."

HOUSTON, *August 15*—It's my first free continental breakfast as a Hilton Honors Gold Member. I pick up a copy of the *Houston Chronicle*.

At the park, I introduce myself to Matt Boyd, one of the pitchers received in return for David Price, and I pick marijuana as common ground. I break the ice talking about my favorite place—Uncle Ike's Pot Shop.

Boyd doesn't give much of a reaction, but later he tells Tigers PR.

I don't find this out until the offseason.

Apparently, it made Boyd uncomfortable.

In retrospect, it was an unnecessary icebreaker. But I am who I am, and Matthew Boyd is who he is—someone I'll come to learn has never smoked weed in his life.

CHICAGO, *August 18*—First time at historic Wrigley Field.

The second-oldest stadium in baseball has no air-conditioning in the press box, which is the smallest in baseball. There is one elevator, way out in left field. At Wrigley, we fight crowds walking down from the press box to the clubhouses.

In the opener of a two-game set against the Chicago Cubs, the wind blows out to left field, toward Lake Michigan. There have been twice as many home runs (4) as innings played (2) when Big News drops from Boston. Dave Dombrowski has a new job.

A couple innings later, I scurry out of the press box—Dombrowski is calling. I scribble quotes from the Red Sox president on the back of a print-out scorecard.

KANSAS CITY, Mo., *September 1*—Introducing the Tiger Beat—the handful of reporters who cover the team daily. There's Rival Cohort Chris McCosky (*Detroit News*), Jason Beck from MLB.com, James Schmehl from MLive.com and most recently, Katie Strang from ESPN.com.

Strang joined us last month, moving from the National Hockey League beat to baseball. She comes to the party with 75,000 Twitter followers. I only have 7,329.

We went out for beers downtown last night. It was fun. But Katie is good at her job, and I'm not thrilled with that, to be honest.

September 2—I am starting to build a relationship with Royals players.

Early in the year, I bugged Víctor Martínez to introduce me to catcher Salvador Pérez—one of my favorite players. One day, I saw them on the field talking, hovering closer and closer until Víctor had to introduce me.

After talking with Salvy, I re-introduce myself to veteran outfielder Jonny Gomes.

“I got a story for you...”

Back in 2013, I was sent to help cover Game 5 of the American League Championship Series. I loitered in the empty Boston dugout with Gomes and teammate Shane Victorino when Gomes put a fat wad of chew into his cheek. He looked at me, holding the pouch: “You want one?”

By now, you know I’m not one to say no. So, I grabbed a pinch, stuffed it in my cheek and started slowly chewing it into place. As I did this, a mega-sized postseason media throng gathered in the dugout for interviews.

I felt the tobacco spread, quickly pooling on the floor of my mouth, leaking down my throat—and I felt a buzz. I remember I saw them walking out of the tunnel as the buzz intensified. There was way too much juice in my mouth. I needed to spit—but where?

Split seconds before barfing on the dugout steps in front of everyone, I jumped out of my seat, grabbed a cup off the Gatorade cart and spit as controlled as I could into the cup. I plucked the rest of the chew from my mouth and flicked it into the trash. Couldn’t find a napkin to wipe my fingers, so I wiped them on my pants instead.

“I was literally about to puke out there.”

Gomes is laughing.

FIRE DRILL

DETROIT, *September 10*—A code green Thursday night. Watching the NFL season opener with pizza and friends on my off day. My trusty sidekick George Sipple is with the last-place Tigers in Cleveland.

Sipple has served as the sports department's do-it-all reporter for 20 years. George primarily covers baseball, pro and college hockey. He's been at the *Free Press* since 1995, starting on the Prep Crew. He also covers auto racing, colleges, everything.

It's a baseball-free night. When I check it next, there is a list of missed messages:

11:08 P.M.— “Is Al on the trip?... Did you see the assistant sports editor's email? A person at Channel 4 thinks Ilitch might have told Bernie about Ausmus being done at the end of the year... You watching???”

Apparently, while I wasn't, Bernie Smilovitz promoted an exclusive report during the break. “A major change is on the way for the Tigers. Tune into *Local 4 News* after the game.”

I reach out to a friend who works at the station. The exclusive report? Brad Ausmus is out after the season—Bernie was at ownership's annual charity golf classic earlier in the week.

Code green is now bright red—a five-alarm fire.

11:27 P.M.—Someone passes along the phone number for a well-connected source. It's a guy who's In The Room, but nobody really knows what he does. I've never met him, so I call Ausmus instead.

I text PR and Dodgers beat writer Dylan Hernández, who says he'll call back—he's putting his kids to sleep.

“What do I do?”

11:52 P.M.—I call Brad. No answer.

“I hate to reach out about this. Have you been told anything about this report?”

“I heard about it.”

“Have you been told anything about your future?”

“I don't really have a comment on my future.”

Frantically texting folks In The Room: “We are about to report that Brad is out at the end of next season. If there is anything you want to let me know, please do.”

Assistant GM David Chadd responds: “Not true.”

I relay the denial to the desk, but the source is already approved. A story is posted, matching Bernie’s report. According to the two largest news sites in Michigan, Ausmus is out.

12:38 A.M.—Dylan Hernández suggests I call Scott Boras, because “Boras knows everything that’s going on.” It’s not even 10 P.M. out west. Boras tells me he hasn’t heard anything, but it certainly wouldn’t surprise him.

I’m assigned a next-day story—who’s up next? It’s on Freep.com by last call. FENECH—AUSMUS OUT, SO TIGERS SHOULD LOOK AT GARDENHIRE.

Yup, Ausmus is out. Or is he?

Myers tells me to cancel my weekend plans: “I need you to be in Cleveland tomorrow.”

CLEVELAND, *September 11*—At Progressive Field the next day in time for Ausmus’ pregame media session. Ausmus isn’t out: He’s being peppered with questions from reporters.

Did that report sting you? Did it surprise you that it came out... angry even?

“Not really.”

Is it awkward?

“Not really... For who?”

For you?

“Not really.”

What’s been the most trying part of this year, Brad, for you?

Ausmus never loses his quip.

“You.”

ARLINGTON, Texas, *September 27*—Sweating out the final week of the season. Six to go.

I’m writing about catcher Alex Avila, who is a free agent this off-season.

The story about Alex is a positive piece—about his lifetime ties to the organization, from son of the assistant GM to starting catcher. We talked last weekend. He reached out afterward, asking if he could read the story before it goes out.

This is a big no-no—against the Journalism Ethics we live by. But the world we live in is nothing if not gray...

“I really shouldn’t.”

But I do.

He doesn’t take any editing liberties. He thanks me for writing it.

September 29—I’m issued the final challenge of my rookie year.

It comes from Nick Cotsonika, temporarily a *Free Press* editor between stops in his sports writing career. I grew up reading Cotsonika in the sports section—he covered the Lions, Red Wings, and Michigan football beats.

He calls to suggest a story on Justin Verlander’s rebirth.

“See if he’ll talk.”

Barely crawling to the finish line, but I can’t say no to Nick Cotsonika. I wait until Justin is alone and ask for a couple minutes.

After a down season in 2014 while dealing with the after-effects of core muscle surgery, Verlander’s rebound has been a relief for everybody. His second-half resurgence spiked when he took a no-hitter into the ninth against the Angels, just like old times. “Obviously, luck always has to be a little bit on your side,” he said.

As it is for me today. Justin is in a good mood.

“Two minutes?”

“Yeah.”

“Like, literally two minutes? Your rules, not mine.”

He’s sitting at his locker, legs crossed, shorts and flip flops.

Honestly, I was hoping for more than two. This story was for the Sunday Paper. But I know beggars can’t be choosers, and if I’m not true to my word...

“Maybe like five minutes?”

“Oh, okay. Now it’s five minutes. Next, it’s gonna be ten minutes.”

Justin is in a very good mood. Of course, he’s got some time.

When five minutes pass, I let him know.

CHICAGO, *October 4*—On the final day of the season I wake up and run 10 miles.

I’m already in the clubhouse when Justin arrives at his locker.

“About time you wrote a good story, Anthony.”

“Every now and then, I get lucky.”

It is the first time Verlander addresses me by name.

Detroit wins its last game but finishes a disappointing 74-87. Their streak of four straight division titles stopped in last place.

The season may be over, but back out in the clubhouse, there's still work to be done. In this last scene with players, coaches and anyone else, I gather as many phone numbers as I can.

Some of them ask, *Why?* "In case anything happens, and I need to get ahold of you."

Why would you need to get ahold of me? "Like, a trade or something like that..."

What if I don't want you to get ahold of me?

Time is of the essence—the clubhouse will only be open for so long. And when it's closed, it doesn't open again until spring training. I quickly make my way around. A couple veteran players cough up their number easily. In busy-bee mode, I walk up to J.D. Martinez, failing to anticipate the towel he's just dropped.

"What the hell, man? Right now? Really?"

Martinez gives me his number.

I decide against asking Verlander for his number. I walk up to him—good meeting you this year, good handshake.

"You, too, Anthony."

"Oh... Do you think I can get your agent's cell phone number?"

He pulls out his phone and gives it to me, which is great—I've been calling this guy's office for months, and he hasn't answered one message.

This exchange draws schoolyard attention. A competitor eyes me. He comes too close and says, "Did he just give you his number?" I turn the other way to avoid him, in case Verlander is watching. He's buried in his locker, gathering his belongings, which now include a pair of Miguel Cabrera's batting gloves.

Miggy gifted them after last night's game, when he went 3-for-4 with a home run to clinch the AL batting title. Cabrera hit .338 for his fourth batting title in five seasons.

I say so long to the batting champ. He nods back.

Lingering in the clubhouse to see who I've missed, I feel a lump building in my throat. It's not the phone numbers and email addresses scribbled in my spiral—it's the years' worth of work that went into building the trust to get them.

With nearly everyone checked off my list, I try to find Víctor Martínez. Even as he struggled this year, Martínez's locker space was always open, a safe haven for a rookie Ball Writer. Martínez hit a career-low .245 with a shell of yesteryear's power.

With Big Víctor nowhere to be seen, I ask Little Víctor.

"He's in the back. He's not feeling good."

I ask if he can tell his dad I said thank you for the help this year. I give him a fist bump—see you next year.

"See ya, Anthony."

Walking out of the clubhouse, I bubble with proud emotion. I pull into the restroom and put myself together. It was a long year. A hard year.

I write slowly, last out of the press box. I take the stairs and walk the concourse, staying in the last moments of my rookie year as long as I can.

BOCA RATON, Fla., *November 9*—Welcome to the offseason.

It begins unofficially this week at the general managers meetings, held annually at resorts in warm-weather locales.

The offseason is the sowing season: It is where relationships are founded and strengthened with pure persistence; where the biggest scoops are had with free agent signings, trades and rumors, where all the hard work is put to test when news breaks at a moment's notice.

This year's events unfold at the Boca Raton Resort & Beach Club Spa. The place exudes elegance: A bronze statue of a woman called "Infanta Margarita" welcomes high-paid executives, agents and reporters, many of them chauffeured to the front of the palm-lined roundabout. I arrive in a rental car.

A potpourri of people strolls through the marble-floored lobby. Others lounge on the couch or linger in the corner.

This is my focus. I'm soon sitting on a couch with Dylan Hernández from the *Los Angeles Times* and a couple of other writers. Shown to the masses, Dylan shares with me his screen, featuring an all-too-familiar troll: "Did Fenech crash a car today? Horrible acne. Try Proactive, you tool!"

Everyone wants to know: "Who is this Internet Stalker guy?"

I am enjoying an advantage as the only local beat reporter in attendance—I cannot shake the satisfying thought of Rival Cohort slamming his keyboard in frustration when he finds out.

Mostly, I try to talk with agents. With more experience comes more confidence, more knowledge. By the end of the week, I'm borderline brash. One sun-soaked afternoon, standing on a pier overlooking Lake Boca Raton, I correctly identify the guy nearby as an agent—sport jacket, shirt unbuttoned, sunglasses—and strike up an introduction. I'm Anthony Fenech with the *Detroit Free Press*. He's Nick Chanock, with Wasserman. "It's my first year, but I don't want to do this forever... I want to do something bigger. *Really* write, you know?"

Chanock's gotta go. Gives me his number. We'll keep in touch.

I meet an executive from Milwaukee and am pointed in the direction of a pot-bellied, bald man with glasses and a Southern accent. His name is Mike Russell, and apparently, it's my lucky day. Rumor has Russell leaving Arizona to return to the Tigers as a special assistant.

The rumor is true, he says—but it's off-the-record to you. I use Russell's confirmation on background. "I don't want to see my name in the paper, now, Anthony."

It was a successful week at the GM meetings—I didn't get scooped.

DETROIT, *November 18*—Pulling double-duty, covering basketball practice when the top National Guy rears his ugly head again: They're closing in on a trade with the Brewers for All-Star closer Francisco Rodríguez, according to Ken Rosenthal.

Nothing back from the Milwaukee guy I met last week. Neither do my other so-called sources. Soon, the team announces the trade, and nothing is left to confirm. Meanwhile, I'm trying to cover two sports at the same time—dialed into a baseball conference call as basketballs rap around the Pistons' practice facility during coach Stan Van Gundy's post-practice scrum.

Tigers PR: "We picked you up asking a question to Van Gundy on the call at the end. Was very strange."

CHARLOTTE, N.C., *November 20*—Waiting in the jetway to board a connector, I'm hit with a text message you never want to receive. My sports editor shares Breaking News.

Another trade, and I'm in no position to write the web update the desk needs immediately. I'm boarding a flight, and for the next hour and a half I'll have no cellular service for the conference call on the trade.

I'm flying to D.C. to see that girl again. I met her in a broken elevator in Chicago the final weekend of the season. Dead serious. I give her this crash course on dating a Ball Writer: "Shit just hit the fan... They made a trade right as I was stepping on."

TOLEDO, Ohio, *November 23*—What Lloyd McClendon saw coming last summer happened—he was fired by the Mariners—and now I'm speeding across the Michigan/Ohio state line to see him.

It was announced today that McClendon will manage the Triple-A Toledo Mud Hens—Detroit's top minor-league affiliate. I'm going out of my way on my off day to acknowledge McClendon's hiring. This is where the conversation we had in Seattle comes in. Back then, he wasn't in a position to give me information. Now, he is.

DETROIT, *November 29*—Worlds collide again: At Red Wings morning skate when baseball news breaks.

“Big signing coming. Starting pitcher. Not sure who.”

The person can’t be more specific. “Just letting you know what I heard.”

Even with a head start, I finish nowhere near first place. Within the half-hour, a National Guy gets the scoop: *Jordan Zimmermann to the Tigers. Five years, no opt-out. And the big one: \$110 million.*

Zimmermann is introduced the next day. The righty starter is the latest recipient of Mike Ilitch’s riches. Ilitch makes a rare public appearance at the press conference. He can’t move around much, but he can still make his voice heard—loud and clear.

“I don’t care about the money. I want the best players—and that’s it.”

One day, a bill will come past due. I don’t want to be covering this team when it does.

Ilitch grew up on the west side of Detroit and began his empire by founding Little Caesars Pizza. He’s won four Stanley Cups with the Red Wings and appears still willing to pay whatever it takes for another shot at a World Series.

He bought the Tigers in 1992, months after typing this return letter to a local youngster, who at four years old already had his future planned out. With help from my dad, I wrote in crayon to Ilitch that I wanted to be a hockey player.

Dear Anthony:

I have read your letter and must tell you what a good printer you are. You can start getting ready to be a hockey player (Red Wing) by

- 1. Eat good food, get exercise, and a lot of sleep, because hockey players have to be healthy.*
- 2. Listen to mom and dad, because hockey players need discipline.*
- 3. Study hard when you go to school, because hockey players have to be smart.*
- 4. Learn to skate and practice a lot, because hockey players need to be excellent skaters.*

You do all of the things I listed above and then write me another letter and let me know how you're doing when you start playing with a Mites or Squirt team.

Thank you for your letter.

Sincerely yours,

Michael Ilitch.

NASHVILLE, *December 6*—This year's winter meetings are at the Gaylord Opryland Resort, a sprawling indoor city 20 minutes from the honky-tonk of downtown. When I arrive, I see Bob Nightengale and stick to him.

Nightengale is *USA TODAY*'s National Guy. We become pals after beers last year.

When I grow up, I want to become the Bob Nightengale of National Guys. Bob is skin-tight with scouts, in touch with owners and has deep relationships in the game.

Me? Not so much. By midnight, I'm scooped again. My team is "closing in" on reliever Mark Lowe, according to Seamhead Jerry Crasnick. I run into him after having a cigarette with a couple of New York writers and ask the ESPN.com senior writer if he's got a contact for Lowe's agent, former player Jeff Frye. For whatever reason, Crasnick shares it. Frye doesn't answer.

I wallow away in my room, writing up another breaking story I can't confirm.

December 7—At 4 P.M., we're summoned to a sixth-floor suite. Behind a table sits general manager Al Avila, flanked by his top lieutenant—assistant general manager David Chadd. Behind them, a bay window overlooks the lobby action below.

Avila says they aren't in active pursuit of free agent outfielders Yoenis Céspedes and Alex Gordon. At 4:05, Bob Nightengale tweets as much: "Al Avila tells Detroit reporters that they are out of Céspedes and Alex Gordon talks."

This surprises all of us on the Tiger Beat. We exit the suite half an hour later with our thumbs atwitter—only to find our meatiest piece of information stolen by a National Guy who wasn't even In The Room.

Nightengale's scoop angers Rival Cohort Chris McCosky, who points a finger: "I know it was you who leaked it to him!" He is guilting me by my employment (*USA TODAY* and the *Free Press* are both owned by Gannett) and concluding that for some reason I must be aiding Nightengale's efforts to scoop everyone—including me.

He grumbles the entire way down the elevator. I pay no attention to the others eye-rolling pleas for peace. There are four of us in the car. I don't bite my tongue. "You've gotta be kidding me. Yes, of course, I want Bob Nightengale to kick my ass."

"Who was it then? It had to be you."

"Just stop, man. This is ridiculous."

"I saw you guys together last night!"

Our insights each day come from the Tigers' media sessions. In the suite, our information is thought to be safe from the National Guys—but like pre-

and postgame managerial sessions during the regular season, live tweeting is prohibited. Most times, the quotes we get are the only chance to provide our followers with exclusive insight. Thus, a speed test commences: They who tweet the quickest get the social media spoils—the retweets and favorites and followers.

I phone Ron Colangelo, asking how the hell did Bob get that? I point the blame at PR.

“I think it was you... I’m not an idiot.”

Colangelo is convincing as he claims innocence—but finding the culprit is fruitless. During Avila’s sessions, the entire traveling front office is present. They sit around, silently judging our questions. They make faces at each other and text people. They are sources—at least one of them Bob Nightengale’s.

December 8—The annual Baseball Writers’ Association of America meeting is bright and early. Writers have crammed into a conference room, where issues are debated and voted on, Hall of Famers are revealed, and various organizational topics are tackled.

This is the profession at its nerdiest. We argue about Hall of Fame vote transparency.

But today is a big day for the BBWAA. Results of a recent vote are revealed and MLB.com writers are now eligible for membership. Previously, MLB.com writers were barred to ensure the BBWAA’s journalistic integrity—MLB.com writers are employed by MLB Advanced Media and operate as an arm of the league. That can create conflicts of interest.

A newspaper story about a player’s domestic violence accusations probably won’t make it onto the website. Team turmoil and selling tickets don’t go together. The sites are there to make money—and negative stories don’t help.

This isn’t to say my MLB.com cohorts can’t be trusted. But the arrangement is awkward, as evidenced by the disagreements. People turning on the people they sit next to 120 days a year.

I need some water in the worst way, so I walk out. I voted no.

December 9—ALERT!

Avila’s afternoon media session has been pushed back, according to Aileen. This usually means a trade is near.

I know nothing of the sort. Those who do aren’t responding.

Once again, a friend helps. ESPN.com’s Marly Rivera helps me piece together the rumor du jour of the hour: Detroit is pursuing reliever Justin Wilson, according to her source.

That's as close as I come to the scoop. An hour later, the trade is broken by a television reporter back home, who isn't even at the meetings—Wilson to the Tigers, two prospect pitchers to the Yankees. At 6 P.M., another alert from PR: "Come now to suite."

JUNK MAIL

From: Web Desk **Sent:** Wednesday, December 16, 2015 3:10 PM

Subject: Tigers, Aviles

In case you didn't see it yet, Buster Olney is reporting the Tigers signed Mike Aviles.

From: VAUGHN HOOGASIAN **Sent:** Monday, December 21, 2015 11:05 A M

Subject: BOO BOO

Dear Anthony: I am surprised that you don't know the difference between inquisition and ACQUISITION!!! Has the FREE PRESS done away with copy editors in an effort to save a few bucks? Check your column of Dec. 17. I suggest you buy a dictionary AND USE IT or at least check it for boo boo's when in doubt. There is a vast world of difference between these two words as you will discover, I hope.

VAUGHN HOOGASIAN (ONE TIME JOURNALISM AND ENGLISH TEACHER)

From: kurt ralston **Sent:** Monday, December 27, 2015 11:28 PM

Subject: Idea

Fans might like to read about your first year as a beat writer. Players, coaches, ballparks, press boxes, cities, restaurants, plane trips... Who was the easiest/hardest to interview? Was there anything unusual, any surprises, any special places/events? Take us through a typical day on the road. What were the hilites and lowlights? Any physical or mental fatigue occur during the nine months?

Congratulations on year one. I look forward to year number two.

ZZYZX, Calif., *January 15, 2016*—I learned many things my rookie year on the beat. I'm re-learning a hard lesson today: Don't travel on arbitration day.

This year, I'm on the highway, 1½ hours outside Las Vegas, foolishly driving a rental car with one hand. My other hand is texting sources, checking Twitter and searching for the next exit. I've been beaten twice. According to Jon Heyman, the National Guy who breaks arbitration deals with superhuman ease, *two* deals are happening.

At 2:46 P.M., Heyman reports lefty Justin Wilson has agreed to terms. Four minutes later, another one: *Tigers, Iglesias settle at \$2.1M plus performance bonuses.*

At Denny's, I write a catch-up story, angry again. Angry at annoying editors. At my sources, who are nowhere to be found. At the agents, for not thinking about me first.

Angry, because I've painstakingly contacted the agents for these arbitration players. I called Jose Iglesias' agent a week ago—we talked for 12 minutes. Angry at Al Avila—I thought we made real progress in the offseason. Last week, he said, "Text or call me whenever you need anything." Angry at Jon Heyman—*how* is he doing this?

After breaking 79 arbitration deals last year, Heyman will up the record to 84 this year. To outsiders, this is what a baseball insider looks like—well-connected, probably cooped up in an office working the phones like a coked-out penny stockbroker. But to an insider, his reporting is beyond the realm. Inexplicable, how he churns a running scroll of scoops like that—minute-by-minute, exact figures, star players and small. When the 4 o'clock deadline passes for teams and players to exchange figures, The Heymachine spits out numbers: *Tigers file at \$6M, J.D. Martinez at \$8M.*

TORONTO, *January 18*—I flew to Detroit from L.A. last night, then to Toronto this morning. It's now almost two and I still haven't left the airport. I've been at customs since eight this morning.

The officer had called me to the window and asked why I was coming to Canada. I was honest: A college roommate works at a PR firm that's hosting a Molson event tonight with an ice rink at the top of a skyscraper. He asked how long I planned on staying. Tomorrow. That was it.

He told me to sit in one of the blue chairs, called me up again a few minutes later and said I wasn't allowed in the country. Canada doesn't permit DUI offenders for ten years. It's only been eight, in my case.

So, I'm escorted onto a flight home. When I arrive, I'm punched in the face by breaking news. Another big signing.

DETROIT, *January 20*—A press conference is called. Justin Upton, a three-time All-Star, is the Tigers' latest free agent import. The slugger will soon be \$132.75 million richer.

"Don't tweet that," Ron Colangelo says. "Don't want moles to know. The Internet Stalkers of the world and his moles follow all of you and know your every move."

If only he knew. But Ron knows more than most—enough to take precautions.

A few years back, Internet Stalker (same one) snuck into a Comerica Park press conference as a reporter for the fictitious *Jewish News*.

In December 2013, they dealt Doug Fister to the Washington Nationals for Robbie Ray, Ian Krol and Steve Lombardozzi.

The trade was unearthed by a no-name, too—a high school senior from Massachusetts broke the news on Twitter. It changed his life: Chris Cotillo became an Internet sensation, and within the week, he was at the winter meetings being interviewed by MLB Network.

When Dave Dombrowski met with the media, my Internet Stalker was waiting. He even got one of his cronies credentialed as a photographer for the phony publication. Soon, Internet Stalker had the microphone in the back row, squeaking a string of questions Dombrowski's way.

"Why did you trade Doug Fister? Did you do your due diligence? Many in the national media said you didn't."

Dombrowski pulled a piece of paper from his jacket. On the paper was a list of other young pitchers the team had considered. He showed the list to Brad Ausmus, sitting beside him.

"I don't weigh such opinions when making decisions. Robbie Ray was at the top of that list. I feel we did tremendous due diligence."

Pardoned from the mic, Internet Stalker pleaded for a follow-up, but security got him out.

January 21—The boys are back in town. I head to the Veterans Affairs medical center in Ann Arbor for the ribbon-cutting of a new wing personally financed by Justin Verlander.

I chose this winter caravan stop carefully. I'd throw the franchise player a bone—writing about his charitable endeavors—and get a couple minutes one-on-one.

I'm right on both accounts. I'm here alone. Verlander gives a little speech, cuts the ribbon, and takes a few photos. Afterwards, I get a couple minutes. Ushered into a side room, unbuttoning his uniform, I ask Justin if he ever looks at the money he makes as a superstar athlete compared to, say, an Army officer in Afghanistan.

"Do you ever think about the difference?"

Justin doesn't get it.

"Do you know how much I donate to veterans?"

"No."

"Then I don't know why you'd ask a question like that."

I was going for something quotable, something to humanize the guy. I try to explain.

"Justin, I wasn't tryi—"

"Got anything else? Because if not, I gotta go."

"I think I should be good."

"Great."

Verlander puts his jacket on and jets out. He must've told Tigers PR. Ron Colangelo texts me.

"Positive story, correct?"

SECAUCUS, N.J., *February 12*—A couple weeks ago, I reached out to the producers at MLB Network, saying I'd be in the area today. I'm in Brooklyn for the premiere of my buddy's new short film. But as I found out this morning, Brooklyn is not in the same world as industrial New Jersey, where network studios are located.

It took almost two hours, but I made it from hostel to subway to another subway to the Long Island Railroad and finally to a shuttle bus to 1 Network Plaza. Couldn't sleep a wink last night. I'm going on the morning show around 10 A.M., live with Harold Reynolds and Fran Charles.

I'm scheduled for two segments. Three to five minutes each. I am wearing a pepper-gray jacket, pink shirt, and against everything I believe in, no tie—I was counseled by MLB Network reporter, runner and supermom Sam Ryan. I'm glad I listened. I feel good walking out of the green room, and the guys make me feel comfortable immediately.

I glance at the TV as the show goes to break. UP NEXT, a promotion says, DAVID PRICE INTERVIEW.

Price is joining the show by phone. He was on hold prior, listening to my segment. Sitting in that chair lends an invaluable legitimacy to your name. Everyone in the industry watches. Players, coaches, GMs. Sources and scouts.

Those you've reached out to and those you'll email in the future. Agents. Fans. Even David Price.

By the time I leave the studio, my phone is blowing up with those people.

The producer asks if I want to be a regular correspondent. They'll pay me. For up-and-down Ball Writer Anthony Fenech, this is definitely up.

SPRING TRAINING

LAKELAND, Fla., *February 18*—A double shot of good news from spring training. It appears Justin Verlander is no longer mad at me.

Not only that, but he remembers my name.

Walking out of Starbucks with my head in my phone and still unsure what day of the week it is, someone holds the door.

“Good morning, Anthony.”

Pitchers and catchers report today and Justin is driving his Range Rover.

Two days shy of his 33rd birthday, he tells reporters that he’s healthy again. After battling injuries for the past two years, he feels primed for a rebound.

“I’m ready to step on the gas. I’m ready to go.”

Scuttlebutt says Verlander has been tinkering with adding a split-fingered fastball.

“Can’t tell you.”

“Can you tell us off the record?” I ask.

No again.

“Because then you’ll write about it the first time I throw anything different.”

February 21—While walking the back fields, I follow the sound of bat cracks in the distance.

The sound becomes more familiar the closer I get—V́ctor Mart́nez is in the batting cage.

Mart́nez walks out afterward: Towel on shoulder, bats in hand, sweat-soaked face. Walks straight by me. No eye contact. Something is wrong. He becomes a barking dog.

“Go away! Go! Go!”

With his foot speed diminished—Mart́nez ranked as the slowest player in baseball last season, at 23.2 feet per second—I keep up with ease.

“I saw what you were saying on TV. No power, nothing this, nothing that. Always talking shit.”

Over the winter, I went on MLB Network and was asked whether the Tigers could count on his power swing returning after he hit only 11 home runs last season. “No, they can’t,” I said. “V́ctor is about to be 37, and he’s shown signs of decline. While they can count on V́ctor hitting for a high average, I’m not sure the power will return.”

He isn’t in the mood this morning. “Away!” he shouts. A security guard runs up.

February 22—Spring training is the leisure season. Optimism intoxicates the air, and eternal wonderment rubs off on Ball Writers, too.

This is the year. They’re gonna win the World Series, I tell my buddy, and I’ll write a book about it. Working title: *Roar Restored—Inside the Jungle with the Detroit Tigers*.

On a turf field named after Ty Cobb, Brad Ausmus addresses the players.

Before batting practice, Kirk Gibson reacquaints himself with Justin Upton. Miguel Cabrera swings a heavy bat. Mr. Tiger Al Kaline is standing behind the cage.

Upton’s father Manny is bouncing around the dugout, starstruck after meeting him.

“I came here to see him. Royalty.”

February 23—There is a lighter feel in Lakeland this spring. Under Dave Dombrowski, the front-office staff was buttoned up—working diligently but not without fear. He was the boss, not a friend, and club-media relations were separated by a thick black line.

Al Avila is different. Tonight, the general manager invites the Tiger Beat to a barbeque. We arrive at a huge house and find out the living room is a basketball court. Wood floors, painted lines and a professional-grade hoop suspended from the ceiling. The court opens into the kitchen, where there are plenty of finger foods, drinks of all kinds, and a huge party sub from Publix.

Ball Writers, front office folks and PR. Breaking bread, boozing and playing basketball under the same roof. A three-on-three game begins. I’m not playing. I treat this experiment the way I treat all social gatherings and general moments of awkwardness: With a beer.

I grab a beer. Soon, I’m explaining the auction mechanisms of my fantasy league to the real-life baseball folks. I seek scouting opinions on my players. The basketball game is still going. People are sweating when I see Avila step outside.

The mansion backs up to a man-made lake. It's outlined with palm trees inside a gated community with a golf course, country club and million-dollar houses. The Tigers' team travel guy is renting the house for the spring.

"You could get used to a view like this," I say.

Al is out having a smoke. He offers me a cigar. Never smoked one.

He shows me how to cut it. As I struggle, he brings out a pocket-size blowtorch and lights it himself. As I cough, he tries to explain how to smoke it without inhaling.

"Stop smoking it like a joint."

We talk about anything except baseball. About Catholic schools, Donald Trump, and not being golfers. About his family and this girl who is coming to see me. The Highest Source In The Land says things to the Ball Writer he really shouldn't. We don't know each other like that. Yet standing here, clinking our glasses, it feels as though we could.

February 29—More royalty in camp. Peter Gammons moves slowly through the clubhouse.

The ping-pong game stops. Alan Trammell wants to shake his hand. Players and coaches young and old address him by first name. Gammons is invited into the coaches' room by Kirk Gibson and pokes his head into the trainer's room.

Catcher Jarrod Saltalamacchia walks out of the clubhouse.

"Peter! How are you doing?"

"Is that really your car, my friend?" Gammons asks.

Saltalamacchia's truck, a white Ford F-150 King Ranch edition with camouflage trim, is raised a foot or two and casts a monster truck shadow over the players' parking lot.

"I couldn't fit that in Boston."

"If you could, they'd take it apart on the street anyways."

Gammons is a runaway waterspout of stories. He is a native New Englander and BBWAA Hall of Famer with a blind spot for the Red Sox. Saltalamacchia played four seasons in Boston. Ausmus grew up in New Haven, Connecticut reading Gammons, who made his name at the *Boston Globe* before becoming the first Ball Writer to bound head-first into television. He joined ESPN in 1989 and became an institution there.

I don't get intimidated much anymore, but my usually talkative self has been following along silently with my tape recorder running, like a cameraman on a reality TV show.

I text John Lowe: "I was just part of a conversation with Peter Gammons."

"Mountaintop," he says.

March 13—Although Opening Day is three weeks away, the deadline for our season preview section is fast approaching. I still don't have a subject for my big feature when I'm forwarded this email from the *Free Press*' entertainment reporter.

KATE UPTON – GRAND SLAM ADOPTION EVENT

It's a press release for an upcoming dog-adoption event hosted by super-model Kate Upton and her boyfriend, Justin Verlander.

"Another chance to talk to Kate?" my sports editor wonders.

It's been well-known not to ask Verlander about the topic—years ago, he pulled a group of beat writers aside and kiboshed any questions now or in the future.

There's an easy angle there—after finishing last season strong, the Tigers' franchise pitcher looks primed for a comeback.

I start by emailing Verlander's parents. Writing a profile on Justin—will they be at his start tomorrow?

"Sounds good," his father replies.

Talking to them, I ask what story hasn't been told. Soon enough, they're glowing about how Justin is happier these days—and how the biggest difference is his girlfriend.

Bingo.

March 26—Cracking Verlander's code proves a tougher task.

I go to Gator for some good juju.

"I gotta put the full court press on Justin today. When I give my sales pitch, can I drop your name, like, 'Ask G about me?'"

Gator resides in the inner circle.

"The article is all positive stuff, right?"

"Yeah, definitely. I'm just thinking about if I need to give him some more peace of mind."

"I don't mind if you want to say, 'I've known Gator, he knows my character, and I know he's a friend of yours.'"

Setting up time to talk, I suggest we meet at Starbucks and ride to the stadium. I'd interview him while riding shotgun in whatever sports car he decides to drive.

"I don't do that kind of stuff."

I want to say there's a first time for everything, but I don't.

March 28—We talk the next morning in TigerTown.

Campus is quiet. The team plays the Yankees in Tampa this evening and not many players are around. Justin walks out with a coffee.

“He kinda opened up,” I tell Gator. “He was good.”

The couple hasn’t spoken publicly about their relationship, but when I ask him just to make sure it’s cool, Verlander says I can talk with her.

“If she’ll talk to you.”

I take a call on the Interstate from a scout with a tip: The Tigers are cutting a reliever.

With our relationship on simmer since the cigar, I go straight to the source—“Can I grab you for a sec when you get out?”

Al Avila is a couple tables over, eating lunch with staff inside in the media dining room. He ignores my text. Picks up the phone and puts it down.

Instead, Tigers PR responds.

“Al said you reached out to him,” Aileen says. “From now on, whenever you want to talk to him, go through me.”

I feel betrayed.

March 31—I broker a deal. I tell the lady that I can get a post about the event on *USA TODAY*’s website. Turns out the lady is Kate Upton’s older sister, who’s running the dog adoption show out of an old airplane hangar.

Upton escapes the crowd of crazies on a golf cart to the back fields, where Verlander throws a tune-up session. Instead of facing the Pirates inside Joker Marchant Stadium, he’s working against minor-leaguers—including his little brother, Ben, a farmhand outfielder who steps into the box and hits a home run to center on the first pitch he sees.

I don’t know if I should shake her hand, I don’t know if that’s weird, so I don’t. Kate Upton doesn’t remove her sunglasses. I get my obligation out of the way, asking about the event. Before I can get a real question out, big sister steps in. “One more, she’s gotta go.”

I ask about Verlander.

“Justin is my best friend. He has made my life full and happy in every way possible.”

And off she goes.

DETROIT, *April 10*—The game got rained out and Al Avila is calling. I haven't spoken to Al since he put me through that whole PR rigmarole. I've avoided even making eye contact lately.

He's driving home. Calling to compliment a recent story. Says he hasn't heard from me in a while and I take the opportunity to let him know why.

"You didn't need to go to Aileen like that."

He hears me out.

"You can't be bugging me all the time, then," he says.

"I don't. You know that."

I hang up under new rules—I'll contact the Highest Source In The Land whenever I damn well please.

HOT SEAT

WASHINGTON, *May 8*—There's a wild rumor circulating and an urgent alert from the web desk to chase it.

The rumor was originated by some internet scrub, who says: "Jim Leyland is expected to be formally offered the job as Tigers manager tonight. Mike Ilitch bypassing his GM, calling personally." Scrub is "100 percent sure."

Despite protesting his lack of credibility and telling my boss I don't want to bug the Highest Source In The Land with this bunk, I follow orders.

On a Sunday night, no less. HSITL has asked me never to call on Sundays.

I text instead after 10:20: "I know it's a Sunday night, but I gotta reach out about this... There is a report out there that Mr. Ilitch is calling or called Jim to offer him the job tonight. On the record, can you say if that is true?"

"No. That's preposterous. Anthony, I am already in bed now buddy."

"Ok, I apologize. So, if I'm forced to write something, can I use your denial?" Must've fallen asleep.

May 9—After posting a winning record in April, Detroit is nose-diving in May. They arrive in D.C. on a six-game losing streak. Brad Ausmus has lost fan support.

On MLB Network, Mad Dog asks if he's on the hot seat.

"There's only so much a manager can do. At some point, the players have to perform."

As a beat writer, it's risky business to put the manager in the crosshairs—doing so could make for uncomfortable quarters going forward.

In the clubhouse afterwards, quality control coach Matt Martin pulls me aside.

"Good job on TV today. Brad saw it, too, and he appreciated it."

May 11—Caught in a downpour walking to the ballpark. Absolutely soaked. Víctor Martínez does me a solid, offering a spray of fine cologne.

Tonight, the Tigers face Max Scherzer.

It was not the night.

Scherzer goes berserk, striking out 20 batters in a complete game win over his former team—the fifth 20-K game in baseball history. I go to the service-level press conference room for his comments. He soon walks on stage, ice wrapped around his right arm. The rest of the media members are still inside the clubhouse, and etiquette says we can't start until they arrive.

Someone in the back snaps the silence, asking if he thought he had a chance at 20 strikeouts.

"I *knew* I had a chance."

May 12—Running late to the train, I'm cold-cocked with a call from my sports editor, who says a top prospect is coming up—can you write about it? I'm in a cab, but sure, and start pecking away on my phone.

I ping a sports writing pal who recently graduated from the beat grind to a fancy features job at some magazine. "If you ever hear of a job like yours, let me know... I'm burning out."

It's my second season.

BALTIMORE, *May 13*—The Tigers are shut out again tonight. Walking out of the clubhouse after the loss, ESPN.com's Katie Strang asks if I heard what Ian Kinsler said.

I don't know what she means at first. Kinsler answered questions short and serious. When asked about Ausmus' job status, he said, "I don't think about that. I don't care about that. I don't care about anything except getting a win."

That's Katie's point. Kinsler could've given Ausmus a *vote of confidence*, put the blame on the players or said it's not the manager's fault.

"He said nothing."

May 14—The roller coaster continues. Detroit has dropped three straight and nine of the last 11. A Tiger Beat colleague shares a scoop of his own—he's stepping down from his spot and out of the business entirely. His marriage is still intact, and he wants to spend more time with his wife and kids, maybe play some more poker.

The baseball beat is often referred to as the Divorce Beat and by now, I trust you see why. A great job for a guy who is single or wants to be. I try not to think

about this: I am rapidly falling into a long-distance relationship with a woman I met in a broken elevator last year.

In the press box at Oriole Park, writers brave the most dangerous working conditions in sports journalism, threatened by high-speed foul balls at a second's notice.

Yesterday, Katie—who is pregnant—became the latest victim. She was hit by a foul ball and heads right back to her front-row seat tonight.

I sit as far back as possible. I'm next to an In The Room source—John Westhoff. He shares a story tip, pointing at the friends and family seating section. "Over there is Warwick Saupold's mom."

Saupold is a rookie reliever from Australia. His mom mad-dashed here to see his debut—27 hours from Perth to Baltimore.

"Now that's a great story," Westhoff says.

I take him up on it, fishing her out of the family area after the game. I say hello to Justin Verlander's parents while waiting for the media elevator.

May 15—Another loss last night and there is a more pressing story. My sports editor has been all over me, asking for a pre-written story in case Ausmus gets canned.

Instead, I went out drinking by myself. Late again to the press box today, I look down and see Katie Strang sitting in the dugout. I drop my things and head downstairs, practically sprinting through the concourse and hurdling the railing to crash her party.

With the manager on the hot seat, Katie arrived early and stationed herself here. Bullpen coach Mick Billmeyer walks by.

"I don't have a good feeling about this week, guys. I just don't."

Tigers trail in the fifth when I wave Westhoff over to my computer. I ask if he wants to edit my story. He slides his chair closer, squints at the screen and looks back in horror as I crack up: It's the pre-written story my boss asked for.

"Jerk."

Try as we may (again), the *Free Press* can't fire Brad Ausmus. Miguel Cabrera and J.D. Martinez go back-to-back in the eighth and the Tigers leave town with a managerial-saving win.

ANAHEIM, Calif., *May 31*—This whole Internet Stalker thing is starting to take its toll. When I'm out with friends in Detroit, I feel under surveillance, carefully looking around. I don't text people back. I watch my surroundings before I speak

It's a relief to get back on the road, this far from home. We're near Disneyland, where my dream has come true—I cover the Tigers. Yet I can't help thinking, more and more, be careful what you wish for.

Today, my dream has taken me into the visitor's clubhouse at Angel Stadium, where I'm in Miguel Cabrera's corner. Miggy sits at his locker.

Miggy, I have come to realize in proximity, is a man child. Signed out of Venezuela for \$1.8 million at 16, he reached unspeakable wealth by his mid-twenties. He's been hailed for his generational hitting ability and handled accordingly since then—he's never done wrong, and nobody feels comfortable telling him otherwise.

Today when I'm in front of Miggy, our roles are reversed. He is the interviewer. We have a small audience—reliever Francisco "K-Rod" Rodríguez is a few lockers to the left, Víctor Martínez is to the right and Jarrod Saltalamacchia is somewhere in between.

He asks something so inappropriate that it stops the conversation cold. "No," I say immediately.

K-Rod, a 15-year veteran, shakes his head at Cabrera's behavior. Víctor stays silent, but Salty eggs him on.

I offer Cabrera an editorial comment I know he'll understand. I point at myself. "Me—Grande," I say, pointing to him. "You—Pequeno."

PR calls the writers into Ausmus' office. I walk away, pretending to be unflustered. I look back and blow Miggy a kiss.

Livin' the dream.

BLUE SPRINGS, Mo., *June 15*—Back on the Jim Harbaugh beat.

I'm assigned to arrive early in Kansas City this week—half an hour into the suburbs for one of Harbaugh's controversial satellite camps for high-school football players. These camps are angering rival coaches, who decry them as a sneaky scheme for extra recruiting visits.

Harbaugh's wife grew up here. I got connected with her brother, who shares a pinch from his tobacco tin and owns a couple bars in the area.

Jim seems happy to see me.

He swims around controversial questions from a local radio reporter. His eyes light up when I decide to play ball. Finally, a question he likes.

"Man, how much do you love football? You can just tell how much you love it out there."

CLEVELAND, *July 6*—My final game of the first half is today in Cleveland. I'm skipping the upcoming Toronto series—I'm still not legally permitted into Canada, eight years into a 10-year ban for misdemeanor DUI. Apparently, the news of my DUI (via Internet Stalker) has made its rounds inside the clubhouse.

"I heard you couldn't get into Toronto," J.D. Martinez says.

I tell him what happened.

"Shut the fuck up," Martinez says, in disbelief of my story.

I hear my DUI brother barking from the back wall of the clubhouse.

Miggy was busted for DUI in 2011, when he took a swig of scotch in front of the Florida cops and said, "Do you know who I am?" I rolled over a PT Cruiser three times and survived.

"If (J.D.) tells you to shut the fuck up," he says, "then shut the fuck up."

"You shut the fuck up," I say, as playfully as I can.

Miggy plays along. The air is not tense. Remember: We're DUI brothers.

For over a month since the off-color question in Anaheim, I've completely avoided him. No acknowledgement, no questions, no kisses blown. Nothing.

But in the past week or so, I've picked up on his body language. He knows I'm avoiding him. Last time reporters spoke with him, I asked nothing. He smacked my back walking away.

Today, I cave.

When I get to his locker, he's sitting on a stool, buckling up a gold pendant. I crouch down and extend a hand. I look him in the eye and say, "Why do you always gotta fuck with me? Huh? Why are you always fucking with me? Have a good break."

Miguel shakes my hand and says nothing. He laughs, which is something.

I walk out with my head high—the guys have been gossiping about me. A strange feeling.

SAN DIEGO, *July 11*—I come to this year's all-star festivities strictly for the airline miles. I meet my long-distance girlfriend here and skip the futures game and the home-run derby.

We go for dinner in the Gaslamp District.

Miguel Cabrera's appearance is the reason the company spent thousands of dollars in travel to send me here.

He welcomes my presence inside the American League clubhouse before the game.

"Even one day off in the regular season helps a lot. I think four days will help a lot."

Miggy proudly shows off his custom Louis Vuitton cleats.

He hands them to me.

“Sweet, huh?”

DETROIT, *July 15*—The Tigers are in the thick of things when the season restarts.

Brad Ausmus never got fired—the day after the Tigers hit back-to-back homers to beat Baltimore in mid-May, Ausmus was ejected for an uncharacteristic temper tantrum that he punctuated by throwing his hoodie on home plate. The team went on a run, winning eight of nine games to get back into the race.

Michael Fulmer, acquired from the Mets last year, has skyrocketed in value, becoming the midseason favorite for Rookie of the Year. Fulmer entered the break on a heater—he’s 7-1 with a 0.63 ERA in his last nine starts.

Justin Verlander has largely picked up where he left off last season, still eating innings and slinging upper-90s fastballs late.

He starts the second half by dominating the Royals at home. Seven innings, ten strikeouts, one unearned run. July ends with an eight-game winning streak.

CHICAGO, *July 25*—At the *Free Press*, we’re all Jim Harbaugh, all the time. Harbaugh gets the clicks. So, after a weekend series against the White Sox, I’m staying another day in Chicago, where Big Ten football media day is being held at the convention center.

I am on Harbaugh Watch, following him around all day for a feature story.

Apparently, Harbaugh has taken a liking to me after the satellite camp story. I’ve kept up with his brother-in-law. Supposed to see him when we’re in K.C. next.

JUNK MAIL

From: Crawford, Kirkland **Sent:** Friday, July 29, 2016 11:58 PM

Subject: Tigers ...

... you out there, buddy?

From: Fenech, Anthony **Sent:** Saturday, July 30, 2016 9:26 AM

Subject: Re: Tigers ...

I'm sorry. Should have emailed you. Probably shouldn't have gone to the game but I was playing hero, spent Thurs night in ER with heat stroke or food poisoning or something. Was feeling terrible by the end and fell asleep right when I got home.

From: Maxwell, Charlie **Sent:** Monday, August 1, 2016 4:48 PM

Subject: Hey Dumbass...

You're late to your FP chats, a smart ass who doesn't know any more about the game than your readers and look like Frankenstein talking through that nose in the game wrap-ups. Don't imagine the FP can afford real reporters these days so they hire the likes of you.

From: Bull, Kevin **Sent:** Friday, August 5, 2016 10:52 PM

Subject: Next week 1A story

Anthony: 1A is interested in a story about How The Tigers Saved Their Season. I would say for next Friday. This assumes they are still doing well and don't get swept in Seattle. I think it's something you can start reporting now. Can definitely take us back to that road trip in Baltimore where we thought Ausmus was close to being fired. Cool?

ARLINGTON, Texas, *August 12*—You can never assume anything in Ball Writing—as sports editor Kevin Bull now understands.

The Tigers did get swept and the editors of Page 1A—the front of the newspaper—are no longer interested in the story about how they saved their season. But Detroit is still seven games above .500 and well within reach—1 ½ games behind the wild-card.

DETROIT, *August 20*—Thanks to a colossal scheduling mishap, I'm back at the ballpark on an off day I had requested weeks in advance. My backup is on vacation, and I'm stuck covering pregame. I have plans tonight.

My goal is to get in, get done, and get out.

During Ausmus' session, I ask about Red Sox slugger David Ortiz, playing his final series at Comerica Park. Ortiz, 40, is retiring after the season and has tormented Detroit over the years.

He becomes the obvious choice for my second story. I'll ask Miggy about him.

Me and Miggy have lived in harmony since last month's All-Star Game. When he appears at his locker, I give him a certain distance, waiting until he sits down before making a move. He's fiddling with his cleats.

I crouch down so we're eye level. Immediately, I sense his combativeness.

"I want to ask you about David Ortiz."

"What about him?"

"You're probably friends, right? What kind of guy is he? What's your relationship like with him?"

"Ask him."

"Well, what do you think of Ortiz as a player? Is there anything that stands out from his swing..."

"He's a lefty hitter. I swing righty."

I crouch lower, trying for eye contact. He's still looking down at his shoes.

"You mean, you can't tell me anything—*anything*—about David Ortiz?"

"Don't talk to me like that."

Instead of diffusing the situation, I choose escalation.

"Don't talk to me like that."

"Fuck you."

"Fuck you," I say.

"Fuck *you*!"

"No, fuck *you*!"

August 21—On this beat, there's only one way to get over things.

Postgame the next day, I see Miggy at his locker—first one to the right. Walking by, I wait for eye contact. When he sees me, I apologize.

"I'm sorry for what I said."

To my surprise, he apologizes, too.

"Look, man. I like you. But sometimes, you can take it too far."

"I get what you're saying, but I wasn't trying to be like that."

"But you were like that."

"I feel you."

We bring it in. Bygones be bygones. Miggy never messed with me again.

PORTLAND, Maine, *August 26*—After lengthy conversations with friends, family and legal counsel, I have decided to defend my name publicly against the false, slanderous, libelous, harassing, defamatory and generally baseless character assassination claims that have come my way for nearly two years.

I just wanted to go on a trip with a woman I've been seeing. A couple months ago, I scheduled this week off. It's going great—well, it was. We're halfway through the trip, driving to a tall mountaintop near the tip of Maine today. We picked up a rental in D.C. and drove up the East Coast—to Philly, Boston for a night and Portland, where I ate lobster for the first time.

Then today I wake up to a flurry of links to the latest stains on my good name.

Internet Stalker's latest post: WHERE IN THE WORLD IS ANTHONY FENECH? He reports I'm on vacation in Europe, citing a "familial acquaintance."

I'm currently in Maine. I've never been to Europe. I'm an hour outside Bangor with a beautiful woman riding shotgun in my rental. She might even like me. A couple of mile markers back, we blew by a moose crossing sign that even in broad daylight can scare the bejeezus out of you. So, if you can call off the crazies from stalking her, too, it would be much appreciated. At least until I can explain to her this whole Internet Stalker thing in more detail.

DETROIT, *August 27*—Nine hundred miles away from my vacation, the headlines say four ejected in tonight's 3-2 loss to the Angels, including Brad Ausmus and hitting coach Wally Joyner.

In the third inning, Víctor Martínez was ejected for arguing balls and strikes. In the fifth, Ausmus and Joyner were kicked out after Kinsler struck out looking. The next inning, home plate umpire Mike Everitt threw out J.D. Martinez, too.

Even though I feel as close to being on a real vacation as I've ever been, Ball Writers never truly take a vacation.

When my phone flashes back to life after six hours hiking, I brace for a flurry of messages. When I put in my PIN, I see missed messages and an unidentified number not in my contacts, maybe from one of Deep Throat's burner phones.

+1248XXX44XX: *Call me.*

WAKE-UP CALL

PECULIAR, Mo., *September 1*—The pennant race takes us to the heartland this week.

For dinner, I drive 45 minutes outside town to Peculiar, taking up a source on his offer.

Merle's American Tavern is the name suggested by Jim Harbaugh. Merle was the first name of the father of Harbaugh's wife, her brother John Feuerborn, and nine other siblings. Feuerborn owns the place.

I clicked with Feuerborn when we met at the satellite camp. He seems to be a good guy to know: Says he's been in Harbaugh's locker rooms before NFL playoff games and inside his hotel suites at bowl games.

I stay at Merle's for a couple beers and a killer cheeseburger and put it on the *Freep* tab.

KANSAS CITY, Mo., *September 4*—Halfway through the rubber game of the series, I head down to the concourse to meet John Feuerborn and his girlfriend.

"I told Harbs you came by the bar," he says. "You're in rare air, man. Harbs only likes two sports writers. You and the guy from San Francisco."

"Tim Kawakami?"

"Yeah."

"Seriously?"

"Seriously."

The Tigers leave town happy. Justin Upton homers in the eighth for the win; it's his seventh home run since Brad Ausmus took him out of the starting lineup as a reset.

In the manager's office, Brad won't take credit for pushing the right button.

"Like I always say—water will eventually find its level."

A smiley face is taped to the straw in the red solo cup on his desk. Twelve games over .500, a season-high.

MINNEAPOLIS, *September 20*—Justin Verlander seeks a buyer for his car. Inside the visitor's clubhouse, Tigers TV broadcaster Rod Allen walks by.

“Hey Rod. You wanna buy my Aston Martin?”

“Too pricey for me.”

Standing nearby, I’m offended.

“Why didn’t you ask me?”

“You got that much?”

“No... But I do have a Cy Young vote this year.”

“Oh yeah?”

That got his attention.

September 21—Per usual, Verlander speaks with reporters the day before his start.

Afterwards, I tell him, “You really know how to fill up the notebook.” He’s not fluent in newspaper-speak. I explain what a “notebook” is—its old journalism slang for side-car story that touches on multiple topics.

With the rest of the writers scattered, I stand between Verlander and Víctor Martínez.

“Back in the day, didn’t writers and players travel together?” Justin asks.

“Yeah. Writers used to ride trains and fly with teams. Some even hung out together.”

Víctor doesn’t believe it. I tell them how they used to be friends but maintained professional boundaries—traveling together, drinking together, intertwined in harmony. Peter Gammons even used to shag flies with Red Sox players.

The amicable relationship dates back to long train rides in the forties, generations before social media, when certain things couldn’t be written about. The writers observed the code because they cherished their jobs and considered themselves immensely privileged.

I mean, how could you not?

I turn to Víctor: “We should hang out sometime.”

They laugh. What a ridiculous concept.

ATLANTA, September 30—Detroit arrives in the Dirty South 1½ games back.

Inside the clubhouse, chatting up lefty reliever Ian Krol when I’m startled by loud screams. I turn to see two clubhouse attendants, still shaking from opening the red cooler—players taped a rubber snake underneath the lid.

“Hey Anthony,” Verlander signals at me. “Are there any Red Bulls in there?”

He wants me to open it. I stare and laugh. Like I’d fall for that. In front of his teammates, the try falls flat.

I sit with Al Avila in the dugout before going on MLB Network.

He's one series win away from taking the Tigers back to the playoffs in his first full season as general manager. They're going to ask me about Jordan Zimmermann, who is returning from injury to pitch this weekend.

"We're going to watch Zimmermann carefully. As far as his role in the playoffs, we'll deal with that once we get there."

I ask if he's nervous about postseason hopes hanging in the balance.

"No," he says. "This is baseball. It's all just a game."

October 1—Tigers won last night. Half a game out, two to go, and I've got my postseason travel booked.

After swatting away his prank attempt yesterday, I come to Verlander's locker bearing gifts today.

Verlander is starting the season finale tomorrow. After a late surge, he's once again considered a top Cy Young candidate—he's 16-8 with a 3.10 ERA and 246 strikeouts in 220⅓ innings.

I baked a fresh batch of brownie points for him. Bad luck had inflated his numbers, and I thought he'd like to know.

His eyes light up: "Good to know."

Against my protest, I'm asked for column on Brad Ausmus' status next year.

Ian Kinsler sits at his locker, unbothered before I walk up and mention this story. Do you think Brad should be back next year?

"Not answering that. Not my call."

"How much of a difference-maker has Brad been this year?"

"It sounds like you already know what you're writing. What are you writing?"

"I'm writing that Al should bring Brad back... I think you guys have done a good job this year given the injuries, and he deserves another year."

"So, write that. Write exactly that. Why do you need my quotes for that?"

"I'm trying to get a player's perspective."

"I'm not the team voice on Brad. I haven't asked a single guy in here about that."

I play it safe and write that Al Avila should bring Ausmus back. My primary motivation—the playoff race is still undecided, and I don't want to cause ill-timed, distracting headlines.

Detroit enters Game 160 trailing the Blue Jays for the last wild-card spot.

Their last stand comes in the eighth, bases loaded, when J.D. Martinez hits a rocket into the hole at shortstop. Dansby Swanson stabs it, starting a double play to end the inning.

Players watch Toronto's game inside the silent clubhouse. In the manager's office, Brad hopes for the best.

“In a perfect world, Boston can win this, and we still control our own destiny.”

By the time the media is kicked out, Jays win.

October 2—There were still scenarios in which the Tigers could play another day, but the season finale was rendered without suspense—they were shut out.

Verlander struck out eight batters over seven innings. For the second straight year, I got a first-name farewell. I didn’t have many phone numbers to gather, and I was surprised Cameron Maybin shut me down. “Hell naw,” he said. Not even his email.

I was less emotional in the clubhouse this year. More assured, more one of the guys, still just an Idiot Reporter. I feel eye-to-eye with most everyone in here.

The players will soon scatter on charters for the winter. I’m flying commercial, with an upgrade. It was a good season—it’s too bad the book won’t happen. Maybe next year.

DETROIT, *October 3*—Not even bloody seven o’clock on the first morning of the offseason and my phone is ringing. Deep Throat is fuming about my Ausmus column.

“I can’t talk for long, but look, Brad is part of the problem. A big part of it.”

He asks if I remember the August 27 game where everyone got ejected.

“I was on vacation. I remember reading about it.”

“That night, after Víctor got thrown out, he left the stadium.”

When the Tigers returned to the clubhouse, Martínez was gone. Andrew Romine mentioned it out loud and Jose Iglesias told Víctor about it.

“The next day, all hell broke loose.”

Martínez confronted Romine, charging at him in a physical altercation that teammates quickly broke up.

“Everyone in there had Romine’s back,” Deep Throat says. “It ruined the room. Víctor became more detached as the season wore on.”

“Brad will be back, I guarantee it. And Wally won’t be back—I guarantee that, too.”

October 4—After scores of unanswered emails and unreturned voicemails—“Just trying to open a line of communication,” I’d say—it’s Mike Milchin himself showing up in my messages.

Milchin is Justin Verlander's agent. Today, he wants to boost his client's Cy Young chances.

"We need a campaign for my boy Verlander and the Cy! Voters vote today! Leads baseball in WHIP, K's, Opponent average, opponents on base %, WAR! 2nd in ERA and innings pitched."

I've been reaching out to Milchin since I got the beat.

After the season finale last year, Verlander gave me Milchin's cell number. I've tried him directly—nothing. I call him out on it.

"Man, I have called and texted you so many times, no response."

"I am VERY low key, Anthony, and never put myself in front of players, which is why I am always silent. This situation w/JV is so important that I cannot sit idle on this. No disrespect intended, I just never talk."

"Just trying to have an open line of communication. Let me see what I can do—I have a vote, so it's kind of tricky."

"Understood. I will work to be more accessible in the future."

I write an article with the historical perspective Verlander is looking for. When the story is live, I send Milchin the link.

"Awesome! Thanks for sharing and writing."

An hour later, Milchin again.

"JV wanted me to send you a thank you for your article and work. He appreciated it very much."

DETROIT, *October 21*—Longtime *Free Press* sports columnist Drew Sharp died today. I met Sharp fresh out of high school working my first internship at Detroit's AM-dial sports station.

During commercial breaks I'd ask Drew about sports writing. More recently, he was my co-host on the Talkin' Tigers podcast.

He had become a local lightning rod, often taking the pessimist perspective, toying with fans' fragile feelings. I know—I hated Drew growing up. I crossed Xs through his column sig. But I always found myself reading what he wrote—and underlining words I didn't know.

When I got to work with him, I instantly became fond of Drew—not for his provocative columns, but for how good a teammate he was. Drew Sharp never considered himself bigger than me, or any writer. Never bigger than anyone on the Sports desk.

I found out one night by accident just how thick Drew's skin had to be.

I had worked late, met a friend for a drink—and then we decided to go exploring in the deserted *Freep* garage. Down in the basement, in a dark corner, we stumbled across two white cardboard boxes, stacked to the brim with letters.

Many of those letters were sent to Drew Sharp. In crooked words, letter writers called him a nigger. They told Uncle Tom to take his sports opinions elsewhere, lest they should be so lucky to see him on the street one day.

The *Free Press* family turns out for the funeral. Michigan State basketball coach Tom Izzo speaks. Sharp covered Izzo before he became a household name.

"I never felt guarded with him. Drew is the kind of friend everyone needs. He was not afraid to tell you what was on his mind, and he was not afraid to disagree with you. In this day and age, we tell everybody what they want to hear instead of what they need to hear. He was refreshing, to me, in that respect."

As Izzo's voice booms through the church, I think about my Internet Haters. About how I'd be remembered if I didn't wake up tomorrow.

SCOTTSDALE, Ariz., *November 7*—Up and at 'em for breakfast, a man jogs past. Navy blue pullover, red shorts, crew socks. Dave Dombrowski, out for his morning run.

"Hi, Anthony!"

Welcome to the GM meetings.

I've come this week strapped with ScoopSheet, the reporting database I've been building for the past month. It tells me when I last talked to a source and when I'm talking to them next. How many kids they have, which players agents represent, which organizations scouts cover.

I'm hoping to connect with new agents here. Agents do provide reporters with more than just information—they also provide access to players.

Tigers' starter Michael Fulmer is the frontrunner for Rookie of the Year. My access comes via his agent, Jay Franklin. The story angle came from an innocent question.

"Anything unique I should know?"

"Did you know that he's a plumber in the offseason?"

Picture the hotshot pitcher craning his neck underneath a sink cabinet, fixing a leaky faucet. When it's published, my Fulmer plumbing story gets aggregated to death by dinnertime.

Al Avila and his traveling contingent appear. Flight was delayed. He's still gotta check-into his room, get to a meeting, then dinner...

"One question each," he tells us. "Better make 'em good."

November 8—I get to the gym at 7:25 A.M. on Election Day, disgusted to see Ken Rosenthal already sweating on the elliptical. When I walk over to the weights area, I'm even more disgusted to see Rival Cohort in a cut-off shirt.

Before I can pick a weight up, my colleague bursts.

"Your column, man," shaking his head. "I don't know why you write stuff like that."

"What?"

"Al isn't going to talk to us anymore if you keep writing like that."

"What did I write?"

"You know what you wrote."

I'm genuinely confused. I wrote today: *"Al Avila arrived late at the GM meetings, his flight from Detroit delayed an hour or so. The delay wasn't his fault... But it's a problem Avila contributed to with wild spending last winter that couldn't deliver enough wins."*

I stay huddled next to Avila from start-to-finish, asking every question there is to ask about the Tigers' off-season plans.

He is an open book. During the half-hour, he frequently flips between on and off-the-record, rambling about this or that. He's my kind of guy—a Ball Writer's kind of guy.

It's almost dark when I walk to the lobby bar tonight. When I squeeze to the front for a beer, someone with a phone exclaims, "We got Michigan!"

Within the hour, it becomes clear that Donald Trump may very well win the presidency tonight.

Heading back to my villa, I stroll slowly past a fire pit, side-eying a man in a white shirt—it's Al, surrounded by Tigers' execs. Loud, laughing and drinking.

I walk up with one objective—to find my way up there. I stop by and say, "Hey."

Al doesn't recognize me at first but once he does, "Boy, do I have a bone to pick with you," he says.

"You know what. Why don't you come up here?"

For the next hour and a half, the Highest Source In The Land holds court—Grey Goose in one hand, Cuban cigar in the other. Legal counsel John Westhoff goads him on. David Chadd sits to my right.

Al airs his grievance.

"It's bullshit what you wrote in the paper, saying I showed up late. I wasn't late! What if my owner reads that?"

I play defense, pulling up the article on my phone.

"I literally wrote 'it wasn't Avila's fault.'"

"I wasn't late!"

Feeling on the outside of an inside joke, I concede.

"Technically, you weren't late."

"Thank you. Now get him a drink."

Avila includes me in upcoming rounds, bantering loudly, unbothered by the Ball Writer who has infiltrated the scene.

Brad Ausmus arrives, fresh off a flight from San Diego. Analytics manager Sam Menzin plays waiter, shuttling drinks from the open bar.

By the second drink, I'm too comfortable here. My foreign presence provides an easy target. *Watch what you're saying when Fenech's around... The Fake News Media... Earmuffs, Anthony!*

They josh, asking me to reveal my sources. I joke back, shining what I intend to be a light-hearted spotlight on David Chadd.

"David Chadd's my source. You guys know that."

"Oh, no, Anthony. No, no, no."

"C'mon. You know I get all the info from him."

"Better watch yourself, Anthony."

I laugh it off. I'm kidding. Obviously.

"Seriously. I'm just kidding."

I've made a Jack and Coke-fueled mistake. David Chadd is my longest-standing relationship In The Room—he was a source, and joking or not, I just outed him in front of his coworkers.

DETROIT, November 16—Toiling for some relationship-cultivating clickbait, I take an informal poll of Cy Young voters.

Justin Verlander is a finalist.

"Every voter I've talked to had him first," one writer says. "A bunch of others, too."

I tweet my findings and hook the big fish himself. Justin likes the tweet and follows me.

Kate leaves me hanging. She will, however, be very active later tonight.

Verlander finishes runner-up, five points behind former teammate Rick Porcello in the second-closest vote ever.

He was left off two ballots altogether—both writers in the Tampa Bay chapter. Neither voted for him in the top five.

While I'm mad scrambling to rewrite the story, Mike Milchin is on Line 1.

"It is my hope that this debacle creates transparency and change. Thank you for your time on this earlier."

One of the voters tells the *New York Daily News* he sent in his ballot with about a week remaining in the regular season, perhaps even before Verlander's final two starts.

Meanwhile, somewhere along the Amalfi Coast, nobody is more surprised than Kate: "Hey @MLB I thought I was the only person allowed to fuck @Justin-Verlander?! What two writers didn't have him on their ballot?"

Upton's 2 A.M. tweet in Italy has the web desk thinking hits.

"Check her out on Twitter. Might be worth writing up."

I would rather write my obituary.

I'm an official BBWAA card-carrying citizen who voted Verlander for Cy Young. I didn't think it was close, and my reporting shows that. Kate Upton obviously agrees.

Channel 4's Bernie Smilovitz calls, wondering if I can come into the studio for a quick hit. I smoked earlier and really should say no, but Bernie is my mom's favorite sportscaster.

In the newsroom, Bernie asks about the vote and then sticks me with the *Entertainment Tonight* question I feared—asking for my reaction to Upton's tweets.

"I'm just glad that I voted for Verlander so Kate Upton can't come at me."

OXON HILL, Md., *December 4*—Walking into the resort, the first recognizable face I see is Jim Leyland. He's on the phone, wearing loafers with no socks.

I send in a quick story when I get to my room—while checking on a few players on the ride here, I learned from Jarrod Saltalamacchia's agent that they're not bringing him back.

I bounce from fresh faces with new perspectives to baseball lifers with the wisdom of experience.

Tonight, the festivities open alongside Kristie Ackert from the *New York Daily News* and Mets manager Terry Collins. Ackert covers the miserable Mets beat; she's quickly become one of my better friends since we met last year.

I move from baseball lifers like Collins to a table with two college-aged kids named Jake Mintz and Jordan Shusterman, who started a blog called Céspedes' Family BBQ. They're a breath of fresh air. We bond over video games.

December 5—I start the winter meetings hot, getting the first scoop out of the way early. Working remotely from my 12th-floor hotel room, I text Ian Kinsler.

"Are you playing for Team USA in the World Baseball Classic?"

"I believe so. The union asked me, Leyland asked me... why?"

"Trying to get a scoop, lol."

To pitching coach Jeff Jones: "Is Justin pitching in the WBC?"

"Not that I'm aware of."

To Brad Ausmus: "A couple things I've heard: Kinsler playing in WBC, Verlander no."

"I haven't confirmed it with either of them. Pretty sure Kins is playing. Haven't talked to Ver about it yet."

After lunch, my scoop scrolls across the TV: KINSLER TO PLAY FOR TEAM USA.

The host of this year's shindig is a resort along the Potomac River and dressed in glass scaffolding reminiscent of modern stadiums.

Between two giant banks of luxury hotel rooms, each 19 floors high, the main floor transforms this week into a baseball-themed winter wonderland. Snowflakes stream from the ceiling, and a large Christmas tree overlooks the water. Criss-crossing the indoor city beneath the glass, baseball executives, scouts, agents, plenty of media and sometimes even the players themselves make their way through the constant hum of industry chatter.

Throughout the week, I use the lobby bar to take my relationship with newly minted sources to the next level. In October, I sent out a 150-person sourcing round—adding five new people per team to the ScoopSheet. I followed up in November before the GM meetings.

The goal is to advance the conversation past emails as quickly as possible. I met a few sources in person at the GM meetings last month.

Afternoon action comes at a press conference inside a walled-off ballroom on the main floor. Today, Major League Baseball released a list of 30 players who will participate in next spring's World Baseball Classic. Jim Leyland is coming out of retirement to manage Team USA.

While Leyland speaks with reporters, his phone rings in clear view of those close to him.

"JV" is calling.

"This is Verlander. Maybe we got him."

Based on my reporting, that's not happening.

Ron Colangelo reaches out around dinner: "Leyland wants to connect with you."

When we do, Leyland is leaving an instant replay meeting.

He still reads the newspaper every day. And he's read fan comments enough to know how fans will react if Verlander passes up Team USA.

I ask him: "Verlander not pitching—is that true?"

"Probably not pitching... Great talk with him today."

The skipper is trying to protect his former player. He's getting in front of the story.

"We had a great conversation, and after we talked about everything, I just felt that maybe it was best for him to skip it. He was into it. He wanted to do it. He was positive about it, but we talked about a lot of different circumstances, and we just felt—particularly, me—that it was probably best for him."

December 6—I finally meet Mike Milchin in the flesh. He stands more unassuming than most agents. Glasses, red sweater, black leather jacket.

“I’m here. Upstairs standing next to the concierge.”

He holds a legal pad, crossing off a list of folks to see as the day wears on.

I keep our face-to-face introduction quick. We chit-chat about Verlander not playing in the WBC. Milchin has a few free agents but says Detroit isn’t in. Firm handshake and a fond farewell. Milchin surprises me—I think we might get along.

Back up in the room, I highlight Milchin’s name in teal.

December 7—Another sourcing milestone, flagging down agent Jay Franklin. After playing phone tag for three days, I pinned him down Wednesday afternoon at a resort watering hole.

I’d been working on Franklin for two years, cold calling and leaving voice-mails. I’ve scared off others with far less, I’m sure. I salute him with a shot of whiskey. One of the more important persons in my life, so it’s good to finally highlight his name—he represents a couple of key players on the team.

A news desert is making the Tiger Beat desperate for crumbs of information. Every time I ask a question I feel like Oliver, pleading for more porridge.

I look hard for things not meant to be seen. Sitting close to Avila’s table during tonight’s media session, I see his phone flash. I text a Houston source:

“(Astros GM) Jeff Luhnow just called Avila.”

“About?”

“That’s what you need to find out.”

My guy wonders if it could be Justin Wilson. The lefty reliever is the Tigers’ most talked-about trade chip.

The Highest Source In The Land has ignored me all week at the winter meetings. I’ve been texting him at the same time every day, to see how long he can keep it up.

“You got anything cooking?”

No answer—again.

DETROIT, January 27, 2017—The *Free Press* drops its latest reorganization today. In a 21-page PDF dubbed “*Freep Forward*,” top editors introduce new Gannett gobbledygook.

My job hasn’t changed, but others have—general assignment reporters are now “storytelling writers,” editors are “directors,” and assistant editors are “planners.” The photo/video desk is now the “consumer product team.”

Every department has a mission statement, except two of them: The copy desk and print team mission statements say only, *Need mission statement...*

According to the document, we still have a (whoops!) music & *entertainment* reporter and a (whoops!) *restaurants* reporter. So much for the copy desk.

In Sports, my boss (sports editor) Kevin Bull is now “senior planner/digital.” There’s also an “OPEN POSITION” for “sports content coach.”

Odds are this position will never get filled.

If it does, God help us all.

SECAUCUS, N.J., *February 9*—Visiting MLB Network’s studios, I peel the visitor’s badge and stuff it in my coat. I’m going on the morning show, sitting across from *Sports Illustrated*’s Tom Verducci.

Ken Rosenthal is behind the glass.

“What the Tigers are counting on is avoiding the injuries from last year. That’s what they’re banking on to get them back to the postseason.”

With time to kill, I message Tim Baratta, a boutique agent who lives nearby in Jersey—the first agent to call me back when I started cold-calling. He calls me “Big Time” over lunch and mentions Tigers owner Mike Ilitch.

Ilitch, 87, hasn’t made a public appearance in more than a year—not even for the team picture last year.

“What’s going to happen to the team when he’s gone?”

Baratta drops me at the train station, and I begin to retrace my steps—New Jersey Transit to Grand Central to D.C.

Thirty minutes outside of Union Station, things change.

Michael Ilitch Sr., the patriarch of one of the most powerful families in Michigan, a self-made multi-billionaire who started Little Caesars Pizza and owned two of Detroit’s storied professional sports teams, has died.

WASHINGTON—My first job is to get another independent confirmation.

I text agents who can help me reach players. No luck with most. I do talk to Scott Boras, though.

He made a lot of money off Ilitch—over \$350 million in contracts since 2004, when he first got Ilitch’s ear by convincing him to sign All-Star catcher Iván “Pudge” Rodríguez.

Boras sold Ilitch on a bigger dream by explaining baseball’s big-spending reality. He convinced him that Detroit was a below-the-radar baseball hotbed. He knew what Ilitch wanted more than anything: a World Series title. “The best way to get it,” Boras told him, “is to buy the best players.” What Ilitch bought was

damn near the dream Boras sold him: The Tigers went on a 10-year run, winning divisions and making deep postseason runs.

Scott sounds unusually emotional. “In the end, what made Mike Ilitch a winner was his passion. Because he really, really studied the game. These weren’t business decisions. This was something very close to his heart.”

PRIME-TIME

TAMPA, Fla., *February 12, 2017*—The calendar begins when I arrive to spring training.

I text Pedro Gomez on the way to the airport.

“Thinking about what you told me about three years on beat.”

“Third year is the defining moment. You now OWN the beat.”

I land in Tampa feeling like it. My third year begins with the first apparent death threat I’ve received. I come across it while strolling through my Twitter mentions in the rental car line.

Courtesy of one Twitter troll: user @d159program: “I hope next headline is ‘FL bound plane crashes, Fenech burns’... I don’t think we’ll need dental records but maybe, because I think Fenech is all burnt up.”

I feel only mildly creeped out. Not quite a death threat but impressed nonetheless by garnering that kind of hatred in the first place. I am a *Ball Writer*—I write about *baseball*.

LAKELAND, Fla., *February 13*—Nothing much is happening in Tiger Town, 24 hours before pitchers and catchers officially report.

I was in-and-out by noon, bringing to mind something a Pittsburgh writer once said: “I would love to see the look on our editors’ faces if they found out what we do early in spring training.”

The routine is always the same early in spring training. Arrive at 8 A.M. and gather ‘round the Tigers’ infield practice area. Watch pitchers and catchers play catch. Half throw bullpen sessions, then they go back into the clubhouse. We follow ‘em, get 15 minutes of clubhouse time and file out half past noon.

I stick around after the other reporters leave, wandering the back fields.

“What’s up, Anthony!”

I hear it clearly from way over here. Justin Verlander raises his right arm.

“What’s up, man?”

After long toss, I ask: Couple questions on the way out?

“No problem.”

Five minutes becomes 30 becomes an hour. At least I'll have a good sunburn.

February 15—This morning, we're allowed into the brand-new clubhouse for the first time.

Joker Marchant Stadium has undergone a massive renovation.

The formerly cramped clubhouse, where players and reporters would literally bump into each other, is now a spacious rival to their Detroit digs. There's enough space for established stars to have two lockers and the kitchen is staffed round-the-clock by chefs. I smell omelets.

This is my new domain as a Ball Writer. The clubhouse is where we do our most important work—reporting, sourcing, relationship-building.

But old or new, all clubhouses are alike. As Kristie Ackert says: "The clubhouse is a lot like the kindergarten classroom—you truly have to deal with every child differently."

Today's child is Justin Verlander, eldest offspring of Rick and Peggy Verlander. Justin doesn't know it yet, but I've got a lesson planned for him.

Following workouts, we crowd around Verlander's locker—beat writers, a couple TV anchors and cameramen, PR folks. I'm to his left. Five or six questions in, when I feel the right lull, I ask him, "Did you blow me off yesterday?"

This doesn't sit well with him.

"No," he scoffs. "I don't know what that was all about."

He takes two more questions, and the crowd breaks up. He walks off, toward the middle of the clubhouse. We cross near a laundry basket.

"I didn't blow you off," he says.

"Well, I was sitting out there."

"Well, I had things to do."

And that was that.

Walking out of the clubhouse, someone looks at me and says, "Why the hell would you do that?"

I know how sensitive Justin is about his on-camera image, which is why I called him out on-camera. One time, he had barbecue sauce on his bottom lip—nobody told him about it—and for a while, he wouldn't talk to the media.

"I don't know," I laugh. "I really don't know."

But I knew—I just wanted him to know I wasn't getting pushed around.

February 16—He likes my tweet this morning, a picture of the waffle machine.

"Good morning, beautiful."

I awoke early to start this spring's sourcing round. From opposing teams' media guides, I came up with a few front office execs for each team, plus scouts and advance scouts. Before our teams cross paths this spring, I'll try to initiate meetings.

This year, I'm targeting younger team officials in line for promotions in years to come.

March 15—HSITL invites me to his spring abode, where we share a smoke on the balcony. Avila is staying at Grasslands, a gated community with a golf and country club.

Avila's place is a second-story flat. David Chadd and another executive, a longtime business guy, are watching the WBC semifinals—Venezuela against Team USA in San Diego.

They don't seem to bat an eye when I arrive, like it's the most normal thing in the world that the beat writer is here drinking with the GM. But I'm harangued when I choose a coffee mug from the cabinet to drink a cocktail.

Avila's drink of choice is Grey Goose with just a splash of tonic. He pours two of them. We get some space and head outside for cigars. He puts the music on.

For the next hour and a half, we smoke, drink and talk. Nothing about the team—*anything* but the team. We're just two guys getting to know each other, making a personal connection.

As if on cue, Avila asks, "You know why I like you?"

"Because I'm cool?"

"It's because of your dad."

As Al's story goes, one day my father approached him near the entrance of the prestigious Detroit Athletic Club. My Dad works the door there. Avila was arriving for an event. Dad, a born Detroiter, is a compassionate man and cares about his three sons a lot. That day, he couldn't help himself: He introduced himself to Avila and asked him to be good to me.

"And I'll never forget that."

Avila himself is a father of three. An all-around good guy. He dips the cigar into his drink. "I could tell your dad is a good man." The best, I say. Avila tells stories about his climb up the scouting ranks and how he met his wife. He refills our drinks twice.

March 28—With Opening Day only 72 hours away and the Tigers' roster not finalized, I wake up on high alert.

“You hear anything?”

“Nope.”

Agent Gene Mato represents veteran righty Aníbal Sánchez, who is locked in a battle with young lefty Matthew Boyd for the fifth rotation spot.

When the clubhouse opens to reporters, I stay out of the dressing room, observing the hallway.

I notice the shades in Ausmus’ office are drawn. Sánchez walks in.

“He’s in there talking with Dubee and Brad.”

Before he walks out, the clubhouse closes.

“Let me know.”

“I was right,” Mato responds.

I don’t actually know what he’s right about. I *think* I know but need to be sure.

Deep Throat keeps me busy while I wait for answers.

“What’s the scoop?”

“Boyd rotation. But I can’t go with it yet.”

“Why not?”

“Because Al and Brad aren’t answering.”

“You’re soft.”

CHICAGO, *April 4*—After a rainout, Opening Day finally arrives.

I’m in my third year of making the Opening Day clubhouse rounds, offering up a handshake and, “good luck, good health.”

This year, I add the training staff to the mix. Trainers, like coaches and scouts, love being treated as being part of the team—because they very much are.

As I stand in the clubhouse pregame, seeking out any strays I’d missed, closer Shane Greene shouts to me from his seat along the wall. I’ve grown increasingly comfortable with Greene over the past year.

“Hey Anthony. Come here.”

Greene thumbs through his phone.

“Remember when you asked if you could see my blister last year and I said ‘hell no’ or something like that? Well, here’s what it looked like.”

He turns the phone to me, showing the kind of multi-colored, oozing blood blister that would put a pitcher on the disabled list—the kind of blister I hope to never in my life see again.

Outside in the dugout, there’s an industrial-strength propane heater at one end, blowing fire. I sit mostly by my lonesome, on the top seat where the manager would.

I’m wearing a red knit winter hat. Wind bounces around the stadium, which is silent but for the symphonic melody of the grounds crew’s equipment

tinkering with the tundra. A pair of bundled-up pitchers walk onto the field and out toward the bullpen. As I start to follow their trail, I feel a hand on my left shoulder.

Al Avila has come to receive his good-luck handshake. We bring it in for a warm hug instead.

And, despite conditions, the game is played. Verlander wins on Opening Day.

ST. PETERSBURG, Fla., *April 16*—I text Al when I land: “Where we smoking a stick at?”

Instant response: “In front of the Vinoy after dinner.”

I drop my bags off at the hotel and pre-drink at an Irish pub a few blocks from the Vinoy Resort. Originally built in the 1920s, this four-star hotel overlooks the bay.

The Vinoy is far too classy for any of my shenanigans tonight. I came on the road trip naked but scored some green from the bartender. He’s got nothing to put it in, so we settle on a Styrofoam cup. When he messages, I carry it with me.

Walking up to the Vinoy, I stash the cup in some tall weeds behind a trash can across the street. Al Avila is hosting a table on the hotel’s restaurant patio tonight. I certainly wasn’t expecting Alex Avila and his wife to be here—the other two gentlemen I don’t recognize.

Even so, it’s good company to join—invited to a post-dinner splash with HSITL, his son, and the family friends I’m soon introduced to. They bow out couple-by-couple until it’s just the two of us left.

One talked his way into drugs earlier. The other keeps talking his way into more drinks before the night finally ends. We embrace for a hug goodbye.

April 18—Standing in front of the visitor’s dugout, staring into the camera, hand shaking a bit as I hold the microphone. Jordan Zimmermann walks by, as close as one can without touching me. I’m waiting for today’s MLB Network spot to begin.

“Face for radio if I’ve ever seen one.”

Zimmermann’s dry humor is appreciated—I’m still more than a tinge nervous for the red light, and he loosens me up. The veteran righty starter is a pretty solid guy, I’ve found—the Wisconsinite out of Division III University of Wisconsin-Stevens Point comes with more normal qualities than most hundred-millionaires.

We exchanged numbers at the end of the season. Our subsequent offseason exchanges were entertaining, with Zimmermann either acting like he doesn't have my number or saying something sarcastically stupid. This is to say—I like him.

OAKLAND, Calif., *May 7*—“*Are those the same pants you had on yesterday?*” Brad Ausmus asks.

“Yeah, they are. Thanks for noticing that. I got nine different shirts for this road trip, and you call me out on the pants. Tough crowd.”

Ausmus is more interested in his tablet than the Tiger Beat gathering round. He's asked if Nick Castellanos is going through a little bit of a slump right now: “Not really. He's actually hitting the shit out of the ball.”

He's following the real-time GameCast data of a Class A minor-league game. Now batting J.D. Martinez, the Tigers' rehabilitating slugger who could return within the week—Martinez has been out with a foot strain since stumbling over a sprinkler in the spring.

“What did J.D. just do?” Ausmus waits for the screen to load. “He hit a home run.”

ANAHEIM, Calif., *May 11*—Waiting for my luggage at John Wayne Airport, itching for a scoop, I decide to give J.D. a try.

“You know when you're joining the team yet?”

We're in Disneyland this week, where Detroit hasn't won a series since 2009. Martinez's impending return should give the starting lineup a boost—he homers again today, this time for Triple-A Toledo. He doesn't text back.

Martinez rejoins the team tomorrow. He singles in his first at-bat, then hits two homers the next night. After the game, I head back to the hotel. In the parking lot, I come across first base coach Omar Vizquel and his teenage son, Nico.

Vizquel off-handedly asks for a ride. I don't know if he's joking.

“I'm looking for the Uber lot.”

“I don't know where the Uber lot is, but I can give you a ride.”

I drive them to the team hotel in Newport Beach.

CHICAGO, *May 26*—Halfway through the longest road trip of the season—11 games in 12 days—I land at O'Hare around 2:30 A.M. and check into my room past four. I set an alarm for 9:30 and shut the curtains.

Stepping into the hotel gym, I'm smacked by breaking news while scrolling Twitter.

"If Tigers are still under .500 by end of June, sources say... all veterans will be available in trade."

I head up to the room and write a story. I don't return to the gym.

May 27—I write a column decoding Morosi's reporting for the readers.

"Within that message was a message from the front office to the team. That message was clear: You guys need to start playing better, and soon."

The words drive Avila berserk—he's booming through my phone between the doubleheader, taking exception to the notion he'd be communicating through the press.

KANSAS CITY, Mo., *May 29*—Avila accepts my apology, messaging early Memorial Day: "I read your stuff. Now we can kiss and make up."

I arrive early to the stadium and hop on MLB Network in a suit while Ausmus completes his workout routine around the field. I sweat through my suit in only five minutes on the field. Afterwards, I squat in front of an industrial fan inside the visitor's dugout to dry off.

Standing alongside Jason Beck in the clubhouse, I scan the large throw-back baseball cards displayed above players' lockers, easily identifying the stadiums the photos were taken in. I acquired this talent rummaging through boxes of my dad's baseball cards in the basement.

"Impressive," Beck nods.

Justin Verlander must think so, too. Momentarily, he walks up with a kind smile on his face, bearing gifts.

"Anthony," pinning a red poppy onto my baby blue blazer.

"Jason," pinning a red poppy onto Beck.

I do my part to further Justin's philanthropic endeavors by writing a piece on the red poppy.

May 30—The next day, as I'm standing in the same spot with Beck, Francisco Rodríguez walks up. K-Rod does not seem happy.

Last night, he blew another save—his fifth in 12 tries this season, ballooning his ERA to 7.79.

Making matters worse, he read what I wrote in the paper. By *what I wrote*, I mean *what the manager said*: “We have to find out if he can pitch with the game on the line, quite frankly.”

This distinction makes no difference to Rodríguez, who holds his phone and waves me closer. On the screen, his career stats are proudly shown—spanning 16 seasons and 437 saves, fourth-most all-time.

“You see these? How many saves? Is that good?”

“Yes, it’s very good... Borderline Hall of Fame good.”

“You think that’s mop-up? I can’t pitch in close games?”

Before I can explain to K-Rod the difference between what I wrote and what the manager said, he shakes his head and walks away.

FIREWORKS

DETROIT, *July 2*—Get a ping from Top Scout: At the park? Let's talk.

Sure am. Media dining room. He's rooting for a quick game—flying out this evening.

Top Scout is a special-assignment guy, handling the highest priorities. He's a trusted advisor for the Cubs front office, who sent him to watch Justin Verlander pitch.

It's trade deadline season and the Tigers are sellers. The rebuild is coming.

Top Scout asks what I think.

Verlander definitely wants out. "He might *need* to get out."

I'd get tons of retweets by disclosing Top Scout, but I don't—with a month until the deadline, I'm not risking relationship gains to feed the rumor mill.

I *do* pass it along to agent Mike Milchin.

"FYI: Cubs sent one of their special assistants here to watch Justin."

He's clubbed by Cleveland, pulled in the fourth inning. For the first time in his career, he strikes out nobody.

Top Scout heads to the airport early.

UP NORTH, Mich., *July 4*—Although I promised not to be on my phone this holiday weekend, here I am—scrolling underneath sunseting skies, still cursing National Guy Jon Morosi to the heavens.

Morosi is one of the nicest guys you'll ever hate. Yesterday, he blew my cover. First, he shared my inside information on Twitter: "Cubs inquired to Tigers on availability of Justin Verlander and Alex Avila, sources say, but sides have not engaged in trade negotiations." Then he called out my source, telling everyone that a "top Chicago scout" was at yesterday's game.

Still thinking about it a day later, since I abandoned the plan of spending vacation without a phone glued to my hand.

Yet here I am, sneaking swipes at Twitter every ten minutes. Tonight, I sit at a campfire on a sweater-weather summer evening—fireworks, stars, all that jazz—after a day I strove to stay off the phone. An off day. I see the progress

I've made—1 hour and 27 minutes on Twitter—a 43 percent decrease from yesterday.

I'm on the beat. That's every day from February to October. These are workhorse sports-writing roles—the first thing you think about in the morning and the last thing you think about at night. Your life is dictated by your job. You're diving out of luggage, usually alone and married to the game.

Soon going overboard, taking a full-blown work call.

Beat mate George Sipple just called to say Mark Snyder, our machine-like Michigan beat writer, is leaving the paper.

The *Free Press* sports department is starting to smolder.

When I became a full-timer in September 2011, the Freep Sports schedule listed 37 names, including 15 writers. Now, we're down to 16 names, with nine writers.

The old newsroom I first walked into was home to a Who's Who of sports writers, starting with Mitch Albom, a pioneering multimedia sports writer who found fame with bestselling book *Tuesdays With Morrie*. But beyond Mitch, there are names like Jason LaCanfora, then a hockey beat writer and now an NFL National Guy. Rob Parker, who trampolined his two years as the *Freep's* first Black sports columnist into TV and radio roles.

Nick Cotsonika, who aced three beats (college, NHL and NFL) before settling in as an NHL National Guy with *Yahoo! Sports*. Michael Rosenberg, a sports columnist snapped up by *Sports Illustrated*. Then there's Jemele Hill, the most badass of the bunch, who went from the *Free Press* to ESPN to superstardom. Last year, Hill—a Black woman, native Detroit and culture queen—made it all the way to the White House, where she hosted a town hall on race with President Barack Obama.

We were a talent factory, with a stable of experienced editors and centuries of institutional knowledge greasing a well-oiled machine.

Freep Sports in the '80s and '90s and beyond was the place to be. Joe Falls. Mike Downey. Charlie Vincent. We covered everything and sent sports writers everywhere—Daytona, Augusta, the Olympics.

Not too long ago, we could make the argument that we were the best sports department in the country. Now, we're just a shell.

Nobody seems safe. Beat writers are in the crosshairs, fighting off aggregators, influencers and hot-take artists. Many left on their own. It felt personal, watching the hardest working reporter walk away. It will get worse in a hurry. Sports editor Kevin Bull resigns, citing "an even more important and involved job... one that centers on my two kids."

But even as the newspaper industry and the *Freep* have been buffeted, the beat remains. My job is to cover a team with its own accelerating change—none of it good.

DETROIT, *July 5*—I get a message from Mitch Albom—he’s looking for his Baseball Writers’ card.

“Do you or someone have my baseball writers pass? Trying to track it down.”

I have been safe keeping his card since the chapter chair handed ‘em out. The Tigers haven’t been good enough to get Mitch out to the yard, save an Opening Day here or there.

He needs the badge for a pregame on-field promotion for his theater play.

Before the best-selling books, Mitch won the yearly top sports column contest 13 times. Only one other columnist has won it twice. He influenced a generation of sports writers, many of whom were introduced to him not via print but on TV—watching *The Sports Reporters* on Sunday mornings on ESPN. He made the job cool.

“I’ll be at Hockeytown Cafe in the theater. Can you drop it by?”

Of course, I can—it’s not every day you get a chance to DoorDash your idol.

KANSAS CITY, Mo., *July 17*—With the trade deadline two weeks away, I’m on special assignment, sort of like Top Scout.

I’m accompanying teammate George Sipple to Kansas City—a good old fashioned fire sale could begin flaming soon, we don’t want to be caught flat-footed.

Inside the clubhouse, players admit to hearing their names.

“It’s definitely getting down to it and you’re hearing it a lot more,” J.D. Martinez says before the series opener against the Royals. “Every time you look at the TV, MLB Network or whatever, you’re constantly seeing it. But I think it’s more for a guy like Justin (Wilson) than me, right now.”

Martinez and Wilson are two of the Tigers’ popular trade pieces. Detroit’s front office has decided to break up the band.

He is a month shy of his 30th birthday and will be a free agent after this season.

Facing a roster reset, Avila is all but certain to trade Martinez soon—so suspicions arise when he’s pulled late in the opener against the Royals. The Tigers are ahead by seven runs and Martinez doesn’t return to the field for the sixth. Injury? Trade? Playing it safe? Someone online says Víctor Robles, a top prospect center fielder in the Washington Nationals system, has been removed from his game. Related?

I text a Nats’ Top Scout: “Tigers want a young CF. Anything there?”

With Martinez's status up in the air, sources come to the Ball Writer for info. A Dodgers guy asks: "Whatcha got?"

I text him back. "Lower back tightness."

Not what the front office wants to hear—Avila had been discussing a Martinez trade with Arizona throughout the day. After the game, J.D. terms his exit "precautionary." He thinks dehydration may be to blame—it was 92 degrees at game time.

July 18—Cooler than that inside the press box, where news breaks an hour before the game. J.D. Martinez, hitting fifth and starting in right field, is "close" to being traded to the Diamondbacks.

"Close" is quickly becoming the accepted way of couching the scoop. A lot can happen between "close" and "done." Three minutes later, after one National Guy is credited with the "close" report, another National Guy swoops in.

It's "done," Jeff Passan says—J.D. Martinez to the D-backs.

Good thing they've got me here: I'm officially beaten on the story. I stop chasing confirmation and focus on what the Tigers are getting in return. I text nine sources, some of them part of the traveling front office party, currently huddled in a suite at the team hotel in Country Club Plaza. The trade is announced before I can get anything more.

We're called down to the dugout to talk with J.D.

Aw. His eyes are red. He hops onto the high seat.

"I grew up a lot here. I love this team, I love this organization. This is the organization that believed in me when no one else did."

After reconstructing his swing, the Astros' cast-off reclaimed his career with Detroit in 2014. He's turned a minor-league deal into \$21.5 million and counting.

J.D. is one of my favorites.

Not everyone is melancholy about the trade.

"That sucks about J.D.," I remark to a veteran pitcher in passing.

"Why? He sucks in the outfield."

KANSAS CITY, Mo., *July 20*—With trade deadline season in full swing, things are starting to pick up. I wake up to a tip from Jordan Zimmermann, who sent a pair of texts my way at 1:50 A.M.

"Got breaking news!... More breaking news!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!"

More substantial rumors need to be chased—a National Guy throws Justin Verlander's name into the wind, saying the Houston Astros are interested in both

Verlander and lefty reliever Justin Wilson. Poking around, I don't hear much about that one.

"Going on MLB Net later," I text a source. "I've gathered HOU interest in Verlander is overblown, would that be accurate?"

"Yes, it is. Probably won't happen."

DETROIT, *July 24*—Like an elephant, Mike Moustakas doesn't forget.

Walking through the Royals clubhouse this afternoon, minding my business, Moustakas calls me out.

"Hey, there's the guy that said we were a beatable team. Who's beatable now?"

When did I say that? A month ago, I went on MLB Network and said time was ripe for the Tigers to make a move: "Beginning with the Royals, they have some winnable games coming up."

Kansas City puts 'em in the casket: The Tigers are swept, outscored 24-6 in the series and fully humiliated at home—utilityman Andrew Romine recorded more outs than malcontent Bruce Rondon, who was ejected for throwing beanballs in the 16-2 loss.

Someone screaming in the showers, half-naked with a full smile walking out.

"I love this fucking team!"

After he dresses, I introduce myself to Moustakas.

"You guys really shoved it up my ass."

July 29—I've decided to write a column blasting the Tigers for their lack of competitiveness, calling them soft for how the team of high-priced veterans were bulldozed by the Royals.

I know my angle and what I'm going to write. Today, I don't see either Miguel Cabrera or Víctor Martínez—some players tend to hide when things aren't going well.

I stay late and wait for Ian Kinsler.

"Leadership... Is there anything this team is lacking besides players? Who are the lead—"

He cuts me off.

He's been doing this long enough to know what reporters are writing about by the questions they ask.

The clubhouse is emptying. "You already know what you're going to write. Just write it."

“Why would it make sense for me to talk about leadership? Because that would portray me as the leader of the team, and then this issue falls on my shoulders.”

Kinsler sits between Cabrera and Martínez’s empty lockers—the two players publicly portrayed as team leaders. He shrugs his shoulders and points at each side.

“What can I do? What can I say to those guys?”

Soon, the conversation becomes off-the-record. The kind that builds trust.

Kinsler says many things without really saying them. When I bring up the manager, he says the problems start above him.

“It starts at the top. At the top.”

Out of the corner of my eye, I see the grim reaper. It’s PR, cutting off the conversation.

“The clubhouse is closed.”

About ten minutes later, I see Kinsler on the field. He’s walking my way with a bat in one hand and another hand extended. We shake hands.

“Thanks for the chat earlier.”

“Same here. I enjoyed it.”

I decide to let him know what I know.

“Say... I know about what happened last year.”

“What?”

“The thing with Víctor.”

Kinsler looks back at me differently, knowing the damage it could do.

“Are you going to write it?”

I won’t write it just to write it—bringing up past clubhouse incidents without current relevance feels like tabloid territory.

He messages later. “Good talk today. Excuse me for being so guarded. I think... I’m not trying to blow anyone up.”

“Same here. I know it’s a sensitive situation... I’m not trying to blow anyone up, either, but it comes with the territory sometimes.”

“I guess. I think this will take care of itself and you will have plenty to write about.”

ARLINGTON, Texas, *August 14*—On my first day back on the beat after attending a wedding in Cancún, I head to Ian Kinsler’s corner. His locker is closest to the showers with an empty stall next door—respect shown to a veteran and former Texas Ranger.

I mention how tired I am from traveling—Cancún to Chicago to Fort Worth.

“Come on, man... You were in Cancún.”

Tonight, Kinsler is ejected in the fourth inning by home plate umpire Ángel Hernández for arguing balls and strikes. After a poor strike call on the first pitch of the at-bat, he sends a sarcastic remark back to Hernández following a ball outside— “How about that one?”

Hernández promptly tosses Kinsler, leading to one of the most memorable interviews of a Ball Writer’s life.

August 15—WHAT’S SAID IN HERE, STAYS IN HERE.

A big banner hangs on the wall in the visitor’s clubhouse here, above where Kinsler is sitting back in a scrum of reporters, sounding off on veteran umpire Ángel Hernández.

“He’s messing with baseball games. Blatantly. It’s not just like a borderline call here or there... I didn’t even cuss at him. I just said you need to re-evaluate your life, man. I’m just saying it’s pretty obvious that he needs to stop ruining baseball games... He needs to find another job. If I get fined for saying the truth, then so be it... He’s that bad. I’m not mad at him for being bad. He just has to go away.”

At the risk of spoiling the fun, I speak up.

“So, is this fair game? I’m just looking for clarity because you’re being very candid.”

“I don’t care. I’ll get fined, I guess. Candidly, leave the game. No one wants you behind the plate anymore. No one... None of the players.”

Kinsler talks for nearly 20 minutes.

“Write what you want. Just keep the cuss words out of it.”

August 16—Brad Ausmus says Kinsler has indeed been fined by the commissioner’s office—it’s by far the highest fine he’s seen in his career.

He won’t disclose the amount. Years later, Kinsler will—revealing it was \$10,000, roughly 18 percent of my yearly salary at that time.

Verlander pitches the series finale against Texas and loses, allowing five runs in six innings. Afterward, he seems to welcome questions about his future.

“Right now, I’m looking around the locker room and Miguel will be back here, I’ll be back here, Kinsler will be back here, Justin Upton will be back here and a lot of other guys. That’s a pretty good core of guys. There’s a brighter side to look at.”

“Is there anything specific in your mind that needs to change?”

Verlander knows where I’m going—the guy who sets the tone in the clubhouse and fills out the lineup card every day.

Verlander pauses. He utters an unconvincing “no” instead.

DETROIT, *August 22*—The commissioner is on the scene.

Making his annual trip around the circuit, Rob Manfred is at Comerica Park. With the coast clear and the Commish in town, I have an easy excuse for conversation with Justin.

I stroll up. “So, Manfred is here today...”

“Do you have any questions you want me to ask him for you?”

Verlander can’t help himself. “Ask him why they keep changing the balls.”

“I gotta throw... But you know what the worst part might be? That it’s going to impact the history books.”

He points to Al Kaline’s locker. “Guys like him, their numbers get shit on now. He’s got 3,000 hits... How many home runs did he hit?”

“399.”

“Exactly. He’ll get passed by guys nowadays—because of these baseballs—guys who couldn’t hold his jock strap.”

In divine intervention, Kaline walks this way. Justin turns back at me, as if to say—*We were just talking about him*. Verlander and Kaline stop to chat, and I join them. They’re talking about the solar eclipse. Apparently, Verlander flew to Nashville to watch the eclipse from inside the path of totality.

He describes how the sky went completely dark—so dark the streetlights went on. How everybody screamed, and some cried.

“It was the most beautiful thing I’ve ever seen in my life.”

“So, you’re kind of a dork, huh?”

“No. I’m not a dork.”

“No, no... I’m not saying it in a mean way. I’m a dork, too.”

“I like astronomy.”

“That’s interesting. I didn’t know that. I like space and science, too.”

I walk down the tunnel to the dugout and send two tweets:

Justin Verlander watched the solar eclipse from the Path of Totality. “It was the most beautiful thing I’ve seen in my life.”

Verlander, an admitted astronomy enthusiast, traveled to Nashville to watch the eclipse in its fullest totality.

I was trying to humanize the guy. Instead, he’s inflamed. A team PR official comes up to me during dinner in the press box and says, “JV didn’t like your tweets. He said he was in a private conversation with Al Kaline.”

Verlander isn’t at his locker postgame.

August 23—Same time as yesterday, just before batting practice.

I'm sitting in the dugout next to Omar Vizquel when I see Justin out of the corner of my eye.

He walks up the dugout steps behind us. I look back.

"Really? Really?"

Verlander returns serve with verbal rage, quickly going 0-to-100. He says this is horseshit and that is horseshit and I'm horseshit. I stand up and trail him out of the dugout.

"Justin, this isn't very professional. Do you want to talk about this?"

"Unprofessional? You know what's unprofessional? Do you know who that was? That's Al Kaline, a baseball legend!"

"Calm down. Let's talk."

Verlander walks onto the field. I follow.

"Get the fuck away from me!"

He walks to the pitchers' stretching circle in left field, shaking his head and waving his glove. He tells the other pitchers how I hijacked his private conversation with Mr. Tiger. Back inside the clubhouse, he shows the tweet around.

My up-and-down relationship with Justin has crashed again.

August 24—On the tarmac at DTW for a short flight to Chicago, watching highlights of today's base-brawl between the Tigers and Yankees.

TV cameras also catch an argument between Víctor Martínez and Justin Verlander, and it's galloping across the Internet. It's unusual for two veteran teammates to go at it like they do—screaming in each other's faces—especially a starting pitcher and designated hitter, who locker at opposite ends of the room.

By take-off, I know the time for the Very Serious Story has come. Before landing, I've decided on a plan.

A crew member comes over the speakers.

"Buckle up. Midway runways are short, and landings can be quite aggressive—make sure your seatbelt is tight."

VERY SERIOUS STORY

CHICAGO, *August 24*—I reach out to sources as we land.

To Al Avila—“I’m writing about how Víctor is a problem in the clubhouse, dating back to an incident last season. I can’t hold off any longer. The timing is never going to be good—but now with what happened today, it’s out there.”

To Ian Kinsler—“I just wanna run this by you. I’m planning on writing about Victor. If you have any thoughts on going about this, I welcome them.”

Avila: “No worries. You do what you have to do.”

Kinsler: “Do what you have to do. It’s your job. Just be careful with the other players. Good luck. Don’t get punched.”

“Lol”

“For real.”

I ask Al: “I’m about to lose the clubhouse for good, aren’t I?... Sorry, just thinking out loud. I strive to build players’ trust, and this might kill it all.”

Soon, he is shouting through the phone, saying how he wishes Víctor would just retire, for crying out loud. If he voluntarily retires, he’d forfeit the remainder of his salary.

The Very Serious Story is eating me alive.

August 25—With the bulk of the Very Serious Story written, I need to talk to Martínez and Ausmus at the ballpark today.

Ron Colangelo calls: “Anthony, what are you writing?”

“Anonymous quotes are not good.”

Víctor was once my strongest player-relationship in the room. When I drove two hours outside Cleveland one summer night in 2014, his minor-league foster parents allowed me into their house in Warren, Ohio, and talked with me for a story. I’m proud of the rapport I share with his son, Víctor Jose—all because his dad one day introduced me as Anthony, “who’s gonna be a really good baseball writer.”

Now here I am, pointing the pen at him.

Ten feet separate where I stand from Martínez's empty locker. When Martínez appears, it's the best-case scenario. He walks out a few minutes after the clubhouse opens. No players sit on either side—not many around, actually. I walk to him and tell him directly:

"I'm writing a story about how you've been a clubhouse problem. I know about the fight last year, and I've talked to players and coaches. So, if you want to answer questions..."

Víctor smirks, paying more attention to the tan bat he's taping up. He plays with the bat in his hands, rolling his wrists while making no eye contact.

"Look, you know I don't want to write this kind of story. I know your family..."

Martínez doesn't break character. Same look, still twitching the bat.

"Write what you want."

"Did you initiate a fight last sea—"

"Write what you want."

I ask Víctor if there's anything he wants to say. He shakes his head, looking straight down at the handle of his bat. He twirls it around and appears to be smiling now.

"Write what you want."

After Ausmus' pregame media session, I linger outside of his office as other reporters leave. I pop my head back in.

"Got a minute?"

As I sit down, media relations manager Chad Crunk appears. Ausmus waves him away.

I give him the low-down. There's a clubhouse problem with Víctor dating to a fight last season, and it's now out in the open. I'm going to write about it.

Brad is nothing if not consistent. He upholds his policy about not speaking on internal issues. Even when I afford him the chance to go off-the-record, he stands strong.

"Are there anonymous sources?"

He's dejected when I deliver the answer.

Back in the dressing room, James McCann wants to talk. In private.

"Can we talk outside?"

In his third season, McCann has earned a chunk of respect inside the Tigers' room. We've developed a good relationship—talking about personal topics, like our grandfathers growing ill and dying, and the challenges of living out of a suitcase.

"Is the story coming out?"

"Yeah. Tomorrow or Sunday."

"Who have you talked to?"

"You know I can't tell you that. All I can say is that I've had this for a while. And I've had people come to me with unsolicited information, that's how bad it's been."

McCann says there isn't a problem.

"It's a problem when guys are talking to me about it."

McCann says I should only write about what happens on the field.

He points out our working relationship, saying it could change: "You've always been good to me, and I've always tried to be good to you. I might not be able to do your interviews anymore if you write this."

We can't find common ground. We do shake hands, though. I follow him back inside, remembering what Pedro Gomez told me last night: "You cannot leave the clubhouse. You need to be in there from start to finish, until the second it closes."

I take in stares. Feels like forever. Finally, PR closes the room.

Tigers lose. The bullpen blows it, again.

Verlander pitches well. He throws seven innings, allows two runs and strikes out eight. But his postgame performance is the main event. As is custom, the starting pitcher always speaks with the media after the game.

We'll finally get the chance to ask about yesterday's shenanigans. The media crowd gathers around Verlander's locker. Rival Cohort begins: "I know you might not want to talk about what happened yesterday..." (Ausmus remarked pregame that Martínez and Verlander were playing cards on the short flight to Chicago.) "Everything is good, right?"

Verlander gladly takes the exit ramp. "All good."

I follow up.

"Justin, what happened yesterday between you and Víctor in the dugout?"

"What are you talking about?"

"The argument which was caught on video and shared on social media..."

Verlander cuts me off. "You should stop."

"The altercation that was shared on social media..."

"OK. I'm leaving."

August 26—Late in the game, a lump in my throat. Been building all day.

Sitting in the back of the press box, off to the side, small table near the fountain machine. I feel like I should reach out to Martínez's minor-league host family and tell them what's coming.

I start crying when I think about it. I walk out of the press box to the concourse ramp to calm myself. Back inside, once composed, I text Bob Bixler.

"Hello Bob, this is Anthony. This is a tough message to send..."

"Thanks for the heads up. Business is business."

He texts again: "I'm in Cooperstown watching Víctor's son play. Just giving you a heads up that I am with Víctor's wife, and I need to let her know what is coming. I'm sure her phone will explode tomorrow."

If we publish the story. Ron Colangelo has been in touch with a new desk guy who was hired in the spring as sports content coach. He and another Gannett editor fret until print deadline passes. But we can still publish online.

"This is going to drop tomorrow," Coach Content says.

"So, what are we waiting for?"

Postgame, I'm in and out of the clubhouse.

Packing up my stuff, Ian Kinsler texts me.

"Be careful. You might lose the clubhouse."

Maybe. But I knew I hadn't lost Kinsler.

Despite any previous pessimism, we iron out the final few wrinkles. The Very Serious Story is in the hopper by 11 P.M., ready to go live online at 1 A.M. local time—the plan is to run it in the following day's print edition.

But nearing midnight, I receive a most unnerving text message.

"U might want to hold off on ur story."

I handle this well: "What the fuck, man?... Sorry... What's up."

"I'm just saying the timing might not be great."

I ask why.

"U will find out tmrrw."

"You can't just say that. Like, there is a story that's going up very shortly. If you have a chance to call me, please do—because I do not want to fuck this up."

"You cannot use this. In any way at all."

"Ok."

"Vic went to the hospital tonight. Heart issues again. Gonna be DL'd. But u can't release this in any way, shape or form."

"Ok."

Brad saves our bacon.

It would've looked terribly tone deaf if we ran it on the day he's sent to the hospital.

"I appreciate you reaching out to me."

"Honestly, if this comes out before tmrrw, it will be a major issue."

"You have my word."

August 27—After fitful sleep, I see a text from a player, sent at 6:16 A.M.

"Did u write it??"

Word travels fast. When I talked to him about the Very Serious Story previously, he asked if it included anything about Martínez hogging one of the clubhouse TVs for video games.

I text him back. “Technically, yes... Did we publish it? No.” I explain why not.

“So that gave u a change of heart??”

“I don’t think we can run that story when he’s on the DL for that. That’s serious.”

“Glad u didn’t print it... Repercussions wouldn’t of been worth it.”

In a yellow cab to the stadium, I start to text Pedro Gomez and realize I haven’t confirmed that Martínez actually went to the hospital.

“The skeptic in me wonders if it’s too much of a coincidence, but I doubt it—that’s serious stuff.”

“That was my first thought, also. We have to be cynical. It’s part of our DNA... This is why holding things is never a good idea. Should have run two days ago.”

Inside the clubhouse, we’re quickly pulled into the manager’s office. Afterward, I attract eyes. Verlander and Jordan Zimmermann sneak looks from inside a cut-out cubby hole that doubles as a video area and snack bar.

I lean against the brick wall closest to Miguel Cabrera’s locker. Only when the clubhouse closes, only then, does Cabrera say something—shouting in Spanish as I turn to head out.

Sitting in the press box before game time, I text Bob Bixler again.

“Obviously, the story is not coming out now. I found out about the hospital shortly before it was set to go live and we canned it for the time being. I hope it doesn’t have to run.”

“I hope it never runs... I hope you understand!!”

Throughout the game, I’m kept company by those in the know.

“Send me the article,” a source says, sharing his personal address.

“That’s a well written drill down on a guy’s deterioration of character. Unpleasant. You may suffer a little blowback. Not on the substance of what you wrote. But on the ever-changing code to not write such things.”

The rest of the day is a daze.

After the postgame manager’s session, I split. Take the stairs to the third floor and quickly pick up my gear in the press box. Not even 30 minutes after the final pitch, I’m stuck behind a crowd of suite-dwelling drunks waiting for the elevator.

The last scene before the elevator door closes: A man’s bald head. Streaks of rain on the window. Dark clouds.

DENVER, *August 30*—The change of scenery has been welcome—my fortunes changed immediately after I landed in Colorado two nights ago. The cab driver got me to the dispensary just before closing time and I’ve slept well since then.

The visitor's digs at Coors Field are decidedly nicer than those in Chicago. With the Very Serious Story shuttered, tension inside the dressing room has dissipated. I've felt my way around, keeping a distance, unsure if I should talk to clubhouse sources in the open.

Justin Verlander is pitching today. Tomorrow is the waiver trade deadline.

Verlander leaves a good impression: He throws six strong innings, allowing one run on three hits. He strikes out nine and records his first career RBI.

They win, all is well, players are in good spirits. Of course, I had yet to walk in the happy clubhouse. Given the circumstances of the previous weekend and communication with PR—that Verlander isn't going to speak with me anymore—I'm on alert.

I tell Crunk: "You have to know that if Verlander doesn't want to speak to the media when I'm around, that's fine. But I'm not going to leave. My credential allows me to be there."

Crunk quietly sends the message to Verlander, who shakes his head in defiance.

Soon, he waves the writers over. Verlander puts on a sport coat, straightening the cuffs.

I wait for two others to ask questions before asking mine.

"How big were those two strikeouts in the fourth inning?"

His eyes dart away.

"Next question. Next question."

I wait my turn to ask another.

"How was your fastball today?"

Justin ignores me.

"Anyone else?"

He leaves.

August 31—When I arrive at the Denver airport for a two-leg trip home, the pieces for a wild trade are coming together in St. Petersburg, Florida.

Today, Astros manager A.J. Hinch is ejected early from Houston's hurricane-displaced game against Texas. Miffed, with time on his hands, Hinch connects with Tigers adviser Scott Bream and rekindles trade talks. From inside the visiting manager's office at Tropicana Field, over speakerphone, the framework for trade deadline fireworks is falling into place.

With my luck, Verlander will get traded while I'm in the air.

DETROIT—I get home after ten. Less than two hours to go, and conditions appear calm on the Verlander trade front, comfortable enough for a welcome back pour.

Deep Throat confirms the front office is In The Room. They are spending the deadline at Al Avila's suburban Detroit home.

I take a call from a Houston scout. We're in the same boat. We know nothin'.

That's when I see a tweet from my buddy.

"Oh, shit... Oh, shit. Gotta go."

The first person I text is Tigers GM—"Is it true?"

"What's going on? There's something out there about the Astros."

No answer back.

Assistant GM David Chadd: "Nothing."

"What's going on? Is there a deal?"

"No."

Rival Cohort retracts his report. "I have been told Verlander deal is off. Apparently, he didn't waive no trade clause."

Tapping in from the subway, a clued-in Astros guy says the deal isn't off. "Shit hit the fan; we had a deal done."

Thirty minutes until midnight. Pour another drink.

I reach out to Verlander's agent again. "Dude. My main competitor has this and you're hanging me out to dry."

Ten minutes before the deadline, I consider breaking forbidden glass: violating one of three cardinal rules to my long-standing relationship with Deep Throat.

I break the glass.

Deep Throat. Finally. "They still haven't said anything. So, we're finding out together."

A buzzer sounds on MLB Network. Midnight comes and goes without a word.

"Nothing????"

Finally, Deep Throat delivers the Big News: "Apparently, he said yes at 11:59."

But I can't claim this as my own yet. To Avila: "Come on. I got a tip it's done. What the hell."

I pray I don't get backdoored by Ken Rosenthal. I type the words in, ready to go.

The Tigers have traded Justin Verlander to the Astros, I'm told.

The cursor hovers over the button—CLICK HERE TO WIN.

Devil on my shoulder: Being first is all that matters. Brain: Being right is all that matters.

Al Avila is calling. I grab the phone as fast as I can.

"Is it done?"

“Yes, the deal is done.”

“Thank you.”

The call lasts 11 seconds. I click here and WIN.

My name crawls across the bright red breaking news bar on the TV screen. According to Anthony Fenech.

September 1—I arrive at the ballpark as Big Man On Campus—the beat writer who scooped the National Guys.

Doubleheader today—Tigers and Indians. I reach out to Richard Verlander, who was sleeping when it all went down. I text Verlander’s agent and notice something strange.

Competitor Katie Strang, seemingly in a rush, leaving between games.

Strang’s reporting nose takes her to a popular brunch restaurant in the ‘burbs.

“I knew it was their spot and figured they would give it one more go before leaving town.”

She took a seat at the bar, sent drinks and intercepted the couple leaving.

Luckily, Verlander kept quiet. His agent gets back to me: “I’ve not commented in 19 years on any transaction and or how/why it happened. Sorry.”

With no thanks to Mike Milchin, here’s the backstory of the deal...

Everything changed with a phone call at 10:30 P.M.—Astros general manager Jeff Luhnow to Al Avila.

Ninety minutes later, the two sides came together. Two Tiger officials made the 10-minute drive from Avila’s house to Verlander’s apartment with simple instructions: “Wait.”

The Tigers put pressure on him by leaking that he blocked it. Minutes before midnight, Verlander waived his no-trade rights.

When the deal was done, I was the first reporter to know. I sat on the news for nearly ten minutes, holding out for a second source. I got that first, too—breaking the Big News about my favorite player growing up.

WORLD SERIES

DETROIT, *May 22, 2007*—It's my first week at the *Free Press*.

I'm 19 and finishing my second year at community college. I didn't really apply myself in high school and got a 2.8 GPA. The plan was to get good grades and transfer to a big journalism school, but school has never been my thing.

So, I'm diving headfirst into sports journalism. I worked an unpaid internship at Detroit's sports radio station last year, and I still write blogs for the show's website sometimes.

Inside a back room on the newsroom's third floor, I receive my first taste of the job, answering phones as coaches call in to report scores and statistics. I put 'em in a text file and send 'em to an editor before deadline.

August 31, 2007—Sports writing is going great so far.

I've earned a bunch of "contributing" bylines for writing short game recaps. I find these stories easily when coaches call in with a close score. I gauge the game's worthiness by asking, "Was it a good game?"

If they answer convincingly, I ask for details and write a short story. Mom cuts them out of the paper as mementos.

Last month, I got the chance to cover my first game—a Little League matchup for the state championship. The local team's victory landed my story in the community section of the Sunday Paper!

The Prep Crew is packed to the gills during high school football season: Six guys every Friday night. Sounds like a call center. One person handles the score list: it's important to get as many scores into the early editions as possible.

We have an eclectic mix on the Prep Crew. One will carve out an impressive journalism career: Jon Machota will one day cover the Dallas Cowboys.

But many have no sports writing ambitions. Corey moonlights as rapper Leaf Erikson. Matt is going to business school. Charlie is a musician. Nobody knows what James does, or if it's legal.

From the back room where the Prep Crew sits, I look over my shoulder at a Sports Department powerhouse: cubicles filled, editors by the dozen and a roster of writers covering everything under the sun.

In 2007, Freep Sports has a staff of 44, including 24 folks manning the desk and 18 reporters covering Detroit's pro and college teams, including columnists and general assignment reporters.

September 5, 2007—Today is my first Tigers game as a member of the media. I'm official. I've got a credential with my name and affiliation: *Detroit Free Press*.

I'm tagging along with longtime Tigers beat reporter John Lowe, who obliged when asked to shadow him at a game. Lowe is an institution.

In the press box, John pulls a thick book from his bag. "Don't let me forget. I have something I want you to read."

Inside the clubhouse, I stand feet away from guys I grew up idolizing.

In the manager's office, Tigers skipper Jim Leyland is lying on a couch in a tank top, smoking a cigarette. He's asked about tonight's rain forecast.

"I had a rule in A-ball... They get on the bus, and I say, 'If you fuckers look up at the clouds, I'm fining the shit out of you.'"

Uproarious laughter.

Leaving Leyland's office, I'm sold on sports writing.

John looks at me. "That is what the Mona Lisa of baseball managers looks like. They're not all made like that."

Back in the clubhouse, I do what any 19-year-old would his very first time here—I walk up to my favorite player, Justin Verlander, last year's American League Rookie of the Year. Earlier this year, I nearly drove my car off the freeway when he threw a no-hitter. It was my grandma's funeral that day, which I think was a message from heaven.

I introduce myself as a *Free Press* intern and ask: "What do you chew?"

"Oh. Dip... Copenhagen straight."

I'm one numb-skull question away from Verlander calling security.

During the game, John has me track Kenny Rogers' pitch velocity. After I transcribe Leyland quotes, he passes me the book.

Leaving the ballpark, I'm hooked. I fear I've been drugged by this life.

February 10, 2008—I'm about to meet another legend today, after picking John Lowe's brain all winter. We'd meet up at bookstores and Ram's Horn.

Seamhead was already a Ball Writer at my age. I'm still answering phones.

But I did end up helping cover five Tigers games last year—and now I’m hanging out with broadcasting legend Ernie Harwell.

I’m at Harwell’s retirement complex for his surprise 90th birthday party. One of his friends invited me, and here I am sitting with Ernie and his wife Lulu.

Me and Ernie, shooting the breeze—my dad’s gonna think this is so cool.

“Who were your favorite performers?”

“The big bands, that’s the era I liked.”

He talks about Bing Crosby and Frank Sinatra. Brings up B.J. Thomas.

“I don’t know if you remember him or not.”

“I can’t even grow facial hair... I don’t remember a lot of those guys.”

I tell Ernie I want to be a sports writer.

“Freelance writer is a tough job. When I got out of school my senior year, I planned to be a newspaper man, and I couldn’t get a job. So, I’m really a failed sports writer.”

Ernie laughs.

I ask for his favorite sports writers.

“I think the sports writers today are a lot better than they used to be.”

Ernie praises Detroit sports writers—Mitch Albom, Drew Sharp, John Lowe.

One day, I hope to be mentioned in the same breath.

DETROIT, *September 22, 2017*—Ten years later, plans change in a hurry. It’s Friday afternoon and I’m ironing my suit jacket, getting ready for a wedding when I get a text.

3:33 P.M.—“What’s going to happen at Comerica today?”

Nothing that concerns me. The Tigers host the Twins—but I’m off.

“Picture Day?” (The day where everyone arrives early for the official team photo.)

It’s a local TV person, who says, “Between us, the Tigers called us to make sure we send someone down for pregame sound. I didn’t tell you.”

That doesn’t sound like Picture Day. It sounds like an alarm. Like I’ve been here before.

“What’s this presser about?” I text Brad.

“How did the beat writer from the paper of record get no heads up on a press conference?”

“Just get here,” Ron Colangelo says.

I text my friend: “I’m really sorry but not gonna be able to make it tonight... breaking news.”

Deep Throat reaches out—got my back. I text Al.

"I got a tip Brad isn't coming back and I'm going to go with it after I shower."

"Shower quickly."

George is there. Presser at 4:30 P.M. inside the dugout.

I'm two streets from home, driving through a school zone when I hit send. I'm not afraid to admit it: I pumped my fist.

Ausmus is out. I don't feel great about celebrating it—I like Brad a lot—but a scoop is a scoop. And if anyone was going to break it, it needed to be us. Been after him for years.

I listen to the presser on the radio driving in.

The Tigers aren't picking up Ausmus' option for next year. Avila says he told him two nights ago, which really kills my buzz from breaking the news.

I consider calling Brad after the game but figure he's all talked out. My column goes live: TIGERS PARTED WAYS WITH AUSMUS 2 YEARS TOO LATE.

KANSAS CITY, Mo., *September 26*—When the final road trip of the season begins, the team rests comfortably in free-fall mode, losers of seven straight. They are 4-19 in September. Between the lines and behind closed doors, most can't wait for the season to mercifully end.

I pop my head into Brad's office like I did last month in Chicago.

This time, I want to clear the air. Taking a seat across from him, I ask if he read my column.

"Yeah, I did."

"What are your thoughts on it?"

"I don't really have many. I'm a little surprised you didn't reach out to me."

Wince. The comment hits home. I should've.

"I could've given you my side of things. I think I've helped you out in the past..."

"And I appreciate that."

Brad thought I was piling on with the column. That wasn't my intention—but I definitely wish I'd called. He should've been given a chance to balance it out.

He's not mad, but he scrolls through his phone.

"The other day, I got this text from a baseball writer. I won't say who, but he said about your story—he said, 'That piece is the problem with our industry these days.'"

I'm dazed. The rest of my time I'm wondering who it is—probably Buster.

If I'm guilty of anything—and I am—it's that I didn't call, which is why I slinked in.

Ausmus has been in baseball longer than I've been alive. And now he's sitting across from a third-year Ball Writer who had the audacity to write that he should've been fired.

"Quite frankly," he says. "You're not qualified for your job."

Wince. He's not trying to be a jerk—I'd probably say the same thing.

I defend my credentials.

"Compared to a guy like John Lowe—no, I'm not qualified for my job... But I've been doing this for a while. I know how to write..."

I should've stopped there.

"I know baseball..."

"No, you don't. You don't know baseball."

What's a guy to say?

"I guess you're right."

October 1—The Tigers have just wrapped up a last-place season (64-98) with a lopsided loss to Minnesota.

When reporters entered the clubhouse, Miguel Cabrera sat visibly emotional in front of his locker with a towel draped over his head. Hitting coach Lloyd McClendon consoled him.

But after disappearing for a minute, Miggy re-appears with a big smile, smells like booze and sways our way.

He comes closer and says louder, "Lloyd McClendon... Fredi González... Ozzie Guillén."

Before I can establish an on- or off-the-record discussion, he's gently led away by the team's Spanish translator.

I wasn't the only Ball Writer who heard Miggy's endorsements. We don't write about it.

I circle back to Miggy on the way out.

"Have a good offseason."

"Later, bro."

Outside the clubhouse, I wait for the Highest Source In The Land. Al walks out with a phone to his ear.

"Just checking my voicemail."

"I just wanted to say thank you."

When we bring it in for a handshake and a hug, I see *Fredi González* on his screen.

"Fredi González, huh?"

"You motherfucker."

October 19—For the second year in a row, my birthday is interrupted by breaking news.

Last year, starting pitcher Daniel Norris revealed he'd been diagnosed with thyroid cancer. This year, the Tigers have hired a manager. In no surprise, Avila has opted for a veteran—Ron Gardenhire, longtime Minnesota Twins skipper.

To my chagrin, I'm caught off-guard by the news, broken by Katie Strang, now with the *Athletic*. I'm furious with Gardenhire's agent, John Boggs.

I was so out of touch with the Tigers' search that I was texting players earlier about support for hitting coach Lloyd McClendon, who was promised an interview.

To Boggs: "Is this accurate about Gardenhire?"

"Anthony, I do not have anything to report at this time."

"John, the National Guys have this. What gives?"

"Anthony, don't know what the National Guys have—only can tell you that I don't have anything to report at this time. Hope you can respect that."

Biting my tongue: "Yes, I do. Thank you for getting back to me."

LOS ANGELES, *October 31*—I've been sent to L.A. on last-minute notice. My editor called yesterday and asked if I'd fly here to cover the rest of the World Series—they're interested in you-know-who.

The Astros are one win away from winning it all and Justin Verlander is on the mound.

In the auxiliary press box texting Gator, who's about to fly to Italy for Justin's wedding on the Amalfi Coast.

In his first-ever chance to win the World Series, Verlander pitches well but allows the Dodgers two fateful runs—Houston scores only once and they lose.

I prepare for the worst—pissed-off postgame Justin who previously swore to never answer one of my questions again.

I don't know what to expect.

His session had already begun when I walked up. Visitors' clubhouse, two people deep—easy to hide but tall enough to see. I wasn't planning on asking a question, especially not after a loss. The last time I tried asking him a question, he ignored me. (Colorado) The time before that, he walked out on the scrum. (Chicago)

Ball Writing ain't easy, folks.

You'd blend in, too. It's the World Series. And the last thing I wan—I'm startled when he spots me and stops.

"Oh, Anthony... Hey."

He says it friendly, like, '*Hello, Old Pal!*'

"Where was I? Oh, yes..."

Great. Now I gotta ask something.
 The Astros PR guy sends a warning.
 "Last couple, guys."
 At the buzzer, I lob a question.
 Justin answers this time. I'm relieved.
 Celebrity news breaker Jon Heyman walks by.
 "He seemed happy to see you. He must like you."

November 1—Houston ambushes the Dodgers in Game 7. They score twice before recording an out. It's 5-0 after two innings and anti-climactic from there.

Verlander isn't needed for duty. He watches the final out from the bullpen, streaming onto the field in a celebratory sprint with the rest of his mates.

Inside the clubhouse after the Astros win the World Series, I awkwardly hover with my tape recorder stretched behind a cameraman while Ken Rosenthal interviews him on FOX.

I'm not the only reporter stalking him when he leaves the TV interview. A pair of entertainment reporters charge his way. I cozy up alongside as a small scrum starts to form. Opposite is a woman from *E! News*, who wastes no time asking about the reported wedding.

"Is it true that you and Kate Upton are getting married on Saturday?"

He doesn't say no.

"I'm not going to speak on the details... I'm just happy we won."

She's intrepid, though. She asks if the wedding is in Italy.

"I'm just glad we won the World Series."

Asked if he has a message for his fans back in Detroit, Verlander says, "Thank you for everything over the years, thank you for recognizing all the hard work that I put in, thank you for recognizing how hard of a decision this was for me. Thank you from the bottom of my heart."

We shake hands—Old Pals once again.

Leaving the clubhouse, I walk past his family on their way in.

I write the stuffing out of that story until the sun comes up:

"Verlander wore an Astros shirt. A backwards hat and accomplishment in his eyes.

"I can't even put it into words; This experience is everything I dreamed it would be."

"But for so long, his dream came true in Detroit. And damned if he didn't try.

"He felt the support of the city this postseason. 'I absolutely did.'

"I'm never going to forget my time in Detroit... It's a special place for me."

"After a few hugs and a kiss from a teammate, eyes still burning and Budweiser in hand, Verlander reached for his cell phone. It was sitting on a toiletry bag in his locker.

"The bag had the Olde English 'D' on it."

I hear from Mr. Verlander, who shares the story on his Facebook page. I even get a message from John Westhoff, who never texts me.

"Nice article about J.V."

"Thanks. See you at the GM Meetings."

ORLANDO, Fla., *November 14*—First night at the lobby bar, I'm talking to a New York scribe when two Tigers guys walk up—Alan Avila and Sam Menzin.

I get on well with Alan, the older of Al's two sons. He is much more cut from his father's cloth than Alex, the team's longtime catcher.

Meanwhile, Sam has been a cold case. I last spoke with him two years ago, when he stonewalled me after his promotion.

"I don't talk to the media," he said.

With drinks flowing steadily, the Tigers Guys mesh easily with us. The writer swaps cards with Sam—something I've been trying for years.

December 10—Back in Orlando for the winter meetings—my fourth.

Opening night isn't laid back this year—two legendary Tigers are up for election to the Baseball Hall of Fame, with the announcement in a couple hours.

Starting pitcher Jack Morris and shortstop Alan Trammell are part of this year's Veterans' Committee ballot for players not elected by the Baseball Writers' Association of America.

I await the Veterans' Committee decision in my room, writing up four different stories to cover all bases—one if both players get in, one if neither gets in, one each if only one gets in.

The official word comes shortly after 6 P.M.—the Tiger teammates are headed to Cooperstown. Morris was selected on 14 of 16, Trammell on 13 of 16. After media teleconferences, Trammell speaks with the Tiger Beat downstairs.

"I'm not usually at a loss for words, but it's overwhelming."

After the scrum, I rush up to the room. I upload the video from Trammell's interview and send it to the web desk. I text with Deep Throat. I phone Kirk Gibson: "About time."

Al Avila shares a video from dinner at Shula's Steak House.

"We gave Tram a standing ovation. Toasted him. Jack is not here yet."

In the video, Tram is welcomed to the private room at the restaurant. The roster of dinner attendees is deep in Detroit baseball lore—Mr. Tiger Al Kaline, Willie Horton, Jim Leyland—along with manager Ron Gardenhire and the rest of the front office.

“Great moment. Thanks for sharing.”

“Yes! What a great night.”

“Let me know if you want to have a cigar after your meeting, before things get crazy.”

“I didn’t bring any. Have one for me.”

“I’m offering you one... Got three.”

December 13—The Tigers have pushed back today’s media session. I’ve been holed up in my room pestering people like Al Avila about Kinsler.

“Checking in on Kinsler.”

I head to the lobby bar and bring two whiskeys back—it could be a long night.

An hour later, I text agent Jay Franklin: “Checking in on Kinsler, sorry to bug.”

He answers. “Get back with ya here soon, buddy.”

6:59 P.M.—Ken Rosenthal reports the Angels are in serious discussions to acquire Kinsler. A few minutes later, Rosenthal goes all the way. “Kinsler to Angels.”

In The Room sources tell me no deal is imminent. The truth between what those sources say and what Rosenthal reported is semantics.

Behind the scenes, Kinsler’s camp has leveraged his no-trade protection. It’s Anaheim or bust, he tells Avila.

While the baseball world waits, ESPN’s Buster Olney throws cold water on the trade: “Tigers do not have an Ian Kinsler deal with the Angels yet, according to sources.”

Rosenthal can’t resist: “Any delay on Kinsler likely would be due to his no-trade. Again, my understanding is deal will happen.”

Meanwhile, I haven’t heard back from Jay Franklin. “Soon, buddy” was an hour ago.

8:47 P.M.—I get confirmation from an L.A. scout, but I can’t go with only a scout. I use it to confirm the deal, then quickly report the players Detroit receives in return.

Soon after, the feeling is downright funereal inside the Tigers’ suite. Team execs arrived envisioning a sweepstakes for Kinsler. Four teams were interested initially. Then he unplugged the game, and Detroit had to settle for what little the Angels offered.

“It’s very frustrating,” Al Avila says.

11:44 P.M.—At the lobby bar, I see a couple guys from the agency that represents Justin Upton. Reuniting with Upton weighed heavily on Kinsler’s decision.

The trade took time because Avila held out false hope that Kinsler would budge. Kinsler phoned Avila with the bad news.

“I don’t know what to tell ya, but I’m only going to the Angels.”

DETROIT, *January 8, 2018*—Nothing to report. It’s a slow offseason for Major League Baseball and Ball Writers alike. Several top free agents are still on the market, including J.D. Martinez.

Meanwhile, I’m not getting many scoops. The Tigers are entering the first year of a tear-it-down rebuild. They did sign veteran righty Mike Fiers (my scoop), but otherwise, just minor-league signings.

The lack of scoops is either due to the Tigers rebuild—or it’s me.

Over the past year, more kid reporters have popped up—college-age guys who are breaking more news than me. I picture them glued to their phones, constantly texting sources.

I don’t know if I have it in me to be that obsessed all the time. Serving the 24/7 Internet and printed newspaper deadlines makes my dream job harder each year.

I became a Ball Writer to *write*—not stenograph seven web updates a day.

Since the new guy took the driver’s seat last year and set the cruise to 150 mph, I’ve been struggling to keep up. Morning web updates. Midday web updates. Pregame, in-game and postgame web updates. Videos, podcasts, tweets. Live chats and awkward questions. Sometimes I get speed from folks off the street.

Reach out to sources, practically begging for morsels of information. I care less and less.

LAKELAND, Fla., *February 1*—In TigerTown early to report on top prospects.

At night, I search for front office guys to go out with. It comes as no surprise that Al is at Chili’s for happy hour.

We decide on Fish City Grill, smack dab in the center of a nearby outdoor mall.

“6:30 cocktails, 7:00 dinner. You’re paying. That big newspaper expense account.”

Tonight is high tide. At the moment, everything is working in harmony. Anthony Fenech and the Tigers are getting along quite well. We’re setting up

stories together, talking on the phone and texting, busting each other's chops. Even Sam Menzin answers my calls these days.

With the rebuild underway, the pressure to win is put on the backburner. The team is relaxed. Going into my fourth year on the beat, my relationships are in bloom.

We sit outside. Drinks and a cigar. During dinner, Avila comments how my bosses must love him—for the info he shares with me.

"They should be more worried I'm getting too close with you."

After dinner, we head to a beer-only bar across the street and order soft pretzel bites. Al talks about his early years in baseball. He tears up talking about how tough it was traveling with the Marlins for years, leaving a young wife and two sons at home.

Avila also lets me in on a blockbuster trade that never happened: Last summer, the Tigers could have traded young righty Michael Fulmer to the Cubs for star shortstop Javier Báez and two prospects—Albert Almora and Víctor Caratini. But the Tigers viewed Fulmer as a rotation anchor—too high a price.

Sitting here, Al isn't the GM. I'm not a Ball Writer. Here, I'm a drinking buddy. A friend.

Still... I'm a Ball Writer. When I get back to my hotel, I immediately write notes on what Avila told me. There might come a day.

DETROIT, *February 6*—Things are going so well, the Tigers let me throw luggage onto their 18-wheeler of baseball equipment, training supplies and other cargo soon headed to Florida for spring training. I'll realize later that this is a convenience afforded to everyone on the Tiger Beat—I'm not that special.

I park my car in the garage back home, where it'll stay for the next six weeks, and give Mom a big hug at departures—it's off to spring training once again.

SECAUCUS, N.J., *February 7*—Making my annual pit stop at MLB Network. This year, I'm a panelist on the network's afternoon show.

I arrive five hours early. We're opening with the ongoing free-agent saga of J.D. Martinez.

Posting up in a shared office, Ken Rosenthal sticks his head in to say hello. Today is his last appearance for a while—he will soon undergo back surgery.

"Six-to-eight weeks."

Overnight, J.D. Martinez finds his name at the head of rumors, due to the latest from National Guy Jon Heyman: "Martinez is telling people in Miami that he's willing to hold out until he gets his price."

Rosenthal matches Heyman's report and adds that Martinez is "telling people that he is fed up with the Red Sox's inflexibility and would rather sign with another club."

With the spotlight on Martinez's situation and three years' experience covering him, I better bring something to the stage. I text J.D.: "I'm in New York to go on MLB Network show and we're going to be talking about you. Is there anything you would like me to get out there, message-wise?"

"I said you don't seem like the kinda guy that's gonna be pissed at a team for an offer."

"Haha I never said those things about being pissed off. Lol I don't know where people get this shit. I just laugh about it. Nowadays people can write anything, and everyone believes anything. What time you going on?"

Before I can answer, J.D. calls me.

"Look, Anthony: If Boston wants me to become a full-time DH, they're going to have to pay a little bit more, you know?"

Martinez tells me not to say this on TV, but he's got two offers—Arizona and Boston.

The benefits of sitting on stage are big when you recognize how they can boost your relationships. Pretty much everyone gets back to you when you're on TV. Ken Rosenthal benefits from this every day. He doesn't *have* to text sources—they text him. He's got the platform to spin their intel for favors in return.

Seconds from live, I hear the show's intro, producers in my ear, and we're off.

Scott Braun, anchor: "This, the latest from Ken Rosenthal, on the five-year, \$125 million offer from the Red Sox. Ken said, 'He is telling people in Miami he is willing to hold out until he gets his price...'"

"Anthony. Do you think that happens? You covered J.D. for quite a few years..."

"Well, first of all, the notion that he's fed up—far be it from me to contradict any reporting otherwise—but people close to J.D. have said that's kind of laughable. This is a guy I've covered for a few years, and it would be very out of character if he's walking around pouting about \$100 million.

"I think the big thing is that he wants to play right field, not be a designated hitter. Boston already has a right fielder, so if they want him as a DH, they're going to have to pay premium for that."

Got the first segment under my belt and the rest was a blur. Positive reviews. Shuttling back to the train station, it's J.D.

"Hey man thanks so much for that I just saw the interview."

He'll remain unsigned for two more weeks, until Dave Dombrowski wins the staring contest with Scott Boras. Martinez signs with Boston for five years and \$110 million.

The news is broken by who else but Pedro Gomez.

He shares his source—J.D. Martinez.

AWARDS SEASON

LAKELAND, Fla., *February 13*—The first week of pitchers and catchers isn't short on drama. Unfortunately, it's self-inflicted.

I commit the worst crime of my career today. Trying too hard to make a joke nobody asked for, I take a potshot at Jordan Zimmermann's injury struggles.

The next day, I seek out Zimmermann to apologize. Got a minute?

"No. You're a sarcastic asshole."

February 18—More clouds hover over TigerTown. The team has lost its veteran star power except for two players: Víctor Martínez, who won't speak to me—and Miguel Cabrera, who is embroiled in an ongoing child paternity lawsuit.

The *Free Press* caught scent of it recently and dispatched a news reporter and photographer to Florida. Cabrera has fathered two children with ex-mistress Belkis Rodríguez, who wants \$100,000 per month in child support. The *Free Press* put a photo of the house Cabrera bought Rodríguez on the front page.

Cabrera has not talked to the *Free Press* about the lawsuit—today won't be the day, either. Joker Marchant Stadium has been taken over by the Miggy Ball 24 youth baseball camp, and the media have been invited.

"Only baseball and the kids' camp, guys," says media relations coordinator Michele Wysocki. She's indicating that asking Cabrera about his out-of-wedlock kids at his kid's baseball camp would ruin the happy vibe.

That's OK. I will get Cabrera one-on-one tomorrow. He'll talk to me. Maybe.

Soon, I've got someone from the desk in my ear, asking if I—or anyone—asked Cabrera about the paternity suit.

"No, but I'm going to ask him in the morning."

"That'll definitely be worth a post. No matter how that goes."

Time to talk to Martínez, who is seated at his locker when the media overtakes him. Martínez, now 39, missed the rest of the year after his trip to the hospital in Chicago. He underwent cardiac ablation surgery two weeks later to address an irregular heartbeat issue.

I usually ask two questions to a player who's clearly ignoring me. Today, I ask Víctor three.

How was your offseason?

Have you decided if this year is your last year?

Are you looking forward to helping some of the young guys?

Martínez answers none of them. Doesn't raise his noggin to look at me. He simply ignores me, as he's done since the Very Serious Story last year.

There's a new sheriff in town.

Ron Gardenhire comes to Detroit after managing 13 seasons for Minnesota. Gardenhire's coaching staff is nearly a carbon-copy of his Twins crew—a loyal bunch of baseball men he trusts.

As a personal rule, I never refer to managers by their nicknames. First-name only. So, while I'll address him in person as Ron, I'll address him in the pages as Gardy.

He brings a new vibe—they put together a playlist for infield warm-ups. Johnny Cash blasts from a big speaker while infielders take ground balls. Zero expectations. Players are loose.

In his first meeting with the team, Gardy told 'em, "I don't know any of you guys, so I'm just going to call you 'buddy' when you're running around—until I can get a look at the back of your uniform."

Inside the dressing room, I feel an unusual energy—and eyes on me. I am standing on the minor-league side of the clubhouse, talking to a third-string catcher.

Walking back to the other side, I see why.

A sheet of paper is taped to the top shelf of each locker stall. I see the headline:

Detroit Tigers Will Stink in 2018

Anthony Fenech, Detroit Free Press

<https://www.freep.com/story/sports/mlb/tigers/2018/02/12/detroit-tigers-spring-training/328555002/>

I pop my head into Gardy's office before leaving. He's sitting at his desk. Liddle is in a chair across from him.

I tap the doorframe.

"I'm a big boy; I can take it. If you ever need me to light a fire under them, let me know."

Turns out, Liddle printed them out himself.

February 20—Out killing time on the back fields when Miguel Cabrera appears.

He's out walking early and sits next to me on a silver titanium grandstand behind the backstop of Field No. 3. Nobody else is here. I ask about his first baseman's glove. The moment seems right, so I put it on and imagine snagging balls at first like Miggy would.

As we chat, a crowd of fans gathers beyond the gate. He hops down and signs autographs.

When workouts commence, I text Pedro Gomez.

"Lengthy baseball talk with Miguel on the bench today, a conversation. Víctor was next to him (for part of this time). I didn't talk to Víctor but Miguel talking to me was big. He will be that bridge."

"THAT is how you cover a baseball beat."

Later, my friend Miggy returns to sit next to me on the bench again. He remains in a good mood. He snuggles up and grins.

"It was Verlander, wasn't it?"

He keeps looking back at Víctor, who's in another conversation at the end of the bench.

"Verlander. The guy... the source."

"You know I can't reveal my sources. You can't ever reveal your sources."

But Cabrera can't get Verlander out of his head, convinced he's solved the mystery.

"It was Verlander! It was!"

He laughs harder, trying unsuccessfully to get Víctor's attention. But he is carrying an incurable case of Fenech Fever—he won't even look my direction, ignoring Miggy's antics.

I get up and leave the bench to them and their speculation.

February 25—Verlander was traded to Houston. After the World Series, we appear to be on good terms. He still favorites my tweets:

"Pitchers and catchers have reported to spring training, but I still haven't seen Justin Verlander. Will ask."

Miss ya, Old Pal.

SARASOTA, Fla., *February 26*—On another postcard-perfect spring day, I drive to Ed Smith Stadium, spring home of the Baltimore Orioles. A message pops in

from my boss. Wondering whether it could ruin my day, I wait to read it until the song ends.

“Congrats on the APSE. Very well done.”

I was honored in this year’s Associated Press Sports Editors’ national contest—the Super Bowl for sports news organizations.

I finished Top 10 in beat writing in APSE’s highest-circulation category.

As Seamhead John Lowe says: “It’s easy to cover a winning team. Anybody can do that.”

Since 2001, only one Freepster has placed in the APSE beat writing contest: Lions football writer Dave Birkett received honors last year. Birkett makes more than double what I do, so maybe I can spin this into a raise.

I thank my sports editor for submitting my work.

“No problem. You earned it. Now you have to one-up yourself next year :)”

WEST PALM BEACH, Fla., *March 4*—The Tigers begin a two-game road trip on Florida’s East Coast—today against the Nationals at The Ballpark of the Palm Beaches, which the Nationals share with the Astros.

I ask a Houston PR flack for directions to Verlander’s locker. When Justin arrives, I wait half a minute and walk his way. I ask him about a *Sports Illustrated* story documenting his ace resurgence in his mid-thirties. In the article, Verlander credits Houston’s analytical advancements.

“Was it really that big of a factor? I mean, you were basically back to yourself, dominating while you were still with the Tigers, right?”

“This is off-the-record, right?”

“Of course... I just came over here to say hi.”

“It’s just different here. That’s all I can say about it. It’s just different here. It’s still way behind over there... Like, in the playoffs last year, what we have is night and day different from what we had in Detroit.”

The conversation is short. I wish him good luck and good health this year. We shake on it.

“Thanks, Anthony.”

DETROIT, *April 13*—Before the series opener against New York, I spend time outside the clubhouse with Willie Horton.

I’ve struck up a nice friendship with Mr. Horton. Today, the Tigers’ legend is sharing a story about his struggling 1980 season with Seattle, when his average dipped below .200 in April.

“I appreciated the criticism. It motivated me.”

Fifty-three degrees and wind-whipping. In the second inning, Nick Castellanos gets twisted up on a line drive off the right field wall, allowing Yankees catcher Gary Sánchez to reach second base. The next batter hits an inside-the-park homer.

On the misplay, Castellanos' development as a right fielder was on display. After the loss, his development as a leader was put in front of the cameras.

He recoils when reporters approach to ask about the play.

"I didn't lose it in the lights. Sánchez just doubled. It was a line drive off the wall. There was no misplay."

Asked if the play was part of his transition to right field, he bristles.

"But I think it's funny. In 40-degree weather, I get a line drive off the wall that's a double and I get a bunch of microphones and stuff in my face asking me if this is a transition, you know? I think it's funny. But it is what it is."

With Mr. Horton's story fresh in my mind, I hold Nick accountable in my column tomorrow.

"Because that's what leaders say."

April 22—After staying out too late with a few visiting scouts last night, I'm back at Comerica Park bright and early.

Gene Lamont arrives for the game and sits in Suite 118—the visiting GM suite. I stop in and say hi. The longtime Tigers' coach retired last year and still talks to Leyland every morning on the phone over coffee.

Last year, when Verlander exploded on me in the dugout after my solar eclipse tweets, Lamont was sitting off to my right.

"Who pissed in his cereal?" Lamont asked.

I shook my head.

"Apparently, I did... You're not going to believe what happened."

Lamont chuckled and stood up.

"Trust me. I don't wanna know."

With a wide-open weekend afternoon—a sunny, spring-like 60 degrees—what do I do? I stay inside my house and watch baseball. Call sources. Text friends.

I reach out to Al Avila. "You wanna get dinner? Cigar?"

"No, I'm pooped. Next time."

Avila changes his mind later on—I'm invited to his suburban home in Bloomfield Hills.

Baseball is on TV and Avila has prepared a charcuterie board of meats and cheeses on the kitchen table. I send a picture.

Caption: "True Life: I'm A Ball Writer. In this episode, I text my GM for a cigar. When I arrive, the GM says, 'I got some munchies for you.'"

DRAFT DAY

BOSTON, *June 5*—After a couple hours' sleep in Atlanta, it's back to the airport.

The annual MLB draft began last evening in Auburn, Alabama, where the Tigers selected Auburn University pitcher Casey Mize with the top pick. I was on the scene, having followed Mize closely after visiting his hometown last month and watching him dominate LSU while Al Avila watched from the bleachers.

The break-neck life has now led me to Fenway Park for MLB Network. The hot topic: Is Nick Castellanos entering the league's elite echelon of hitters? Through two months, he's hitting .333 with 6 homers and 19 doubles.

At the park, I text J.D. Martinez, and we reconnect in the stairway to the Red Sox dugout. I ask him if Castellanos should be considered elite.

"If yes, I'm gonna quote you. If no, I won't."

"Define elite. Like top ten?"

"Just hitting ability. It's a 'no' if you gotta think about it... Ruined a great opening, though."

J.D. laughs.

"I'm sorry, bro. I think elite is a strong word. I think you could say he's on his way to becoming elite. But I think u need multiple years to say that—that's my take."

After my TV gig, I see Tigers quality control coach Joe Vavra sitting in the dugout, scrolling through his phone in disbelief. Today, he's a proud father filled with emotion. Vavra tries to keep up with congratulatory messages—his son, Terrin, was drafted in the third round by Colorado.

June 6—Bending the rules, I dial traveling secretary Brian Britten. I'm in a terrible spot, 25 minutes from Fenway Park. He finds an open room for me at the historic Commonwealth Hotel—five minutes' walk to the park.

After the game, I ride the elevator with Miguel Cabrera. Miggy locks a goofy stare at me, smiling like a crazed clown until I finally say, "You're weird."

I share a shrimp cocktail at the oyster bar next door with Kirk Gibson, who broadcast the game for FOX Sports Detroit. Across the aisle, Nick Castellanos sits at a booth with his girlfriend, Jess. He waves us over.

The Tigers have lost both games here, outscored 14-1. In last night's shutout loss, young third baseman Jeimer Candelario took a ground ball off his wrist and left the game.

"You couldn't do this anymore," Gibby says, "but back in our day, someone would hang a tampon in the guy's locker the next day."

Castellanos has played with veterans his entire career. All-Stars and future Hall of Famers.

"You'd have to take a finger off for me to leave the game. Playing alongside Miguel Cabrera? Are you kidding me? You should see the kind of stuff Miggy has played through."

We get another round and get to talking about how I got here.

"I covered Gibby back when he managed in Arizona. My first season covering baseball." I tell Nick what a good manager Gibson was before Parkinson's disease began affecting him.

"I believe it. I love this man."

DETROIT, *June 13*—The mood is sullen inside the Tigers' clubhouse. Mighty Miggy is out for the season.

His left arm is braced, ready for surgery. Cabrera sits stone-faced, devoid of his usual joviality.

"I'm like in shock right now. It's tough, but in the same way, I gotta go out and fix it and try to come back better."

Cabrera left last night's game wincing in pain after a swing in the third inning.

After the media circle dissolves, Cabrera hangs out with teammates in the corner, sitting inside his empty locker stall. There's no rush to clean it out.

I walk up, wish him luck with surgery and pass along my business card.

"Text me if you want." (He doesn't.)

I find Nick and say: "It's your team now. Good luck."

CLEVELAND, *June 24*—Sandwiched between Tigers Twitter Guy and Seam-head John Lowe, who joined us after Sunday service, church program in tow.

The Tigers need religion. After arriving sky-high with a five-game winning streak, they're currently getting blasted by the Indians, 12-2, in the series finale.

The losses are taking a toll on Deep Throat, who looks ahead.

“Who’s starting for Oakland?”

“Bob Welch.”

“Not funny.”

“Vida Blue, maybe.”

“Stop.”

He doesn’t appreciate my gallows humor, invoking long-retired Oakland hurlers who mightn’t break a sweat against the free-swinging Tigers youngsters.

John Lowe gets a jump on traffic. Sensing I need religion, too, he leaves me today’s program. I pass it to Tigers Twitter Guy.

“Peace be with your mentions.”

Detroit is outscored 26-3 in the series. Postgame, I hang around the clubhouse long after the rest. Waiting for the team leader, who appears many minutes later, mostly naked and slightly surprised to see me standing there.

Nick Castellanos is one of the most tenured players on the roster now, and with that comes responsibility to speak for the players when things aren’t going right. Nick passes his first test with flying colors, facing the music after the lopsided loss.

“It’s just growth. You’re either in it for the long haul or you’re not. Getting your ass kicked is a part of learning how to become a good team, and it’s no secret that if we want to get to the World Series, we have to get through Cleveland.”

DETROIT, *June 26*—Lounging on an off night, I feel my skin tingle. With the postgame show muted in the background—TIGERS LOSE SEVENTH STRAIGHT—I hear from Deep Throat.

“Something’s up. Not a roster move. I can’t say any more.”

I try to catch Al Avila on his ride home from the ballpark. No answer. I call again a few minutes later. Voicemail. Send a text. “Call me on your way home if you want.”

I won’t hear from Deep Throat again tonight.

June 27—HSITL still hasn’t gotten back to me, and my grapevine of sources appears to be gagged. Another call goes unanswered. One message comes back negative—“haven’t heard anything.”

Just when you think you’ve got this job figured out, you’re back to texting clubhouse attendants.

Luckily for me, nobody else can, either. Media are quickly ushered into Gardy’s office, where Al Avila is waiting. He reads a team announcement, relieving pitching coach Chris Bosio for bad behavior. Avila declines specifics.

“Word on my end is that Bosio used inappropriate language,” a scout says. “Someone brought him decaf instead of regular,” Daniel Norris says.

One of his teammates gives a more serious answer to my text.

“Apparently something was wrongfully said to an employee, although I don’t know if I fully believe that.”

I press for details.

“Dude, I get it, and if it’s something the team has told us little about and have told us to be hush-hush about, like this incident, you will get vague answers. Like my current ones haha.”

In the press box, I whip up a story with my earbuds in. At the top of the hour, TV man Brad Galli gives the most concrete report so far. Galli says Bosio allegedly “used racist language” toward a team employee.

Tigers’ pro scouting director Sam Menzin soon barges through the door. Apparently on Freep.com right now, there’s a picture of bullpen coach Rick Anderson above the headline: TIGERS FIRE PITCHING COACH BOSIO.

Menzin points at me.

“That’s the problem with *you guys!*”

I’m caught off-guard and take out my earbuds.

“I don’t have anything to do with that. But I’ll let the desk know.”

Menzin is already walking out, almost as if he’d caught himself—as if he had an out-of-body experience.

I vow to never forget it.

TAMPA, Fla., *July 12*—It’s taken three years, but Ball Writing has finally broken my body.

I haven’t had a normal bowel movement for almost three weeks.

I spent more time in the restroom at Tropicana Field the past few days than watching baseball. Which isn’t the worst thing—the Tigers were swept by the Tampa Bay Rays.

Today, I’m flying early—Tampa to Cincinnati to Houston to visit Old Pal Justin Verlander. He’s set to face the Tigers for the first time this weekend. With the Astros playing a matinee today, I should’ve been able to make it there for pregame clubhouse and exclusive quotes.

In Houston, I run to the restroom. It’s hellish.

Cabbing into the city, I text a friend who’s a team doctor for the Detroit Red Wings.

“I haven’t done drinks or drugs in a couple weeks, but symptoms have continued. I went to urgent care and got some meds—I need this cleared up before I see my girlfriend next week.”

“Go get checked out.”

At the hotel, I ask the concierge if there's a hospital nearby. She points me to a place ten minutes away. Instead, I drop my bags and get a cab to the stadium. I enter the Astros clubhouse at Minute Maid Park—open until 11 A.M.—and see Justin at his locker.

He's occupied. Justin has been cornered by a foreign reporter who wants him to describe the talents of L.A. Angels' superstar Shohei Ohtani.

"I can't speak to facing him as a pitcher, so I can't say."

I'm standing around in the background. A minute becomes three. Justin certainly sees me. The longer this interview goes, the less time he'll have for me—he looks ready to scoot away.

Sure enough, when the interview wraps up, I'm quickly shooed away.

"Gotta go."

"Not even for a couple quick ones?"

"Nope."

Justin turns toward his locker, looking for something.

"What about after you throw?"

"I won't have time then, either."

"Not even if I changed my trip and took a 5 A.M. flight to get here?"

"Not my problem. I talk tomorrow."

"Well, if you change your mind, I'll be waiting in the dugout afterwards."

"I won't."

He doesn't. After Justin throws a bullpen session, he walks past me in the dugout and into the clubhouse. He doesn't break stride.

I give samples and soon find myself strapped to a hospital bed with an IV in my arm.

I pick up a prescription and dinner to-go, then purchase *Titanic* on pay-per-view for \$3.99. Life's too short.

HOUSTON, *July 15*—If karma is a thing, we're seeing it at Minute Maid Park.

Verlander is getting tattooed by the Tigers. In the second inning, he's taken deep by catcher John Hicks, who hails from the same hometown as Justin. Hicks' older brother, Daniel, was best friends with Justin growing up in Goochland, Va.

Detroit homers thrice more off Verlander and Old Pal takes an unlikely loss.

The Tigers snap a seven-game losing streak, heading into the break with a payback win.

DETROIT, *July 20*—Tonight, for the first and only time ever, I leave the stadium through the underground tunnel that leads to the players' parking garage. I hop into Kirk Gibson's white F-150 and hitch a lift back to his house in the suburbs.

Riding shotgun, I ask Gibson for as many PG-13 stories he can share about good friends and Tiger teammates Alan Trammell and Jack Morris, who will be inducted into the Baseball Hall of Fame next weekend. Off the top of his head, he recalls the time when Dave Rozema accidentally hit Trammell with a wine glass, causing 40 stitches, and the time when Morris purposely dropped the baseball after Hall of Fame manager Sparky Anderson came out to pull him from the game.

"Jack went, 'Oops' and picked up the ball. So later they had a little meeting and Sparky said, 'Nobody shows *me* up. I won't show *you* up. You don't say anything to the press about me, and I won't say anything about you. Nobody throws anybody under the bus.'"

Back then, I saw the future clearly—one day, I'd be covering the Tigers and Gibson would be managing them. After he took the Diamondbacks from worst-to-first, winning the National League West in 2011, Arizona went .500 two straight years, and Gibson was fired in 2014—when they finished in last place.

By that point, Parkinson's had begun affecting his movement.

As we turn into Gibby's subdivision, I think of that summer. I think about what my dad told me back then. I was 21, about to drive off to Phoenix to cover big-league baseball for the summer. The radio was already up full blast when I hit the road and saw my dad in the rearview mirror, waving his hands frantically for me to stop.

When he reached the window, he said, "Don't let Gibson intimidate you." I laughed. Dad didn't.

"Anthony, don't let Gibson intimidate you."

Gibby was known as one of the most hard-ass players of the eighties, an All-Star, longtime Tiger and college football star, too. He was a physical force with a flair for the dramatic—his pinch-hit, walk-off home run on one good leg in the 1988 World Series with the Dodgers remains one of the most iconic home runs in baseball history.

Gibson, 61, is a local legend. He grew up in nearby Waterford, starred in football and baseball at Michigan State University and will go down as one of the most beloved players in Tigers history. I met him in his office the first afternoon at the stadium.

"I'm from Detroit."

And now, I look back and see the merit in Dad's advice: If I had slunk in the middle rows, stumbled when I asked questions or didn't stand steady in the dugout for nearly ten minutes, waiting to say farewell at summer's end... if I had been intimidated by Kirk Gibson, I wouldn't be here today.

Inside the house, Gibson opens a bottle of tequila. His wife is here—she puts out a bowl of popcorn. We talk in the kitchen, around the island. I browse the living room, taking in photos and mementos of the family.

Gibby takes me down to the basement, which looks like most basements—boxes and clutter, recreation activities, a TV and an old cloth recliner from grandma’s house.

Down here, more than three years into his fight with Parkinson’s, Gibby annihilates my athletic ego. He whips me in ping-pong and pool, twice each. Although his hands can shake uncontrollably and his movements can be stiff, Gibson’s still got elite hand-eye coordination.

When I’ve had enough, we refill our drinks and watch some baseball highlights.

KANSAS CITY, Mo., *July 25*—After today’s matinee, the front office will fly to Detroit on the team’s private plane and then to Cooperstown for Baseball Hall of Fame induction weekend.

I’ll fly commercial to Albany, about 1½ hours’ drive time from Cooperstown. I don’t even know where I’m staying. Everything within a 30-mile radius is booked—“Has been for months,” a front desk worker told me last week. And since I don’t know where I’m staying, I don’t know if I should get a rental car.

Arriving at the ballpark, I see a missed call from Kirk Gibson. I call back; he’s staying in a house in Cooperstown this weekend with a few other couples. One of the wives burst her appendix—and that couple can’t make the trip.

“There’s gonna be some rules, but would you be interested in staying with us?”

COOPERSTOWN

COOPERSTOWN, N.Y., *July 27*—The first rule of the Cooperstown House is you don't talk about the Cooperstown House.

"Incognito," Kirk Gibson texts me. "U will get killed if you blow our cover."

Three married couples and I have gathered at a cottage off a county road in central New York. They are here to celebrate their friends and former Tiger teammates Jack Morris and Alan Trammell getting inducted into the Baseball Hall of Fame. I'm here out of dumb luck, a last-minute replacement for another couple who couldn't come. I'm also here as a Ball Writer to cover induction ceremony weekend.

I was invited.

Gibson sits on one of the beds, across from me. He reminds me of the first rule of the Cooperstown House.

"The wives are watching." He's not kidding. "Labatt or Coors?"

I'm staying with Gibby and former Tiger teammates Tom Brookens and Lynn Jones and their wives. The wives have created a lawn-chair circle of their own nearby. The guys talk about the good ole days, when the Ball Writers used to hang out with the players. About the time they saw *Free Press* sports columnist Joe Falls at a bar in Edison Plaza. Another time when Morris put a small reporter in a garbage can.

"We even liked a few of the writers," Brookens says.

Gibson: "But only a few. So be careful."

July 28—Leaving a hall of fame party, walking to Tigers' HQ. The front office is holed up this weekend in a four-bedroom colonial hidden behind tall trees.

"Which house is it?" I text Al Avila.

"Corner house. Lights on in the back."

Walking up, I see Al in the kitchen, through the window. I walk around to the back patio. More Tigers officers. Stay there for a couple hours, share some laughs.

At 2 A.M., I try to sneak quietly through the squeaky side door of the Cooperstown House. At 3:30, as I work on a 3,000-word story at the kitchen table, Gibby comes out of the main floor bedroom.

We speak softly. He sits on the rocker next to the couch.

"You gotta ask yourself," Gibby says, "Do you want to be a golden retriever... or do you want to be a pitbull?"

DETROIT, *July 30*—Trade deadline eve, I receive an auspicious text from a Red Sox scout.

A few days ago, I shared a trade idea: "Just spitballing. You guys should get Kinsler."

The former Tiger is having an unimpressive season, at least statistically, with the Angels. But he's a clutch player, an asset to any team. BoSox guy isn't convinced.

"Three years ago, Kinsler's an upgrade but right now he's not."

"He can play. Brings that (Dustin) Pedroia-type edge. Seems to have gotten old in the offseason but I wouldn't bet against him in the second half."

"Kinsler is still owed five million or so. I love Ian but he would not really help."

That was three days ago. Tonight, I get this: "You may be on to something."

Another scout says I'm right. I have it from two sources, but neither is In The Room. I can't risk being wrong. Worth a shot, I text J.D. Martinez.

"You hear anything?"

"You crack me up lol"

"Dude, I'm just trying to break some news. I've texted Kinsler three times lol."

"Lmfao bro I'm in the middle of a game and you're texting me about a trade."

11:32 P.M.—As I sweat out the scoop, feeling it slipping away—I've had it for an hour now—I see a saving grace.

Kinsler's agent Jay Franklin calls.

I pick up first ring.

"Hey, what's going on?"

He hangs up. Texts me.

"I'll call you back."

11:33 P.M.—Seconds later, a tweet from Ken Rosenthal. "Red Sox get Kinsler."

Ball Writing: Where you can do everything right. You can get the scoop. You can have the contacts. You can pick up right away. And still, the agent could be

trying to call Rosenthal, not you. The guy could hang up and immediately call him with the scoop.

Four minutes after midnight, it's Dave Dombrowski. Always returns your message, no matter how big or small.

"Yes! You can see the deal was announced."

I count to 10 and decide to sleep on it before texting him back.

"I wanted the scoop. Thanks for getting back to me. Good luck the rest of the way."

July 31—This year, Al Avila is trying to peddle marginal pieces at the trade deadline. At the top of the list is Mike Fiers.

In January, they signed him to a one-year, \$6 million contract for this very reason—to flip him for prospects in July. So far, he's held up his end of the deal, posting a 3.48 ERA in 22 starts.

He joined Detroit after winning a World Series with the Astros in 2017. He's almost two years away from blowing the whistle on the elaborate sign-stealing system Houston used while winning that title. He will speak to the *Athletic* for a Nov. 12, 2019 story, saying: "That's not playing the game the right way. They were advanced and willing to go above and beyond to win."

In the days leading up to the Tigers' trip to Houston earlier this month, Fiers told his pitching mates to watch out for what might be in store at Minute Maid Park. Game 2 of the series was the worst of Michael Fulmer's career. He allowed a career-high 7 runs on 10 hits, walking off the mound more annoyed each inning.

"I swear, they're cheating," he said in the dugout.

Every time Fulmer would throw certain pitches, he'd hear different sounds coming out of the home dugout. Houston wasn't even offering at certain pitches, he complained. Fulmer was knocked out of the game in the fifth inning.

He will allude to this trip when talking to the *Athletic* in 2019: "We had a lot of young guys with Detroit (in 2018) trying to make a name and establish themselves... I wanted to help them out and say, 'Hey, this stuff really does go on. Just be prepared.'"

"I have discussed Fiers with several clubs, but none feel he can make a difference," Avila said last night. And with veteran reliever Shane Greene, "the return is poor right now so we can wait till winter or next year."

Middy of the trade deadline, I reach out to a Cleveland exec about Leonys Martín.

"Any chance of adding Martín today? Heard you guys looked at him recently."

An hour later, I'm scooped—Martín has been traded to Cleveland, according to Robert Murray, a newcomer to the National Guy scene.

Fiers is still out there. I decide that perhaps I can be of use to the stressed-out GM.

Offering myself up, I ask Al Avila while driving to the park: “How many teams are in on Fiers? And do you want me to put that out there?”

Two teams: “One just wants us to dump him, and the other is considering how much to offer. No matter what you put out, I don’t think it will matter.”

As I pull into the Comerica Park parking garage, with the 4 P.M. trade deadline less than an hour away, Avila says he’s close to sending Fiers to the Oakland A’s. I park the car and put the news out there.

“The Tigers are close to a deal that would send Mike Fiers to the Athletics, I’m told.”

Never before have I couched a scoop as “close,” essentially leaving room for error in my reporting. Today, I do—100 percent confident in the source but not 100 percent confident the source isn’t selling snake oil—with me as his top salesman.

My report spreads on Twitter. Bob Nightengale passes it on. MLBTradeRumors.com posts a link. I ask Avila.

“Where’s it at?” With his silence comes a knowing panic. I sit frozen in the car.

Avila calls back. Uh-oh.

“Why did you put that out there?”

“Because you told me you guys were close on a deal for Fiers.”

“I said we were still ‘talking’ to them.”

I punch the dashboard.

“Fuck!”

“It’s OK...”

By using me to leak the false report 42 minutes before the deadline, Detroit was able to send a signal to other teams interested in Fiers, of which there was at least one. Milwaukee showed mild interest—but never acted.

Neither will Oakland. The report put the onus on them to potentially settle for the sake of saving public face. A’s fans on social media are enraged at ownership for not adding pitching help for the stretch run.

The longtime A’s beat writer weighs in, shooting down my report.

“Two sources are telling me they do not think the A’s are close to obtaining Mike Fiers.”

Avila calls again. Says a deal is still doubtful. Of course.

“Can I put that out there?”

“Yeah.”

“For real this time?”

He hangs up. I tweet an update: “The Tigers and Athletics do not yet have a deal done and there is doubt one will be finalized by 4 P.M. Fiers’ remaining contract is an obstacle, I’m told.”

The top of the hour passes and Fiers isn't traded. Before joining other media inside the dugout for a post-trade deadline presser, I call Avila from a service-level stairwell.

"You're going to have to throw me under the bus. Whatever miscommunication that was, I'm going to have to eat it. When I ask, just say the report wasn't true."

During the presser, I ask him: "How close were you guys to trading Fiers to the Athletics?"

"It never got to the point where I felt that we were going to make a deal."

"Was money an issue with a deal getting done?"

"No, money was not an issue. We're trying to accumulate the best players and talent possible, so money was never an issue."

Well, no, that's not what he said privately. I take it like a man—on the chin on Twitter.

"My reporting that the Tigers and Athletics were close on a Mike Fiers deal and his contract was an obstacle, was incorrect."

Furious with myself. Yesterday, my gut told me yes—that my Boston guy was in the know on the Kinsler trade, but I didn't go with it. Today, my gut says Tigers GM is using me to create leverage for Fiers, and I do go with it.

To avoid further shame, I don't stand up from my third-row seat the entire game. Like caring for a sick child, Tigers Twitter Guy brings me refreshments throughout.

As the worst day ends, when it couldn't get any worse, I get a call from Kirk Gibson.

I'm in trouble. Tram's wife is upset she was mentioned in the Cooperstown story—she doesn't like the public eye. I can't win.

August 1—I wait outside the clubhouse for another big fail moment.

I'm waiting to nab Alan Trammell to apologize to him and his wife. With the team headed on a road trip, I don't want it to linger.

"Gibby told me about it last night."

Tram is cool. Says he understands.

"You didn't even need to apologize, Anthony... honestly. But I appreciate it."

OAKLAND, Calif., *August 4*—Last night, halfway through the Tigers-A's opener, Oakland starter Brett Anderson had yet to allow a baserunner when I decided

to muck things up. I tweeted that I picked Anderson, never an All-Star, “just to face the Tigers in fantasy baseball”—poking fun at their lack of offense.

When I get to the stadium today, Chad Crunk is texting: “Just giving you a heads up. You might hear some stuff from our guys about your fantasy team tweet from last night.”

Crunk escorts me in—his name suddenly reminds me of a fight promoter.

The first thing I notice is that somebody has printed out my most offensive tweet and stuck it on the bulletin board by the door. There’s silence. I walk around a circular table, one of three in the room. I maze around them all. More silence.

Finally, James McCann breaks the ice. He’s seated at his locker. Víctor Martínez is seated at a table, holding an iPad, and Nick Castellanos nods his head nearby.

All players listen in as McCann asks, as a prosecutor might, “Were those your tweets?”

“They were,” I say.

“Why did you tweet them?”

“It’s just kind of my style.”

“Well, you know we don’t have to talk to you in here, right?”

Detroit’s veteran has the attention of the room.

“You don’t have to talk to me, no.”

Another player pipes up from behind.

“There’s young players in here!” says closer Shane Greene, raising his voice. “They see that stuff!”

“Point taken.”

I’m last among media who file into Gardy’s office.

“Did he take his whoopin’ yet?”

“Yep,” someone else says.

I appear in the doorway.

“There he is!” Gardy grins. I stay in the clubhouse until it closes.

When I leave the clubhouse, I head to the dugout, as I would before batting practice on any other game day. McCann walks out.

“I had a feeling I’d find you out here... It wasn’t personal.”

“I respect that.” We shake hands.

ANAHEIM, Calif., *August 6*—When I land in SoCal, my phone returns to service with a Ball Writer’s worst nightmare.

The *Free Press* and the Tigers have been trying to reach me, over and over. Texts pop onto the lock screen, contacts still syncing, no idea who they are. A slight panic sets in.

“Creating a slug on trade. He’ll get three quick grafts up. Sub ASAP.”

“Feeling vindicated I hope.”

“We’ll have Al Avila available on a conference call at 3:30 ET this afternoon. I’ll send dial-in information momentarily.”

“You alive?”

I click over to email. More messages from the sports desk and Tigers PR. A headline on Freep.com. The Tigers have traded Mike Fiers after all—you’ll never believe where.

**TIGERS ACQUIRE TWO PLAYERS TO BE NAMED LATER OR
CASH CONSIDERATIONS FROM OAKLAND IN EXCHANGE FOR
MIKE FIERS**

How could this happen? Because the major-league trade deadline is not really a deadline. It’s just that after July, players must pass through waivers and could be claimed by another team. Fiers passed through, and here we are.

Walking through the terminal at John Wayne Airport, I dial into the call with Avila and join the reporters asking questions through a moderator.

“I think Anthony Fenech has one follow-up and then we’ll conclude the call.”

“Of course he does,” Avila interjects. “Anthony always has a follow-up question.”

“Yeah, Al, what are the names of the players on the list that you have to choose from?”

“Well, that’s the comedy part of it,” Al laughs. “Obviously, I can’t give you those names.”

In the future, the Tigers will choose two players. But that’s at a later date—on the teleconference, Al is feeling good and cracks an inside joke directed at me.

“Anthony, you can pat yourself on the back that at the trade deadline you did break the story that we did have something going on with Oakland.”

Avila the comedian adds that I must have had a “good source.”

SALT LAKE CITY, *August 9*—On the flight home, I’m alerted by the sports desk about a story posted by *Bleacher Report* about HOW KATE UPTON SAVED JUSTIN VERLANDER’S CAREER.

It’s a headline-grabbing love story, with Justin crediting his wife for maybe saving his life, finding him a physical therapist who remade his body, and generally inspiring his return to glory.

“She kept me from jumping off a bridge. Who knows if I’m even here if it wasn’t for her?”

It’s an uplifting piece about the power of love. But red flags fly.

In the story, Justin claims the Tigers misdiagnosed his injury in spring training 2015 as a triceps strain. He missed the first three months of the season.

"I knew something was wrong. They take me out and misdiagnose me... Didn't get an MRI. Because it was so mild."

The story says, "Local writers seemed disinterested in following up on his health or its effect on his play" and reeks of melodrama. OK, well, I believe we've clearly established that this Ball Writer did closely follow his health issues.

Astronomical web traffic is there for the taking. The Freep Sports desk acts fast. JUSTIN VERLANDER SAYS KATE UPTON SAVED HIS LIFE FROM DEPRESSION is the leading story on the *Freep's* mobile app.

I know enough to know this won't be the end of it. Houston visits next month.

DETROIT, *August 10*—Verlander has apparently apologized to the Tigers for his comments.

I get a text from an editor tonight: "Hey there. You have anything coming on the Verlander/misdiagnosis stuff?"

"I don't. I was told they weren't talking about it yesterday."

"Well, they talked to the *Detroit News*. Did they just give it to them? Can we try and confirm that Verlander apologized?"

I rage-call Tigers PR. Luckily, he doesn't answer. I eventually cobble this together: "Through a team spokesperson, the Tigers did not comment directly on Verlander's claim (of misdiagnosis) or the nature of his apologies, but provided details of his injury rehabilitation process, which refute his claim."

Ron Colangelo returns my call and carefully feeds me details of Verlander's apology. Ron says it centered on the word "misdiagnose."

I've already reached out to his agent.

"Does Verlander have any comment on this misdiagnosis quote?"

"I wouldn't be able to comment for him."

"Can you ask him if he would?"

"To be honest I'm not sure that's a good call on my part. I have never commented on anything publicly and or asked any of my players to comment on anything. It's the Bill Belichick model of representation. (Keep your trap shut, say nothing.) I would ask him directly if you would like an answer."

Milchin attaches his wisdom to my words.

"I hear you and am always happy to help with info, but pressing too hard for quotes will make relationships erode as opposed to grow. You'll get there, you're too good.

"And you do it the right way, unlike most of the assclowns dickwads."

BURN OUT

MINNEAPOLIS, *August 16*—With no rooms available downtown this weekend, the traveling secretary helps me book a room at the team hotel—the luxury-brand Loews, located in a tall tower around the corner from the ballpark.

Checking in, I run into Al Avila and TV broadcaster Rod Allen, who are heading out the door. “We’re going for a cigar,” Avila says. “Meet us there.”

When I arrive, there’s a table of players to the right of the rooftop bar. To make certain they see me chumming with the head honcho, I fetch drinks. I walk slowly, careful not to spill—the way one might say I’ve been carrying Al’s water this year. Three cheers to the *Free Press*—I pick up this round.

Smoking cigars to the stubs, the sun goes down.

August 18—Before the media are admitted to the clubhouse, I’m standing against a brick wall in the bowels of Target Field when Rod Allen walks up.

He appears not to care that longtime broadcast partner Mario Impemba is standing close by, in easy range of his booming voice.

“See?” he blurts.

Rod is shaking his head while talking to me, looking at Mario.

Last night, he made a passing mention of their relationship—or lack thereof. This was news to me.

Rod and Mario have worked as the popular Tigers’ TV tandem for the past 16 years. Turns out, the broadcast partners haven’t shared a meal in years.

“Like, how many years?”

“Like 10 years.”

What he said last night, Rod repeats much louder today.

“Dude just doesn’t like me.”

I try to avoid the spreading awkwardness by ignoring him.

I look down at my shoes until the clubhouse opens.

DETROIT, *August 23*—Ronny Rodríguez hits his first home run—the Tigers' third homer today, securing free Arby's curly fries for fans at participating Metro Detroit locations.

Colleague Vince Ellis checks in. Ellis, the Detroit Pistons beat writer for the past 10 seasons, is sitting behind home plate.

"Who is your backup?"

"Don't have one."

George Sipple left last month after 23 years. Couldn't pass up the hours and higher pay at a public-school job and left me to die.

"I'm burned out," I tell Vince. "I've covered the last 19 games."

"You got to speak up."

I call my boss on the way home. Nineteen straight, including two roadies—one to the West Coast. Almost embarrassed, I ask if I can skip the upcoming three-city trip.

Done. This works out perfect, he says—corporate recently levied a travel mandate and he wants to save \$3,000 on Tigers the rest of the way.

August 30—Living my best life on the Burn Out List, lying around watching *90 Day Fiancé* when I get a text message from hell: "I'll call you in a few."

It's my boss, who says the Tigers hit back-to-back homers in the ninth at Yankee Stadium.

Víctor Martínez hit a game-tying homer, the very next guy (Niko Goodrum) hit another, and now it's 10:39 P.M. and I'm not on the Burn Out List anymore: Coach Content takes another piece of my religion, asking if I could write about a game I didn't attend. A game I wasn't even watching.

Newspapers these days.

September 5—By myself at the neighborhood watering hole when something strange catches my eye—Kirk Gibson is on TV for the Tigers-White Sox series finale in Chicago. Strange, because I talked to Gibby yesterday—and he wasn't in Chicago.

He's sitting alongside a fill-in broadcaster. What happened to Rod and Mario?

I reach out to a FOX Sports Detroit executive. Wonder if Deep Throat knows. "Why aren't Rod and Mario on tonight?"

"Ask them, but rumor has it they're suspended. I only have a few details, so I'm counting on you for more."

Funny.

“I got a call saying they fought and not to talk about it. Same rules as always: I never told you any of this. But I believe it was physical.”

More texts. To the TV producer, Kirk Gibson and Rod Allen. I text Rod twice: “Call me.”

Dots appear on the screen—he’s typing back.

“Free Press Anthony Fenech.”

The message is a mistake, meant for Allen’s agent, to let him know the press is on it.

“I will later.”

He never does. Neither he nor Mario nor anyone else I contact responds besides Deep Throat. He predicts they’ll both be fired by Happy Hour tomorrow but can’t say more. The quiet—too quiet—keeps me up all night.

September 6—By dawn, it’s out. Another reporter was on the case—Katie Strang, of course—and her scoop is racing across the Internet: TIGERS BROADCASTERS INVOLVED IN PHYSICAL ALTERCATION.

A month later, FOX Sports Detroit parts ways with the broadcasting pair. The inside story:

“The fight started over a chair. Allen arrived to find Impemba in the booth—what began as a request for the comfortable chair ended in an argument. The conversation turned heated about Allen not showing up early for a scheduled interview. Tensions simmered during the broadcast and boiled over postgame.

“The argument centered on Allen’s frustration with Impemba questioning his professionalism. It continued with Impemba’s finger in Allen’s face and ended after Allen put his arms above Impemba’s shoulder, below his chin, and pushed Impemba against the wall before they were separated by a freelance TV producer.

“‘It was not a chokehold,’ Allen’s agent Tom Shaer said—a claim confirmed by two other persons with knowledge of the situation.”

September 11—Coach Content had the date circled for weeks.

“We’ll need to ask Verlander about the misdiagnosis quote when he gets to town. I’m sure it will come up in the scrum, but if not, let’s make sure it does.”

Pitching against his former team for the first time, Verlander returned triumphantly to Comerica Park last night. He threw seven innings, struck out ten, and received more standing ovations (three) than runs allowed (two).

We crossed paths in the visitors’ clubhouse after the game.

He said “Hi, Anthony” and answered my question, so maybe we’re good again—at least until he knows why I’ve come back today.

I don't want to put Justin on the spot, so I ask for his schedule the rest of the series.

"I gotta steal a few minutes with you."

He tilts his head.

"What's it about?"

I explain I've got orders to ask about his comments in *Bleacher Report* last month.

Busy today. He's gotta go throw. Try coming back tomorrow.

September 12—Same place as yesterday. I pull the recorder from my back pocket and reintroduce the topic.

Verlander has already apologized publicly for the "misdiagnosis" comments. Two days after the story was published last month, he reached out to Al Avila and trainer Kevin Rand.

He leans back, fingers tapping the armchair.

"I'm just gonna let it lie. No point in dredging up the past anymore."

"So, I can quote you on that?"

"I could also give you advice on what to say—and you can take it or not."

"Sure... go ahead."

"I would just say, 'No, they didn't (misdiagnose) me.'"

"My words weren't wrong. I wasn't wrong... I think the article made a little bit of a bigger deal out of it than should've been made."

I switch my approach.

"This is me and you talking here... you came really hard at me earlier, and I'm just working to get you to trust me, because I feel like for the first four years, or three years, you did trust me."

"I tried to talk to you."

"And Justin, when there's people coming to me, saying 'Victor's a problem in the clubhouse'—these are people inside your clubhouse, right? They're going to lose respect for me if I don't write that. And I understand that creates a storm, but that's just part of the job sometimes."

"That wasn't my problem with you. It was the lack of respect for the players. You walk around like you think you're better than the players."

"What?"

"The first time you ever interviewed me. You ask me a question, and you can't even look me in the face—you're looking around the locker room, looking for your next story. It's just consistent stuff like that."

"I went to great lengths to cultivate this relationship with how important you are to the Tigers."

We're interrupted by a clubhouse kid.

"All right... What I'm going to do is—since there's been a lot of conversation here, I'm going to put together a quote for you."

"OK."

"And I will be back here after the game and I will read it back to you, just so we double-check."

"I appreciate that."

Upstairs, I'm flagged down by Astros PR Gene Dias. He asks if we can talk in private and pulls me outside the press box.

"Justin doesn't see any need for the story."

I just spent the better part of ten minutes talking to him about it.

"I think it would be beneficial for your relationship going forward if you didn't write the story."

"You know I have a job to do. Justin's been a professional for a long time, he knows how this works."

"I'm just telling you what could happen."

I listen to the tape and scribble out a quote: "I'm going to let it lie. No point in dredging up the past anymore. I think the easiest way for me to answer it is, it was initially diagnosed as a triceps, and it ended up being a lat. Those are the facts. I don't have any ill will towards them. Like I said, I think that article blew it out of proportion. I don't know if the original diagnosis caused anything—I don't know if it caused me extra time—I don't know. This organization did a lot for me, and I really don't hold any ill will."

Postgame at his locker, notebook flipped to the quote.

"I don't see why the story needs to be written. I already apologized."

"Justin, it's my job. I have bosses who tell me what to do."

I am knee-deep in the gray area of sports writing: No, I shouldn't have suggested him an answer earlier. Yes, I was doing it to help him out. No, I didn't need to cobble together a quote or double-check it with him. Yes, I'm doing all this to preserve our relationship going forward.

But Justin doesn't like when people say no—especially people like me.

I begin reading the quote like I'm reading his rights.

First, he says it was off the record.

"I asked if I could bring my recorder out. I took notes the whole time."

"You're the only one who asked about it. If you write that, I'm not talking to you anymore."

I pulled out my card.

"If there's anything more you want to say, here's my number. My deadline is 6:30."

"I've never texted someone in the media."

"Well, there's a first time for everything."

And to his credit, Verlander snickers, before saying this:

"Are you blackmailing me?"

“Justin, that’s ridiculous.”

“Well, we’re done here. Good luck to you.”

I could tell by the way he said it; he was saying goodbye.

MILWAUKEE, *September 28*—For the last road trip of the season, I have one request.

I text the Highest Source In The Land: “I want to have a cigar with Gardy and Steve Liddle. We have two nights left. Make it happen.”

From the outside, Miller Park looks like a spaceship. But at field level, with the retractable roof closed and the lights dim, it feels homey.

It’s the final weekend of the season. The Tigers clubhouse is open.

I saunter onto the field, where I stumble upon a tender scene.

For perhaps the final time on a major-league field, Víctor Martínez is throwing batting practice to his 14-year-old son, Víctor Jose. The apple doesn’t fall far from the tree—Víctor Jose mimics his dad’s movements in the box, spraying balls from both sides of the plate. Martínez implores him to keep his weight back, hands in.

Martínez is officially retiring after this weekend, putting the injuries, tension and torment of his final seasons behind him.

On September 22 against the Royals, Víctor recorded an infield single in the final at-bat of his career. In a short, tearful farewell to the crowd before the game, he said, “From the bottom of my heart, I can only say thank you. Thank you for being behind us all these years, supporting my teammates, supporting myself. Thank you very much.”

The day I first met Víctor Martínez, I forgot what I wanted to say. Four years ago, at spring training, I mustered up the nerve to ask him about catching. It went fine until I forgot my first question. Standing there, completely blanked out, I said as much. Torii Hunter sat to his right.

“You hear this, T?” Martínez said. “He is minor league.”

He didn’t say it dismissively, rather endearingly. The next day, Martínez saw me and said, “Hey, Minor League.” I was in, wearing that name as a badge of pride.

Perhaps this nostalgia could ease our more recent tensions. I try to flag him down in the dugout after he finishes batting practice with his son.

“Víctor,” I call out.

“Víctor,” a bit louder.

He doesn’t even look my way. Down the steps and into the clubhouse.

I’m not surprised. Don’t necessarily blame him. If the shoe was on the other foot, I might act the same way. Just wanted to say thanks. Víctor had as much

impact on me as any player I've covered—he was the first guy to make me feel comfortable in the clubhouse.

September 29—When I wake up, I text Dick Leinenkugel.

“Always fun to run into guys smoking cigars outside the Pfister in the wee hours of the morning!”

After the game, it's back to the Haunted Hotel for the last hurrah.

The Highest Source In The Land is standing at the bar, speaking with a couple of middle-aged women. One of them is Kelly or Kathy or Kristen. The women are on a quest to attend a game at every big-league stadium—and Detroit's traveling secretary has hooked them up with rooms.

The women are drinking cocktails, and Al Avila has a pop when I walk up and introduce myself. HSITL had all the attention until the Ball Writer butts in.

Coaches sit at a table nearby: manager Ron Gardenhire and his wife, Carol; quality control coach Joe Vavra and his wife, Lynn. I step away from the bar to say hello to the Gardenhires and Vavras.

Avila is looking at me as I return to the bar. He is talking about me, telling the ladies how I'm a newspaper rat and can't be trusted. How I hung him out to dry last month with my coverage of a Tigers' roster screw-up in Minnesota.

“That's not what happened. Ladies, this is what happened...”

Before I can explain, Avila loses his mind and pushes me. In front of everybody at the lobby bar, including the team security guy, who's sitting at the end of the bar with his wife.

Losing my balance, I spill the drink on my sleeve.

Avila ushers himself away to cool down. One of the coaches' wives offers me a napkin.

Al returns and we hug and make up. Get drinks and go outside for a cigar. I smoke half—it figures to be a long night—and leave the other half on the ledge behind the ashtray. We go inside, then back outside, and my half-smoked cigar is gone. While we look for it, a guy with a backpack jaywalks from across the street, beelining for us.

He arrives holding what appears to be my half-smoked cigar in his hands.

“Is this yours?”

We close down the lobby bar. Tigers GM, the ladies who want to see every ballpark, and another guy they welcomed to the group. We go up to one of the ladies' suites. Nothing frivolous or even semi-scandalous, just five people having a good time trying to finish all the alcohol in the suite.

Not even five hours earlier, Al shoved me at the lobby bar. Now, at almost 3 A.M., we're leaving the suite, stepping into the elevator together.

September 30—In the postseason clubhouse, I settle accounts. Apologize again to veteran righty Jordan Zimmermann for the tweet I made in spring training.

Exchange so-longs with catcher James McCann.

“Thanks for being accessible this season.” Offer best wishes to every player who walks by—even as I realize that the Tigers are getting less recognizable by the year. It takes time to build meaningful relationships.

I wait for Nick Castellanos out of respect for the player-reporter relationship we’d built this season.

Castellanos stayed in the dugout long after the last out, watching the sold-out stadium send the Brewers off to the postseason with a standing ovation. He watched it all. He was a rookie when the Tigers last made the postseason. Naively, he thought champagne celebrations would be a yearly occurrence. Four years later, the championship contender he came up with is rebuilding—and Nick figures to hear his name in trade rumors this winter.

“We’re not on that side. We don’t have a tomorrow. You’re frustrated when you’re on this side. It’s the last game of the season and music’s not playing, everything is quiet, so it’s not an environment that I’m happy in. But it’s reality.”

Nick reflects on the year, his first as a team leader.

“As a player, I’m still inconsistent. As a leader, I get selfish at times when I’m struggling. In general, we have a lot of work to do. Me, personally, I have a lot of work to do.”

DETROIT, *October 1*—Tell me about it.

The day after the season ends, I fly from Milwaukee back home, drop my bags and dart to the Corktown neighborhood.

It’s the second iteration of Miguel Cabrera’s kids camp and the man himself is here. Cabrera is on the mend from the biceps rupture that ended his season in June. Arm in a sling, smile on his face, like he’s happy to see me.

We’ve developed a rapport over the years, me and ol’ Miggy. What kind of rapport, I’m still not sure, but for example, just now... he’s sitting in a swivel chair a few feet away and I’m standing amongst a handful of media types not giving him attention when he takes a love tap at my crotch.

He’s like a puppy in a big dog’s body.

I came here to cover my ass—whenever the franchise player talks, someone needs to be there. Since I’m riding solo, that someone is me. Even if it’s a travel day following a weeklong road trip. After running ragged since February, losing my backup, I get this email at 5:48 P.M. on the first day of the offseason.

“Noticed your phone was off (or died?) This week: have season grades done by Wednesday morning. You can work on them tomorrow. Beyond that, plan to look at Tigers free agency. Could be a listicle. I also think a postseason prospect ranking would be good to have over the next week or so... and maybe set the early odds on who the Tigers will pick in next year’s draft in another post?”

No word yet on a day off.

Got a day off. First trip to Malta, last person in my family to visit. Stayed in my second-cousin's villa. Wrote someone an email I never sent. Looked for speed, but they don't prescribe it here. Read books, read for days. On buses to Golden Bay, on rocks at Anchor Bay, with mojitos at Paradise Bay. Ball Four by Bouton and Hell's Angels by Thompson and All The President's Men by Bernstein and Woodward. Met family, went to church. Received communion, couldn't understand anything else. Googled "where to watch NFL football in Malta" and found a sports bar, where I watched the Lions lose. Threw shots back with a guy from Chicago or Atlanta who claimed he was an extra in Gladiator. He took me to ancient ruins where Julius Caesar fought off the Vikings or something. Heard from Top Scout, who was in the Dominican Republic watching a prospect. "Playing damn good here! Bat and glove both." Walked past the place my Nana and Nanu lived before coming over on the boat, took a pic. Smoked weed out of something called a volcano and kept my nose clean until I met my third cousins. Did a lot of coke in St. Julian's, lost my baggie in some cathedral. The cathedrals were cool. Lots of them and the one in Valletta was intense. Ate a lot of pastries. Cheese pastries, meat pastries, sweet pastries. Stuck mushrooms into pastries. Hallucinated on the ripples of the water, the waves. By nightfall I had hiked halfway across the island, past an old man selling veggies at the side of the road. Played bocce, shot at rabbits in the country, smoked cigarettes, probably a pack a day. That's all I did some days, was read. Saw a lot of horses. Didn't shoot at any but did eat horse meat in a village called Żebbuġ or Żurreiq or Żejtun. Ran out of books, bought more. Got a 787-page Tom Wolfe novel for two Euro, read it in three days. Read about New Journalism. Dropped a towel next to a Dutch girl wearing a black tank top that said BALI, hitched a ride back with her. She invited me to watch the phases of the moon, but I passed. Sent congratulations to Red Sox players for winning the World Series. Took a call from Deep Throat while hiking Comino island, went drinking with my cousins until the next day, when I didn't have aspirin for the flight home. It was sublime.

VIVA LAS VEGAS

LAS VEGAS, *December 9*—Heading to the winter meetings, I get a text from Ian Kinsler.

“You should write an article about why a reunion for me to the Tigers would be a good fit.”

I return to Las Vegas, a familiar place where I spent nine formative months working for the *Las Vegas Sun*. I covered my first beat here, the Wranglers hockey team, a farm team of the NHL’s Phoenix Coyotes.

This was nearly a decade ago: Before the Oakland A’s threatened to move here, before the Oakland Raiders would move here, before the city got its first major sports team—NHL’s expansion Golden Knights in 2017. Before the sports arena was built and ground broken on the new \$1.9 billion football stadium.

Now I’m back as a Ball Writer. The casino floor is populated with familiar faces. Small talk with a Rival Exec (future GM) on the way to the front desk.

Baseball folks move between the Mandalay Bay Casino to the Delano Hotel, the shared Vegas Strip property where this year’s winter meetings are being held. The lobby bars are already swelling.

Kinsler sends thanks for the story.

“Stir it a little.”

December 10—A bad-influence friend from the past stopped by last night with a box of beer and a bag. Bad decisions were made, and I didn’t get back on the floor until news had broken: Detroit signs Jordy Mercer.

Boras client, but I don’t bother bugging Big Agent this week. Boras represents the marquee name on the market: Vegas’ own Bryce Harper, who appeared on the cover of *Sports Illustrated* at 16 as “Baseball’s Chosen One.”

Impossibly, Harper has all but lived up to that hype. His career is currently on Hall of Fame trajectory—no surprise to the locals, who have been hearing about him since Little League.

I watched Harper take batting practice at CSN the fall before he was drafted. I was there reporting on a couple of his teammates and never talked to Harp-

er—Chambers and Co. kept him off-limits to the media. The closest anyone came was *Sun* colleague Rob Miech, who wrote a book about Harper's season at CSN.

Harper will sign with the Phillies in February for 13 years and \$330 million—the largest contract in baseball history.

December 14—More news: Kinsler signs with the Padres, two years for \$8 million.

Back in my room, I sit up at a message from Deep Throat.

A trade is afoot.

"Hardy's going to the A's. Frankie Montas and Sheldon Neuse coming back."

I message Hardy. "Hey, I heard you got traded to the A's."

"Haha I haven't heard anything."

"Ok. When/if you do, let me know. Also, congratulations... Boy or girl?"

I text Al Avila twice—"Hardy to A's???... I heard Hardy got traded to the A's, is that true?" I call Avila twice. When I nudge him *again* five minutes later, he calls back.

"The deal isn't done."

Avila is perturbed he has to deal with me, a potential fly in the ointment of a lopsided trade he's lined up with Oakland. He shoots me straight: The deal has been agreed to, pending physicals. Their team doctor is performing surgery and hasn't reviewed the medicals.

We make a deal—I'll stop snooping around, and he'll let me know immediately when it's done.

When Avila hangs up with me, he dials up lieutenant Scott Bream, screaming him off the green at a Scottsdale, Ariz., golf course.

"How the hell is this stuff getting out?" he asks Bream.

The Highest Source In The Land is on a warpath trying to find the front-office leak. Is Deep Throat at risk?

Avila tries to fish out my source when we next speak on the phone.

"Who told you?"

"Al, you know I can't tell you that."

"Where did you get the information from?"

"I'm not gonna answer that."

"What team did it come from?"

"You're putting me in a tough position here. I'm not going to lie to you. That's all I'll say."

"I know who it was that told you. 'Oh, I know...'"

Worrying for Deep Throat's welfare, I wait impatiently for the doctor's word.

To Hardy's agent: "Have you heard anything?"

“No sir. Detroit said he was 100 percent healthy when he left at season’s end.”

Sitting by the phone when Avila calls: Oakland’s doctor nixed it.

“He evidently didn’t like something he saw. There’s nothing we can do about it—it’s their prerogative.”

Avila is dejected. The deal would’ve been a boon for Detroit. Montas will open next season hot before receiving an 80-game suspension for testing positive for a banned substance. Hardy, meanwhile, will suffer a bum elbow in 2019—cutting his season short.

Deep Throat circles back after hearing the news: “Good thing you didn’t go with it.”

DETROIT, *January 4, 2019*—Ringling in the new year at a swanky cigar bar in suburban Detroit.

The Highest Source In The Land is wearing a burgundy turtleneck and reading glasses that he flips on when checking his phone. Al Avila is drinking the usual tonight. I’m drinking wine.

The meeting is status quo: Steak dinner, cigar, a few drinks—HSITL gets the cigars, *Free Press* gets the rest. Avila tells me who’s been chosen as the team’s new TV announcer; I swear not to share.

Our relationship blurs between sources and friends. We barely talk about baseball. We talk about him trying to see his grandkids more and how I want a job at the *Washington Post*. About NFL football (he’s a Miami Dolphins fan), attending a Catholic school growing up (I went to church every other day), and even social media (he recently started an Instagram account).

The relaxed moments are fleeting. I’m entering my fifth year on the beat, and this could very well be my last. Although I’d love to spend my entire career here, I’m resigned to the reality that time at the *Freep* may be running out—for better or worse.

I’ve already aced the Tigers beat and I’m still getting paid less than \$50,000. I’m craving a new challenge and begging for more development. I barely made it out alive last year when George Sipple left midseason.

I don’t have support from my own front office. I’ve soured on my dream job, and it’s starting to take its toll.

My New Year’s resolution is to Make Ball Writing Fun Again. I want to tell fun stories and have fun writing them and live every day this year on the beat as if it’s my last.

It’s snowing when we leave. Avila is stopped by a stranger on the street. The stranger introduces himself— “You’re Al Avila, aren’t you?”—and compliments him on the job he’s done.

“I’m rooting for you.”

Walking away, Avila sounded relieved the stranger said something nice for a change.

I’m rooting for Al, too. Does that make me a bad journalist? Or does it make me human?

January 15—A lot has changed since I stumbled upon fantasy camp on the back fields of TigerTown last winter. But this year we’re making Ball Writing fun again. So, in December, I signed up to play ball with bankers, accountants, lawyers—Tigers fans eager to wear the Olde English ‘D’.

For me, it was a no-brainer. Fantasy camp provided a chance to light myself on fire and tell a story that will assuredly leave a smoky plume of questions about sports journalism ethics—as if sports journalism is anything but entertainment at its core.

“Great news! We’re excited to have you.”

The camp director says fantasy campers are divided into teams. What kind of team do I want to play for? I don’t follow.

“Do you want to play for a good team or a bad team?”

I think about it.

“Bad. Definitely bad.”

“Great! I’ll put you on the worst team then.”

LAKELAND, Fla., *January 28*—Fantasy camp begins with a powwow. All 72 participants circle round, standing outside the Tigers’ minor-league clubhouse, listening to Jerry Lewis’ opening remarks. This week, each player has a locker. Inside hangs a team uniform—home or road. Mine says FENECH on the back. No. 19.

I’m on Team 4, the Worst Team. According to flyers posted around the locker room, we’re supposed to wear road grays today—but all I have is a home white. No matter. I put on the Tigers uniform and trot out with the rest of the campers.

We stretch and play catch. Each team takes ten minutes inside the Willie Horton batting cages—the same cages that Miguel Cabrera uses. By the time Team 4 takes our cuts, they’ve got a road gray for me—no name or number on the back.

This fantasy camp, celebrating the 35th anniversary of the 1984 World Series team, offers a number of coaches who played for the 2006 Tigers, my favorite baseball team ever.

Both of Team 4's coaches are from the '06 team: longtime lefty starter Nate Robertson (head coach) and one-time flame-throwing righty reliever Joel Zumaya (assistant).

The fantasy continues when I receive the Opening Day nod. Nobody spoke up, so I said I could pitch, and I threw three innings. At least 70 pitches, easily, until my arm got tired—I haven't thrown that much since I got cut from the community college team my first year. I was all-area my senior year. Hit .310 with one extra-base hit, got my picture in the paper, all that.

"Good job," Coach Nate says, taking the ball. "We're going to need you for innings, so rest that arm up."

January 29—Wearing whites, I'm on the bump again.

My arm feels fine in the first inning, but then I throw 60 pitches in the second, knocked for seven or eight runs by undefeated Team 1—the best team in fantasy camp. One of the real-life Tiger players gets a whiff of this and sends a couple of trainers to check it out.

Anthony Fenech, a man with many a night perched in the cheap seats, is unable to throw a pitch over the plate in coach pitch. His arm hurts.

Video of my performance circulates online, shared on Twitter by fantasy camp beat writer Jordan Zimmermann. He includes my stats: *@anthonyfenech line vs Tigers Fantasy Camp: 2/3 IP, 2 H, 5 BB, 5 ER, or, not very good.*

I sit at my locker scrolling through the ridicule, lucky the video culprits didn't stick around. I actually went back out for *another* inning and moved up five feet, like it was coach pitch.

Everyone shacks up at the Ramada Inn, fantasy campers and coaches alike—even real-life ones. I walk past Tigers' third-base coach Ramon Santiago with an ice pack on my knee. "Now you know how it feels, *An-tony*."

February 12—Arriving at the park, I walk past Jordan Zimmermann in the parking lot.

"Here's trouble."

Pitchers and catchers have reported to camp.

With everyone trying to catch a first look at the 2019 Tigers, PR is cracking down on the Fake News Media. Ball Writers are welcomed to camp with frustrating news of restricted access—we can't watch bullpen sessions from behind the screen anymore.

"Did you have to miss softball fantasy camp for this?"

It's good to be back.

February 19—I'm on the back fields watching Hall of Famer Alan Trammell work with prospect middle infielders during minor-league mini-camp.

"That's it?" Tram asks. "That's it for the day? Are you kidding me?"

It's nearly 5 P.M. Tram has been on campus since 7 A.M. After drills conclude, walking toward the mess halls, Tram spots stray baseballs beyond the outfield fence.

He stops, picks up one ball. Then another. And another. Soon, he's walking behind center field, throwing each ball back over the fence. A couple of clubhouse attendants see this and speed over on a John Deere. They pick up Tram, whooshing past me.

"Hello, Anthony!"

I first met Trammell in 2009, as an intern at the *Las Vegas Sun*. He came to town that spring as the Chicago Cubs' bench coach, serving as acting manager for the team's Cactus League exhibition against the Chicago White Sox at downtown Las Vegas' Cashman Field.

Introducing myself, I called him "Mr. Trammell." Ten years later, he's "Tram."

LAKELAND, Fla., *March 1*—Today in the parking lot, Miguel Cabrera vrooms around the corner in a car so exotic I couldn't tell you what it was.

Miggy drives at me. He hits the gas, and I stick out my leg.

"You wish!" he yells out the window, speeding away from my chances at a seven-figure injury settlement.

This is our relationship now—playful threats of vehicular manslaughter.

March 4—The big kid in class is cutting up, so I have to tell the teacher—former media relations director Aileen Villarreal, who's now Cabrera's PR handler.

I inform her that Miggy, as the only recognizable player in the Tigers' young clubhouse, will be featured in this year's season preview—but he doesn't wanna do it. I also tell her I called Cabrera's agent, Fernando (Fern) Cuza.

"He said he was gonna talk to him when he comes to Lakeland next about how it's good for him."

I email the story pitch: "I want to give people a look at 'The New Miggy'—how the past year away from the game has impacted him and what his

future holds. My goal is to get under the surface, so fans see the core of Miguel, his passion for baseball, family and the Tigers.”

Villarreal emails back: “Fern wanted me to let you know; he and I will be in Lakeland in the next couple weeks and will talk to Miguel.”

The teacher and principal are on the way. That’ll show him.

LAKE BUENA VISTA, Fla., *March 6*—I see pro scouting director Sam Menzin in the media dining area, which reminds me. During the game, I text Menzin, taking him up on his dinner invitation from a couple days ago.

He’s seated alongside the rest of the Tigers’ second-tier hierarchy, a row behind the team’s top officials—HSITL, assistant GMs, Jim Leyland.

“You like seafood?” Sam messages me. “I took Katie to Gary’s Oyster Bar last year. My reporter tradition.”

“Wow. I’m second-fiddle to Katie.”

“Hey, be happy I asked you.”

LAKELAND, Fla., *March 7*—I’m at breakfast with Craig Monroe at Cracker Barrel when I get a call from a scout, who says the front office is freaking out because earlier I’d texted some provocative questions to the Highest Source In The Land.

Buzzed from a quad-espresso coffee, unable to hold the hot potato any longer, I tip my hand. I text Al, letting him in on the secrets I know.

“If I report the Astros have maintained contact about Nick Castellanos, would that be accurate?... And that you guys turned down (Alex) Bregman for (Michael) Fulmer two years ago!”

Bregman is Houston’s young superstar at third base, an RBI and home-run machine.

These questions trigger a flash five-alarm meeting in TigerTown. Avila calls the front office into a meeting room and threatens to fire anyone found to be the source of the mortifying media leak. I get a message from Sam Menzin.

“I have to cancel our dinner. Sorry, stuff came up.”

After breakfast, I head to the ballpark for the Tigers-Cardinals. Midway through the game, I stir the pot—letting HSITL know that I know about him taking his front officers to the woodshed.

“So did you find the leak?”

Stuck in a slow crawl of fans and senior citizens after the game, Avila calls.

“I can’t hear you that well. I’ll call you later.”

Walking out of the manager's office, I see a missed call from Menzin. He calls again. I answer, speaking softly, walking faster, shaking a tail of trailing writers. They take the stairs to the press box... I stay straight onto the empty concourse.

Sam Menzin is in an absolute frenzy.

"Slow down, Sam. Slow down... What's wrong?"

"I shouldn't even be calling you right now."

Menzin's voice rises. He asks for my sources, saying he wants to know where I got that information.

He asks about specific folks: "Was it (scout)?... Do you talk to (executive)?"

"Look, Sam. I'm not going to tell you who I am or am not speaking to. You know I can't answer that. I wish we had that kind of relationship, but you never even talk to me, man. You haven't given me anything in five years, you know?"

In this rare moment, I'm a reporter with an advantage. Menzin is like a sea lion shaken off its ice patch by Avila's scare tactics—and he's seeking help from a shark.

"Anthony, I could get fired. I could lose my job. He said he's gonna fi—"

I cut him off.

"Sam, chill... I hate to say it like this, but that's not any of my business. And it's not yours, either—you didn't tell me anything about the Bregman deal."

I try to calm him down.

"We had plans. How about you just meet me at the oyster bar like we said. We'll talk then."

"Anthony, I can't."

Sam says that his parents are in town. That he feels like he's going to throw up.

"Look, I'm not writing anything about it right now, OK? But this is literally my job... what's in it for me?"

"Nothing's going to happen, Sam. Enjoy dinner with your parents."

"You are doing your job," my source says, "very, very, very well."

March 8—This afternoon in TigerTown, I'm waiting around to watch Miguel Cabrera field ground balls. No other reporters. Earlier, I noticed the bench coach replacing the agenda taped to the clubhouse door: CABRERA—GROUND BALLS —FIELD #3, 1:30 P.M.

I could have shared this half-baked exclusive on Twitter—*Miggy To Field Ground Balls!*—but then I'd have blown my cover. I still need to get him all to myself. I'm going to pull off a mega Miggy story for the 2019 season preview. But Cabrera sees me coming. He holds up his hands, laughing uproariously.

"No comment! No comment!"

LAKELAND, Fla., *March 9*—Michael Fulmer has grown testy talking about it, insisting he's not worried about his fastball.

"It's not like it just vanished anywhere. It's going to come back."

According to scouts' radar gun readings, Fulmer's fastball registered 88-92 mph today—still short of the mid-90s he typically sits. He's tired of answering questions about velocity—especially from the guy with a 32.80 fantasy camp ERA.

Fulmer's body is much older than the 26th birthday he celebrates next week. After rehabilitating from another knee surgery this winter, the big righty hasn't passed the eye test this spring. Among the most laid back in the clubhouse, Fulmer looks over this scene—he stands silent, in surrender almost, while reporters prod.

I tell him what I'm writing—that he doesn't look the same. Am I wrong?

"Well, you're wrong because I thought you guys are more result-oriented... So, if my velocity is up and I have a bad game, you're result-oriented. And if my velocity is down but the results are good, you guys are still worried about my velocity. Which one are you going to take there?"

I provide my answer in the column: "I'm going to take the Fulmer who throws 95 mph. But I haven't seen him yet and I'm starting to wonder when—or if—I will again."

FORT MYERS, Fla., *March 10*—I pack my bags, fuel up the rental and leave early for spring break—the Tigers and I need a little space. Plus, Pedro Gomez is scheduled to be in Red Sox camp tomorrow.

My annual pilgrimage to Fenway South is for a glimpse at a young farmhand named Rio Gomez.

Gomez is not projected as a top prospect or even a future major-leaguer: Gomez was drafted two years ago in the 36th round out of the University of Arizona as a soft-tossing lefty reliever—he's 24, past puberty by professional baseball standards, expected to start the season at Class A.

Yesterday, I saw his dad was in Florida and wondered if he would be close enough to meet up. Pedro Gomez answered: "Heading to The Fort (Myers) for a Rio Gomez two-inning intrasquad outing and then home to PHX."

I had to be here for that. When I see Pedro, I'm beaming. I give him a big hug, and we catch up. A man wearing a Sox polo walks up with a smile on his face.

"The VP of player development," Pedro says, introducing us.

"What are you doing down here?" the guy asks.

“I came here to see him.”

I can’t recall ever seeing or hearing Pedro nervous—probably a product of his Cuban heritage. Waiting for Rio to walk out, Pedro is quiet. I want him to have that moment by himself. You never know how many there will be with people you love. Make that call. Take that drive. Tell someone you love them.

I tell Pedro. We hug it out.

A rival executive shares news while I brunch with scouts in the media dining. It’s a link for a job opening: RED SOX BEAT WRITER—THE BOSTON GLOBE.

Covering the Red Sox at the *Boston Globe* is arguably the best beat in baseball—a major newspaper in a baseball-mad city where some of the greatest sports writers of all-time have written—Gammons, McDonough, Montville, Ryan, Shaughnessy.

ATLANTA, *March 19*—High noon at the world’s busiest airport, I get a tip from TigerTown. Michael Fulmer is injured.

I hear from Deep Throat while mad-dashing for my terminal to Tampa.

“You hear about Fulmer?”

“No, what?”

“Tommy John.”

Four alarms. Immediately, I call and text Al. I text Sam Menzin in hopes that after our last conversation, he’ll become a useful source.

Deep Throat tells me not to run with it right this second.

“It’ll be easy to trace back to me.”

I miss my flight. No reply from Al or the agent. On the tram to the next flight, I message Deep Throat: “Al is gonna screw me.”

Tigers PR announces the news before I step off.

All that for no scoop.

GLOBETROTTING

TORONTO, *March 28*—Welcome to Canada, at long last. I arrived from Tampa yesterday. Cold, gray, rainy, the whole deal—good thing baseball is played under a roof here.

I buzz around the Rogers Centre during the team's preseason workout. It's my favorite baseball holiday, the Opening Day sourcing round, Christmas Eve to Christmas. I record an interview for the *Freep*'s weekly Tigers podcast with the new TV broadcaster, exchange pleasantries with players and coaches.

I get a scoop from clubhouse manager Jim Schminkel. I snap a shot for Twitter.

Back in my hotel room by half past noon, I shower and pull up the ScoopSheet. From my computer, I rapid-fire good luck messages across the league, personalizing the greetings: *How's it going?... What's your coverage like this year?... Safe travels.* I do this until midnight, leaving West Coast guys for last.

March 29—I walk to the dome for Opening Day: Tigers-Blue Jays.

Nick Castellanos' outfield glove sits on the railing of the dugout. 'Go Get It' is embroidered in dark leather.

An hour before first pitch, I send my application to the *Boston Globe*.

NEW YORK, *April 3*—Phone interview today.

Clubhouse in the Bronx opens at 12:30 P.M., but I'm skipping. Instead, I'm 22 stories high in my midtown Manhattan hotel room for a 30-minute call with the *Boston Globe*.

I keep 'em on for 44 minutes, the sports editor and two assistants. He was quick to respond to my application, which included these references: Pedro Gomez, Bob Nightengale and Al Avila. Listing the general manager of the team is certainly not conventional—but I did it intentionally.

The Highest Source In The Land makes my references page stand out. It begs to be asked about.

“I think it’s very important to have a good relationship with your GM. I put my GM down there because I think he’d give you guys a unique look at the way I cover a team.”

After the interview, I take the 4 Train to The Bronx. Yankee Stadium is sterile and too corporate but still carries the ambiance of a baseball Mecca. Today’s train ride was a herky-jerky hell with standing-room riders pressed against each other, the past two nights have been cold, and what kind of Mecca doesn’t have windows in the press box?

I spot Seamhead George King in the cafeteria in the second inning. King sits at a roundtable, material sprawled out, updating his game logs by hand.

The Tigers catch the Yanks at the right time. They win the series, heading to Detroit with a winning record.

They will lose 114 games this season, among the most ever. But for now, they are 4-3. Tomorrow is the first and most popular game of the year. Brown liquor, keg beer at the fantasy camp tailgate—an Opening Day made for the ‘Ball Writing Fun’ movement.

I wait for Miguel Cabrera postgame. He knows what to say.

“Tell Detroit we’re coming.”

April 20—Scott Boras called this afternoon to let me know that Nick Castellanos signed with him. Apparently, Nick ditched his longtime agent, who has always been helpful.

I put the headline on Twitter and the story in my back pocket. The *Globe* is watching. Next week, they’ll ask about the scoop, noticing Big Agent’s accessibility. By that point, I’ll be following the Red Sox closer than the Tigers, sizing up the Boston beat and trying to snuff out information about the search.

I keep my sources in the loop. Executives, scouts, even the PR chief over there I’ve gotten to know. The night before I leave, I meet with a Red Sox scout I’ve known for years at a dingy dive near the airport. He helps me compile a list of story ideas for the interview and wishes me good luck.

BOSTON, *April 22*—Inside the press box at Fenway Park, there’s a framed picture of the *Boston Globe* sports front on October 22, 1975—the day after Carlton Fisk hit one of the most famous home runs in baseball history.

Today’s game gets rained out. Doubleheader tomorrow—bad news for anyone who has an interview at the *Boston Globe*.

April 24—The interview was rescheduled for today, within the hour.

I snap a selfie in the back of a taxi to the newsroom. Ron Colangelo checks in, looking for a scoop.

“How did yesterday go?”

“Heading there now... Let’s get it.”

“You would enjoy living there. Going to Fenway every day is special.”

When I get checked in, sports editor Matt Pepin gives me a newsroom tour. It’s everything. People. Vibrancy. Windows etched in the design of historic Boston events. Big, but not too big, like the *Washington Post* was.

Mr. Sports Editor throws a curve—I’m meeting with the *Globe’s* top editor in 15 minutes, not this afternoon, like the itinerary says. It’s been a car wash of interviews since then.

What would you bring to the beat? “Creativity. I really like to let my personality show.”

Your key to reporting? “It’s all about building relationships.”

My biggest win might’ve been eating my whole meal at lunch—my stomach develops armor when stressed. He shared a story about the local sports scene that hit close to home. Apparently one time a guy wrote something and didn’t cite the other station—the guy got attacked online and outed for crap in the past.

“It wasn’t pretty.”

“I can imagine.”

CHICAGO, *April 26*—I climb into Andrew’s Navigator at O’Hare charged up on coffee.

Last night in Boston, Jordan Zimmermann left his start with an arm injury. Zimmermann is scheduled for an MRI and I’m all-over Deep Throat—given the circumstances, he’s graciously lifted the Three Commandments.

Mid-afternoon: “Al has the info, and we are releasing a press note at three.”

Wait—what info?

I call Al Avila. He doesn’t answer. Deep Throat got to my urgent questions. “Will call in a few.”

Avila beeps in while we’re on the phone. PR puts out an announcement—Zimmermann won’t have elbow surgery, but he’s going on the ten-day injured list. He will speak in the dugout soon, says media relations director Chad Crunk.

Zimmermann’s eyes are red when he does. He’s clearly been crying.

Down below, Zimmermann walks alone in right field, hands in coat pockets. He can't play catch or participate like a healthy player, and I can't help but hurt for him. Guilt swells. I send Zimmermann a message:

"Hey man, I know I don't need to, but I wanna apologize again for that tweet last year. And I'm sorry you have to go through this. None of us will ever know what goes into staying on the field and how you guys can't control when your bodies let you down.

"It was tough talking to you about it today and I know you were holding it back. I wouldn't be able to say this to you in person, so yeah."

"No worries."

MINNEAPOLIS, *May 12*—The suspense is killing me.

I'm losing sleep over the *Globe*. Who the other finalists are. What my chances are. Why they haven't called. I toss and turn and pick up my phone in the middle of the night, scouring the Internet for clues.

It's been more than two weeks. Decision day is looming.

DETROIT, *May 13*—Mom picks me up at the airport.

"You look exhausted."

"These have been the longest two weeks of my life."

That's around the time I saw the missed call I'd been waiting for. He left a voicemail.

"Just calling to catch up with you regarding our position here at the *Globe*..."

I waved Mom out of the house. Preparing for the biggest call of my life, I got down on my knees and prayed. Not for the job—but please, God, let whatever happens be the right thing.

I take a deep breath. Call back. God answered my prayers: I didn't get the job.

It was hard to process and getting blurry and I spit out a follow-up.

"Where did I come up short?"

"You didn't come up short, Anthony. We really, really liked you. It was a tough decision, but we just thought there was a better fit. If I say any more, I will get slapped on the wrist by HR."

He needn't. I'm a journalist—I can read between the lines.

Hell yeah, I cried. I sobbed. I'm devastated, embarrassed, heartbroken. I really thought I was going to get it. Worst of all, I feel trapped now.

I shaved my mustache, blared the music and missed a call from a Houston number. Thought it was spam until I got this: “This is Gene Dias from the Astros. Please call me when you get a second.”

Just what I needed. I called back and he asked if I’d be at the ballpark today—Houston is in town. I tell him no. It’s a travel day for me. He asked if I’d be there at all this series and if I planned on speaking with Justin Verlander.

“OK. You might not have been planning on it, but I wanted to let you know that after last time—what we spoke about last season and when Justin said he wasn’t granting you interviews anymore—he said on the flight here that he will be sticking to that.”

I tell Dias I understand. No Verlander. Got it.

I hang up the phone. Somehow, someday, I laugh. Life’s funny like that.

ROAD TO OMAHA

KANSAS CITY, Mo., *June 12*—Skipping town after the second game, hitting the road for three hours. I'm driving a lime green Camaro, flipping through the radio dial on a dark construction detour after midnight. Listening to a debate on porn—healthy part of society or public health hazard?

Arriving in Omaha, I settle in for my new assignment on the college baseball beat.

No, I did not quit. Yes, I chose this. I saw the planets aligning a week ago, when the University of Michigan advanced to the Super Regionals in the NCAA Tournament. Already in the area, I planted a bug in my sports editor's ear—*this* is the story we should be covering.

Detroit wraps up its series against the Royals at Omaha's TD Ameritrade Field tomorrow night—it's a grand-opening big league game to kick off the College World Series. I get to stay when the Tigers leave and cover a winning team for a change.

For the first time since 1984, the Wolverines are in Omaha—the heartland city that has hosted college baseball's annual championship since 1950. They arrive as the most unlikely of the College World Series' eight teams—a cold-weather, Big Ten program that has stolen serious attention from the Tigers.

OMAHA, Neb., *June 13*—Kicking up stones, I pull into a parking lot at a local high school.

I'm late, but in the right place—a bus emblazoned in maize-and-blue lettering blocks my view of the field where Michigan baseball is finishing practice.

On that bus is Chris Fetter, a friendly face I've known almost as long as I've been covering baseball. Fetter, 33, was one of the first pro scouts I met on the Tiger Beat—we were both sitting in the media dining room during a rain delay in 2015. Fetter was an Angels pro scout before leaving scouting for coaching. After a stint at Ball State, Fetter returned to his alma mater as U-M pitching coach last season. His star is shining brightly, and he's being mentioned for big league jobs.

Michigan is led by up-and-coming head coach Erik Bakich. My pre-scheduled interview with him runs long, as the team waits impatiently on the bus.

Fetter sends a picture of his favorite Anthony Fenech moment. I'm sitting slack-jawed in the third row of the press box, head back and eyes shut during a doubleheader.

"C'mon. You're putting us to sleep."

June 17—After Michigan's tournament-opening win over Texas Tech two days ago, I met up with a trio of player dads. They celebrated the win; I celebrated covering it. Before tonight's game, I stop for *another* beer with the dads.

I'm having so much fun in Omaha; I don't even mind the goofy stories the desk shamelessly throws my way.

Even here, I keep my ear to the pavement.

"You hearing anything about Tigers?" I ask around.

Rival Exec: "Heard they are winning the whole thing."

Since they left Omaha, with freelance writers covering their misfortunes, the Tigers were swept by the Indians. By the time I leave Omaha, they'll be on an eight-game losing streak. Things on the farm aren't much better—after rocketing up the system, last year's top pick Casey Mize hits the injured list with shoulder inflammation.

The majors seem a million miles away. Next month's trade deadline seems light years from now. It can stay there. For the next few off days, I live the dream at the College World Series. It's as if the Ball Writing gods knew exactly what the 'fun' movement needed.

In Omaha, I wake up late, enjoy unlimited juices and pastries at the breakfast bar and take a nap before covering practice. Michigan has been using Creighton University's field. After today's practice, I take the college newspaper staff out for burgers—paying it forward is a Seamhead tradition.

I'm having more fun than I've had in years. I'm reporting, too, building up the college baseball network I started last year. I run into Auburn pitching coach Steve Smith roaming the concourse, take calls from PAC-12 head coaches and top junior college coaches and even get agent Casey Close on the line.

Close, an agent at Excel, is a Michigan alum. He played on the Wolverines' last College World Series teams in 1983-84. Close was *Baseball America's* player of the year as a slugging senior outfielder in 1986 but found success off the field in pro baseball. He represents A-listers, including future Hall of Fame shortstop Derek Jeter—who committed to U-M before signing with the Yankees in 1992.

I've been trying to get in touch with Close for five years. I've called, emailed, sent his assistant old pictures and clippings from the *Freep* archives, everything. At long last, I highlight his name in green on ScoopSheet.

June 19—Criss-crossing the empty campus on an electric scooter, I chase stories with an enthusiasm unknown to mankind. After interviewing Fetter for a story, I speed to an interview with Vanderbilt head coach Tim Corbin.

Corbin gave Michigan head coach Erik Bakich his big break in 2002, hiring him as a volunteer assistant at Vandy, which is now considered the nation's top program. Corbin has led the Commodores to Omaha twice, winning the national title in 2014 and finishing runner-up the following season.

Now, 17 years later, Corbin and Bakich will square off for the national championship.

"I never would have believed it," Corbin says.

Bakich, 41, has finally broken through in his seventh season at Michigan. The Wolverines' run has made the youngest head coach at a power-five conference a hot commodity—and athletic director Warde Manuel is already cornering Bakich for a contract extension. Manuel's overtures in Omaha will be finalized in the winter, keeping the coach in Ann Arbor for two more years.

"I don't think there could be a better way," Bakich says of his reunion with Corbin, "than to meet in the College World Series finals."

June 21—Michigan stamps its spot in the finals by beating Texas Tech *again* tonight. The Wolverines are trying to add a third national title alongside the 1953 and '62 teams.

Despite arriving here as an underdog, U-M doesn't lack talent. Four players were selected in the MLB draft earlier this month—all Michigan natives.

Senior first baseman Jimmy Kerr was the Tigers' 33rd round pick. Kerr is a third-generation Wolverine—his grandfather John played in the 1962 College World Series, and his dad Derek played in '84.

Covering the Wolverines, I've got the college game down again. I've been on the beat before: I covered the Central Michigan Chippewas in college.

With no pregame duties here, I arrive early and get comfortable at the dads designated bar.

I message Al Avila: "Miss you."

"You cover college baseball now."

"We had a few good years together."

"Stop it."

June 26—Michigan and Vanderbilt split the first two games in the best-of-three finals to set up a grand finale.

Almost two weeks after I arrived in Omaha to cover college baseball, I'm still here, still having fun and still reporting like the sports writing championship is on the line.

In the afternoon of Game 3, I arrive at the team hotel early. Family, friends and fans are sending the Wolverines off at 3:25, but the usually helpful sports information director won't tell me where the team is meeting pregame.

"You should tell me what time/ballroom their pregame meeting is in. Could get color of them coming in and out."

"We're keeping today the same as all others. Fans and media are welcome to be in the lobby."

I love a good challenge, so I text my network of dads— "Anyone know what time team meeting is? For story."

At the Marriott. Staking out the meeting room levels. When the team arrives on the second floor, I watch them walk in and walk out.

Their final meeting began a minute early, at 3:14, when the door closed to the ballroom.

That time had a purpose—attention to detail—and was the last Erik Bakich-ism on the back of the Wolverines' blue workout shirts, right below the letters, 'LFG.' I take note of the crowd, and the police escort the Wolverines receive for the drive around the block.

The press box is decidedly more crowded tonight—I'm packed into the front row next to the college sports writers, no elbow room.

U-M started hot, opening the game with three hits and a run, but early momentum stalled. Vandy scored six unanswered runs, cruising to an 8-2 win.

Postgame, after attending conference room interviews and gathering quotes around the crestfallen Michigan clubhouse, I leave my stuff in the press box, exit the stadium and hustle to the hotel. I'm running in my shirt, tie, jacket and dress shoes. I'm winded by the second block.

Sweating through my jacket, I get to the team hotel—hands on knees and breathing heavily—before the Wolverines' bus pulls up to another roar.

DETROIT, *July 4*—Back on the Tiger Beat and left to my own devices on Independence Day, I reach out to Al, suggesting we smoke a cigar in the name of freedom.

Avila is eating dinner at a local bistro and invites me over afterwards. He suggests I take an Uber. We sit on the patio at sunset, drinks poured, cigars lit, fireworks crackling over a half-constructed house beyond the backyard.

Al asks how I'm holding up after the *Boston Globe* job fell through. (They never called him.)

I'm honest and say I'm still struggling.

"Everything is temporary."

July 23—Cloudy with a 90 percent chance I start trouble today—rain is in the forecast, and I don't really want to go to work. The Tigers are 12-46 since I didn't get the *Boston Globe* job.

I seek out Sam Menzin. I'm flying to Seattle tomorrow for a two-week, three-city road trip through the trade deadline, and now is my last chance to impress upon Menzin that he still owes me. Trades are coming, and this Ball Writer needs some scoops.

"Let's meet up for a few at the park today. Wherever, whenever—I'd like to talk to you."

"About what? I'm pretty tied up today."

"Personal in nature. Don't give me the run-around. It won't take long."

We talk between the sloping concrete walls of Section 223, stepping into the Comerica Park concourse when it starts pouring rain.

I make sure to pump Menzin up, acknowledging the frustration he feels being forced to wait his turn for more influence.

Menzin says Avila has warned the front office about being tight-lipped. But he also says, "I can't guarantee anything," which leaves the door open. He outs himself as being in touch with *another* National Guy. "I've even told Buster (Olney) about needing to be quiet right now."

But I'm not going to be patient. The trade deadline is coming.

ANAHEIM, Calif., *July 31*—Nearly 20 unanswered texts to Al Avila tells you everything about how this trade deadline is going. After getting frozen out by my own team's front office, I'm relying on second-hand sources, Snapchat messages, and Scott Boras to break news. It's a humbling position for a beat writer, but it's also liberating—when your primary sources cut you off, you get creative.

Conditions in sunny Orange County are good for last-minute trade deadline drama. Playing a matinee on the West Coast has created an unusual situation—the 1 o'clock deadline coincides closely with the first pitch, scheduled for 1:07 P.M.

I'm trying to salvage something from a deadline that feels like professional quicksand.

I text a source at hotel breakfast: "Accept my Snapchat. Don't text me back."

Anything going on with Shane Greene?

"No," the source "snaps" back.

Greene, the Tiger most likely to be traded, asks for the latest details.

"Gun to my head, I think it's gonna be the Braves."

An hour before the game, Greene is reportedly traded to Atlanta.

"Close," one insider says. "Done," another echoes. Six minutes before the game, I'm still in the dugout. The national anthem plays. Last I saw, Nick Castellanos was in the on-deck circle, but I've lost him. Playing Telephone while taking the stairs—texting or tweeting or talking on Facebook Messenger.

I hear from a third-hand source that Castellanos has been traded to the Cubs. They share a screenshot of a conversation with a second-hand source who works in the clubhouse. I text Avila once more and Scott Boras again. "No news." So, I give him some news: "Cubs I think. He left the dugout."

It's true.

"Cubs," Boras says.

I can't tweet it fast enough. Ken (expletive) Rosenthal beats me by two or three seconds.

HSITL ghosted me, but he can't hide forever. In a conference call with reporters, I ask what he'd say to fans who are underwhelmed by the moves—in exchange for the best reliever traded (Greene) and an impact rental bat (Castellanos), Detroit received four middling prospects.

"I don't know what you mean by underwhelmed. I thought the return was pretty good considering the market for relief pitchers, the competition, and everything involved."

The utopian phase has worn off. I'm an unhappy Ball Writer rapidly outgrowing his patch of land, becoming a big pain in the Tigers' behind.

Rival Exec talks me down. Over an hour on the phone. He knows how it goes: "There comes a time where you gotta punch back."

ARLINGTON, Texas, *August 3*—Since I arrived here for the final leg of the three-city trip, I've been putting together the Trade Deadline Exposé—unearthing moves Al Avila should've made, analyzing his below-average return on players and questioning why he keeps making similar mistakes.

Two years ago, teams were hot for righty starter Michael Fulmer: The Cubs offered shortstop Javier Báez as the centerpiece in talks, plus a pair of prospects; Houston offered third baseman Alex Bregman as the centerpiece in talks for Fulmer and lefty reliever Justin Wilson.

Avila didn't act on those deals, and things went sideways—Fulmer underwent elbow surgery in March, while both Báez and Bregman have blossomed into

bona fide stars. This year, Avila passed on trading veteran lefty Matthew Boyd, who was perhaps the most attractive starter available on the trade market.

At 28, Boyd is in his prime. Boyd is coveted not only for his pitching but also his contract—he doesn't hit free agency until 2021.

The exposé carries perhaps tougher implications than those two years ago: Instead of alienating the problem child in the clubhouse, I'll be alienating my best source for cigars and information—the Highest Source In The Land—and, in turn, most of his In The Room officers.

I've been cutting out the booze lately, but this pushes me to a late-night establishment.

"I feel like I'm gonna puke," I text a friend.

Explaining to a Freep Sports confidante how we got here, I second-guess myself, wondering if I reported the story with too much emotion: "Basically, Al stonewalled me. From not getting back to me about Jake Rogers' call-up at the start of the trip (gave him and others multiple chances) to him ghosting me at the trade deadline. I've had his back consistently. And it's because I like him—not because I believe it.

"I just flipped when I was sitting in the dugout empty-handed watching another college kid break the Shane Greene deal. I felt humiliated, so I said, 'F' it. This is done with."

And emotion aside, the Tigers and their fans deserve better from the GM. At midnight, the story goes live on Freep.com, detailing Avila's past and present failings.

Avila didn't do Castellanos' trade value any favors in the winter, responding to the outfielder's preference for a preseason trade, "Quite frankly, there has been no interest at this point." And he closed up shop early on Boyd's bustling market, telling the lefty a week before the trade deadline that he was unlikely to be traded.

In the Trade Deadline Exposé, rival executives speak out, calling the Tigers' price on Boyd "borderline comical" and the team's rigid negotiation stances "impossible to deal with."

"The end result was another missed opportunity, aided by self-inflicted issues in marketing their players, a lack of creativity in finding the best returns and, of course, the shrinking trade market, which has long been their excuse for not bringing back significant prospect hauls."

Last week in Seattle my workout was cut short by news of a lawsuit—the team was sued by the clubhouse attendant who was allegedly subjected to a racial slur last year from Chris Bosio.

Avila, assistant general manager David Chadd and special assistant Willie Horton, the famous former Tiger star, are the only current employees listed in the complaint.

It upset me that the team took advantage of Horton.

After I chased that news from Seattle, we flew to Anaheim for the trade deadline. Got nothing from the front office. Now I'm in Texas and my phone hasn't stopped flashing texts since the story about front-office malfunctions went live.

"Lots of respect that you called them out on it."

"I was wondering when you were gonna drop it. You'd been sitting on it for a loonnnng time. Al must've really ticked you off..."

I reach out to Rival Exec. "There will be repercussions."

DETROIT, *August 5*—Back home after 12 days on the road, more Tiger Beat drama.

They're talking about the exposé on 97.1 The Ticket in Detroit and 96.1 The Game in Grand Rapids.

"I'll tell you right now, this piece that Fenech wrote today. Find me the last time someone wrote something this impactful. This thing's picked up by every outlet out there—because it says something. Because it calls Avila and this organization out for what they are. You got a beat writer putting his balls on the block."

Across the state, a friend checks in.

"Someone called you a hero."

PR reaches out. Ron Colangelo says Al wants to talk about the story. I'm "off" today, but I'd rather nip this in the bud. Sure, I'll stop by.

Deep Throat checks in. "Heard you're meeting with Al later today. Stand your ground, man."

Yesterday's article has challenged my good standing with Avila, who says my reporting wasn't true—"well, not entirely." He is sullen, not steaming mad, and doesn't ask for my sources this time.

"If you have someone on your side leaking incorrect info, then that's an even bigger problem."

Avila says reading the story felt like getting stabbed in the chest.

I tell him I texted him so much at the trade deadline and got nothing in return.

"I'm not doing my job, my position, my readers justice by not reporting what I know—especially when I'm not getting anything from you."

Avila doesn't say much, but I know our high times are over. I hear it in his voice; I see it in his face: I hurt the Highest Source In The Land.

A LETTER TO THE EDITOR

From: Thomas, Christopher **Sent:** 8/20/2019, 12:15 PM

Subject: Tigers today

Might be worth asking J.V. about if Bregman had been traded to Detroit, would things have been different. If he's got access. Would tie in nicely if we end up getting Bregman.

To: Thomas, Christopher **Sent:** 8/20/2019, 1:28 PM

Subject: RE: Tigers today

I apologize if I'm coming off a certain way, but I just need to make a couple points here: There is a very minimal chance I will be asking Justin Verlander anything. When he returned to Detroit this season, I received a call from Astros PR saying that Verlander would specifically not be talking to me. Why? Because I was the only person to ask him last year—at my editor's request—about his injury misdiagnosis claims. I understood then that it would harm my future relations with him, but I did it anyways.

So, if I'm in the Astros clubhouse looking for Bregman and a scrum appears, sure, I'll go over there, once again putting myself in a situation that will almost assuredly result in Verlander ignoring my questions or taking the opportunity to publicly bully me. Walking around as the Tigers' public enemy No. 1—these guys have been avoiding eye contact with me since Aug. 5—will help me going forward because I've crapped where I eat and now I gotta make do.

From: Thomas, Christopher **Sent:** 8/20/2019, 2:05 PM

Subject: RE: Tigers today

Seriously, man, if his stance is that a reporter from Detroit can't ask him about a very serious claim that he made about his time in Detroit, I don't know what to tell him. You did your job. I think you've been fair in your scrutiny of the franchise, and the questions are definitely worth asking. It's not as much about page views as much

as holding the franchise accountable for their decision-making during this process. I think you've done a nice job finding things to talk about during a time when there isn't much to talk about. It isn't easy, and I recognize that. Thanks for doing it.

* * *

HOUSTON, *August 20*—The mess I'm about to step into was created last week. I stopped by the *Free Press* newsroom to check my mail, and Coach Content caught me flat-footed. I was catching up with another editor when he said, "Let's have you follow-up with Bregman while you're in Houston to get his thoughts."

Still basking in the afterglow of a clicks bonanza from the Trade Deadline Exposé, he wanted more juice—the lowly Tigers aren't bringing eyes to the site these days.

I hoped it'd slip his mind, but nope. "Don't forget," he emailed yesterday, "as we mentioned before, we gotta get Bregman talking about the possibility of being a Tiger a few seasons ago. The sooner we get that one pregame, the better."

So, here I am. Walking into the Astros clubhouse to find Alex Bregman. Responding to my August 4 report, which said two years ago Detroit rebuffed Houston's efforts to trade for Michael Fulmer using Bregman as the centerpiece, the cocksure superstar tweeted, "Nah, false."

Days later, Bregman's tweet was gone. Weeks later, and Commander Click wants me to ask about it. The first person I see? Bregman, inspecting a box of brand-new bats in a hallway off-limits to the media. Inside the room, Old Pal is not at his locker. I keep an eye on Bregman's stall.

The digital clock says 3:04 P.M. I set a mental five-minute timer to get out of Dodge. Haven't seen Bregman—I'm hoping he went to the batting cages after picking a winner.

The Tigers' TV guy and a cameraman enter the locker room. Rival Cohort Chris McCosky hustles in. More writers gather—all at Verlander's locker. He finally appears, squeezing into the center of the scrum.

Ball Writers want to know how the future Hall of Famer feels about facing his former team tomorrow night.

I was hoping this wouldn't happen. I didn't want this to happen. Forced to decide between staying here—on Bregman watch—and walking over to the Verlander crowd, your fearless *Free Press* Ball Writer decides to join the fun (of course he does).

Walking slowly toward his locker, past the digital clock. Justin spots me and says:

"I told you guys..."

His eyes dart from side to side. We make eye contact at least once.

"I'm not talking with Fenech here."

I look at him and shake my Baseball Writers' Card.

"Hey, I have my badge here."

He's inflamed.

"All right. Well, then I'm not talking. Sorry, guys. You guys know what he did."

Actually, they have no idea. And when you come right down to it, neither do I.

Verlander turns around and grabs his phone. Apologizes once more to the assembled media standing at his locker, struck silent in awkwardness.

He points at me.

"The only person I said I wasn't going to talk to. Everybody else, bring it up with him."

Nobody does.

Verlander walks off.

One of Houston's PR guys stands nearby—communications manager Steve Grande.

"So, that's how you're going to play this?"

"Yeah... How would you play it? Leave?"

Grande shakes his head. He mutters something about not thinking about my colleagues. In fact, I am thinking about my colleagues—anyone gonna speak up? The Tigers' TV guy looks bewildered: "I don't know what the hell's going on."

I stick around long enough for Verlander to return to the scene. He sits down for a teammates' card game—and plays gossip girl under his breath.

"Standing right there."

A player shoots a quick glance. Others take turns looking the Idiot Reporter's way. I stay in the clubhouse for 12 more minutes, according to the digital clock. After Justin blew me off, I couldn't just flee the scene. Now I'm just lingering to prove a point.

Later, I discover the laughs on me. Verlander met up with Rival Cohort for a one-on-one interview—arranged by the Astros—before returning to his gossip and cards.

I can't help but think: Instead of talking *about* me, could have talked *to* me—maybe we could've come up with a solution to what's still bothering him. Maybe.

Astros PR keeps an eye on me as I keep an eye on Bregman's locker. He never shows.

Back in the friendly confines of the visitor's side. Chit-chatting, stuffing my slacks with bubble gum. Jordan Zimmermann has a look on his face.

"I heard Verlander's looking for you."

My first thought: How does Zimmermann know that Verlander walked out in protest no more than 20 minutes ago?

On second thought: “You’re kidding me.”

The Tigers lose, falling 50 games under the .500 mark. During the game, I get a text from a Toronto scout in attendance, who says, “I’d travel with a bottle of moonshine if I were you and had to watch this team every night.”

Postgame, I make a point to speak with Miguel Cabrera, previewing tomorrow’s main event. For the first time, Cabrera will face off against Verlander. The future Hall of Famers were teammates for ten seasons in Detroit.

“Another day at the office. I know what he’s gonna do, so...”

When I ask Miggy how Verlander will pitch him, he doesn’t hesitate.

“Inside. He’s gonna pitch high with a fastball and use his slider to try and get a first-pitch strike with the breaking ball and that’s it.”

I tell Miggy his secret is safe with me.

“I’m not going to write anything... because if he reads it, then he’s going to know.”

In lieu of moonshine, I meet up with my Blue Jays buddy at a downtown tap house. I give him the backstory. About the solar eclipse tweets, the injury misdiagnosis questions, how Old Pal blew me off earlier and what I tweeted postgame: “Asked how he thinks Verlander is going to pitch him, Cabrera said a bunch of stuff I’m not posting on Twitter because Verlander checks my feed obsessively when he plays the Tigers, no doubt.”

It’s satire, obviously. Like Justin Verlander would ever read my tweets.

August 21—Standing next to an Astros PR guy at the urinal.

“You think Gene (Dias) is going to be pissed when I go ask Verlander questions after the game?”

He laughs uncomfortably and returns to his front-row seat along Dias. The Astros’ VP of media relations is in his mid-fifties. Been with the team for 10 years. He spent 20 years with the Phillies before that. The message I let slip is delivered. Dias glances at the third row. He gets up and gestures to join him for a chat. Here we go again.

“Why are you going to talk to (Verlander)?” Dias asks.

I need postgame quotes from Verlander because, in my boss’ words, “That’s the story we sent you there to cover.”

Dias: “This isn’t the first time he’s told you this. You know why Verlander doesn’t want to speak with you.”

“No, honestly, Gene, I don’t—why?”

“Because of last time. Because you wrote what you wrote. He told you he wouldn’t be talking to you any longer.”

I tell Dias that I’ll be in there—I’m credentialed. “I have a job to do.”

“He doesn’t want to talk to you. You know this.”

"I know, but I have a job to do. My editor wants me to go over there."

I'm "antagonizing" Justin, he says, which makes me laugh.

"Give me a break, Gene. He's a professional baseball player, for crying out loud... I'm just doing my job."

We end the conversation as far apart as it started. It doesn't inspire confidence I'll be allowed in the Astros clubhouse postgame—BBWAA protection or not. I'm an out-of-towner. This is Dias' turf. A credential won't matter when push comes to shove—he is the gatekeeper.

I call our guy in charge. Chris Thomas. Once again, I express caution. I suggest skipping the Astros clubhouse after the game, barring a no-hitter or something.

He's not having it.

"You need to go over there, no-hitter or not... Verlander is the local story, which is why we have you in Houston right now."

I call Pedro Gomez. He's at home in Phoenix, before flying out to Minneapolis tomorrow for a long weekend road trip—he's covering the Vikings-Cardinals preseason game.

I tell Pedro the Astros are trying to keep me out of the clubhouse. Pedro says call Mike Teevan, MLB's VP of communications. Teevan has heard similar stories but offers no quick fix.

Pedro: "You should consider asking your editor if you can write a first-person piece about the absurdity of all this. Write notes down of what the Astros have said to you. Use them. Let the baseball world know how petty they are being."

Pedro will be in my ear all night. He's been there as a Ball Writer—reporting on problem children like Curt Schilling, Barry Bonds, and many more.

Continue volleying texts with Gene Dias.

"Hey Gene, it's Anthony, just circling back: For our Detroit readers, I'm going to your clubhouse after the game to listen to Verlander and ask questions about his performance tonight."

"You are aware that Verlander has said he will not talk to you, correct?"

"Yes, but I have an obligation to my readers. If he doesn't want to talk because I'm there, I'll report what happens. But I will be in your clubhouse. My BBWAA card allows that. He's under no obligation to speak with me but neither he nor anyone can prevent me from doing my job."

"You have done your job. You have made it known that you want to talk to him. He has declined. As a courtesy, I can revisit this with the player postgame. OK?"

"I appreciate you asking as a courtesy... I'll be in your clubhouse postgame."
Pedro Gomez is fired up.

"The Astros don't get to dictate your story. Do your job. Stand your ground. Don't leave the Astros clubhouse until it closes. Make your point. If that means

he doesn't speak at all, then so be it. This makes me incensed, but I'm guessing you can tell. My Cuban blood is boiling."

So is mine. I send Astros PR *another* message.

"Just so you know, I've been in touch with MLB, and they have assured me that I cannot be prevented from entering your clubhouse."

"Thx for the info."

Dias' paycheck comes from the Astros. He's doing what he's paid to do. My paycheck comes from the *Free Press*. I do what I have to do.

"Tell Teevan that you don't want to get down there and have some overzealous security guard try and prevent you from doing your job," Pedro says, "because if that happens, that scenario may keep you out long enough where JV will finish and you'll be fucked."

Verlander dominated in a complete game, striking out 11 with no walks. He allowed two hits. Ronny Rodríguez hit a solo shot in the fifth inning, and John Hicks did it again in the ninth. Stepping in against big brother's childhood buddy, Hicks retained hometown bragging rights: He homered, his second off Verlander in as many years, and the Tigers pulled off the biggest single-game upset in baseball history, 2-1.

"Win of the Year!" Ron Colangelo with a massive understatement.

But instead of beelining to the visitor's locker room and interviewing Rodríguez, Hicks and pitchers Buck Farmer, Daniel Norris and Tyler Alexander—who combined to silence the Astros—I head the other way as assigned.

"What a win for them... and my boss wants me to go to the other side. I'll hustle back."

I end up standing near the end of a long line of media waiting to gain entry to the Astros' clubhouse, anxiously scrolling through my phone. I know what's going to happen next.

Pedro reminds me: "Take notes of everything. Detail everything. Document it. Make sure you have it."

9:27 P.M.—Trying to get social media attention, the *Freep* Twitter account sends a cute breaking news tweet, extra-cheeky and factually incorrect, linking to my game story:

#BREAKING: Justin Verlander once again pitches Detroit Tigers to victory, 2-1 in Houston.

The sports editor texts me: "Hey, that headline was intentional, I'm told... I can change if you want, given touchiness of everything."

Ya think?

9:30 P.M.—Gene Dias: "I'm going to speak with Justin again to see if he'll talk to the media with you present, but I don't expect anything has changed."

I reiterate the party line: I'm a BBWAA member—I get the same access as everyone else.

"Why are you doing this?"

“What? My job?”

9:33 P.M.—He’s back.

“Justin said he is not talking with you there. You’ll come in when I get you.”

9:35 P.M.—Doors open. The line snakes into the clubhouse. A super-sized security guard stands in my way. “You can’t go in right now.”

I think about juking, but there’s backup—two others stand nearby.

9:36 P.M.—I text MLB PR Mike Teevan: “Just got stopped by security... Verlander is not talking with me there and Gene has said I can’t come in with the others, until he gets me.”

I call Teevan. No answer.

Pedro: “Show your card. Tell them to scan it. It’s in good standing. You’re allowed.

“Ask the guard why you can’t go in. Keep all these notes. Take out your phone and shoot video. Ask why you aren’t being allowed in on camera.”

Fidgeting on my phone, I approach the security guard who stopped me.

“Why can’t I go in?”

“Gene said, ‘I’ll come and get him when he’s ready to come in.’”

The guy has a clean-shaven head. He wears khaki pants and a team-issued employee ID badge hanging from a belt loop. I take a few steps back and snap the cover shot of my career—three security guards, standing side by side in front of the Astros clubhouse.

9:39 P.M.—Teevan, four minutes later: “I reached out to Gene and he said he’ll be getting you shortly.”

9:41 P.M.—Dias waves me in—six minutes late.

As I enter the room, the media scrum slowly dissipates from Justin’s locker. Cameras are down and reporters have retreated. While I was kept outside, Verlander talked about the loss.

“One bad pitch in the ninth inning. We battled back, and I give it back in the ninth. I don’t blame anybody but myself. I could have done a better job executing a pitch there.”

Old Pal sits in his chair. He’s expecting me.

“I’m not answering your questions.”

On the winners’ side, media relations manager Chad Crunk turns the music down as reporters make their way around the victorious clubhouse, sans one. The worst team in baseball just beat arguably the best team in baseball and Verlander, who will *finally* win his second Cy Young Award this year.

Too late for Ron Gardenhire’s postgame session, I join the clubhouse mix. Tonight’s hero draws a crowd. Hicks was claimed off waivers last year.

I stick my recorder into the scrum around Hicks.

“It’s surreal, for sure. I’ve kept track of him his whole career and it was a special moment getting to catch him (with the Tigers). And then getting to hit against him... I mean, he’s got me plenty of times. But I’ve gotten him twice.”

Afterwards, I'm intercepted by Jordan Zimmermann, who's been full of jokes lately.

With that same cheeky look as the other day, he grabs my Baseball Writers' Card hanging from my lanyard, shaking it as a prop for his comedy: "Is this the wrong year you're using?"

Zimmermann's wondering why my badge didn't work entering the Astros clubhouse earlier. He thinks it's hilarious that he knows why. So do I.

"Really?"

Daniel Norris overhears. He asks what happened. Another joins in.

"Ver is an egomaniac," someone shrugs. "Everyone knows that."

9:44 P.M.—Leaving the clubhouse, I call my boss.

"You know we're going to have to write about this, right?"

The mad dash begins. It's a five-alarm fire—and this one has my name in it. I exhaust my contacts, going all the way up to MLB's top-ranking PR official, chief communications coordinator Pat Courtney, the commissioner's right-hand man. I try to track down the BBWAA president and reach out to association secretary Jack O'Connell. I reach Crunk, who comes through in the clutch, sending a copy of the collective bargaining agreement.

9:46 P.M.—I leave Gene Dias a voicemail, letting him know we're writing a story.

Returning to the press box, Dias is leaving. The door shuts behind him.

10:30 P.M.—I head to the Four Seasons team hotel, find a second-floor table with a nearby electrical outlet and post up there. I've got one more story to write.

The loud music of the lobby bar tries to lure me. I've been off the sauce for seven days and pass up the temptation with one concession—the Jack Daniel's mini I keep in my work bag in case of emergency.

Working into the wee hours with the help of trusted colleagues Pedro Gomez and Bob Nightengale from his hotel room in New York, my sports editor and I try to decipher CBA language and BBWAA rules.

The story goes live just before two in the morning.

3:04 A.M.—I leave the Four Seasons so late, the Astros' next opponents have already arrived for their upcoming series—a puddle of Angels luggage takes up half the valet line when I grab a cab.

Could text Brad Ausmus but no—the Angels arrive having lost back-to-back walk-offs against the Rangers.

Back in my hotel room, it's quiet. Scrolling through the story over and over, yawning in bed. It's on the front page of Freep.com, my cover shot included. Just a matter of time it's everywhere after that.

I text my friend: "Gonna wake up tomorrow to a 'Justin Verlander Hates Anthony Fenech's Guts' story on *Deadspin*."

I guess it could be worse. I could be the guy who bet \$63,250 on tonight's game and lost.

UNETHICAL

HOUSTON, *August 22*—Must have dozed off in my dress slacks—four in the morning, maybe?

The personal issue between old pals is on the home screen of Freep.com: ASTROS BLOCK FREE PRESS FROM JUSTIN VERLANDER'S POSTGAME MEDIA SESSION.

My name's not mentioned, but the secret is out. A rising tide of interview requests has already begun—morning shows back home are on the case.

"If you're awake, do you want to talk about the incident?" a radio producer asks.

The cell phone flashes again at 5:47. It's MLB PR: "Catching up on the missed call and messages you left since we last spoke. I went to bed after your 10:39 P.M. text."

Well, I'm glad one of us did. Not that I'm any worse for wear: I woke up wired with a nervous energy that reminds me of sixth grade. A field trip to an amusement park, deathly afraid of roller coasters and squeezing the safety bar all the way up. I learned an important lesson that day: Sometimes, all you can do is take the ride.

I survived but haven't been on a roller coaster since... until now.

"Sorry to bother you," someone from News Radio 950 texts me. "I know your phone must be blowing up."

Soon, it will be—with friends, family, colleagues, sources and randoms wishing me well.

I ignore all but a select few. I've been keeping a tally of phone calls since last night: *Nightengale... Pedro Gomez... BBWAA president...*

Evan Drellich texts me: "Gene Dias, ladies and gentlemen!"

Drellich is a longtime colleague. He was the Astros' beat writer until 2016 and knows more than most about dealing with them. He tweets: "A fun 'did you know' from half a decade ago. The Astros held a meeting with the top two editors at the *Houston Chronicle* when I was there in an attempt to get me fired. Why? Because I asked about and wrote critical things."

"Off-the-record," he asks, "What happened? Like why is he mad?"

A reader emails: “Was it simply because Verlander took a blow to his sizable ego after getting beaten by an epically bad team and didn’t want to face questions he found humiliating? Is he really that sensitive and petty?”

I lay on the bed, stare at the ceiling and count down from 90.

This is when it hits me: I am now the subject of the story.

10:32 A.M.—Breakfast at the Sam Houston Hotel.

After placing my order, I call Drellich, catching him up on the past five seasons of Fenech-Verlander sagas. About solar eclipse tweets, clubhouse freeze-outs and the Kate Upton Saved My Life story.

Before I cut a fork into my eggs, Mount Verlander erupts on Twitter.

“I declined to speak with the @Freep rep last night because of his unethical behavior in the past. I reached out to the @Freep multiple times before the game to notify them why and to give them an opportunity to have someone else there. Ironically they didn’t answer.”

“Although I tried to avoid this situation altogether, I’ve still reached out to @Freep multiple times today with no response. They’re still not interested in my side of the story.”

Gulp down breakfast. Gotta go. Still talking to Drellich when the elevator arrives. He asks if I want him to put anything out there, something to share my side.

“I’m good for now, but I’ll let you know.”

Drellich does what he can, spinning context into the growing chaos. He shares his recent column in the *Athletic*, headlined, “The first rule of beat writing: Don’t talk about beat writing.”

“These aren’t issues reporters often pick through publicly. Media complaints generally fall on deaf ears. Twitter harassment doesn’t need to be deliberately sought by those who encounter plenty already from the burn-the-media crowd.

“Beyond the almighty power of common fear, though, is a guiding principle at work, rooted in old-school journalistic training: You are not the story. Do not inject yourself.”

Drellich tweets about the dilemma: “Fenech is in this bind now. Air it all out? Stay quiet?”

Justin just called me the nastiest word in journalism without substantiating his claim, like someone accusing him of taking steroids with no proof. He’s essentially invited me into his social media echo chamber—Verlander has 1.9 million followers.

He unfollowed me early in the 2017 season. Asked why, he said, “Too much sarcasm. I couldn’t take it anymore.”

10:57 A.M.—The sports editor responds to Verlander from his personal Twitter account: “I would like to know who you have contacted @freep about telling your side of the story. My reporter has not heard from you directly, nor

have I. My email is listed on the article we published last night—I am more than happy to speak with you about it.”

ISE Baseball CEO Mark Pieper called his work number and left a voicemail, but Thomas didn’t check until just now. Both Pieper and fellow ISE agent Mike Milchin has my number. Just saying.

11:03 A.M.—The midday show on MLB Network Radio SiriusXM 89 weighs in with an interview of former Mets GM Jim Duquette. His take? “There must’ve been some critical articles of him (Verlander) in the past.”

Duquette is asked if Verlander should have “let bygones be bygones and let everyone in—or just single out one person in particular?”

“It’s definitely not a good look.”

11:27 A.M.—I’m trending on Twitter. By noon, someone turns the feud into a meme, comparing a ‘Tale of the Tape’ between the contestants. Every half hour, the feud is mentioned on The Ticket’s sports radio update. The meme gives my mustache the edge over his.

Deadspin’s story has been up since mid-morning—ASTROS BAR REPORTER FROM POSTGAME PRESSER AT JUSTIN VERLANDER’S REQUEST. The reporter messages that she’s “writing about you being barred from the Astros postgame presser last night. What was their reason for keeping you out? Did you or your bosses lodge a complaint? Also happy to hop on the phone if you have a few minutes. Thanks.”

I ignore her, like the rest of reporters who fill my text messages, direct messages, Facebook messages and email. There are already stories in the *New York Post*, *Sports Illustrated*, and *The Big Lead*. *Awful Announcing* and ESPN.com. Radio shows and TV stations are asking, even a blogger from *Barstool Sports*.

1:05 P.M.—MLB releases a statement: “Per our Club-Media Regulations, the reporter should have been allowed to enter the clubhouse postgame at the same time as the other members of the media. We have communicated this to the Astros.”

Messages arrive from everywhere. “You’re Big News on the radio,” a local radio host says. “People backing you.”

I’m jacked up, bouncing off the walls again, buzzing from extra-leaded coffee—and angry, absolutely. Too much adrenaline for a hotel room, I go down to the third-floor workout room. The TV in the corner scrolls the global news (... \$16.3 TRILLION CLIMATE PLAN • AMAZON FIRE STARTED BY HUMANS • NEW POLL PUTS TRUMP APPROVAL RATING AT...) while I spend an hour on airplane mode, insulated from the chaos on my phone.

AIRPLANE MODE

Mom: Woohoo best game Tigers could win—against Houston!!!!

Verlander's Former Teammate: Fenech-Verlander beef is exactly what I needed in my life.

Unknown (313) Number: Any comment on the locker-room incident?

Gator: He's not talking about you is he? Lol

Drug Dealer: Lmk if anyone tries to mess with you.

No Clue: verlander beefin with you? whats up man?

Radio Host: Hey bro, long time ... any chance you can come on about the Verlander thing?

National Guy: Anthony, don't let the creeps get you down. Astros PR? Worst PR guy in my experience, which probably covers 100-plus PR guys

Pedro: This is such a scary moment. It allows every club to say they can keep whoever they want out of their clubhouse. This is why this is an important matter. You're not wrong here. Remember that.

MLB PR: Hi Anthony, I just tried calling you. Here is a statement that we wanted you to have first. We have gotten some other requests from reporters and we will send this to them as well. But we wanted you to have it first.

BBWAA President: Anthony, I'm sorry for missing your calls. My phone was charging downstairs overnight and I didn't hear it ringing.

Another Former Teammate: Yooo what's Verlander's deal?

Ex-Girlfriend's Roommate: Thought the reporters weren't supposed to be the news? Wasn't expecting to see you the topic of the little red ribbon at the top of the Freep.

High School Classmate: Why is Justin Verlander trashing u on Twitter hahah?

Deep Throat: I'd say you're the most popular sports writer in America today.

Rob Parker: Anthony, that was so lame by Verlander. Hope ur OK. U wanna come on my radio show for a few minutes tonight?

National TV Reporter: Crazy you're on his mind so much. You should be flattered.

Copy Editor: Did you ask about the eclipse again?

Top Scout: Just read your name in ESPN. That's great. Getting your name out there!

Mom: Omg. Call when you can.

2:44 P.M.—The barrage of messages continues when I return to reality.

Dylan Hernández: “Guessing everyone’s been bothering you today, but out of curiosity, why is Verlander so pissed at you?... Are you going back at him today? I think that’s what you have to think about.”

Hernández, a *Los Angeles Times* columnist (former Dodgers beat writer), is a like-minded hellraiser—perhaps the inspiration I need.

“Was in airplane mode. As of right now, no. I would LOVE to write about it, though.”

3:17 P.M.—Taking the hotel shuttle bus to the stadium, reading the Astros statement: “Reporter Anthony Fenech was delayed temporarily from entering the Astros clubhouse following last night’s game. This course of action was taken after taking into consideration the past history between Fenech and one of our players, Justin Verlander, Verlander’s legitimate concerns about past interactions with Fenech, and the best interests of the other media members working the game. We chose to prioritize these factors when making this decision. Fenech was allowed access to the clubhouse shortly after other media members and had the opportunity to approach Verlander or any player he needed. We believe that our course of action in this isolated case was appropriate.”

“Keep copious notes in this entire chapter of your life,” Pedro says. “Everything. Who’s contacted you. What they’ve said. Who you’ve contacted... Down the road, you never know.”

3:46 P.M.—No security guard triple-team today. The Bad Boy of Ball Writing is back. My every move is watched inside the Astros’ clubhouse. *Of course*, I needed to off my phone. Nothing good to see there at the moment: *Y’all are nothing but leeches... You are a true dipshit... Fenech is garbage. Good for JV.*

I stand in the middle of the clubhouse like nothing’s wrong. Head up, eyes forward, no phone.

Old Pal isn’t here. During a quiet moment, I hear PR flaks chat outside the clubhouse.

“He’s in there alone. I wouldn’t leave him in the clubhouse by himself.”

I don’t take it personally. It’s not why I’m here. Access is why I’m standing inside the Astros clubhouse again today. Access is the reason the Baseball Writers’ Association of America was founded during the 1908 World Series, when the Ball Writers had finally had enough.

According to baseball historian John Thorn, the BBWAA was born when writers “continued to suffer mistreatment during the Cubs-Tigers World Series that followed. The writers covering the Series were outraged at the treatment accorded them. In Chicago, out-of-town writers were placed in the back row of the grandstand. In Detroit, the writers were compelled to climb a ladder to the roof of the first base pavilion, where they were forced to write in the rain and snow that hampered the Series. Finally, unwilling to endure these conditions another year, the writers decided to organize.”

On the day of decisive Game 5, *Free Press* sports editor Joe S. Jackson rounded up the earliest traveling writers at Detroit's Hotel Pontchartrain, where 24 white men from big league cities east of the Mississippi became founding fathers of the BBWAA.

A constitution was established, an agreement of decency formed with the league, and writers were never again banished to stadium rooftops—or, at least in theory, banned from locker rooms.

I return 111 years later to enemy territory in the name of Jackson, my *Freep* forefather who once covered notoriously nasty Tigers outfielder Ty Cobb, a Hall of Fame player who slid with his metal spikes up. Jackson nicknamed Cobb the “Georgia Peach” in a *Free Press* column. He paved the path to where I stand in the Astros clubhouse today.

3:49 P.M.—I take notes on everything and nothing at all. Mostly, the scene:

Not many players in the clubhouse. Most are holding iPhones and iPads. Three guys playing Fortnite online—veteran outfielders Michael Brantley, George Springer and pitcher Wade Miley. Reporters talk to a rookie outfielder.

Jose Altuve looks knowingly across the room. The Astros' superstar second baseman sits at his locker, speaking in Spanish to a teammate who turns around to look at me.

3:53 P.M.—David Barron introduces himself from the *Houston Chronicle*. Says he's working on a story about the flap with Old Pal and asks, “Do you have anything to say about it?... Or is the paper speaking for you?”

I have a lot to say about it, believe me. But I defer.

4:09 P.M.—Back in the friendly confines of the Detroit clubhouse, the visitors are still buzzing after last night's win. Nineties R&B slaps from a slim boombox as I arrive in Gardy's office pregame. Kci & JoJo, I think it was.

“They let you in here?”

“What can I say to piss you off? I've pissed everyone else off.”

“I never said you haven't pissed me off.”

From a Ball Writer's perspective, the tragedy about this whole episode is not the viral attention it's garnered—it's that the terrible 2019 Tigers won the biggest game of their season last night. There haven't been many wins (38), there won't be many more (9), and last night was the best of 'em.

And here I am, gobbling up the headlines for feuding with a player on the *losing* team. I'm supposed to ask for comment, but I'm being asked for comment. I cover the Tigers, but I went to the Astros clubhouse after the game yesterday—and again today.

4:28 P.M.—Standing in the Detroit clubhouse, I'm alerted. “Call me please.”

They want me to provide a statement. We don't consult on what to say. I call a friend who knows a friend in PR crisis management, who advises strongly against the first ditty I scribbled down.

“Why not?” I snap. “He can dunk on me, but I can’t dunk back?”

My statement: “I’m extremely disappointed with the Astros’ inexplicable decision to limit my BBWAA-credentialed clubhouse access. In my time as the Tigers beat writer, my foremost goal has been fair and ethical coverage. I am confident that goal has been clearly and consistently achieved in my body of work and with the personal and professional way I build relationships across baseball.”

7:28 P.M.—*Chronicle* reporter David Barron sits in the front row as tonight’s game begins—I don’t know Barron beyond earlier, but he did strike me as a reporter who knows what to do with background information. Purely on that hunch, I walk down to his workspace and lean into his ear: “I know I can’t talk about this, but you can put on background if you want that I was in the Astros’ clubhouse. I’m just letting you know.”

His story tomorrow includes this graf: “Verlander was not available in the Astros’ clubhouse during the 50-minute period that it was open to reporters. Fenech was present in the mostly unpopulated clubhouse for at least 20 minutes.”

12:08 A.M.—Stepping onto the hotel elevator exhausted, I press for the wrong floor twice. It feels good to be home—even if it’s a hotel room.

Kristie Ackert: “Text me tonight just to let me know you are ok. We are concerned.”

“I’m down, I’m tired, I’m done with today. But I’m ok.”

As I slowly pack for tomorrow’s early flight, my good name bakes to a crisp in the spotlight. My grandparents came to this country on a boat and started from nothing so I could one day write about baseball... for what, now?

My phone flashes occasionally, like a thunderstorm passing through. One message is from a local TV reporter— “I will read your book one day.”

SportsCenter plays in the background. World champion fighter Conor McGregor appears to be screaming during an interview. The TV is muted.

My name scrolls by on ESPN’s BottomLine: *Verlander calls Detroit Free Press reporter ‘unethical’—Reporter kept from Astros clubhouse after Wednesday’s game.*

I watch it over and over, like I’m in a trance. Like I’m hypnotizing myself into accepting my new name. Is that who I am now? An Unethical Reporter?

Scrolling through a looney bin of emails, I see a note from the same *Freep* editor who reached out years ago when Internet Stalker tried canceling my career before it began.

“Yesterday and today may not go down as your favorites but they’ll make you an even better reporter than you are. Stay strong. You have fans rooting for you from the newsroom.”

August 23—Arriving at the Houston airport, I have 152 unread messages.

Scanning through while snacking on a breakfast bagel at the gate, I can't help but notice who *didn't* reach out. Al Avila must've sent a front office edict after the Trade Deadline Exposé—no talking to Fenech... or else.

Many of the unread messages asked: What did you do to Verlander? Why does he hate you so much? What's the beef?

In retrospect, our relationship was probably doomed from the start—by no fault of our own. I've mentioned that Justin was my favorite player growing up. I think subconsciously that was hard to shake—maybe I tried too hard to make him the person I wanted him to be. The guy I thought he was as a fan—a down-to-earth dude you could grab a burger and beer and chill with.

Justin is not that guy. Maybe he used to be. Now, he's a famous professional athlete, an alpha dog and the most sensitive kid in class. His critical flaw is ego—same as mine.

I knew I was getting under his skin to the point of no return. I knew something like this was possible—"putting myself in a situation that will almost assuredly result in Verlander ignoring my questions or taking the opportunity to publicly bully me."

In covering my favorite player, I've gotten to know him in a way I wish I never had.

When Mom picks me up from the airport, she brings Fuzzles, our family's geriatric cat. Fuzzles is 19 years old—she's staying for the weekend as my emotional support animal. In more peaceful times, Old Pal wished Fuzzles a happy birthday.

It's good to smell home. I throw a load in the laundry and hopscotch around town running errands. Dropping off clothes at the cleaners, I get an unknown call. Miami area code.

I haven't answered an unknown call for years—some people out there pay others to prank me—and I don't know what compelled me to answer this time.

"Hello, is this Anthony?"

A pit forms in my stomach. "It is."

"Hi, this is Allyson with the Dan Le Batard Show... Dan's talking about the thing with Verlander yesterday and he wants to see if you can come on the show for a few minutes."

ABORT MISSION ABORT MISSION ABORT MISSION

"I'm actually kind of in the middle of something right now. Can we do this later?"

"He's wrapping on it soon. Can you do it i—"

ABORT ABORT ABORT

I hang up on poor Allyson. Nothing against her or Dan, but we're going to need to see some proper ID. Secondly, I don't think I'm in the right frame of mind to talk about this for the first time publicly on the Le Batard Show—driving

around town with my emotional support cat riding shotgun and dirty clothes in the back.

The phone rings again.

ABORT ABORT ABORT

Instead, I pick up again. Allyson again.

“Hi, Anthony. Do you have just a second? Dan wants to talk to you. We’re in a break, I’m gonna put him on the line.”

Le Batard is one of the best sports writers of his generation, and these days a media brand unto himself. He was born and bred at the *Miami Herald* and began his ascent as a talented, personable, pull-no-punches Ball Writer and columnist in the nineties.

But I don’t know if Allyson is real or if I’m being pranked again by Internet Stalker... next thing you know, someone who sounds like Dan jumps onto the phone.

“Hey Anthony, it’s Dan. So, we’re talking about this and what happened...”

He says we’re not on the air.

“Dan, you know how this goes. The guy didn’t like what I was writing about him and the questions I was asking him and he’s a prima donna and decided to take it out on me on Twitter.”

“OK, Anthony. Thanks... gotta go!” And that was that.

I can’t say for sure it was Le Batard. I can only pray another prank call doesn’t surface.

DETROIT, *August 24*—Forty-eight hours later, and the Verlander storm isn’t over.

There’s a story coming in tomorrow’s *Free Press*—a column, really, and not mine. Sports editor Chris Thomas is writing about the Astros’ gross malfeasance. I’ve been uneasy about it from the start.

Last night, I talked with colleague Evan Drellich, whose advice was let things lie. “Once the weekend hits, nobody will care.”

Put another way: Verlander could have knocked me upside the head with a baseball bat, and some folks would still blame me for standing in the clubhouse.

Thomas’s column—ASTROS, VERLANDER, AND FREE PRESS: HERE’S WHAT HAPPENED—will post on Freep.com tomorrow as a defense of my rights as a reporter.

The word ‘unethical’ attached to my name makes me sick. I wait on the couch for the column to appear online.

Finally, there it is: “When the Astros used three security officials to stand between Fenech and the clubhouse while Verlander spoke to reporters on Wednes-

day night,” Thomas writes, “it sent a message that the BBWAA is powerless against baseball’s biggest stars.”

The column lands in the pit of my stomach—1,466 words piling onto my only regret of the past week: that none were written by me.

In the past few days, I’ve been written about far and wide. By reporters who reached out and those who never bothered. *Barstool Sports* bloggers and NBC Sports reporters—even the rival *Detroit News*.

Maybe I should have followed Pedro Gomez’s advice. He suggested I write a first-person piece. I certainly had the standing—last year, I received national Top 10 beat reporting honors from the Associated Press Sports Editors, the highest honor for any sports reporter covering any team. Much of my contest entry included stories about Justin Verlander.

I would have loved to have written about Old Pal again, explaining in my own words what had happened and how this all came to be. But I wasn’t ready to write about it. Didn’t know how long it would take. I had no clue, in the moment, that it would take years.

Thankfully, I wasn’t scheduled to follow the team to Minnesota for the rest of the road trip. But in Ball Writing, as in life, the news always seems to find you.

Lunchtime, a fire breaks out—Twitter user @NotIanKinsler says prospect Willi Castro is being called up.

“Report that I had it first,” Not Ian Kinsler tweets.

Really not in the mood for getting scooped by a parody account. Half an hour later, I’m still hot. An hour after Not Ian Kinsler’s report, I’m left hanging. Again.

The Tigers tweet the news on their official Twitter feed.

The call-up stirs excitement from starved fans and sends me up the wall. Freshly wounded from the week, still stonewalled by team sources—and maybe a little hurt I hadn’t heard from some of ‘em—I lash out at the Highest Source In The Land.

“Another one you told PR to announce so I couldn’t break it.”

I’m confused and grasping for straws. Three weeks after putting Avila’s decision-making in the crosshairs, this Sunday’s sports front is dedicated to mine. I hurl the remote into the cushion, only serves to inflame me—I want to break something. I’m an unethically stained Ball Writer with no sources, now giving credit to parody accounts: “@NotIanKinsler was first to report the Castro promotion.”

Embarrassed and angry, even after cooling off, I message HSITL: “Hey, taking a step back. Been a long week for me personally and professionally. I understand our relationship has changed and I am not going to scorch Earth every time you don’t help me.”

I consider reaching out to my new competitor for advice: I’d like to become Not Anthony Fenech. Any ideas?

TWO YEARS EARLIER

Tuesday, December 19, 2017—Woke up to a flurry of alerts. I'm in the tabloids again.

"You see he did another fine piece, lol," a friend says. "Guy is obsessed with you."

Last Friday, the *Free Press* announced they had fired a Pulitzer Prize-winning columnist and editorial page figurehead after an internal investigation found examples of "inappropriate behavior toward female colleagues stretching back several years."

Today, I've been lumped into the mess.

"Why is a well-respected, award-winning journalist like (redacted) out at the *Freep* while Anthony Fenech is still gainfully employed as the paper's Tigers beat writer? Fenech allegedly was involved in a workplace affair with (another employee) when she was at the *Free Press*."

By the time I get out of bed, sports content coach Chris Thomas is calling. He doesn't say hello or even why he's calling at half past nine on a weekday. He immediately asks about a former employee, identifying her by name. Taken aback, I indicate that I don't hear what he said. "What?" Thomas asks again. I say I'm not comfortable speaking about this. He asks if I could come in and meet with executive editor Peter Bhatia, who asks what my relationship was like with (former employee). I say that we became close friends and could not remember. No union rep was present.

A co-worker tells me to contact HR and I can't stop thinking: If they can ask me that, what *can't* they ask me?

August 29, 2019—So there was that. I did nothing. And today, after 12 years in journalism, I have been asked to write a feature story about a PR person. Not a player or coach or fan—a PR person.

My boss emails about a story on Ron Colangelo and his connection to Arizona State football coach Herm Edwards, whose Sun Devils play Michigan State next month.

“Hey, man: Edwards is really close with Colangelo. Might be good to ‘featurize’ it heading into the game.”

I mention it to Ron in passing at the salad bar. He rolls his eyes. “Please don’t.”

The request is ridiculous at best, the timing curious at worst—just last month, I started digging into a story about a couple of business-side executives who were let go. Ticket guys with plenty of tenure.

I’ve spoken with four or five sources. One female employee started crying during our call.

I don’t know if the email is a suggestion, an assignment, or how to respond.

September 11—Driving through drizzle into work, endless dark skies forecast a long night ahead. The radar doesn’t look much better.

But with the Yankees in town and only 12 home dates left, the Tigers will allow time for the weather to turn. This season, baseball attendance has continued its downward trend, dipping for a fourth consecutive year as games skew longer and less action-oriented for an audience whose attention span shrinks by the second. In Detroit, long gone is the heyday of \$200 million payrolls and topping three million fans annually—crowds have dropped on average 19 percent from last season and 40 percent since the team’s last winning season in 2016.

The rebuild is taking a toll on the ticket office, where a mass exodus of sales staff is underway: According to records I’ve patched together with business-side sources, 38 ticket employees have left since 2017 and nearly 70 percent of the 41-person staff will depart this year. I’ve been keeping track since July, when a pair of longtime business-side executives curiously departed.

Last month, I talked with a ticket-department employee who cried describing the work environment—alleging a sexist culture and employee mistreatment under recently installed upper management. She passed along a number to speak with a former employee.

When I called, the former employee said, sorry, but she just got a new job and doesn’t want to talk about that. A few minutes later, she called back.

“Hey. I just wanted to call and let you know that... You know if you write this story, you’re not going to have a job, right?”

September 13—The city is abuzz: Meaningful baseball has returned to Comerica Park.

Once an annual postseason tune-up month for the perennial-contending Tigers, recent Septembers have been more taxi squad tryout camp than pennant race. It's easy to forget that just five years ago, Detroit won its fourth straight American League Central title.

Then Anthony Fenech took over the beat, and everything went to hell. The Tigers have gone 331-460 since, finishing in last place three out of five years.

Alas! The buzz, festivities, meaningful baseball—yes.

Tonight marks the start of the World Series Of Misery, pitting two familiar contenders: Orioles (48-99) vs. Tigers (43-103). At stake: The first overall pick in next year's draft. Your host: The most miserable Ball Writer of them all—*Mr. Unethical!*

Entering the long weekend set, Detroit is 4½ games ahead for the worst record in baseball. The O's are at a similar rebuilding point, having finished last in the American League East three years running. The series opener is for the record books: The matchup features the most combined losses (202) of any matchup in American League history.

It figures to be a busy night at the ballpark. Today is Picture Day and Friday Night Fireworks *and* we've got special guests: the Michigan Baseball Team 153 Wolverines, who will be honored pregame.

After Tiger players pose for the 2019 class photo in center field, team chairman and CEO Christopher Ilitch takes questions from the media, which for months has been egged on by an impatient fanbase.

He isn't available often, but when he is, Tigers PR makes sure he's marinated with talking points.

Case in point: Ilitch begins today's presser with a PR-coached announcement of "clarity" on manager Ron Gardenhire's status for next season—but he doesn't confirm what exactly that clarity is. Ilitch says Avila is "on the same page," but won't say more.

Good for me, because Al and I have been talking again. I text him while waiting my turn to grill Ilitch on his job performance.

"Is Gardy coming back next year? Chris said you've addressed it, but I don't recall."

"He is coming back."

Inside Ron Gardenhire's office, a last look at the cozy access of our times: A veteran manager, 61, set to return for a third season after going 111-212 the first two years, stands up behind his desk. His office is filled with media.

Out of respect for his coaching staff—some of whom may not be returning next season—Gardy refrains from comment when asked for his reaction to Il-itch's comments, which seem to signal he'll be returning as manager in 2020.

"That's for a later time. We still have some weeks here to play. We're going to have meetings—let us have our meetings and go from there. We don't really talk about that stuff; we're just trying to finish the season."

Three reporters sit on the couch. TV play-by-play guy in one chair, radio play-by-play in another. Media and PR (three of 'em) stand around the office. I'm in the corner, zoning out on a pile of books, when a title catches my eye. *Ego Is The Enemy*.

Not long from now, I'll find this sentence in an old notebook, written when I was hanging out with Seamhead John Lowe back in the day: "Don't let your ego take over."

Mine probably has, for better and worse: Do you know how much confidence is required to work a big-league clubhouse of millionaire Adonises, some of whom make more money in tonight's game than you made last year? The Teflon shield you must burn into your psyche to endure loss after loss, battling National Guys, Rival Cohorts, Old Pals and Internet Stalkers?

The unnatural machismo you must at times exude, trying to survive in a testosterone-charged room of pro athletes as a punk reporter for the Podunk Press. Some of these guys, you grew up rooting for. Many, you have little in common with. All of 'em, you'd probably trade spots with—who among us grew up dreaming of being the Ball Writer?

The scene is a final vestige of access this generation, a color picture in gray times. In the years to come, this kind of close-quarters access will become extinct. Gardenhire today talks to a room of reporters at arms-length for more than 15 minutes. Reporters in the future will be lucky to get the manager in the dugout—with marketing dollars at stake, teams will soon put their managers on stage, answering questions in front of corporate-sponsored backdrops.

September 20—The final home stand of the season gets off to a fitting start.

A substitute TV reporter opens with an amateur hour question for Gardy:

"Coach, last homestand... any message to the fans?"

"Well, yeah... that's a good start."

Gardy must've actually read *Ego Is The Enemy*, which has been on his shelf for the past two years. I've seen managers flip their lid for being called "coach." It takes much more to fluster a manager who's lost 108 games this season—and counting.

"It's been one of those seasons where hopefully, you've seen our young kids develop and you know what, thanks for hanging in there with us. It's been tough

for everybody—the coaching staff, everybody—and we really appreciate your support. So, thanks for hanging with this ballclub.”

The Tigers open the week against the White Sox and division-leading Twins, facing an embarrassing mark of futility—they must win one of their final six home games to avoid becoming the first team in modern baseball history to lose 60 home games in a season.

Before the opener, I catch up with James McCann, who signed in Chicago last year. His twin boys are in town.

“They’re getting big.”

I wrote a feature story on the twins, born two months’ premature last spring. In five seasons with Detroit, I built a good relationship with McCann, whose first year as starting catcher coincided with my first on the beat.

After the Tigers declined to tender him a contract in the winter, McCann is mashing with the White Sox. He was a first-time All-Star this season, currently hitting .274 with 17 home runs and 57 RBIs. He mentions the mixed feelings seeing his former squad struggling like this: “As far as from a player’s standpoint, you want competitive teams on the field—and take this organization out of it, there’s multiple teams facing 100-loss seasons. I think that from a player’s standpoint we want the most competitive teams on the field day in and day out.

“Being part of teams that are rebuilding, it’s tough. It’s a different feeling coming into a September ballgame with the playoffs on the line.”

McCann singles in the top of the second inning, upping his average to .375 in 40 at-bats against his former team. The Tigers are throttled, 10-1. Two days later, they snap a five-game losing streak, narrowly avoiding the record for most home losses.

September 25—Normal day at the ballpark.

Tigers lose their 111th game of the season to the Twins, who wait an hour and 18 minutes for Cleveland to lose in Chicago before popping champagne in the visitor’s clubhouse—Minnesota is the American League Central champion.

Across the hallway, the home team cleared out long ago. There was no similar celebration after clinching the worst record in baseball—even if it results in the top draft pick, widely projected to be Spencer Torkelson, a slugging sophomore who broke Barry Bonds’ freshman home run record at Arizona State.

Postgame, I split from the clubhouse pack for a quick catch-up with Miguel Cabrera. His 17th season has shown that even with age, an impressive ability remains. At 36, Cabrera is hitting .282 with 10 home runs and an on-base percentage of .358. He will play a team-high 134 games (108 as designated hitter) despite dealing with a lingering right knee issue and assorted other ailments for most of the year.

Miggy will never swing as mighty: He'll hit .255 with 34 home runs, 187 RBI and a .363 slugging percentage the next four seasons, aging into his late thirties about as gracefully as one could have hoped in 2014, when former team owner Mike Ilitch made Cabrera a Tiger for life, signing him to a 10-year contract extension for \$292 million—then the largest deal in baseball history. Miggy made \$54,347 per plate appearance this year.

I approach his locker while he slips on sneakers. Jeans are on. No shirt, but gold chains.

"My editor wants me to do a story on you. Can I talk to you this weekend for—" Miggy cuts me off with the same wildly inappropriate question he asked me in Anaheim three years ago.

This time, it doesn't stop the conversation cold. I'm shocked he hasn't grown up—our relationship has—but I've seen this absurdity before.

Immediately and matter-of-factly, I say, "No."

He drops the charade. "We'll see. I don't know."

CHICAGO, *September 27*—In my worst nightmare, I wake up in a chilly hotel room in the South Loop and stare outside. Clouds cover the lake. It is rainy, windy and gray. Take a taxi to the ugliest baseball stadium ever built. In this nightmare, I am stuck in traffic and heading to U.S. Cellular Field to cover not one game between the Tigers (46-112) and White Sox, but two. A doubleheader.

This is not surprising. It's always raining in Chicago and in my head. It was raining when Andrew's Navigator picked me up from O'Hare yesterday evening, while walking to the party store for a Red Bull this morning, and now arriving at my personal house of horrors.

"At least once a year here, I wonder, 'Why am I even going to the park?'"

"An appropriate place to end the year," a colleague responds. "Brings things full circle."

It is only then, while watching touristy ads scroll by on a seatback monitor, when I consider for the first time that this weekend could be my last on the beat.

My memories here are not all bad.

While U.S. Cellular Field is far and away the worst on the big-league circuit, it also holds a sliver of fondness in my heart. It was in the press box where I first met Deep Throat in the flesh, while waiting in line for coffee during the final series of my rookie year.

"I think I know you."

Visiting team officials usually sit in a neighboring suite and often walk over to use the espresso machine—the only remotely redeeming quality about the entire place.

This chance interaction came years before I agreed to the Three Commandments, before I even got Deep Throat's number. We'd only traded emails, but he responded warmly that day.

"I've read plenty of your stuff. You do a good job."

This season, however, I'm not so sure. I've been on the fritz since the middle of May, I can't remember the last time I've attended morning clubhouse, my entire career is now encapsulated in an ugly eight-letter word, and yet here I stand, at the finish line of my fifth season. Still alive.

After a 52-minute delay, Hittin' Harold Castro opens the doubleheader with a single. Castro, a rookie utilityman from Caracas, Venezuela, is unabashedly my favorite player on the Tigers. In a strong first impression, Castro has shown professional bat-to-ball skills and solid defensive durability—playing 47 games at infield, 44 at outfield and seven positions in total. Two years after nearly being cut loose following a down year at Double-A, Castro has carved out a bench spot on next season's roster. Since May 1 in Philadelphia, when Castro arrived at the stadium for his call-up in the fourth inning and slapped a first-pitch single in the ninth, all he's done is make contact.

"You gotta be ready for it."

Many young Latin players have come through Detroit in recent years. But few have hung with Cabrera the way Hittin' Harold has this year—and Miggy only hangs with guys who hit. Young sports writers: Pay attention to who hangs out with who in the locker room.

After Castro's single, Cabrera drives him in with a blooper. He is all smiles at first base.

Cabrera was chatty earlier. With the team's Spanish-speaking translator nearby, Miggy gave a season-ending address—talking in English about the Tigers' losing season ("Frustrating"), his health ("Surgery is off the table"), and how he viewed his individual performance in 2019. "Really, my goal this year was to finish the season. I wasn't paying attention to numbers, I was more paying attention to at-bats, getting ready and not being hurt."

Game 1 pauses at 5:39 P.M. when the tarp monster returns during a downpour. An hour later, everyone is told to go home—both games postponed, another doubleheader tomorrow.

I don't wake up. In this nightmare, I'm left at U.S. Cellular Field waiting 40 minutes for my ride. Andrew apologizes for the delay when he arrives—he needed to take All-Star slugger José Abreu home first.

September 29—The regular season finale feels like Christmas morning. I can't fall back asleep.

My first call goes to Deep Throat.

“Big day.”

“We did it.”

That’s one way to put it. Feeling dangerous, I answer some questions on Twitter while commuting to work. Someone asks if I can finally take some time off. “No. The baseball news cycle has long since become year-round.” Another person asks for my favorite moment of the season.

“John Hicks catching the first pitch from his mom.”

I’ll highlight the moment in my annual season-ending memories column: “Hicks caught the first pitch from his mother, Karen, with tears in his eyes on ‘Pink Out the Park’ night. Karen has battled breast cancer throughout Hicks’ career and fought tears herself before delivering a strong throw. Hands-down the best moment of the season.”

Instead of tweeting out the starting lineup like I have for the first 160 games of the season, I make an exception for the finale:

Game 161: Finally.

Reporters pack into the visiting manager’s office—which, like most amenities here, are among the worst in the big leagues.

Ron Gardenhire begins his final pregame media session of the year.

“Fitting. Chance of rain.”

Gardenhire’s 16th season in the dugout was a struggle, to say the least. Standing closest to Gardenhire, he speaks for the both of us.

Reporter: *Ron, what’s held this group together despite everything from the outside?*

“Vodka.”

Reporter: *What will you do in the offseason to get recharged for next year?*

“It’s easy. You go home. I’m gonna relax with my daughters... drink. Then drive down to Oklahoma and see my grandbabies and my daughter. And drink a little more. And then I’m going to fly to Fort Myers. That’s where I’ll relax a little bit.”

Me: *Will you drink in Florida?*

“Water... A lot of water. It’s hot down there. I sound like I drink all the time, but not really. I normally wait until after 10 in the morning.”

Today’s *Freep Sports* cover boy goes deep. Miggy’s homer comes despite playing on a bad knee that’s moved him off first base. For the 114th and final time, Tigers lose.

Rookie Travis Demeritte strikes out to end the season—fittingly, it’s a team record.

Sitting in the final class of the year waiting for the bell, Rival Cohort is still taking notes.

As the rest think about what’s next—smoking a cigarette, drinking afterwards, possibly quitting our jobs—veteran sports writer Chris McCosky covers his bases. As he always does.

McCosky has been at the *Detroit News* since 1994 and is believed to be the only sports writer in Detroit's rich history to cover all four professional beats.

He asks Gardy why Víctor Reyes was pulled after a bunt hit in the sixth inning.

Gardenhire explains he wanted to preserve Reyes' .304 average—the traditional mark of a successful season.

The outfielder also made a lifelong fan this season in Broxbourne, England, of all places—where last month a die-hard fan got off work, cracked open a pale ale lager and, perhaps as a symptom of watching too much Tiger baseball this year, tweeted, “If the Tigers take a single game off the Astros this series, I will get a Víctor Reyes tattoo.”

Reyes started the series with a bunt hit, smacked his first home run the next night and Detroit beat Houston on the last normal day of my adult life. He hit .331 with 3 homers and 12 extra-base hits in 37 games following Jed's tweet. True to his word, the mad Englishman received a tattoo on his left calf this month with the player's name and uniform number (22).

He tweeted the next day: “I am hungover. Hope you're happy.”

Hangover—the best word for this season. A six-month hangover that you couldn't shake.

I am all but emotionless entering the dressing room for this season's final reporting scene. A roster of relative no-names bid farewell. Many won't be back, instead recycled elsewhere during another rebuilding winter. Some of the guys I don't even know.

Five years after adrenaline-rushing this same clubhouse, asking veteran players for phone numbers as the final task of my rookie year—players who I'd worked hard to build trust with... I barely know the nameplates now.

Without a contact list of players or agents to get (I haven't updated ScoopSheet in months), I don't stay for long. I say goodbye to the usual suspects—veterans, coaches, trainers, Miggy and the team translator.

Walking out of the clubhouse, I wonder if I'll be back—or if I want to be.

DETROIT, *October 4*—After spending the past month in an emotional spin cycle, I'm holed up with enough supply to fend off even the most intrusive self-loathing thoughts.

I won't sleep for days, burrowing into cardboard boxes, notebooks and old tape recorders. Receipts rubber-banded and piled by month and year. Receipts everywhere. Hundreds, maybe a thousand. Organized by time and date, work and personal. Finding much more than items and purchases—it's like my Ball Writing life is unfolding in front of my eyes.

The deeper into the memories, the less pain I feel, the more I want to keep going. Exhilarating and out-of-control, but onto something.

Message Mom on bingo night, asking if she can stop by after. She brings food, which is good, because I haven't eaten in quite some time.

"Don't freak out. I'm in a good place now, the best place in months."

But I can't fool Mom. She can see I haven't been eating or sleeping. I explain what the drugs are, what they do, why I started taking them (work) and why I think I'm taking more than ever (coping mechanism/addiction).

She's horrified. Asks me why. Am I trying to hurt myself? I don't really know—but no, I don't think so. It's emotional. We yell and scream and cry and get into cold, hard truths. How things have really spiraled after the incident with Old Pal.

I take off my shirt. "*Look* at me—I've lost like 30 pounds since Opening Day!"

Telling all to Mom feels like a weight lifted. I grab a handful of pills from the bottle but give her the rest. I make a promise to Mom before she leaves. A promise I won't break.

My next steps are clear. I book a flight to Malta and scribble more words about the book that's quickly coming into focus.

The working title is *OFF-THE-RECORD*.

Fell into a comfortable routine—gym, beach, receipts. Hogged the copy machine at a corner store across from a religious dome spared during World War II, when a bomb dropped but never detonated as people sheltered inside. Gym, beach, receipts. Bought a used Kindle for €10, case included. The Astros were at it again. While celebrating their win over the Yankees, a front office flak allegedly berated a female Ball Writer in the clubhouse for her public disapproval of the team trading for Roberto Osuna, a former All-Star reliever who served a 75-game suspension last year for violating MLB's domestic violence policy. A Sports Illustrated reporter wrote about the flak's diatribe, Astros PR called the reporter a liar and the next day the Astros had to apologize. Sat one night at a noisy club with an American day-trader who picked up a parakeet fetish while living in Thailand when I got a text that Old Pal coughed up the lead in the World Series. Went to the sports bar to watch Game 7, rooted for the Nationals to win, and they did. I left around 5 A.M. and the cabbie talked the whole way home, an Indian man with friends in America who are working whenever he calls. "America, it's a work country. Here, if you work 10-15 hours, you can live still. In America, if you don't work 40 hours, you can't live." He makes €1,500 per month and can still pay his rent, eat a little bit and maybe save one or two-hundred Euros. Bought a notebook from the bazaar and kept a journal. Ten pages, twenty pages, inside a teal green notebook until my hand cramped. Talked to people who don't watch baseball, don't care. They don't have dryers in Malta. No central A/C or heat and snails come out when it rains. Two years ago, corrupt government influences killed the country's top investigative reporter—the mob laced her engine with a bomb and let the ignition do the rest. Went to church every week, washed my face with holy water. One day it rained and I saw my name online. It rained all day, when I walked through the village without an umbrella and went out of my way to step on every snail I could find. I stayed 35 days, including my birthday, drinking alone on the promenade, watching happy people, wondering where my twenties went and how I can get them back.

BOTTOM NINE

LONDON, *November 14*—After more than a month away, I'm heading home when an email arrives: LAYOFFS LOOMING

The *Free Press* needs to cut three reporters and a photographer. Seven years of seniority should put me in the clear. A good thing?

I've never felt more insecure about my career.

DETROIT, *November 22*—I pull myself together and decide to meet with *Free Press* brass before the winter begins. I'm going to go on the offensive.

"Haven't gotten a raise in five years and none are coming," I tell a friend. "I need to keep developing and growing and it's not happening. What am I working toward here? I want to know what I need to do to be a columnist, how close I am."

I email my editors: "I had time to think while I was on my trip, and I'd like to share those thoughts with you guys in order to best position ourselves for success going forward."

We set a meeting for Monday morning.

November 25—Heading into the newsroom, I cover my bases with sources before beeping into the building.

To Al Avila: "Are you going to make any news in the next two hours? Heading into a meeting with my bosses, don't want to be caught off-guard."

When I get to the *Freep*, I meet Thomas at his workstation. We walk into Peter Bhatia's office together; Thomas takes one side of the small round table; I take the other. Bhatia sits behind his desk.

Written in my reporter's notebook are an outline of ideas, a list of grievances, other talking points. I'll never get to any of them. I won't even flip the notebook open or take my pen out.

“Well, Anthony, as you know, we’ve had some ups-and-downs over the last couple of years, and you’ve had to endure the abuse from Verlander and the Astros, as well... I know you had some issues with the way we handled that, but our intent in all of that was to back you, 100 percent...”

“But where we’re at right now, I think it’s the right time to make a change with the beat.”

Bhatia says pro basketball writer Vince Ellis is taking a buyout, and I’ve got a choice to make: I can cover the Detroit Pistons and NBA basketball or—as Bhatia urges—volunteer to take the last remaining buyout offer on the table.

“Seriously?”

Trying not to raise my voice: “Did you *read* some of the stuff I wrote last year?... And I got an APSE award the year before that.”

I’m angry now. Very angry.

“Like, I own the beat... it’s not even close.”

Coach Content chimes in: “Awards aren’t the only thing that matters.”

“What does matter then? Web hits?”

He laughs. “You think that’s all I’m about is web hits.”

“Yeah, I do.”

Snapping at each other, our frosty relationship is on full display. The short back-and-forth leaves our personality conflict bare. In one breath, Chris calls me “the best sourced reporter in the city.” In the next, he says that I can’t adapt to covering a beat.

This is about as much talking as we’ll do. I ask Bhatia, “Do you know how this is going to look for me professionally?”

With years of breaking the cold-blooded truth to people, he plays it cool.

“I understand you may not agree with our decision... but that’s what we’re going with.”

He says Ellis took the buyout over the weekend, giving them flexibility to make the move. Now, it’s my decision: Slide into Ellis’ spot covering the Detroit Pistons and NBA or take the final buyout remaining. If there aren’t enough volunteers, then one photographer or web editor will be laid off based on seniority.

I’ve got seven years under my belt, so I’m safe. Bhatia can’t force me to take the buyout. But his message about my future at the *Detroit Free Press* is clear.

I stand up and numbly shake hands all around. My face is flushing as I stumble out of the newsroom, feeling like I’ve been hit with a flash-bang grenade.

Hours later, still reeling from the meeting, I receive a phone call from Willie Horton—one of the organization’s legendary figures. Earlier this off-season, he called, suggesting we meet sometime soon.

His timing prompts me to wonder: Has he somehow heard about today’s meeting?

He doesn't mention it. Neither do I. He invites me over to his house tomorrow and I accept eagerly. We hang out in his basement museum—signed baseballs, photographs, plaques, a wood-carved figurine of Tiger Stadium.

After nearly two hours, he passes over a folder of hitting strategies and an email report he sent directly to the Highest Source In The Land. Before I go, I'm introduced to one of his daughters.

I message my closest work confidante: "On the day they told me they didn't want me covering the Tigers anymore, I broke a trade and received a call from Willie Horton, inviting me to his house."

SAN DIEGO, *December 8*—The Winter Meetings again. Perhaps, for me, the final one—a scary thought I cannot shake. It is raining as I arrive at the Manchester Grand Hyatt Resort.

I can still see my first day ever at the Ball Writing carnival. I remember pulling out my wallet to make sure I had at least five business cards packed into the outside flap.

Today, I have none. I don't even have a back pocket. I'm wearing sweats. Waiting for the elevator, I run into an Arizona reporter. When we return from lunch, Kristie Ackert is at the sports bar. Dylan Hernández is here somewhere. The whole gang.

There's no Tigers-oriented celebration this year. Second baseman Lou Whitaker is not elected to the Hall of Fame by the veterans' committee, as double-play partner Alan Trammell was last year. Sweet Lou was selected on 6 of 16 ballots, falling short of the 12 required for election. I didn't even bother to pre-write a story—Whitaker's been getting screwed for years.

I'm here as a lame duck, a hawk whose wings have been clipped. Only a select few know how my career hangs by a thread, but everyone knows who I am—the unethical guy who Justin Verlander doesn't like.

Five years ago, this was still a dream. I hadn't the earthliest clue of how to get scoops. A simpler time. Just happy to be here, closing the lobby bar each night, meeting new people all the time.

Tonight, I go to my room after dinner. Take a sleeping pill. In bed by 11.

December 9—The last thing I want to do is linger at the lobby bar for familiar faces. As expected, everybody asks about the Verlander thing. It's frustrating because it's not something I can explain in one standing conversation. Not something I particularly want to explain.

Reporting-wise, I'm in a tight spot. Aware of my impending assignment change, Al Avila and other officers have no incentive to help me. The last thing they want is the *Free Press* getting cold feet about re-assigning me. I've become an annoying, truth-telling pest.

Not only that, but Deep Throat isn't here this year. Vacationing somewhere tropical. Might not even be in the country, I can't remember.

"Are you still in the loop of things going down?"

"No."

I lay low in my room. When I see someone I know on the floor, my first instinct is to walk the other way. I haven't aggressively sought out info from sources.

Unlike five years ago, I know nearly all the agents, but I haven't reached out to many this offseason... can't remember the last time I opened ScoopSheet.

Jim Leyland still wanders around the winter meetings like he did back then, looking for restaurants the way teenagers look at mall directories—lost. Leyland is looking for lunch when we cross paths. He asks if I'm hungry. "Wanna join?"

We sit at a white-table Italian spot. First topic is Lou Whitaker's Hall of Fame candidacy. Leyland managed Whitaker in his first full season in the minor leagues in 1976 at Class A Lakeland. Whitaker was 19. Two years later, he'd win Rookie of the Year.

I ask Leyland if he thinks Whitaker is a Hall of Famer.

"I do... I do."

"Do you think he'll get in eventually?"

"I do... I do."

Leyland will eventually be canonized in Cooperstown himself. As with all managers and executives, Leyland was voted in by the veterans' committee and inducted in July 2024.

The waitress asks about Leyland's shiny ring—he's wearing his 2012 American League championship ring.

"I never wear any of them, but when I come to the meetings, sometimes people like to see 'em. So, I just picked this one."

He says he's won 12-to-14 rings between the minors and majors.

"You can have it if you want it."

"Really?!" she laughs.

More folks walk up.

Braves manager Brian Snitker is joined by Jonathan Schuerholz, the son of Hall of Fame executive John Schuerholz.

"He's a good manager," Leyland says of Snitker. "He paid his price."

Snitker's minor-league tour of duty makes Leyland's 11 years seem short—Snitker, 64, managed 20 minor-league seasons before debuting in the majors in 2016.

Over a quick snack, I ask Leyland about managing and the benefit of minor-league experience.

"It's like with anything... You've seen that movie before. When a situation comes up, you've seen it before."

He likes the younger crop of guys, but he laments his generation hasn't gotten more chances, too.

"I'd just rather see guys like myself get a chance from a selfish standpoint. Guys that have paid their dues."

Lunch is quick. I got a pasta starter and a glass of white wine. He got a sandwich, no wine. Despite pleas that the *Free Press* can afford it, Leyland picks up the tab. I don't know if he knows what's going on with me, or if we just happened to bump into each other in the right place at the right time.

Walking back to the hotel, we run into a couple of Tigers Guys and stop to say hello. Leyland points at me.

"He's ripping somebody today. You know that."

Leyland is prophetic. Turns out that The Highest Source In The Land is selling today—and I'm not buying.

Sounding like a robot programmed to parrot buzz-phrases, Al Avila talks about "building it up" at his first media session of the week inside the team's suite. Avila uses some variation of the phrase seven times in 37 minutes.

I comment to a colleague: "Five bucks says he was coached to say that."

"I have absolutely no doubt."

I write a column critical of the approach, calling out the Propaganda Police:

"The Tigers wanted Avila to deliver optimism—they sense fans' frustration reaching a boil. They know confidence is at an all-time low.

"Instead, he offered words he can't back up: The message of a team ready to turn the page, of having money to spend, inching ever closer, and excitement—a message that sounds like the start of the process. Back then, it was a 'retool,' not a 'rebuild.'

"It's more lip service than substance. They're good at delivering buzz phrases."

December 10—I work from my room today until the Tigers media availability at 4:30, when I decide to raise hell again.

Al Avila sits flanked by manager Ron Gardenhire and VP of player development Dave Littlefield. They drone on about analytics and the minor leagues before I jump in.

"Four years ago, I think it was in Nashville, you said you were going to come up with the 'Tiger Way' plan. Kind of like a uniform plan for players to play the game..."

"We have a manual. It started with Tram, and Sam (Menzin) is the one that put it together."

I've been poking around about this Tiger Way thing, and guys across the minors haven't even heard of it. I ask Al to describe it.

"Well, there's a lot to that, to just make a comment. And you can fill in the blanks a lot of different ways, but we want our players, obviously, to play the game the right way. Obviously, we want the hustle, we want the fundamentals, things of that nature. So, when you look at the Tiger Way, it's running the bases, defensive situations, knowing where to set up, where to hit the cut-off man, things of that nature. It's no different than the Dodger Way when I grew up. It showed you where you're supposed to be set up on almost every play defensively and how you're supposed to approach certain situations.

"So, it's a step-by-step manual for the player, but also the coaches as a guideline. That's the best way I can explain it."

Avila chuckles.

"It's not like a quote or a phrase or anything like that, you know? If that's what you're asking."

It's not. I ask: "Do you guys have the manual? Can I see it?"

"It's in the computer. No. It's ours."

"There are people in the organization that have not heard anything about this. I ask them, 'Hey, what's the status of the Tiger Way—has this been done?' They say they have no idea what this is. So, you're saying that it's in the computer. Any kind of proof this has been done would probably be helpful in disputing those claims, I guess."

"I'm not going to get into that if you're going that direction."

"But you are saying that it has been done?"

"Yeah. But as I told you, it's always a work in progress."

I connect with a minor-league manager after the media session.

"I asked Al to show me the Tiger Way tonight."

"And u probably got a confused look."

"Brutally awkward. Stumbling and bumbling about what it is, and then he says he won't show it to me."

The manager laughs. "Because it doesn't exist!"

Five years earlier, I proudly introduced myself to Ken Rosenthal in this lobby. Met Scott Boras here. Back then, I wanted my phone to flash 24/7/365 with "important people," influential dealmakers and the ilk.

Now, I just want Rosenthal to walk up to me like he did a couple years ago in K.C., coming over to say hello, shaking my hand in the clubhouse and complimenting me on the "heck of a story" I wrote the previous weekend about the Tigers' collapse.

I want to feel like Fenech again—not an unethical schmuck, uncomfortable in his own skin and shying away from folks like Rosenthal. Right now, we're on

opposite hotel escalators, and I keep my head down. I raise it long enough to catch a stray glance from baseball's No. 1 National Guy. No acknowledgment. Ken—like everybody else these days—looks at me like I'm a ghost.

December 11—Bright and early, the annual managers' buffet brunch.

American League skippers crowd into a ballroom, sip coffee with the local Ball Writers and take a class yearbook-style photo.

At our table, it's Ron Gardenhire, the Tiger Beat and Tiger PR (Ron Colangelo, media relations director Chad Crunk and another staffer). There's an empty seat between Gardenhire and me. He leans over and asks, "I thought you were moving to the Pistons?"

"Where did you hear that?"

"It's all over the Internet."

Gardy doesn't know not to joke with me like that—I have PTSD from being all over the Internet for five years. Furiously scrolling through Twitter, I can't find anything. I think he's pulling my leg—but clearly, Tiger Guys have been talking in the suite.

4:50 P.M.—PR sends an alert ten minutes before today's media session: "We are pushing Al's session back. Please be on standby."

I bug Deep Throat again during his vacation. He's been my safety net for years, but I'm wondering if he's turned on me, too. "Have you heard the length of Al's contract?" Deep Throat: "Will be happy to talk after vacation is done."

"You're a jerk."

Deep Throat: "You're a jerk. I told you on the phone I was headed out of the country and wasn't going to be any help. Quit bugging me with this shit."

A day after pressing Avila on the Tiger Way, I contemplate more wartime reporting.

Surveying more sources, I ask if it's fair game to ask about (and report on) the length of the contract extension Avila signed last summer.

Pedro Gomez says so: "If I'm a fan, that's something I'd like to know. Why the secret?"

I decide to let things lie for the night. I poke out a story in my room and head down to the Seaport Ballroom, where the Professional Baseball Scouts' Foundation banquet is being held. Kristie Ackert is there.

"Free drinks."

"Get me a glass of red."

It's waiting when I get there. Dinner program is under way. I sneak into an open seat at a front-row table. Kristie's boyfriend asks about the book. "Is it a bridge-burning book?"

Poking my head into the lobby bar after the scouts' banquet, I still can't escape the Astros and Old Pal. Industry scuttlebutt remains fixated on an unfolding cheating scandal involving Houston's 2017 World Series team—sign-stealing using cameras and trash can banging to tip off hitters.

The irony isn't lost on me: while I'm being called "unethical" by Justin Verlander, his team was cheating their way to a championship. Within weeks, MLB's investigation will cost three managers their jobs, including Houston's A.J. Hinch.

I swore I wouldn't stay in the lobby for more than one, but here I am, holding a third drink.

Later, I step out for a cigarette, and the bizarro worlds I've been living in this week collide. Al Avila strolls through the lobby with a drink. Odds are, it's not his first or second. We're in the same boat—except I've got smokes. So, we come together, again. As uneasy as I may feel these days in public, I'm always comfortable around Al. Even now. Even after grilling him in the team suite.

One night we decided that, if we crossed paths in the cosmos at the right time and place, we could have grown up best friends. Al even invoked divine intervention.

"This was His way of bringing us together."

December 12—Five years ago, I'd contact sources like a mad man, building my baseball spider web from brunch time until the lobby bar. Now, I can't get out of here soon enough.

Unfortunately, I can't escape until the Rule 5 draft is complete. Detroit selects pitcher Rony García from the Yankees, but before I can even research him, my phone explodes with Austin Romine signing news.

I spend the morning chasing contract details, texting agents, and trying to nail down figures—the usual winter meetings chaos, but without any enthusiasm.

At the airport, I spot Tigers legal counsel John Westhoff—the same guy I saw before my first winter meetings five years ago. When small talk turns to my impending assignment change, I fake a smile: "I'm actually looking forward to it."

Flight home, I write about the Romine signing. Two years ago, he caught for the Yankees, helping ignite a brawl with Miguel Cabrera. Now he's a Tiger. Baseball's funny like that.

4:02 P.M.—After filing my column, I'm slapped in the face. An email lists three open jobs—mine among them. Reading it makes me sick with embarrassment.

8:21 P.M.—Ron Colangelo texts a link about Pistons center Andre Drummond being a game-time decision due to an allergic reaction to an avocado.

“See what awaits you...”

I can’t decide if he’s being supportive or touchdown-dancing on my grave.

December 16—Deep Throat is officially back on American soil.

“Hi Anthony, thank you for letting me enjoy my trip. I got you something and that’s a heads-up the Lou (Whitaker) number retirement announcement will come as soon as tomorrow if you want a story prepared.”

Deep Throat’s heard chatter about “not saying anything to Fenech.” He keeps in touch. But after the Tigers iced me out at the winter meeting, he’s keeping in touch. As are others.

“How you doing?” a co-worker asks. “Hanging in there.”

“Let’s catch up tonight bro!” a local TV reporter says. “You doing okay? I’m at the fucking Pistons tonight.”

“Did you quit?” a former colleague asks. “Or you moving to Pistons. Sorry about the abrupt message. Just surprised to see a job posting.”

Me, too.

December 21—Deep Throat drops an early Christmas present down my chimney, tipping me off that the Tigers are signing first baseman C.J. Cron and second baseman Jonathan Schoop.

With the team on high alert, I can’t verify through the Tigers without exposing Deep Throat— one of my only sources left. I work the agents instead.

When I call Schoop’s agent, he puts me on hold and immediately leaks the news to National Guy Ken Rosenthal, who tweets it out while I’m waiting on hold. I’m not kidding. *While I’m on hold*. When he comes back on the line, he gives me the same information.

After getting beat by Rosenthal by two minutes, I manage to beat Jeff Passan by three on the Cron signing.

Not bad for a local guy who’s been told he can’t cover baseball anymore and was eating Rice Krispies Treats for breakfast.

December 23—Word that I’m not long for the beat reaches Internet Stalker, who does the honors. He breaks the news on a burner account named after his dog—the Twitter account he’d been using to harass me has been banned.

“Marlo the Mutt Scoop: The *Free Press* has an ad for a new Tigers beat writer. Fenech leaving. Most predictable thing ever.”

December 25—Merry Christmas!

I receive a text from a local media friend, wondering what's going on. He shares a bulletin from the Michigan State University sports journalism department, advertising my job: *The Detroit Free Press is looking for a Tigers beat reporter.*

"Everything ok with you?"

"Yeah, I'm not covering the Tigers anymore."

"Sheez. What's next. How can I help?"

"I'm going to be covering the Pistons."

"Good Lord."

"I know."

I'm still on the beat until the *Free Press* finds someone—Vince Ellis's last day isn't for a few weeks. Vince sends me the link for credentials to the NBA All-Star Game in Chicago.

All is not calm. All is not bright.

December 26—A local reporter publicly connects the dots: "So Anthony Fenech to exit the Tigers beat and switch to covering the Pistons to replace the buy-out-taking Vince Ellis—and a new hire to cover in place of Fenech?"

This lights up my phone. "Your choice or theirs?" a minor league guy asks. "Something up?" a former colleague wonders.

I spend the holidays ignoring calls and trying to dive into NBA sourcing. I've been building a new ScoopSheet (SwooshSheet), going through media guides, picking sourcing targets for the Pistons beat. Vince passed along contacts for scouts with the Heat and Nets.

December 31—We had to put Fuzzles down today, four months shy of her 20th birthday. I was in sixth grade when we got her, a little ball of long gray hair. She always lived with Mom but stayed some weekends with me.

Fuzzles stopped eating a few days ago and kept sitting on the heat vents for comfort. We took her to the vet, who ran some tests. Kidney cancer.

So, yeah. 2019 was a shitty year.

DETROIT, *January 23, 2020*—Still twisting in the wind, I'm sent today to the Tigers' winter caravan kickoff at Comerica Park, like any year.

"You coming here today?" Ron Colangelo asks. "Great."

I wear my unconventional best—snake-skin cowboy boots. If this is the last time I see Michael Fulmer, I want it to be in Nanu's boots—I've been telling Fulmer about them for years.

Any day could be my last day Ball Writing. My job has been offered to one person and you're going to want to be seated for that one.

Jordan Zimmermann wonders why I'm here.

"I thought you were covering basketball?"

January 24—Covering TigerFest as a lame duck came less than 48 hours after I sat in a newsroom conference room with the first candidate to interview for my job: Ball Writing BFF Kristie Ackert.

Yep. Of all the sports writers in the world, Coach Content landed on her.

I have a "serious" question scribbled on my notepad—"I heard you like to steal M&Ms from the freezer, is that true?"—and give a serious answer when she asks: "Would you support me if I did end up taking the job?" "Absolutely," I say. "100 percent. You're one of my best friends and I'd want to do nothing but help you to succeed and I would love to work with you... but I'm going to be honest and I've told you this. I'm trying to get out of here. I've been trying to get out of here for a year, so I don't want you to take the job thinking that I'm going to be here. Because I probably won't be."

The *Daily News* ended up offering Kristie more money to stay and our sports editor was having trouble finding someone. One of the people he contacted, a direct competitor, got in touch and wondered what was going on. "It surprised me," he said. "I think you're one of the best in the country."

So, I called Coach Content, that's how serious I was, and I set up a meeting, determined to fall on the sword. I psyched him out with buzz words: Content. Engagement. Clicks.

It worked, and he gave me back my job.

He shared the good news at a colleague's going-away party. For a brief second, I felt relief for the first time in Lord knows how long, like I could smile again, until he said this:

"Don't fuck it up."

February 25—Today, I'm in the newsroom to present my findings of the investigation story I've been working on since last July, when I sent Ron Colangelo to voicemail during one of Gardy's pregame media sessions in Kansas City.

"Call when you can," he texted me.

That was the first tell.

I had texted him minutes earlier: a business-side scoop designed to ruin his day: "Do you have any background or a quote for when I write that two of the top ticket guys got fired?" That he responded so quickly, with a call, then a text, was unusual.

As the Tigers struggled through another terrible season, my reporting eye strayed elsewhere in the organization. That morning, I heard those two executives, both closely tied to ownership, were recently dismissed.

Colangelo's top priority is protecting ownership's brand. He called again later, saying in so many words that there was nothing to see there. I believed him, and called the source who tipped me off, and talked to them for hours about how the people have been leaving in droves since new management was installed, and here's why.

I called people while on holiday in Malta and went to get a pizza with two Tigers folks immediately after the flight back, right around the time I started turning up the volume—two weeks before I was taken off the beat in November.

I speak in front of six people, including the top news editor and sports editor. The investigations editor was scheduled to show up, but they announced he's leaving just a few hours ago.

In the meeting, I break down what I have:

"Last June, a veteran Tigers VP of ticket sales hosted a barbeque at his house to reward the ticket department for hitting their goal. The goal was met despite working under a young VP hired in February, whose leadership style has driven a mass exodus of employees. The week after the barbeque, the two veteran VPs were fired."

"The firings were the Tigers' latest effort to distance the business side from an old guard of employees who worked under Mike Ilitch. Since he died, employees lost their company pension in 2017; ticket employees work under uncertain commission pay, which has spurred legal action by one former employee; and work culture has cratered."

"Ownership's recent executive hires have contributed. One major hire was arrested for twice exposing himself in public and subsequently fired. And the latest VP hire has driven the ticket department into the ground. Among claims levied: The new ticket VP has allegedly asked a female employee to change into a dress before a prospective client gathering."

"In total, over 70 people have left the business side over the past two seasons. Employees describe a non-diverse organization that does not value its workers."

They asked questions; I gave what answers I could.

Focus on one thing, they said. We need more. Someone willing to go on the record.

March 3—Good news: I didn't fuck it up. Today I make it "official-official" in the newsroom.

I was told two weeks ago that I was back on the beat, but Boss has so far balked at sending the Ball Writer down to spring training. The backup Lions football writer remains in TigerTown.

A few days ago, he said he had a memo for me to sign, and after that, we were golden.

Reading over the memo, I spot a big red flag. It says I must grow page views by 10 percent year-over-year. I ask him if I could have the union rep to give it a look. Union Rep says don't touch it—performance-based clauses are not permitted for bargaining unit employees.

Thwarted, he sends another memo, no gotchas about it. He offers this recent evaluation:

"Anthony has shown exceptional improvement in communication and collaboration over the past month after being reassigned from the Tigers beat in November 2019."

SAN PEDRO de MACORÍS, Dominican Republic, *March 10*—A buddy asks what I'm doing here.

"I got my job back."

"What???"

It's a long story. What matters is that I'm here, where the back roads are bumpy and my driver crawls between sugarcane crops in his wife's Subaru.

Oliver Arias, a Dominican area scout, has been my tour guide and interpreter for two days while I report from the Tigers' academy.

After the nightmare of 2019, being back on any assignment feels surreal. Yesterday I profiled the mystery top prospect from Cuba they sent me here to cover. Today I'm watching 80 international prospects emerge from dormitories at 9:21 A.M.

Two flights away from spring training, the coronavirus dominates the media cycle. Eight cases in Florida yesterday—the state's first significant jump.

In the morning, another jump. Mom is terrified. "Are you in FL yet? Got your wipes? Don't shake hands with anyone... Over 1,000 in U.S., 30 deaths."

ATLANTA, *March 11*—Two-hour layover. More people wearing masks than I've ever seen, including bartenders. Every TV shows red breaking news ribbons: CDC: AT LEAST 1,200+ COVID-19 CASES IN U.S.

Messages when I land in Tampa: "When you have a min, give me a call."—Willie Horton. "Call if you get the chance."—Deep Throat. "Are you in Lakeland yet?"—Mom.

I call Mr. Horton (no answer) and talk with Deep Throat for 20 minutes on the drive, then check into the hotel and head to the bar.

Sunny, 77 degrees, and smells like spring training. I made it to Florida for Ball Writing's best month. Only got 14 days, let's make the most of 'em.

LAKELAND, Fla., *March 12*—By morning, the sports world begins to spin more slowly.

"Hopefully you brought your wipes," Mom texts me. "They quarantined Pistons. They played Jazz on Saturday. The player from Jazz has the virus."

Two days after Utah's All-Star center Rudy Gobert mocked questions about the pandemic, touching recorders and microphones following a press conference, he tests positive. Gobert was scratched in the lead-up to last night's Utah-Oklahoma City game, which was soon postponed, setting off a firestorm of events.

This morning, many in baseball forecast the same fate. "We're always the last to act."

Me? I'm just happy to be back, even if it's in a mask.

I arrive for my sixth spring training the same day as the coronavirus. I hit the ground running—there is other important news besides impending doomsday. This week was the Tigers' open tryout, one of the few remaining in baseball.

I check with a source. Nobody was signed.

All I know right now is that it's good to be back. Good to see the parking lot attendant whose name escapes me. "Why hello stranger!" he beams. Good to see the lobby secretary and Michele Wysocki, who last season left her job as Tigers media relations coordinator—she has tickets on the Margaritaville patio deck in right field.

With clubhouses closed, Tigers PR facilitates interviews by request. I ask Crunk for players' union rep Matthew Boyd and the team's head trainer.

I go 1-for-2 in my spring debut. The trainer can't talk, but Boyd does—speaking to reporters inside the lobby at team HQ, expressing hope that baseball won't shut down.

He stands six feet away, behind an elastic line. He's wearing metal spikes, holding a baseball glove, planning to throw later in the outfield.

"If you get sick, you get sick. There's so much that is out of your control. You can do what you want but you can't go live life out of fear—that's not what you're supposed to do. That's not living as you're called to."

Boyd is asked if he thinks spring training will continue.

"I think the show is going to go on as long as it can."

Detroit takes the field for stretch, calisthenics and batting practice.

I climb over the short fence next to the dugout, where Miguel Cabrera welcomes me to camp the only way he can—he gives me the finger.

Miggy loosens up behind the cage, readying for batting practice. I smile and wave back.

Teams begin pulling their scouts from the road.

Rival Exec: "Multiple teams are pulling scouts: Red Sox, Angels, Cardinals, and others."

Adjacent to the media dining tent, former Tiger reliever Shane Greene stands outside the visitor's clubhouse. Greene is still with Atlanta after last season's trade. He's as surprised as anybody that they're playing today.

"We touch the ball on every pitch," Greene says, spinning a ball off his fingers in slow-motion. "By just throwing the ball, players could be at risk."

Having a margarita in Section 105, Wysocki texts me: "Stop by if you need a break."

"A break or a margarita?"

"Well, I'm not sharing mine."

My days in baseball may be numbered, as well. The desk has sent six text messages and two emails so far today—and the game hasn't even started.

When it does, Víctor Reyes makes a nice running catch in left field.

While the Braves and Tigers begin play, the sports world continues toward a hard stop—and speculation ensues baseball is next.

"MLB is on deck," Deep Throat warns.

In the newsroom up north, the editor on duty agrees: "Start pumping out that 'MLB is shutting down' story. Looks like it's inevitable."

Deep Throat is on Line 1: "MLB statement at 2."

"How some teams haven't told their guys to go home is beyond me," one source says. "MLB blew this one hard. When the NBA suspended, it should have been immediate."

Selfishly, I'm glad it wasn't.

Tigers lead Braves, 2-1, bottom of the sixth.

Shane Greene finishes a scoreless inning by striking out Cabrera swinging. In midseason form, Miggy appeals the checked swing to the first base umpire, who upholds strike three.

MLB announces it is suspending spring training and pushing back the start of the regular season by at least two weeks.

Opening Day was supposed to be March 26. Now it's April 8, at best.

This game continues. Down three runs in the ninth, Hittin' Harold Castro smacks an RBI single, and Detroit brings the tying run to the plate. With dark coronavirus clouds moving in and spring training already doomed, the crowd stirs for the last time in who knows how long.

The rally falls short. Tigers lose.

Postgame, Boyd addresses reporters again. Privy to private Players' Association discussions, Boyd shares what he can about the immediate future.

"I was wrong earlier. Didn't take long for that to switch around."

The team will stay in Lakeland until further notice. Informal, optional workouts will be conducted.

After Boyd speaks, Al Avila and Ron Gardenhire step in.

Avila wears a navy polo; a ballpoint pen hooked between buttons. The Tigers will have their facilities deep-cleaned, top-to-bottom. No positive tests so far. Gardenhire is asked how he found out—from a field-level security guard, he says, who showed him his phone.

"Read this."

"I kinda got a game going on. So, it was different. No doubt, it was different."

It's good to see them—even if we are standing six feet apart and roped off. I stand in the back of the reporting bunch, next to a stairway that winds up to the Tigers' front offices.

Walking behind me, Al pinches my ear.

A scout friend suggests dinner before the world ends.

Larry the press box attendant is gone, and the computer screen is asleep. I've been the last man hanging for almost half an hour now—no lights, mini fridge locked, sun shading a stadium that might not get much use for a while.

I don't write. Just sit and think.

After years of filing quickly to meet print deadlines and feed the web and promptly leave the park, I can't bring myself to do anything but sit here and think about the good ol' days. Sometimes, I smile.

I think about my first time here, a problem child for PR even back then. Left unattended at spring training in 2014 as an emergency fill-in for Seamhead John Lowe, I took a picture of a gag posted in the clubhouse—a picture of backup catcher Bryan Holaday in a stars-and-stripes women's one-piece photoshopped into a mock *Sports Illustrated* swimsuit cover.

Of course I tweeted it, before Crunk pulled me outside and asked me to delete it—and the picture from my phone.

I was thrown into the Ball Writing fire when the Tigers were blindsided by an injury to Jose Iglesias, the young dynamo defender at shortstop, who was forecast to miss many months—if not the season—with a tear of the patella tendon.

Five years since then. How would I break the news if the shortstop goes down now?

And when I first met Víctor Martínez that week in 2014. He called me “minor league” back then, and I worked hard on our relationship. A year later, my first covering the team in 2015, he was struggling early, hitting .240-something with only four extra-base hits.

One night, the Tigers lost a tough one in extra innings, and after reporters from his scrum scattered, Víctor called me back.

“Hey, Anthony...”

With a backpack on, turning away from his locker, he reached out to me for a fist bump. I complied, and it made me feel good as a young reporter—he gave me a sign of respect. Then he walked off through the clubhouse manager’s office and out the door. I think about how I’ll never talk to Víctor again.

I continue to sit in the Joker Marchant Stadium press box, trying to imagine what the stadium looked like before. When there weren’t seats in right, no Margaritaville porch, just a few tall palm trees and green netting to catch homers and protect reporters and others outside the clubhouse from getting blistered with foul balls.

I strain to see it. Back when there were black chain-link picnic tables out there, the kind you could stick your fingers into, where I once interviewed my favorite baseball player growing up and got razzed by Jim Leyland and spent the doe-eyed days of my cub reporting youth. A place far in the fantasy of the past, so far away from the reality of now, where I’m afraid to leave the press box because I don’t think I’ll ever be back.

THE PANDEMIC

LAKELAND, Fla., *March 13*—New this morning: Two Utah Jazz players who were at Detroit's Little Caesars Arena last weekend have tested positive.

I haven't showered since the Dominican and I'm not planning on it until I get back home.

I work the baseball switchboard from Starbucks, texting everyone for updates. "Is this stuff true about you guys being told to go home?"

Clubhouse source: "Yes but can't talk about it."

Player: "No. Don't believe so. Nothing is mandated."

Avila: "MLB has shut down ML and MiLB spring training. All players can return home."

Even with teams telling them to scram, many players remain stubborn.

"It's not required," Boyd says. "We want to stay ready to play."

I put my untouched luggage back into the trunk. Sadly, my time with the silver Corolla I picked up 48 hours ago has been cut short. I'm returning her 12 days early.

At the toll booth, I'm dismayed to realize I'm short. Car in park, I claw through the cabin—beneath the seats, between the seats, in the back—as someone pulls up. Panicking, I hit the gas and pass onto the toll. A flash—guess I'll be hearing from the State of Florida.

On the road, I get a text from Nick. "It's a personal choice" about whether to stay or go home.

You don't need to ask me to leave Lakeland twice. I do feel warmly about my adopted spring home. But if the coronavirus means end times for all, well, Polk County, Florida is among the last places on Earth I'd want to spend my final days.

I text Mom that we're taking off soon. We get in at 11:15. She'll be there. Last door to the right of baggage claim, like she always is.

Eyes closed, engine humming. My phone pings. Guess who.

"Got anything leftover for the morning?"

I put the phone on airplane mode.

DETROIT, *April 6*—Sometimes, sports writing means making tough calls. Three weeks after the pandemic hit, the *Free Press* received a tip. Al Kaline had died.

A connected freelancer called in, and within minutes, the desk reached out with a phone number for Mr. Kaline's oldest son, Mark. My first job was to text him.

"I am sorry for reaching out to you under these circumstances, but we are putting something together about your dad and wanted to reach out to the family for any kind of comment. Again, I'm sorry for your loss and having to reach out at this time."

Somehow, my second task was even worse.

Willie Horton, Al's teammate and dear friend of 50-plus years, was next on my call list. He once saved Kaline's life when, in 1970, Kaline collided with another outfielder, swallowed his tongue and crumpled to the ground unable to breathe. Horton rushed to his side and cleared Al's airway.

As I called Mr. Horton, it was sunny and springtime. At 77, he was gardening outside his home. I didn't want to be the one to tell him if he didn't already know, so I asked a circumspect question about hearing anything about Al Kaline. He said no, nothing new, just saw Al last week.

Calling back minutes later, Willie was crying, wailing upon learning the news. It took him nine days to put the loss into words.

"It's my whole life. That's all of Willie Horton's life as a professional."

June 13—Any day could be my last.

This evening, I share my plans with one of my best friends and one of my younger brothers, who is piped in from D.C. on FaceTime.

I came over with a printed two-page dossier. I am quitting my job to write a book.

The document is titled FENECH 2.0.

Half an hour later, Scott Boras calls again.

"Is that Boras again?" my buddy says. "Is it?"

"Yeah," staring at the phone.

"Did you text him?"

Boras called earlier. I texted him back, told him I was on deadline. Said I'd call back later.

I let it ring twice more before picking up. Can't ignore Scott Boras—not even tonight.

"Hey, what's going on?"

"Hey Anthony," he says, in his Scott Boras voice. "How are you?"

June 18—In February, I stood in front of folks in a *Free Press* conference room and laid out everything I had about the investigative story. Good start, they said. Keep digging.

It's been nearly a year working on this story solo; I've crossed everybody in the ticket department who's answered off the list.

Time is crimping to pull it off, so I decide to poke the hornet's nest.

I tweet: "If you work in the Tigers ticket office and have yet to receive your commission pay, contact me at afenech@freepress.com, doing a head count."

I tweet: "In other Tigers ticket sales news, three employees were fired on Monday for drinking beer in the parking lot after a recent mask-making shift—further fueling employees' beliefs that Ilitch Holdings is trying to get rid of as many employees as easily as possible to save money."

"As of the new year, at least 77 business-side employees had left the Tigers between 2018-19, including 42 last year as new upper management began decimating the organization's culture established by former team owner Mike Ilitch, according to records kept by the *Free Press*."

The tweets did what I thought they might. Just not this quickly.

Fifteen minutes later, from a former Tigers executive: "Phones are blowing up across Detroit right now. I'm already feeling it. It was a topic on our morning call that I didn't start."

"Don't encourage me."

The next morning, Tigers PR sends an update to tweet: "The team has paid out all commissions to ticket sales employees through May, according to a team spokesperson."

June 23—In the most journalism moment of my life, I am knocking on the door of a man's house who I have never met, who to my great thrill opens the door and waves me to the backyard.

He lets me beyond the fence and locks the gate.

"I didn't want to talk out there."

Apparently the Ilitch family doesn't mess around.

The months-long investigation into the tanking ticket department has led me here, to the secluded backyard of a well-to-do suburban Detroit subdivision, a long ways from the beat.

I laugh; the man doesn't. He's not kidding—they've been known to have private investigators keep watch on current and former employees alike.

He's a former employee bound by non-disclosure and non-compete agreements, still collecting paychecks from the Tigers since they let him go.

I've been sitting on his number since fall and showed up tonight out of the blue without even the courtesy of a text. The meeting amounts to a Hail Mary for the story. Time is running out.

The guy sitting across from me is taking a risk even talking to me. The next guy will practically throw me off his porch. There's a family inside and a sports writer on his patio who he doesn't know from Adam and who hasn't a clue how to get what he needs.

There's a notebook on the table, but I'm afraid to write.

All I remember is how he started tearing up when speaking about the allegations of mistreatment of female employees I'd mentioned.

I asked him if this story would matter. If it would get any traction of change from ownership.

"I think it will. If there's anything they don't like, it's being embarrassed."

I couldn't have been there for more than ten minutes.

I was a rookie all over again, but I knew enough to park the other street over. Walking back, I feel like a badass. Like I can't believe that just happened. I had nothing to show for it.

The story never ran. Coach Content said we might have to "punt until the off-season," and I knew I didn't have that long.

July 1—With baseball season still up in the air—players and owners continue to bicker over schedule, payment, rules and player safety protocols—I break Ball Writing quarantine. I drive to a nondescript warehouse in suburban Detroit.

I've been invited. Sort of. I know a guy who knows a guy who runs a local travel baseball program.

The guy tells the guy who tells me that Miguel Cabrera has been using their facilities for the past three days. He says Miggy flew up from South Florida over the weekend and wanted somewhere to hit, so his guys made a couple calls.

"*That was somebody from the Tigers,*" the guy said. "*They're coming up here to hit.*"

When they arrived in an all-black Range Rover, the guy's jaw dropped. Waving them to the side door, men jumped out holding baseball bats.

"Emerging from behind is Miguel Cabrera with a mask on. I'm like, 'No way.' I'm like, 'That's not *a* Tiger, that might be the greatest righty hitter of all-time.'"

Cabrera is tuning up for the start of summer camp. Workouts begin two days from now at Comerica Park.

For some reps before then, he takes cuts in the same batting cages where teenage players spend hours honing their developing skills, hoping to earn a college scholarship.

I've been invited by the program director.

"My guess is 3:30-ish. They usually run half an hour behind."

I'm ten minutes away and promise to wait until he arrives.

"I don't want to betray their trust, so let's make sure it's ok."

I don't know if Miggy's crew is aware, so I loop in former Tigers PR Aileen Villarreal. "I doubt Miguel will say no with you being there," she says. "I support you because I think it will turn out to be a good story but have to stay in the background."

Cabrera is joined by teammate Harold Castro. Castro hit .291 in 97 games last season, showing bat-to-ball ability that led one Ball Writer to nickname him, "Hittin' Harold." (Me.)

Miggy loosens up with a weighted bat.

"Hey bitch."

We bring it in for a handshake and he pretends to hit me upside the head with the bat. Approval.

A cloth mask hangs from my ears, below my face. The others aren't wearing masks. I'm unsure if I should put it on.

Soft-tossing and going through tee work, Cabrera looks fit. Dare I say slim. He rips balls fed through a JUGS machine, smacking a shotgun echo around the cages.

They pile into the Rover and drive off. I have an exclusive—a video, some photos, behind-the-scenes access.

It'll be the closest any Ball Writer comes to Miggy all season.

July 14—During this morning's summer camp activities at Comerica Park, two of the Tigers' top prospects go head-to-head in live BP. Righty starter Casey Mize throws against this year's top pick, Spencer Torkelson.

I shoot video. I process it, upload it, send it in.

But not even that is enough. Not even a main story, a sidebar, instant observations and a video. Driving home, I get an email asking for *more*.

"Hey, man. Is anything coming on them facing off? Would be good to have a headline on it, please."

My reply while sitting outside the liquor store.

"Yeah, I can give you a few grafts. Give me like 15 minutes."

At home, I chug from a pint of tequila. Cobble together a few grafts at the kitchen table. Chug. Format the story shell with three inline links, SEO and meta

title, Google search keywords and at least one video embedded. Chug. Hit send, chug again.

Luxor Liquor has become a postgame stop, day or night. Today, it's not even 4 P.M. I got a fifth instead of a pint after seeing *another* email.

But today, unlike any previous days waging silent wars against myself, today I collapse my head onto the keyboard and cry. Today, for the very first time, I surrender. I told myself the last time that I'd never cry over this job again.

I text Pedro Gomez.

"I'm thinking about pulling the plug on my job very soon."

July 15—Hungover and hankering for a pizza. There are nine days until Opening Day.

Five months ago, career up in the air, they sent me to Cleveland to cover basketball.

Walking out of the arena, the Cleveland Indians' stadium advertised a countdown: 46 DAYS UNTIL OPENING DAY.

That day came and went when COVID threw an unmistakable curtain over my Ball Writing career, which was soon reduced to daily streams of the "Virtual Tigers"—broadcasting a PlayStation 4 simulation of MLB: The Show on Twitch. They had me writing recaps of the Virtual Tigers games.

This whole scene led to heavy drinking. And now here we are—picking up a pizza on the way to work.

I bring it unbothered through the COVID security line and leave it on the counter in the media commons, an open invitation for any other sports writers in attendance. I post it on Twitter for the folks at home who have been following summer camp's daily activities.

"Today is the pizza party. The Jet's Bread is for Al."

It's the first night game of summer camp. A handful of sports writers are here, still wearing masks and sitting at a distance. One per row. The Tigers are playing themselves again—another intra-squad scrimmage with no fans in attendance and, for the very first time, artificial crowd noise piped through the speakers.

Ron Colangelo, who began his career as a minor-league radio broadcaster, steps in as public address announcer. The Tigers' PR chief introduces players from a nearby luxury box, close enough so I can see him scroll between innings, shaking his head at what I can only hope is my latest tweet.

"For the first time in years, crowd noise has returned to Comerica Park."

I have been giving the PR department a rough go of things, with frustration and finality snowballing into the summer months. Frustration over the investiga-

tive story, because I can't seem to find that fearless source to get it past the goal line. Finality, because I know time to get someone on the record is running out.

So, I'm not shocked when my boss texts me. But I'll admit to being surprised when I saw the reason why.

"Tigers are freaking out because this makes it look like MLB's COVID protocol is being busted in the media room."

He asks if I can clarify on Twitter that there isn't actually a pizza party.

"You really weren't joking. You want me to reply to everyone saying it's not a pizza party?"

Uncle Fen isn't allowed to bring Jet's Pizza for the campers anymore.

July 20—Some personal news: I've decided to quit my job, effective today.

On the last day of summer camp, I am speeding down the freeway, screaming at the songs on the radio, and I'm scared shitless, if I'm being completely honest.

I woke up feeling dangerous and shared my plan with Deep Throat.

"If you don't think I'll order pizza for PR as a thank you for their help this summer ..."

I don't think he believed me but promised not to try and talk me out of it.

Opening Day is four days away and I am still standing on the diving board, scared to jump. I don't know how to leave the only job I've ever wanted.

Two weeks ago, I texted my closest work confidante: "My internal clock is telling me I have to say something soon." Last week, I wrote a farewell letter but didn't drink enough to hit SEND. I've even considered going full Barry Sanders and just disappearing.

I've created a monster and now I've got a reputation to uphold, so let's get on with it.

Late in the final scrimmage of summer camp, socially distanced from reality and light years beyond the best decision I'll ever make, I step into the concourse and put the plan in motion—a plan I came up with all by myself.

I call the nearest Jet's Pizza and place an order for two large pies, bread and a two-liter of pop. Instead of hanging up, I put it on my personal credit card and leave a contact number for Tigers PR.

A voice echoes in my head with odd satisfaction. "Now, you've *really* done it." Instead of calling back and cancelling the order, I turn my phone off.

I'm betting when it comes back on, there will be a text message from Tigers PR, Coach Content, or, if I'm really lucky, both. If not, we might be all out of options.

Powering back up, I'm peppered with texts. The delivery man couldn't find the stadium. Comerica Park security is looking for me. Deep Throat can't believe I actually did it.

The phone rings. You-know-who.

Quick conversation. He asks me to explain.

Instead of telling him to take this job and shove it, I go through with the act. I tell him the gesture was for a job well-done. I sent the Tigers free pizza. Not a bomb.

“Fenech, you know damn well how sensitive they are about these kinds of things. You are a very smart person—I do not understand on what level it would be OK to send food to Ron, who is very obviously hypersensitive to these things. Can you help me understand that?”

I’m all out of ammo.

“I don’t think I can.”

He sighs. He’ll call back.

“I have to think about this.”

Sinking into the couch, I smile with soaked relief.

And I sit there and think about how, if I live to write that sports writing book, this is how it would end, with the phone ringing and everything else a beautiful blur—a ride so real, I couldn’t have made it up.

London was a mess. Spent fourteen days quarantining at an airport hotel. On the third day, called MetLife. When the lady on the line asked what I was filing for—mental health or substance abuse—I said both. That job was going to kill me, I said, and downloaded Tinder. “From America, writing a book.” Everyone asked about the book, so I changed my bio to just an American flag and made up a new story every time. I’m a software tech dual-citizen who used to work for Microsoft. Told a woman named Francesca that I was a sock model. Spent the new year many months sober, sitting on the porch step of a converted boat house smoking cigarettes along the sea. Got a tip, a message on my phone. Amber Alert back home. WHERE IN THE WORLD IS ANTHONY FENECH? It wasn’t always fun, it was lonely, we were in lockdown, and some days I found myself longing for it. When the Free Press found me, I thought they’d gotten me again. They offered each employee complimentary election day pizza, and I sent mine to Deep Throat. Corporate called, Coach Content was leaving, was I coming back to work? Got laid off on a Zoom call, citing something in the bargaining agreement, didn’t bother to look. Got here on my birthday. Next day, everything closed. Masks everywhere—even outside, even at the beach. Rode the bus, left my phone, chased it around for hours, to a half-rate hostel in the south. Got a text from Andrew the Chicago cab driver. Where had I gone, why hadn’t I called. “The story begins in the back of your SUV,” I said. Relapsed the hardest when I found out. The Super Bowl started at midnight and there were drugs and new friends and a cab to the easternmost point of the island, to a fishing town I couldn’t pronounce. Keys, credit cards, crying on a bench. The sun came up. I wondered if he ever thought about me. I googled my name. “One of these days,” the story said, “we will find out what happened between Anthony Fenech and life.” Every day, I thought of that day. I went through a lot of days of just picking up my pen and holding it. And I picked it up every day and one day, after many months, I picked it up. I was sitting there, and I looked at it real hard and I went—

DEDICATION

This book is dedicated to Pedro Gomez.

Pedro was an ESPN television reporter since 2003 and one of the country's foremost baseball journalists when he died unexpectedly at age 58 from a heart attack on February 7, 2021. He died watching Super Bowl LV with friends in his Scottsdale, Arizona home.

Pedro was the son of Cuban refugees, born 20 days after his parents arrived in America. He grew up in Miami and spent 35 years covering baseball—America's national sport and Cuba's, too—at the *Miami News*, *San Diego Union-Tribune*, *San Jose Mercury News*, *Miami Herald* and *Sacramento Bee*. In 1997, he became a columnist and national baseball writer at the *Arizona Republic*.

I loved Pedro Gomez the way I love my father. Our connection began in November 2014, within weeks after I took over the Tigers beat at the *Detroit Free Press*. We met not in a dugout or baseball press box, but at the Detroit Lions' football practice facility as the Buffalo Bills and New York Jets were conducting workouts. A snowstorm had forced the Jets-Bills game indoors at Detroit's Ford Field.

Pedro was covering the practice for ESPN. I was a newly minted Ball Writer. When I introduced myself, his eyes lit up. Our first phone conversation lasted an hour. Little did I know that would be the rule—not an exception.

Pedro supported me unfailingly, many times at a moment's notice, and stood by my side during the most stressful moments of my career. When I last talked to him, texting him in the heart of the pandemic summer in 2020, he did not know of my internal turmoil. He didn't know about *OFF-THE-RECORD*. "I pulled the plug."

As Pedro always did, he immediately called back. He did not mince disappointment with the boneheaded pizza delivery plan I carried out. It was audible in his voice, the exasperation of his words, and the seriousness with which he said, "Anthony, you committed career suicide."

I knew that kind of honesty was not easy to share. He sounded like a dejected dad—I had let him down. A couple days later, I messaged him.

"I really appreciate the honesty you gave me a couple nights ago. I know you were disappointed to hear that, and I was embarrassed to tell you about it—you have put in so much time with me because I'm much better than that. You're right, the pizza didn't 'just happen.'

"I made the decision; I did it consciously and I am aware of the future implications this may have on my place in the industry. While I wish I would have acted more mature in carrying it out, I hit the breaking point and made a move.

"I am very confident in my ability, and I feel very strongly that this move will put me in a better position to make the kind of impact I desired to make in this industry. I'm looking forward to sharing these thoughts with you.

OFF-THE-RECORD

“Again, I really appreciate the honesty. Though, yes, it was pizza—it is embarrassing, and I am not looking forward to others who I respect like you receiving this information. I know it’s not easy to tell me that I committed ‘career suicide’ and I know you’re not being mean, but this is why I trust you so much—because it’s not BS.

“You’re one of the most important people in my career and I’m indebted for your help. I’ll get at you early next week with an update. Appreciate you.”

“See, this is what I saw in you five years ago. Everything you wrote here has so much of YOU in it. It’s heartfelt and definitely feels sincere. It’s like a young player making it to the bigs and he’s unsure of himself but when he gets there, he does something special, meaning it’s inside of that player. It’s IN you. Second chances are a staple of our society. Make a comeback.”

I never got back to Pedro with an update. I never told him about this book. Never called him again to chat, to kill hours talking baseball, journalism or life.

Pedro stood by me when not many did—because he’d been there.

He called immediately. “History will be on your side.” I will die wishing Pedro Gomez could read this and I would urge the Baseball Writers’ Association of America to honor him with the highest award in the profession.

Although Pedro was most widely known for his television reporting on ESPN, he was a Ball Writer at heart, born and bred from an undying love of the game. After his death, close friend Steve Kettmann edited a book on Pedro’s life, a collection of essays from a Who’s Who of baseball luminaries—from famous reporters to star players to legendary managers.

The book, *Remember Who You Are: What Pedro Gomez Showed Us About Baseball and Life*, is a touching tribute to a man who is a Hall of Famer in every sense of the word. As a father to sons Rio and Dante and daughter Sierra. As a husband to Sandi Gomez, president of the Pedro Gomez Foundation. As a reporter. As a person.

My hope is that someday his legacy is honored in Cooperstown with the Baseball Writers’ Association of America’s Career Excellence Award. There is not a Ball Writing Hall of Fame that’s complete without Pedro Gomez in it.

To support Pedro’s Hall of Fame legacy in sports journalism, consider connecting with the Pedro Gomez Foundation. It’s a non-profit created in 2021 to further students’ aspirations in baseball, journalism and beyond with endowed scholarships at Arizona State University and the University of Arizona. The foundation also offers a ten-week paid student internship at the *Arizona Republic* newspaper, partnering with the National Association of Hispanic Journalists.

To donate to the Pedro Gomez Foundation, visit the website at <https://www.pedrogomezfoundation.org/>. For more information, email the foundation at info@pedrogomezfoundation.org.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

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My eighth grade English teacher is the first person who comes to mind.

She kept me after class and said that my essay made her laugh; that I had a gift. I'd been searching for her when she emailed the address below my story about Al Kaline. We talked for more than three hours; it was COVID and I told her about my career crossroads and this crazy idea I'd been working on.

"Anthony," she said, "You're better than them. You're better than all of them."

When I couldn't disagree, that's when I knew I had it bad.

Dad called me "Champion" growing up, and Mom read to me every night as a child.

The fingerprints of the *Detroit Free Press* are all over these pages: The most raw, incomplete version of this book was read by a veteran copy editor who read it twice more after that. It wasn't much of a book until I found the correct email of an esteemed editor from years past. We connected through James Jahnke's annual bowl pool. When he read some pages and said, "Anthony, I think you've got a book here," I knew I had my man.

Mr. Sports Editor went through every word by hand. He printed 'em out, marked 'em up, and screenshotted 'em back. A year later, he had officially wrangled my wild horse writing into a working manuscript. The *Free Press*' influence goes beyond the newsroom, to the many readers who found my personal email address over the years. Corresponding with Tigers fans made me feel normal again.

I have been fortunate to work with personable editors who have afforded me the freedom to choose which shape I wanted to be in this cookie-cutter industry. The guy in Las Vegas who bet on Tony Gold. A pair of editors in Pittsburgh nurtured my confidence while working the city desk for free.

Thank you to those who trusted me with this project, especially those who may have found themselves part of the story through no fault of their own. The respect and understanding with which you've treated me under most unusual circumstances won't be forgotten.

A brigade of beta readers made this book better, beginning with a classmate from high school journalism class. My best friend has read *OFF-THE-RECORD* twice, one of only two known to scale the first full draft. (690 pages.)

The other owns an American sports bar and never knew me when I was an American sports somebody. My Malta friends allowed me to be myself again.

This book doesn't exist without my aunt, who believed in me more than I believed in myself at times. The girl I once met in the college newsroom never gave up on me, even when I made it difficult.

I generally find these missives to be gross public displays of name-dropping, networking and navel-gazing in an industry that is already a few notches too incestuous, but if I didn't thank anybody, they'd be calling me a jerk.

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First Edition: May 2026

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Library of Congress Control Number: 2026909148

ISBNs: 9798995630401 (print), 9798995630418 (ebook)